The Flap of a Butterfly's Wings

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The Flap of a Butterfly’s Wings

by Lushina

Summary

Time: something that means everything and nothing.

Izuku knew this. He knew how important and precious it was. He knew how dangerous it could be.

Yet, he still tries to change it.

Izuku needs to fix his mistakes, no matter the costs. He needs to save everyone from the horrid deaths that had enveloped them. He was a hero, it was his job to save everyone he possibly could. It was his one purpose in this world and he was willing to give his life for it.

So he travels back in time, but it's further back than he thought it would be. That's okay though, because maybe he can maintain his relationship with Kacchan and look after his mom better. Plus he'll have more time to form his plans.

Only, it doesn't go exactly as he planned.

For every different decision he makes, every new step Izuku takes, another nightmare comes his way.

He swears to save everyone he loves, no matter how many flaps a butterfly may take.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Different Ways

The first thing he was acutely aware of was the smell. The metallic sent was so strong that he fought to hold in his gag reflex. He was disoriented; unaware of what had just occurred only a few minutes prior.

And when he did remember, the memories flooded him with such agony that his legs almost gave out from under him. When he remembered exactly what he had just done, he suddenly found it so much harder to breathe. He forgot *how to breathe.*

He felt the selfishness crawl up his spine that he was even able to draw in a few short gasps of polluted air when everyone else's right to breathe was stripped away from them before they could even blink.

He should be dead. He's the one that deserved it, he's the one that deserved the pain. That's what his tormentors told him at least, and he believed it with *all his heart. He should've been the one on the ground, unmoving. But here he was, very much alive in a field of bodies.*

He wondered how long he stayed there. How long his hands shook, how long it took him to comprehend that this wasn't a dream and never will be.

Whether it was seconds, minutes, or hours, he didn't know. Nor could he bring himself to care. He let a single tear escape his eye as he drew in a breath that turned into a broken chuckle. He should've known this would have happened, why hadn't he known? Maybe he was just never meant to be happy.

Or... Maybe he could be.

Izuku stood up straighter and willed his hands to stop shaking. He had no idea how far back he will able to go, or the drawbacks, but he needed to try.

If he couldn't do that then he might as well just give up.

He screwed up once, he'd be damned if he did it again.

Everything flashed white and he let his eyes close; he felt himself fall,

but he never hit the ground.

When he woke up, he found himself in the arms of another. The soft, gentle fingers caressing his head and the gentle rubs on his back made him fight to stay awake, and eventually, he was being pulled back into darkness. The exhaustion far too deep to ignore.

When Izuku woke up again, things were a lot clearer. He knew where he would be, but he still couldn't help the feeling of surprise wash over him as he found himself at his childhood home, before he moved into the dorms. Izuku realized that he was once again in the arms of the another, only he wasn't being carried this time and was on what seemed to be the couch. When he looked up he came across another pair of green eyes. He couldn't help the tears spring into his eyes and spill down his cheeks because *this was his mother* he was looking at. She looked so much younger and healthier than before and the worry lines his mother possessed from the other timeline weren't there anymore.

Izuku promised himself to make her worry as little as possible in this life.

He let his small arms wrap around his mother's frame as tight as they could. He didn't know how old he was, but he was definitely young enough to where it was hard to form full sentences.

A few weeks later, he was sitting at a table with a small cupcake in front of him. There was a small candle that was shaped like the number two sitting on top of it.

His mother and the Bakugo family were the only people there. The only people he needed.

He blew on the candle.

"K-kacchan."

He was having a play date with Katsuki when he had let it slip. His mother and Mitsuki were laughing while taking a video of the whole thing. He was quite embarrassed with all of the extra attention and he felt his face heat up which only seemed to make the two adults giggle even more.

Even though they were only a few months apart, Katsuki was already stronger than him and had the exceptional ability to speak almost fluently while Izuku still struggled. He had to keep reminding himself that he was two, but it still frustrated him, because even now, Katsuki was ahead. He wanted to be equal with him again, just like he was in his last life. It scared him to think that there relationship might be rocky like it was last time. Katsuki and his mom were the only things keeping him sane and he didn't know if he could loose Katsuki again. Even if it was only for a few years.

Kacchan gave him a look of surprise, but he could faintly see the red the hovered on his cheeks. "W-what did you just say?" He couldn't tell if he made him angry by calling him the nickname. He just hoped Katsuki would let him call that again. Izuku doesn't know if he could ever call him 'Katsuki' or 'Bakugo' without it feeling weird on his tongue.

He took a minute to think, because while he was getting better at talking, it still took a lot of concentration. "I... I called you Kacchan. Do- do you not like it?" He hated how childish and weak he sounded, but how could a two year old *not* sound childish?

Izuku looked at Bakugo expectingly, hoping that he'd be okay with it. He had worked really hard in these short few months to become closer to Katsuki than he was during the last time he was this age. He didn't want it to go to waste. "N-no. I like it." Kacchan had declared while the faint red on his cheeks darkened.

He couldn't help but smile.

Inko knew her child was different.

Before the age of two he had tried to start talking in complete sentences and he *even* tried to read. The first time Izuku grabbed a book and started to read it, Inko thought he might have just been pretending. After all, she herself read all the time so maybe he was copying her. She let him keep at it, because at least it occupied him and gave him something to do.

It wasn't until Izuku's second birthday that she realized that he *indeed* was reading and not pretending. It baffled her, how could her son know how to read? She hasn't even thought about teaching him how to, and yet, here he was, reading children books that seemed to bore him. When he had gathered courage to ask for a book that she was sure that even *she* would have trouble reading Inko found herself at a loss.

Inko bought it for him. After all, if he couldn't read it now (She was positive that he couldn't), he could always try again in a few years.

He finished it in a week.

To prove it to her that he did read it, he tried his best to explain it using words that confused her (she may or may not have looked a few up).

He was also extremely protective of the people that he was comfortable around, which wasn't a lot for a kid his age. He asked about the Bakugo's everyday and asked about their kid, Katsuki, at least twice a day. It was the worst for her, though. It made her concerned because he would make sure he was next to her almost twenty-four seven and if he wasn't near her for more than twenty minutes, he'll go off asking a million questions about where she was and what she was doing. Inko had a suspicion that her son had a some type of separation anxiety from the way he was acting. It wasn't until he was positive that she wouldn't leave him did Izuku start getting less clingy.

Then the nightmares started to appear. At first, Inko thought nothing of it. Everybody gets nightmares, it's completely normal. That is until she noticed how he would wake up screaming at least once a week with a face filled with so much horror that she just *knew* that this wasn't normal. The bags under his eyes never seemed to go away and she worried how much sleep Izuku was exactly getting because it couldn't be enough for someone his age. It couldn't be healthy.

Inko had taken him to the doctors after the third week of Izuku's night terrors. The doctor said that he should grow out of it and prescribed some sleeping pills.

It didn't help the fact that Izuku refused to take the pills. He would look at the pills with such distaste and he flinched every time Inko tried to persuade him to take one. He refused, and even tried to convince his mother that he was sleeping a lot more now, that he didn't need some medicine to help him. He was doing fine.

It was another bad night for both of Midoryia's. Inko's stress wouldn't let her mind calm down enough for her to fall asleep so she settled with making some tea to help calm her. When she was making the tea, Inko heard the soft pitter-patter of her son's feet coming down the hallway. He had peaked through the door and asked if he could have some tea, too. She wasn't sure if she should let her son stay up this late, but it seemed like he wouldn't be able to sleep either way.

So they huddled on the couch together with a warm cup of tea in their hands. This wasn't the first time this had happened, and probably not going to be the last. Inko was internally grateful for her son, because without him, she wouldn't know what to do. He was everything to her, and she would protect him with her life.

"Do you want to talk about it?" She knew the answer, but Inko found herself asking him this every time.

He stopped his head mid-swing and seemed to reconsider. This sparked a hope in Inko that she might finally find out what's been haunting her son. Izuku put the now empty cup on the coffee stand and snuggled closer to

her and closed his eyes.

In a voice that was a whisper, but also held a wave of calmness that was about to contradict what he was about to say he spoke, "There's just so much blood. Too much blood. No one should be able to bleed that much, it should be impossible." And then like he hadn't just said something so disturbing, he fell asleep next to his mother.

Inko was horrified. Her son was way to young to be conjuring up those images, let alone have recurring nightmares about them. There had to be something she was missing. A villain attack that he had heard about? A glimpse of someone's TV?

Her son was different in ways that made her smile, made her cry, and scared her.

But Inko will always love him no matter what.

Memories And Nightmares

Chapter Summary

Izuku is three (again) and goes to the doctor’s (again).

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Maintaining a three year-old personality was hard. Harder than he thought it would be.

He wasn't like the other kids at school, and that seemed to scare them. Or at least weird them out to the point where they wouldn't talk to him. Izuku didn't mind though, he had Kacchan and Inko and that was all he needed. It's not like he didn't try, because he did -it seemed to make his mom happier-, but he was older, and he always had this tired aura around him. The kids noticed this; They were more observant than the adults, knew that he wasn't normal. Izuku tried desperately to find his old welcoming, friendly presence from his past life and on his really, really good days, it *did* come out if not only a little dimmer.

The adults never paid any mind to it after getting to know him (as much as he would let them. He wouldn't take any chances). They always ruled his introverted, slightly anxiety induced, personality to his incredibly high IQ. He tried his best to hide his intelligence at school in order to stay in the same grade and not intimidate the other students even further, but it was getting hard. School had just started for him again and he was already smarter than his past self. Not that he would ever believe it, though. No matter how many compliments Izuku got, it was never enough. *He* was never enough. He felt like he was lacking something that he had before, something that was missing from him.

He just couldn't remember.

The day he turned three he had begged his mom to let him join martial arts. As many styles as possible. He needed to gain muscle and surpass his skill from the last timeline; it wasn't enough from the last time.

Inko had been unsure -she hated the thought of her baby getting hurt, but once she saw the pure determination in her son's eyes, she just couldn't find it in herself to say no.

The teachers had been astounded by the pure skill Izuku had already possessed. He did everything they asked him to do, and if he couldn't do it the first time, he would keep on doing it until he mastered it. Two months in, and he was on the top level on multiple different styles and had took a special place in the hearts of his teachers. The sheer determination of the kid amazed the teachers and worried them at the same time.

"Are you sure you don't want to take a break?" Asked Asa-Sensei, the judo teacher.

"I... I'm sure." The panting didn't really convince the teacher, but she let it slide. He had been at it for hours without taking a break and she didn't want him to pass out from exhaustion.

Turns out, that's exactly what had happened. It nearly gave Asa a heart attack and she -along with his other teachers- would force him to take breaks from that point on.

It was scary how quickly the kid had wiggled into everyone's hearts.

"Kacchan?" The whole day Izuku was a bundle of nerves. They were outside in the park and were admiring Katsuki's quirk. It had manifested a few months ago, and tomorrow Izuku will be going to the doctor to see why his quirk was late.

Of course, he already knew the answer.

"Yeah, nerd?" Bakugou asked while looking away from his palms that were cackling with sparks.

"Let's say I was diagnosed as quirkless. Would you and I still be friends?" He had been dreading this the entire day, but Izuku *had* to ask. He needed too.

Kacchan drew in a breath, shocked at the question. For what seemed like forever they sat on the grass in silence. "You're not going to be quirkless, Izu. We're going to be the most powerful hero duo, remember? I'll be number one and you'll be number two, just like we talked about." This was all he needed for his question to be answered. He should've known that it was going to be the same, that Kacchan would think of him as useless and eventually push him away.

Izuku guessed he would just have to change that. He couldn't afford to loose Kacchan, he wouldn't even let it come across as a possibility. Not again.

"If I'm quirkless," He needed to word this correctly; he only had one chance at this, "I'll still be a hero, no matter what. Being quirkless doesn't mean useless, **Katsuki**. If I'm quirkless and you push me away, I'll just push harder, okay? I won't -I *can't* loose you to something as stupid as being quirkless." The use of Kacchan's first name had surprised both of them. Izuku had never used anything besides his nickname and frankly, he didn't want to call him anything else ever again.

The look on Bakugou's face almost made Izuku burst out into a fit in giggles, but he swallowed it down. He was scared to think what Katsuki would say next, if he was going to say anything at all. The silence was starting to make Izuku nervous and on edge.

"Whatever, damn nerd." Izuku smiled because Kacchan hadn't disagreed with him, and that was a win for him. Tomorrow, when he's diagnosed as quirkless, he'll make sure to prove to Bakugou that being quirkless doesn't mean being useless.

"Kacchan! You just used a no-no word!"

"Tch. Shut up, Izu!"

They both layed on the grass, tears of laughter escaping their eyes. Izuku knew tomorrow is the day a lot of things will change, the day where he was marked useless to society.

He'd just have to change their minds.

The next morning Izuku woke up in pain.

It felt like hundreds of thousands of needles were pricking at his skin every time flesh brushed against something. He could hear so many different heart beats, he heard every intake of breath of the people near him, he could even hear a cry for help in the distance. He could see things with so much detail now (he already had good eyesight), everything was just so much more detailed. He could smell his mom cooking breakfast; it was like he was smelling it upfront and not in entirely separate rooms. *It was too much*, it was overstimulating his brain and he didn't *know what to do.*

He was supposed to be quirkless.

How could this happen? This sensation of being overstimulated felt so familiar, and again, he just couldn't remember. Could it have been what the league did to him? He knows they did something, something to turn him into a monster. He was clutching his head with both of his hands and was in a fetal position. Why couldn't he remember what they did to him? He was so stupid, because he couldn't even remember *how* he went back in time. How did he do it? He knows that he was a monster, that *they* made him into a monster.

He heard a whisper in his head: *door*.

He immediately sat up, because that whisper just seemed oh so familiar to him. Sure enough, he heard his mom knock on the door not even five seconds later.

"Izuku?" She popped her head in and smiled at him, "Oh, good! You're awake! Happy birthday sweetie! I made you breakfast and then after that we can head to the doctors to get some information on your quirk. Sound good?"

He nodded with a bright smile and heard her footsteps -that seemed a lot louder now- moving away from him and realized that the pain was a lot more manageable now. He could still feel things painfully well, but everything was duller now.

It was like he had just gained control. It almost seemed like second nature in a weird way.

It confused Izuku, because whatever this was (He was *quirkless* -this couldn't be a quirk) is making perfect sense now. Izuku tried hard to focus on one thing, which he choose to be hearing. He closed his eyes and thought about hearing as many things and as far as possible.

It almost knocked the breath out of him at the intensity of it. It was *so much worse* then the first time. He heard the talking of people that *had* to be at least half a mile away from him. The breathing of people, some fast, some that were slowing bit by bit. He heard screams; screams of people having fun, screams of shock, *screams of pain and horror.*

Izuku snapped his eyes open and just like that, everything had dimmed once again. He rolled over and consequently fell out of his bed to which he quickly got back up onto his feet.

Maybe he didn't have as much control as he had thought.

Although he was still completely and utterly confused (admittedly a little scared), Izuku was able to get dressed. Although it was pretty uncomfortable with the fact that he felt every time the fabric brushed against his skin. He went downstairs to be greeted with a little too much food for it to be considered breakfast. It didn't help considering that his nervousness about seeing the 'doctor' made it seem impossible to eat. He didn't want to worry his mother though, so he ate his rice and miso soup along with some steamed vegetables. He had tried to eat some of the grilled fish, but couldn't bring himself to do that.

The plan was to go to the doctors and then visit the Bakugou family. He was exited about that, even though he would have to tell Kacchan that he was quirkless.

"Your son is quirkless."

The 'doctor' had said. *The doctor that had caused him so much pain.* He had tuned out the rest of the conversation, the conversation that was already engraved into his mind. Even though he already knew this was the case, it had still somewhat surprised him. By now, he had convinced himself that whatever had awakened this morning *was* a quirk. So why was he still diagnosed as quirkless?

As they said their goodbyes to the doctor, Izuku noticed how he glared at him. The man with glasses had a knowing look in his eyes. Izuku knew why he gave him this look, so in return Izuku gave the man a very subtle, but hate filled glare. The old man seemed shocked by this, and before Inko would notice, Izuku shot the guy a very innocent, childlike smile. It pleased the greenette at the dumbstruck look the man had adorned onto his face.

And with that, they walked off.

In the car, Inko was shooting her son worried looks. Expecting him to break down and cry, but he didn't. He didn't even seem surprised at the fact that he was quirkless.

"I'm sorry." The words had tumbled out of her mouth before she could even think about it, and she instantly regretted it. She just pulled up to the Bakugou's driveway and took this time to really look at her son. He had darker eye bags than last month, she quickly noted, and his shoulders were slightly hunched up and on guard. It was like he was *expecting* someone to come out and attack him at any second. Inko hated to admit it, but she was used to that by now. The only time when he truly relaxed was when he was with her and the Bakugou's. But even then, that was very rare.

She noticed how his eyes bored into hers. His eyes held a fierce ferocity to them, as if to say *don't you dare be sorry. I don't want it.*

"Don't be sorry, mom." And as if that explained everything (Which it did not! Inko thought exasperatedly) Izuku hopped out of his car seat and out the car. Inko followed, because what else was she supposed to do? This was not how she imagined her son to handle the news of being quirkless. She expected to have to cancel their meet up with Katsuki and having to hold Izuku in her arms as he cried.

But this was her son, and he was full of surprises.

"You're quirkless?!" Kacchan yelled out a little bit too loud for Izuku's taste. He couldn't help but wince, because it was only his first day with his hypersensitive/awareness. And maybe some sort of six sense? He'll focus on training it tomorrow. He just had to focus on this right now.

"Yup!" Perhaps he shouldn't have said it with that tone of carelessness, but it was true. *He didn't care.*

He never realized how upset Kacchan had been at his diagnosis, but now he did. Why didn't he know he wasn't the only one affected by the fact that he was quirkless last time? Why was he so selfish? Oh god, this was why Katsuki hated him. Because while he was wallowing in self-pity his best friend had to cope with the fact that their dreams of becoming the most powerful hero duo would be over. *Why was he so selfish?*

He saw Katsuki's eyes fill up with tears, and he *panicked*. He hated it when Kacchan cried, it just wasn't right. It wasn't him.

Waving his hand frantically in front of him, "That doesn't mean we can't still be the most powerful duo, Kacchan! It just means I'll have to work harder than everyone else. Please don't cry, because if you cry than I'll cry and you know when I cry I can't stop and *ohgodIhateitwhenyoucry*-" He would've have continued to mumble, but he was abruptly cut off.

"Shut up, stupid Deku." They had both froze at the nickname. Despite the attended meaning, it had brought a wave of calm over Izuku. He had finally gotten his name back, and it felt *really good.*

"Deku... I like it! It reminds me of the word 'dekiru' which means you can do it! Great idea Kacchan! I'll use that as my hero name." He said with a smile that had shocked Katsuki.

The coldness that adorned Katsuki's eyes made him flinch because he had *never* wanted to see that look pointed at him *ever again*.

And at that moment, Izuku knew that he might just loose his best friend again.

"Hey, Izuku? It's about time to get heading home. It's getting late and I want you to try to get at least some sleep tonight." Izuku was about to protest but his mom beat him to it, "Don't even try to hide it, mister. I know you haven't been getting enough sleep."

He sighed. Izuku really, really didn't want to worry his mother. He couldn't allow himself to be a burden. "Hey mom?" Izuku asked. He may not be able cure his nightmares, but he could try and stop Katsuki from leaving him.

His mom and Kacchan gave him both curious looks. "Can Kacchan and I meet up at the park tomorrow after lunch? We wanted to play heroes!" Izuku said with fake enthusiasm. He could practically feel the rage boiling off of Kacchan.

"Wha-?!"

"Of course you guys can! As long as Mitsuki is fine with it." Inko beamed.

Izuku grabbed onto his mother's hand and before he walked out of the door he said, "Really?! Thank you mom! See you tomorrow, Kacchan!"

He tried to ignore the glare that was burning his back.

Where is he?

Just a few minutes ago he was underneath his blankets and now... now he was in a very familiar cement cage and tied up in a very familiar metal chair.

Why was he here?! He shouldn't be here. Unless they somehow kidnapped him again. Unless they remember too and they came here to kill him. Shitshitshit-

Only he was back in his original seventeen year old body and not his four year old one. He had all of his scars back, and he could see new injuries that decorated his skin. He couldn't feel anything, though. He was numb.

His head snapped up to the sound of footsteps. The footsteps that he had always dreaded to hear. The sound that meant pain was coming. Pain and pain and pain.

He looked up to the person that caused this. Caused him to turn into a monster. Someone he should've looked up too was the person he hated second to himself.

"Today we'll be doing something... new." The familiarity of it was driving his insanity to the edge. What was he going to do? What *was he going to do?!*

The man reached his hand to Izuku's forehead and he couldn't get away. He was tied up and why was it getting so hard to breathe?!

When All For One touched his forehead, Izuku was meant with a blinding pain. A pain that was so much worse from the two weeks of torture that he had already endured. A silent scream escaped his mouth as he tried to endure it. Because that was all he could do.

Once the pain that felt like forever but couldn't have been more than a minute Izuku felt a different kind of pain. It was almost relieving because he knew what this pain was. The sensation of a thousand needles pricking his skin had invaded his senses. Along with the overwhelming sense of being able to hear and see everything. If he concentrated, Izuku could even taste the stale air mixed with dust.

His eyes looked up to the face of his enemy, "So you survived. Not many people can survive having a quirk forced into their body. Maybe you are useful after all." And then he left; leaving Izuku alone in a cell that he was way to familiar with as it was to him.

When he snapped his eyes open he was sweating profusely and the tears that escaped from his eyes couldn't be stopped no matter how many he wiped away.

But he remembered. He remembered this quirk, he remembered how he go it. He just didn't remember everything. He hoped someday he will, even if going through the torture again will be absolute hell.

He felt the fogginess that had been clouding his brain ever since he started his new life clear. If only a tiny bit. It was a footstep but it was *something.*

Even though Izuku was still tired, he gained an energy that he hadn't had in awhile. He would make it last, even if it was for only a tiny bit.

Chapter End Notes

There's chapter two! I hope everyone liked it. I'm sorry if this chapter was kind of slow. The next chapter will hopefully be more exiting for everyone.

By the way, I'm going to try to update at least once every week. I'll make sure my update schedule is somewhat regular.

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

The Weight of A Promise

Chapter Summary

Katsuki and Izuku get to hang out.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku was walking by himself to the park to meet Kacchan. His mother let him go by himself since the park was only two blocks away and knew he was going to be safe.

Step by step. Breath by breath. Each *blink* Izuku took his anxiety only seemed to climb higher and higher. Yet he *knew* that it wasn't from meeting up with his friend; no... it felt a lot more sinister. Izuku urged his tiny legs to walk faster because the sooner he was with Katsuki, the sooner he would be safe from this lurking dread.

And he was so, *so* close. He could even see Bakugou's bushy ash blond hair (and even though he was still half a block away he could still see it with such detail) not to far away.

But then he heard a scream off in the distance. It was filled with so much agony that Izuku didn't even think about how his legs sped up, passing the park. He briefly wondered if Kacchan had seen him but brushed the thought away because it didn't matter. *Someone was in pain* and even though he was only four, he'd be damned if he didn't try to help. He kept running to the sound of the scream and the breathing that was ever so slowing. He ran, even though his lungs burned and his legs ached, he wouldn't stop. *Couldn't* stop. When he finally made it to the secluded area, he just stood there. He couldn't hear the women's breathing anymore. *Why wasn't she breathing?!* He hadn't made it in time, he couldn't save yet *another* person.

There, slumped against a wall was a women in a business suit. She had dark purple hair up in what used to be a tight bun. It looked liked all the energy was sucked out of her. The women's skin was grey and all shriveled up like a flower sapped of it's water. Her abdomen had a hole in it and the blood was seeping through her suit. There was so much blood. *How could someone bleed this much?! Why couldn't I save her?! Why why why?!* Her eyes were open, staring at the wall in front of her. Her lavender eyes were dull, so dull. No trace of life inside of them. It was to late. *ToLateToLateToLate-*

Izuku screamed.

Izuku stared blankly at the ceiling. He wished his bed could swallow him and only let him out until things were okay again. Until *he* was okay again. He just wanted to forget, but he didn't *know* what he wanted to forget. His past life? How he became a monster? No, that wasn't it. He didn't want to forget the other time. He needed it, it was apart of him. Izuku wouldn't be whole without it. The women with the dead eyes? How he couldn't save her, or anyone else for that matter?

Or was it that he just wanted to forget himself?

He couldn't help but think that that would be nice, even if it was only for a second.

Izuku could hear his mother's concerned voice talking to Auntie Matsuki and Kacchan. He knew he could probably listen on to the conversation if he wanted too, but he didn't. When one of the police officers walked him home after the whole ordeal, his mother had been terrified. After he was in the safety of the home she hugged him while he had just stood there, unblinkingly.

His mother wanted Mitsuki (probably for her own comfort) and Kacchan to come over. Izuku felt bad for ditching Katsuki, and wanted to make it up to him. He knew he probably shouldn't feel guilty, but he was afraid this was only going to mess up there already straining relationship.

Izuku continued to stare at the wall when he heard a knock on the door. He knew immediately that it was Kacchan since it was like he was lightly punching the door instead of actually knocking on it.

"Come in." His voice was only above a whisper since it hurt to talk normally due to his screaming not even two hours ago. Izuku felt the door creak open and then shut close. Izuku couldn't help but flinch when he felt the light dip in his bed, but forced himself to relax. He stiffened once again when he was forcibly rolled over to his side into a tight hug.

This time, Izuku had hugged back. Hugs from Katsuki were rare, but were always the best. He had seemed to always know when he needed one, and Izuku was grateful for that.

"Listen, nerd. I have no idea what happened since the old hag and Auntie Inko didn't tell me anything, but I know it was bad." He felt the hug tighten ever so slightly, forcing Izuku to hide his head in Bakugou's chest. "And even though I'm still mad at you, I'll let today slide. Got it, Deku? After you get over this, I'll just resume to being mad at you, so don't think you're off the hook." At the use of his old hero name, Izuku began to cry. Fisting Katsuki's shirt into his small hands.

"It's... It's not <u>fair</u>." Izuku whimpered, already feeling guilty about the forming wet spot on Kacchan's shirt. "It's not fair, Kacchan." He felt Bakugou stiffen- he probably thought he was talking about being quirkless-, "I could've saved her, but... but I wasn't fast enough." He was sobbing now, and he couldn't stop. "M-Maybe I-if I

was faster than I could've stopped it, but it was already *too late.* Kacchan, why was I so slow? Why couldn't I *save her?* There was *so* much blood and her eyes didn't hold the sparkles like our's do. *It's not fair.*"

He knew Kacchan probably didn't fully understand what he was talking about, after all, he was only four. But Katsuki was smart, so he wouldn't be surprise if he did actually understand.

"S' not your fault." The softness of his voice caught him off guard. He had never heard that tone of voice come from his friend before. Izuku could only nod. He wasn't sobbing anymore, but he hadn't stop crying, either. Izuku didn't think he could if he tried.

They laid there until Izuku cried himself to sleep. Katsuki just held him, because he didn't know what else he could do. His mind couldn't comprehend what his best friend (yes, best friend) had seen. A selfish part of him *didn't want to know* because he had never seen Deku so sad before. Sure, the nerd always had a quiet, older air to him then the other kids did, but he knew Izuku. He knew that even though he almost always flinched at unexpected sounds or contact, and he found it hard to trust others, Katsuki knew there was another side to him. A side that only his family and auntie got to see. When the kid was brighter, almost putting the sun to shame, and when he could talk your ear off with his habit of muttering. Yes, Bakugou *knew* Izuku just as well as he knew Kacchan. Heck, sometimes he thought Deku knew him better than he knew himself.

Today had scared him. When he walked into Deku's room to find him just staring at his ceiling with that blank stare, it worried him. Not that he would ever admit that, of course. He wouldn't admit that he hated that look that Izuku had adorned on his face, and he hated that he didn't know what he should do. He didn't know what happened, but Katsuki knew it wasn't good. The explosion quirk-user knew that Izuku loved hugs, so he did just that.

It wasn't until Deku sobbed those words. He thought it was about him being quirkless. He wished it was, because this was *so* much worse. Katsuki didn't understand some of it -and he had a feeling that Izuku didn't explain all of it- but he knew that someone had died, and Izuku saw it. Or, at least the body. Bakugou had hated how the greenette blamed himself for not being able to save the person he was talking about. Because he knew that even *he* couldn't have saved them.

Again, it scared him. It scared him because he realized just how delicate that bright and sunny side of his best friend was. He was terrified that that side might get lost forever in a dark abyss. He didn't want that to happen. He couldn't let that happen. Because when Izuku let that side of him shine, that's when Izuku let himself be *truly* happy. And even though Katsuki was still mad at him for accepting being quirkless so easily while he was devastated, he still wanted Izuku to be happy. Izuku was right, it wasn't *fair*. Izuku didn't deserve this, he was far too nice and gentle. Why do the kindest of hearts always seem to break first?

"I'll protect you. I promise, Izu." It was a promise that he didn't know himself how to keep, but he would be damned to break it. It was the only thing that reassured him enough that everything will be okay in the end. He let himself fall asleep to that promise.

He didn't know how, but he would protect his best friend, no matter the costs.

Izuku woke up in a panic. He felt confined, but safe. It didn't matter if he felt safe, though, because he was trapped and he had no idea why. The images from his nightmare came back to him like bolts of lightning. His dead friends, teachers, villains, his mom, the business women, and Kacchan. He let out a petrified scream and shoved whatever it was that was trapping him off of him.

It landed with a thud off of his bed with a "What the hell?!". Izuku carefully looked over the edge of the bed to meet with angry ruby eyes. He sighed in relief because he was not trapped in a metal chair and his friends were not bleeding out (he tried to ignore the eyes of the women. The first one he couldn't save in this life).

Izuku snapped his head to the door after looking at Katsuki's angered and confused expression. His mother stepped in not too long after and gave him a look of concern. "Izuku, are you alright? I heard a scream." His mom could not know that he had screamed because it was just another one of his night terrors. She couldn't know that he wasn't getting any better and that he had lied to her.

Izuku flashed her a bright smile and lied through his teeth, "Yup! Kacchan and I were just telling spooky stories to cheer me up, and one was supperrr," He expanded his arms out to exaggerate, "scary. I just couldn't help but scream. Sorry if I worried you."

Inko sent her son a small smile, but her eyebrows were still furrowed in worry, "Okay, honey. Dinner should be ready in a couple more minutes, I'll call you guys down when it's ready."

"Okay mommy!" Inko smiled once more and left the room. Midoriya let out a small sigh of relief and then turned to Bakugou. "I'm so sorry I pushed you off the bed, Kacchan! I woke up and I didn't know where I was for a second and I kinda felt trap so I pushed you off the bed and I'm so sorry. Please don't be mad, I mean- I understand if you are mad anyone would be mad if they just suddenly get pushed off of a bed with no warning-!"

"Shut up, Deku! I'm not mad, just... shocked." Katsuki muttered.

"Really? I'm glad you're not mad!" Izuku beamed at him, hoping he wouldn't question the lie he had just told his mother. Izuku couldn't help but hate himself because lying these days was almost as easy as breathing and he hated that.

Of course, fate was never kind to him.

"Why did you lie to Auntie Inko?" Kacchan suddenly blurted out. Izuku paled; he *really* didn't want to tell Kacchan about his night terrors. What if he started to think that Midoriya was some kind of freak? Someone not worthy of his friendship.

He already wasn't worthy.

"I just didn't want to worry her. I think me being quirkless is already enough to be worried about. Especially if I still want to be a hero." He knew how much he burdened her during the last time, to the point where she got sick a couple of times. He never, *ever* wanted her to get sick because of him ever again.

Katsuki gave him a skeptical look -he knew that Izuku was avoiding the details of the reason this whole situation even started. He let it slide though, since he wanted to talk to Deku about something far more important. "Why do you still want to be a hero? You're quirkless." It made him angry that Izu still wanted to be a hero; he's just going to get hurt, or worse. Bakugou tried to shake that thought away but it only made him angrier.

Izuku smiled at him. During their second year at U.A. Katsuki changed for the better after some therapy and apologized for the years of torment. Midoriya, of course, told him he forgave him a long time ago (although he still had nightmares of those words and explosions, but he chose to ignore that). All Izuku wanted to know was why he had bullied him for so long. For the longest time Izuku thought it was for only one reason: He was quirkless. But the truth ran way deeper than he had expected. Kacchan begrudgingly admitted that he didn't want Izuku to become a hero only to get killed because he was quirkless. So, Katsuki did the only thing he could think of doing that might stop him. Was it right to do that? No, of course not, but knowing the *real* reason gave Izuku a sense of long-needed closure. After that day, him and Katsuki became to two sides of the same coin. It took awhile to gain back the trust that had been lost, but they overcame that. It was one of the best memories Izuku had of that time.

"It's okay, Kacchan. I won't die. Like I said before, I'll just have to work harder than everyone else. So don't worry, K?" Izuku was shocked to see that Kacchan had tears running down his tears. He felt really guilty now, he didn't mean to make Bakugou cry.

Katsuki hated when he was sad, he didn't know how to deal with it. So instead he took all that sadness and turned it into anger. "Stupid, idiotic Deku! Who said I was worried about you, I couldn't care less if you died or not. Damnit, I hate you." His voice began as a shout but by the end, it had turned into a rasped whisper.

Izuku enveloped Katsuki in a hug. Bakugou tried to push him off at first, but eventually gave up. "You don't hate me, Kacchan. I'm sorry I made you mad, but I mean it. I'm still going to be a hero, and we'll still be best friends." He stated it as if it was the simplest fact, and in a sense, it was. He is going to become a hero, and Kacchan and him will remain friends. And that's that.

"Why are you taking this so easily? Shouldn't you be devastated that you'll never obtain some cool quirk?" They stopped hugging each other now and were sitting cross legged in front of each other.

"Kacchan... People aren't created equal. That's life." Izuku paused to think if he really wanted to say what he was going to talk about next. He decided he *didn't*, but would have too. "Which brings me to something else. Can we make a deal?"

Katsuki smirked at him, "You know I'm not one to back down on deals, nerd."

"I know, I know. But this one is different, and won't make sense. Probably not until you're older." Bakugou wanted to make a snarky comment about how Deku just called him stupid, but held back from the serious look in his friend's eyes.

"I'm sure. Now just spit it out already."

Izuku gulped. He hated this, but it would protect Kacchan. "Ignore me at school. Heck, you don't even have to act friendly to me. Just whatever you do, don't say we're friends, act like we're friends, or even *imply* we're friends. We can hang out anywhere outside of school just as long the other kids don't see us."

Katsuki had a hard time hiding his surprise -which quickly turned into anger, "So you're embarrassed to be around me now, Nerd?! Asking me to avoid you and crap. That's pretty low."

Izuku felt and looked absolutely horrified at this, "W-what?! No, Of course not! In fact... never mind." He didn't want to tell Kacchan that he should be the one embarrassed to be around him, "You just have to trust me, K'? I can't tell you why because than you won't listen. You'll benefit from this, promise."

Bakugou wanted to ask him how in the hell he would benefit from not talking to his best friend, but Izuku was smart. Smarter than him (not that he'd ever admit that out loud!), so he knew that the green haired boy had to have some reason behind this idiotic request.

"Fine. Just as long as we get to hang out after school." Katsuki muttered that last sentence, not wanting to admit that he actually *liked* to spend time with Deku.

Izuku didn't was to tell Kacchan that adults could be cruel and kids could be even crueler. If the children at his school found out that him and Kacchan were still friends after he was declared quirkless, well... That won't go down so well. He doesn't want other kids to avoid Kacchan because they were still friends. No, that's the last thing he wanted. So that's why he'll go through the years of torment all over again. Alone. And yes, he could probably beat up all the kids this time, but he didn't see the point. He's gone through it once, he can do it again.

He just hopes that Kacchan will never find out.

Midoriya smiled at Katsuki, "Thanks, Kacchan! That means a lot to me!" Izuku took a quick sniff of the air and silently winced. The amount of smells that invaded his nostrils made him slightly nauseas, but he was getting better at controlling it. If only slightly. "Dinner's ready." Izuku announced and started to walk towards the door only to stop and wait for Bakugou.

"And how do you know, Deku?!" Katsuki yelled as he a walked -more liked marched- towards the door.

Izuku smirked, "I just do!" And walked out of the room with Kacchan in toe.

"Tch. Damn, nerd."

Chapter End Notes

Lol. I am not going to say sorry for causing Izuku pain. Never.

Okay, but I just love this chapter! It was super fun writing with all the angst and some fluff mixed on well. I hoped everyone like it as well!

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

The Purpose of a Friend

Chapter Summary

Katsuki finds out about something that Izuku tried so hard to hide.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Where did you get all of those bruises, Deku?" It's been six months since Izuku was declared quirkless again and five months since the bullying has started. Izuku thought that ignoring the words would be easy -it was easy for him last time so why should he be having a harder time now? He remembered that in his last life, he had a lot more difficulty getting over the punches that were thrown at him than the cruel words that people had spit at him. The punches were no big deal, in fact, they distracted him from the whirlwind that was beginning to form in his mind.

Perhaps it was because he was a lot more optimistic and cheerful last time than he was now. He never believed them when they told him that he was *worthless, useless, a waste of space.* But now... It was harder. Sure, he had been telling himself how useless he was for awhile now, but when you actually *hear* it from other people it makes it seem so much more real and true.

So yes, he was struggling, but he was doing okay and that was the truth. He had his mom and Kacchan to help him get through it even if they didn't know they were. Izuku tried to cheer himself up when the words got to him a little too much by thinking that he had almost mastered his new quirk. All of his senses were always slightly enchanted now so he could always be alert. Izuku still gets shocked by the sheer intensity of it when he chooses to focus his quirk on a single sense at full power, but he was slowly getting used to it. He hardly ever focused solely on his hearing unless he absolutely he had to. The screams he would hear just became *too much* especially since he knew there was nothing he could do about it.

He hasn't told anyone about this quirk, not even his mother. He knew that this wasn't normal, and could scare people. This could mean he might be experimented on and Midoriya didn't think he could go through that again.

"Hey, Nerd?! Are you even listening to me?!" Kacchan and him were at the park when Katsuki noticed some of the bruises that adorned Izuku's arms. Something he had tried so hard to hide.

"Oh! Sorry Kacchan. I guess I spaced out. What were you saying?" Izuku knew that Katsuki hated the promise that they made half a year ago, and that he was slowly losing his patience. Izuku really wanted to keep him from finding out about the truth behind the bruises, but it was only a matter of time and he knew it.

"I said where the hell did you get those bruises!"

Izuku frantically waved his hands through the air and looked anywhere but Katsuki, a bad habit when he was lying. "Oh you know! I was just being my clumsy self. Nothing to worry about!" Izuku internally winced at how obvious the lie was and just hoped that Bakugou would let go.

Of course, he didn't, "Stop lying, idiot. You're not even good at it... most of the time. And who said I was worried! I'm just wondering..." Izuku saw Kacchan's eyes widen before he spoke (more like yelled) again, "Don't tell me someone is doing this to you?! Just tell me who and I'll beat them to a pulp!"

"N-no one did this to me I s-swear! It doesn't matter anymore." He tried desperately to make Kacchan forget about this and move onto something else, but he knew that Katsuki wasn't going to let it go no matter how much he wanted him to.

"Izu why aren't you telling me the truth? Do you not trust me anymore?"

Izuku gasped at the statement and frantically shook his head, "W-what? No, of course not! Kacchan, I trust you with my life!" Some things were just better left unsaid, that's all.

"Then why aren't you telling me the truth?" Izuku was now at a lost for words. Bakugou had him backed in to a corner with no way out. He just stood there, refusing to tell the truth because he couldn't risk his friend's reputation over his own selfishness. There's no way. "Tch. Fine, don't talk to me until you tell me the truth." Izuku could only desperately watch as his only friend turned around and walked away from him.

Izuku reached an arm out towards him, but what was the point? Kacchan wasn't going to talk to him until Izuku told him the truth and that was not going to happen no matter what. Maybe their friendship would always be cracking during this time no matter how he tried to change it. Maybe... This was for the best.

"I'm sorry, Kacchan."

Today was a horrible day.

Kacchan found out.

It had been a month after their fight and neither of them have talked since then. The bullying had expectingly gotten worse and the kids were pushing it by doing things to him in the classroom now and not where nobody would notice. They must've figured out that even the teachers didn't care what happened to the quirkless kid and the cruel kids took full advantage of that.

It was the end of the school day and he and Kacchan were the only ones in the classroom since they had to clean up. They of course, didn't acknowledge each other the whole time. They were just beginning to pack up when Izuku's main tormentors came into the classroom. Izuku visibly tensed up and started to pack up faster.

He had just slung his yellow backpack over his shoulders when they called him out. Izuku notice how Katsuki slowed down his packing probably because he sensed the tension in the air. Midoriya cursed his luck, why did Kacchan have to be here out of all times?

"Well if it isn't quirkless little Deku." The leader of the group, Craig, said.

Izuku just ignored them and tried to walk past them with his head down. He was close, too, but when his quirk whispered to him that a hit was coming Izuku knew that he would be coming home with new bruises. Bruises that were starting to get really hard to hide from his mother.

The time traveler forced himself to ignore his instincts and not dodge since that would only make them angrier. A few seconds later, he was falling and hit the ground with a thud. He held in a groan when his shoulder met the brute of the impact. The worse was that he knew that Kacchan was still there. He knew that Kacchan found out the secret he tried so hard to hide from him. All that hard work and pain had gone to waste.

"You really are useless, aren't you?" Benjiro stated as if it was a pure, well known fact. He kicked Izuku's stomach a few times before he suddenly just... stopped.

Izuku looked up from his fetal position to see Benjiro on the ground holding his cheek with tears in his eyes. He slowly moved his head to see Katsuki giving all of them a death glare with his fists clenched.

"Get out of my sight or die!" He heard Kacchan scream at them and then the scurrying of his bullies feet running out of the room.

Right now, Izuku was having a hard time focusing on anything but the pain in his stomach. Benjiro had really upped his game with the beating because damn, his stomach really hurt. If only he had the same level of pain tolerance as his last life; he guessed he'd just have to work on that.

Midoriyas noticed Kacchan come over to him and he felt himself get lift up as Katsuki started to carry him on his back. God, Izuku was so tired. This month he had hardly gotten any sleep. The stress of the argument

with Bakugou only added fuel to his nightmares preventing him from getting little to no sleep.

He woke up a while later in his room to someone gently pushing him. He opened his eyes to only meet Kacchan's red ones. The explosion quirk user had a really serious expression on his face and Izuku could feel the dread settling in for the upcoming conversation.

Izuku sat up on his bed while letting out a wince as the action sent a jolt of pain in his stomach. Once he was situated, he took a deep breath and looked at Kacchan who hadn't said anything the whole time.

"Why... Why wouldn't you tell me you were getting bullied?" Izuku knew that Bakugou was desperate for an answer, he deserved one.

"I have multiple reasons. Y-you just wouldn't understand." The green haired boy answered in barely above a whisper.

"I won't understand unless you tell me, idiot!" Bakugou snapped.

"I didn't want to ruin your reputation, okay!" Izuku cried out. There was no point in hiding it anymore, so might as well get it out.

"W-what?" He could tell that Kacchan was shocked and didn't really blame him. Katsuki probably just thought it was a stupid reason, but it wasn't. Not to Izuku.

"Imagine if the kids at school found out that *the* Bakugou Katsuki was best friends with a pathetic quirkless kid? They'd turn on you, that's what! They'll bully you like they bully me. It might not be as much as physical, but sometimes the words hurt more than the punches ever will. Trust me, Kacchan, you need a good reputation and lots of friends for your confidence of becoming a hero to be strong and unbreakable. You need all of the support you can get because the more you have, the stronger your path to becoming a hero will get. *That's* why I couldn't tell you. Because no matter how much I want to be selfish and tell you about all the things they say and do, I *can't*. I can't burden you." By the end Izuku was out of breath and his emotions were all over the place. He prayed that Katsuki would understand what he just said and continue on with the deal they had made.

"I *wish* you were selfish!" That had shocked Izuku. Him being selfish never turned out good, and it never will. "Maybe we can tell a teacher, or what about auntie? She'd know what to do!"

Izuku almost felt sorry for Katsuki, but also slightly relieved. Kacchan still had a mind of a child; meaning his problem solving was simple and uncomplicated. He didn't know the complications that came with living in this world just yet, and that wasn't good nor was it bad.

"Kacchan, you don't understand. There's no way the teachers would believe me. They'd probably blame me and say that I was 'provoking them' or that it's 'Just teasing'. Because as much as they try to hide it, I know they don't care about me. They could care less about what happened to me. And my mom is out the question. I don't want to burden her more than I already am." Izuku let out a sigh at Katsuki's expression. It was a look of total disbelief and denial. Izuku had to remind himself that Bakugou has just only turned five and probably hasn't heard of discrimination let alone *know* what it is. "Kacchan, I'm fine, really. Just forget this day ever happened and let's just go back to our deal, okay?"

Katsuki frantically shook his head and stomped a foot on the ground. Izuku felt a wave of anger develop in him because Kacchan was *not listening* to him. Couldn't he see that he was *fine*? Couldn't he just let this go, just this once? Well, apparently not.

"I won't go back to that so called 'deal' we made, damn nerd. Why would I want to be friends with them extras anyways? They're all fakes." Katsuki's tone made it final. He was not going to change his mind no matter what Izuku said.

No. This couldn't be happening. He couldn't let his only friend get bullied, too. Izuku was so frustrated, why couldn't he do anything right? All he wanted was to not burden someone for once, but here he was, putting unnecessary weight on his friend's shoulders.

Izuku didn't even realize he was crying until he felt a teardrop hit his hand. He hardly ever cried anymore; Izuku has learned that when people see you cry, they label you as someone who is fragile and weak, so he's tried his hardest to stop crying. But sometimes the tears slip by unnoticed until it's too late to stop them.

"P-please Kacchan. I-I can't let them hurt you. You're one of the most important people to me and I can't burden you. *God*, I'm so sorry. I'm pretty weak, aren't I?" He wiped his face with his hands, trying to will the tears to stop falling, but they wouldn't stop. They just kept falling and falling and falling and they wouldn't stop.

"You really think so lowly of me, Deku?" Izuku snapped his head up to face Bakugou. Had he really implied it like that? "Those kids are probably to scared to even *think* about hurting me let alone actually doing it. It's pretty rude of you too think of me so low."

"Kacchan! I'm so so sorry! I didn't mean to imply it like that, honest! You're the strongest person I know, and I didn't mean to be rude. I'm super sorry!"

"I wasn't finished nerd, and stop saying sorry."

"Sor-"

"Stop! Don't you know how to listen, or are you deaf?! And stop saying you're burdening me like it's a fact. You're not burdening me or bothering me so stop saying you are. If you're bothering me, I'll tell you. And you're not weak. You seem to forget that you take martial art classes four times a week."

At this, Izuku's tears stopped flowing and it was replaced with a rare blinding smile. He never thought to ask Kacchan what he thought about the 'deal' they made. Izuku assumed that it would be for the best. Turns out, it wasn't. Midoriya still felt the weight of the guilt for letting Kacchan find out though. No matter what Katsuki said, there will always be a place in his mind that would think that he is a burden.

"Thank you, Kacchan. I needed that."

"Yeah, whatever. Now get some rest, Nerd. You look like you haven't slept in forever. And if you're wondering, Auntie isn't home. Probably at work."

Just as Kacchan was about to leave, Izuku called out, "Wait! How about we have a sleepover today? My mom is making Zara soba for dinner." The mention of the cold soba dish made his mind flashback to both good and bad memories of a friend with a cruel life. A friend that he should've helped more.

"Tch, sure."

It was two weeks after Kacchan found out and Izuku was sitting on the swings all alone. The clouds were setting in, threatening to devour the only warmth Izuku had. Katsuki had the flu and wasn't aloud to come to school today. That just meant his so called peers had no restraints to hold back. No one ever bullied Katsuki after they found out he was still friends with Izuku. But they weren't exactly friendly, either. No one talked to him unless they had too and the guilt was slowly eating away at Izuku.

It didn't seem to bother the explosion user, though. He seemed like he kind of enjoyed never being bothered anymore. Midoryia knew that he must've at least miss the praise he got, so he tried his best to always bring confidence to his friend. Just not to an insufferable amount like last time. Not only that, but Kacchan helped ward off the bullies that had haunted him. That didn't mean it totally stopped, though.

So here he was, sitting on a swing with a bruised face and shattered heart. It was times like these when he realized just how truly alone he was. No one knows what Izuku knows and no one has ever gone through what he has. No one will know the real him; no one will ever fully understand him. Izuku clenched the chains of the swing until he feels his skin break. He squeezes his eyes shut as if to will the loneliness out of him.

"I have a gift for you, son."

"You will be the perfect puppet."

"Can you promise to save me in the next life?"

"I love you."

"And what are you doing out here all alone?" Izuku snaps his eyes open and is meant with very familiar blue eyes. Just seeing his bright eyes filled with kindness bring a sense of home in Izuku. He's exactly as he remembers, if not only a little younger and more *alive*. He's in his original form, with his face slightly sunken but not as bad as before, and his blond hair was slowly dancing in the wind.

Izuku wants to hug him and never let go but he knows he can't. He doesn't know him yet and won't for another nine and a half years.

"Just a bad day as all." Izuku says as Yagi takes a seat on the other swing next to him.

"That's perfectly normal. I have bad days from time to time as well. May I ask what your name is?" His voice was calm and reassuring, just like it had always been.

"I-Izuku Midoriya. It's a pleasure to meet you."

"It's a pleasure to meet you as well, young Midoryia." Oh how Izuku missed that name, "My name is Yagi Toshinori."

They sat in peaceful silence. Izuku couldn't believe how lucky he was to finally be able to meet the person he looked up to like a father this early on. Maybe he had a chance at warning him about his battle. That's the least he could do after all the amazing chances Yagi had given him.

"Hey, Toshinori-San? Is it okay if I tell you something that will make absolute no sense but might help you later on?"

"I'm all ears."

"Okay. Umm... Just promise me when you go up against the one you fear most. Please, *please* don't shoulder the weight of doing it by yourself. Ask for help. It's okay to do that sometimes." Izuku silently berated himself for being such a hypocrite.

Toshinori looked slightly startled and apprehensive, "Young Midoryia, I'm afraid I have no idea what you're talking about."

Midoryia smiles and hops off his swing, "It's okay, you don't have too. Just promise me you'll think about what I said, alright?" Yagi stood up and slowly nodded. This time Izuku didn't hold back and ran up to the man's leg and hugged him. "It was truly nice met you, Toshinori-San. I hope I'll get to see you again someday. Stay safe." And with that, Izuku reluctantly walked away and didn't even dare look back.

He just hoped that All Might had listened to him.

End of arc one: New beginnings.

Chapter End Notes

Arc one is done! This will probably be the shortest arc in this story. Did you guys like the introduction of All Might?

I absolutely adore this chapter, and I hoped you guys liked it as well. I am so grateful for each an everyone of you and I forever will be.

I hope everyone has/had a good day!

Torn Apart

Chapter Summary

It’s Izuku’s fifth birthday.

Stuff happens.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The sky was a piece of art. Stroked with pinks, oranges, reds and purples. The beautiful colors were caressing the faces of the two inseparable best friends. Everything that happened that day had been perfect, nothing had went wrong (Izuku ignores the feeling that it was too perfect. That someone like *him* should find it impossible to have such a wonderful day like this one.)

"Happy birthday, Izu." They had spent the entire day together, that was all Izuku had wanted for his fifth birthday. The day had been full of laughter and smiles and everything had just felt so *light*. Izuku couldn't remember the last time he felt like this, like his old self. He had to remind himself not to get lost in it because as soon as he's alone, this feeling will be wiped away from him (but is it really that bad? To get lost in the feeling of happiness? Izuku tells himself that, yes, it is bad.)

Katsuki couldn't believe how his friend shined. He's seen how Izuku sometimes let's out that delicate light of his, but he never knew that Izuku could put the sun to shame. Today, Deku was nothing like that anxiety-ridden boy who flinched at anything too sudden. Today, he acted like he should. A child. Izuku talked Katsuki's ear off but it was nothing like his worry-induced muttering. As much as it made him happy to see his best friend (only friend) like this, it also saddened him. He worried about when the next time he would be able to see Izuku like this, or if this might be the first and last time.

"Thank you, Kacchan, for hanging out with me. You're the best!" They were just walking out of the park to Inko's house where they were to have yet another sleepover. They talked about staying up the whole night eating junk food and watching hero movies, but both secretly knew that they wouldn't make it pass midnight. Couldn't stop them from trying, though.

Over the months, the two had become closer than ever. They hardly ever separated unless they absolutely had too. They always knew when the other was upset even when they tried to hide it. They were each others comfort against the unknown. They knew each other, though, and they knew that they would never leave the other behind. It was an unspoken promise between the two. Never having to be said, never having to be talked about. They were enough to each other and will always be.

Katsuki blushed, "Yeah, whatever. It's not like I had anything else to do." Izuku laughed, but it was quickly silenced by his quirk telling him something bad was about to happen. The soft prickling up his neck the clear

indicator. He quickly looks around and sets his eyes upon a tall man. He had black hair that just passed his shoulders and ice cold blue eyes. This man immediately sent off alarms inside Izuku's head. He needed to get out. Grab Kacchan and run. Run far, far away from the man. He just had to move and go somewhere safe. Somewhere with people. *They had to leave!*

"Kacchan." The explosion user glances at Izuku and tenses. Midoryia's face is calm and relaxed, but his eyes scream panic. "Let's go somewhere else, okay? My marital arts dojo is close and I've been meaning to take you there."

His voice left no room for argument, "Yeah... Seem's like fun."

And Just like that, Izuku grabbed his arm in a death grip and told him to *run*. The man was slowly walking towards them, with his aura darkening into something dark and malicious. As they were running, Izuku suddenly loses feelings in his body and falls to the ground dragging Katsuki with him.

It was the man's quirk, Izuku soon realizes. His mouth was full of grass and he's pretty sure he twisted an ankle, but Katsuki was unaffected. *His quirk must only be allowed to effect one person at a time.*

The man sent him a bone chilling smirk and Katsuki was frozen in place as fear slowly took over him. "Kacchan, run!" When Katsuki didn't listen to him, Izuku only screamed louder. The man was so close. "Are you deaf?! Run! I'll be okay, I promise. I'll find you again."

"Deku." Kacchan got up and ran. He was too weak. That man... Katsuki knew he didn't stand a chance against him. So he ran, hoping against all the bad that he could get help in time. "I'll save you Izuku! I promise, I will always save you!" Bakugou had screamed with all his might. Everything would be alright. It had to be.

By the time Katsuki had came back with a hero, they were gone.

This couldn't be happening again.

Stuck in the back of a black truck, not being able to see anything. The man had put quirk canceling cuffs on him, so all of his enchanted senses had gone back to what they used to be. The cuffs were digging into his wrists, making them bleed, but the pain didn't faze him at all. All Izuku could do was to keep track on how long it had been since he was pulled back into this nightmare. How far he was getting away from Kacchan.

He tried his hardest to ignore the flashbacks, or how his breathing was getting faster the more his thinks about what was happening.

The black van with scratched nail marks from past victims. The feeling of total uselessness. Not being able to see anything. The overwhelming sense of total and complete loneliness.

"I promise I will always save you!"

Kacchan... Katsuki was safe. He had promised to save him and just those words alone meant the world to him, even if the probability of him being saved by a five year old was low. But those words brought hope to Izuku that he could make it out of this. No matter how long it took him, no matter what happened to him, he *will* escape. He promises himself that he will reunite with Bakuguo some day, even if he forgets about him. Izuku wouldn't care because Katsuki is everything to him, he is his lifeline. Because no matter what, Izuku will... he will always-

Midoryia suddenly topples over when the truck comes to an abrupt stop. Izuku can't help but think that whoever kidnapped him was pretty stupid since they were only ninety-five minutes away from Musutafu. Hero's could easily track him down at this distance, but Izuku knew that these were just false hopes. That there had to be something else that would make it harder to find him.

He shuddered when he thinks of the man's icy eyes and menacing aura. This man was not to be taken lightly and even without his quirk telling him, Izuku knew that things were just going to get harder from here on out.

The doors to the van are busted open and Izuku is momentarily blinded by artificial light. He isn't given the time to adjust because he is harshly pulled out of the van and falls to the cement ground. By the earthy smell, Izuku knows that they are underground which will only make it that much harder to find him (Izuku thinks hero's shouldn't waste their time trying to save him when there are a lot more people out there worth saving more than him).

The man grabs him by his hair and forces Izuku to his knees. The time traveler tries with all of his might to keep a calm facade, and so far, It's working. Even when the kidnapper puts a blind fold over his green eyes and forces him to stand up by his hair -he doesn't even wince, let alone show his rising panic.

The man pushes him roughly and drags him somewhere. They stop for a moment when Izuku hears another set of footsteps.

"Is this the new kid, Keres?" What sounds like a women with a deep voice questions.

"Yup. The profile says he's quirkless, but I didn't want to take any chances. The little bitch hasn't even cried out yet." It sounded like he was stating a challenge to Izuku. Like he couldn't wait to see just how long it would take for him to *break*.

To bad he was already broken.

"Oh, I'm sure he'll crack soon. Young ones tend to do it earlier. Who's he caging with?"

"Boss said to cage him with that fuckin' creepy kid." Whoever this kid was, the man clearly didn't like him.

"That outta be interesting. Ya' think the kid's going to kill him before he even gets a chance?" Not something Izuku is practically worried about, but not something he's going to brush off.

"Nah. Kid's smart enough to know he'll be punished for that. After our shift do you want to have another one of our... sessions?" Izuku tries his best to not think about what "sessions" mean, but it's pretty clear to how Keres's voice gets deeper as he says it.

Ew.

"Whatever. I'll meet you at our normal spot." He hears her footsteps start top walk off and than Izuku is shoved once again. It takes about five minutes until the man pushes him to the ground and takes the blind fold off as long as the chain connecting the cuffs. To his disappointment though, the cuffs stay on.

The man walks out of the cage and shuts the door, "Welcome to the Arena, kid." The greeting is dark and it signals that it isn't a welcome, but more like a sentence.

His cage is one of many; he see's people in separate cages that all look vastly different. Some have absolutely no hope in their eyes while some have a glint of murder. It makes Izuku so sad to see children just a little bit older than him, half starved to death with too many scars to count. There are people who look like they've been here for years upon years and some who look like they've been here for a couple of weeks.

"So you're my roomie. You look pretty weak." Izuku looks over to see a kid only a few years older than him. His light blue hair and chapped lips strike a familiarity in him but he can't find it in himself to make the connection.

"Where am I?" Izuku must've shocked the other boy with his calmness (He was on a verge of a panic attack, but he's learned how to hide that over the years) because it takes a moment for the blue haired boy to answer.

"Like Keres said, you're at the Arena. It's where they force people to fight each other, and depending on the level you're on, it could even be to the death."

"What are the levels?"

The kid signs before speaking again, "Listen up, because I'm only going to explain this once. There are seven levels to this hell hole. The first one -the one you'll be starting soon, is called pawn. This one's simple, it's a one-on-one battle with no quirks. Person standing at the end wins and moves on to the next round. The second one is Beta. Here there will be ten 'contestants' put into a maze. There are traps of various degrees, so stay on guard. *Always* stay on guard. First one out moves onto the next level. The next one is Hunter, the stage I'm on. The amount of people put into this round is always random. I think the most I've seen is twenty-five. It's basically like the first one except weapons are involved. The only things I know about the other four is that their names are Knights, Assassins, Serpent, and Crow. Those are when they get more... deadly."

"What happens when you complete all of them?"

"People say you get released, but I think that's BS. The Arena probably just sends you off somewhere else or they kill you."

Izuku nods his head, "So all I have to do is get through all the levels and then I might be able to leave? It sounds too easy, and just like you said, I doubt they'd actually let you go. There would be to many risks behind that. If we wanted to escape we would have to work together, that way we could get everyone out. The only chance we have to get everyone out is probably when we complete the last level. Yeah, that could work, I just need to be pati-"

"Would you just shut it! I've been here for nine months and I'm only on the hunter stage. Do you have any idea how many times I've almost died?! And it's only the third level! Besides, you don't even know who the boss is. All I know is that he's a monster and if you want to get past him, you'll have to find out what his quirk is and how you can work around it. Just face it, your little 'idea' or whatever is as good as dead. There's no way you're going to escape, let alone help free everyone here."

Izuku brushes off the stranger's rant with ease, "Don't worry. I'll be able to do it, but we'll have to get along. Team work is essential. Oh! And by the way my name's Izu-"

He gets cut off once again, "Hold it. We don't do real names here. It's too personal and no one wants their 'before arena' life to be stuck in the 'during arena' times. I want you to call me Tomura. I am nine years old and my quirk is disintegration."

"Promise to save me in the next life."

"I promise. I'll save you!"

It was him... It was Shigaraki Tomura. The one he had promised to save from the league. The one he had to inevitably *kill*. He couldn't believe that Tomura had been here for who knows how long. How long had he suffered? First it was this, and then he had to venture out to a whole new hell.

Why had life been so cruel to him?

Why wasn't anything fair?

Still, no matter how well he thought he new Tomura, he didn't know this one. This one was still a kid who hadn't yet been corrupted by society's evil.

Tomura scratched his neck before continuing, "I'm not saying your little idea will work, cause' there's a lot of holes in it and is next to impossible, but I *will* cooperate with you. That doesn't mean I won't fight you if it comes down to it, so don't start to get all buddy-buddy on me."

Izuku smiled brightly at him, "Thank you, Tomura! Now, what should I have people calling me? Something simple and easy to remember. I can't do Deku, maybe Zuku? No, that's to close to my own name."

"Hato."

Izuku tilts his head, "Hato? Like a Dove?"

Tomura nods, "Yeah. Doves symbolize peace and hope and I think out of everyone here, you have the best chance to bring that to us."

Izuku brings out his hand, "It's nice to meet you! My name is Hato and I am five years old! And... well, I'm kind of complicated when it comes to having a quirk."

Tomura smirks and shakes Hato's hand, "It's nice to meet you, Hato. Complicated is fine. It just makes things more interesting."

Chapter End Notes

Sorry this chapter is kind of late! I've been having a rough few weeks and I've been kind of struggling, but don't worry! I'll still make sure to post a chapter at least once a week still!

I hope everyone had an amazing holidays and that everyone has/had a good day!

The Name That Means Hope

Chapter Summary

Izuku's first day at the arena.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Now that his mind had finally gotten a chance to *process* everything, Izuku was finally starting to feel the panic. As he laid on the cold cement floor (the cage was too familiar to his liking and only seemed to increase his panic) with it being to dark to barely see, struggling to breathe. Everyone was sleeping -or at least, pretending too-, and Tomura was hunched against the wall across the small cell. He remembered back to the old Tomura and how he always seemed slightly too childish for his age. Izuku finally understood that it was because he never had the *chance* to be a child, and to Izuku, that was really sad. He probably never experienced childlike curiosity, or the feeling like everything's going to be okay, no matter what happens.

Izuku promised that he would save him in the next life and he attends to keep it. He hoped that whenever they escape this place (he wants it to be soon, but feels as though it's going to be a lot longer), that he will be able to take Tomura with him, to his mother. So he can experience love and warmth for possibly the first time. He never wants him to gain the name "Shigaraki" in this life, because that'll just mean he'll be in the clutches of All For One again. Then it'll just be so much harder than it already was.

He wondered how his mother was doing. She's probably gotten word of his kidnapping and is probably worrying and stressing about him. What if she starts losing sleep? Or stops eating healthily? Aunt Mitsuki will be there for her, so she won't be alone. Hato finds some comfort in that, because he knows how much his mother craves company. He's the same after all. Izuku tells himself that before he knows it, he'll be out of here. So will everybody else trapped here. Yes, he'll probably have a *little* bit more trauma, but he already has *so much* of it, so what's the harm in adding some more?

Izuku, most of all, wants his Kacchan. Katsuki better not be feeling guilty about what happened, because he simply *shouldn't*. It wasn't his fault, and it never *will* be. Izuku wishes desperately to tell him that, to hug him, and cuddle with him like they always do when one of them -or both- are having a bad day.

Izuku won't even *pretend* this isn't a bad day. It'd be stupid.

Thinking about Kacchan and his mom makes his breathing calm, even though thinking about them just causes him to worry about what they're doing right now. He tells himself that he can do this, that he'll beat every single level no matter how injured or scared he gets.

(He ignores the inevitable future where he will have to kill someone because right now that's too much for his brain to handle and it's starting to get harder to breath again and he just needs to *ignore* everything and go to sleep.

But he can't, because than he'll have nightmares, and Izuku is smart enough to know that the prisoners and guards won't be happy with his screaming, even though he's starting to get better at staying completely silent when asleep; just some nightmares will always need to be screamed. So he won't fall asleep, even though he desperately needs it, he won't. He can't.

But he's *exhausted* and ends up falling asleep anyways.)

"Wake up you piece of shit." Keres bites out as Izuku snaps his eyes open and quickly looks around, forgetting where he was for a second. Soon enough, he remembers his new reality and forces himself to look at the man. "It's your turn, kid. Now get your ass up and don't you dare complain or I'll make you regret it."

Hato takes a quick glance at Tomura to see him looking the entirely different direction. Izuku sighs, and gets up to get whatever is going to happen over with. Keres roughly grabs Izuku by his shirt and pulls him out of cell. He locks the door behind them and then continues to drag Izuku down the dimly lit dungeon.

After about two minutes of walking, they come to a stop next to a tunnel with an iron gate blocking the entrance to what Izuku assumes to be the arena. He hears loud cheering for what seems to be like hundreds of people and can faintly see the fighting area that's surrounded by huge stone walls.

"Try not to die, yet. It's not as entertaining." Keres says, trying to scare the small boy in front of him, but all he receives is a blank stare. Izuku has over a decade of fighting experience and isn't exactly worried about going up against one opponent. He's terrified, yes, but it's not the fighting that scares him. It's that someday, he's going to have to kill again.

Memories of blood on his hands. Choking and choking someone to death. Feeling the crunch of a skull against his fists.

He couldn't feel his body. He didn't want this. Why did everything have to go so wrong?

Hato takes a deep breath as the gate opens just as the one across the arena does. Without needing the extra push that Keres sure wants to give him, Izuku walks forward into the arena. Across from him, he sees a women in her late teens with dark red hair and brown eyes. Her arms are covered in scars and bruises and her eyes

shine determination but the fear in them is as plain as day to Izuku. She must be new like him and Izuku desperately hopes that she survives long enough for him to save her.

"Start!"

At the loud sound, Izuku flinches but quickly recovers. Hato dashes forward before the women even has time to register. Once Hato gets close enough, on instinct, the women quickly jumps back on her bare feet. Hato just continues to run forward and too quick for the women to act, ducks down and swipes her feet from under her.

The red head quickly gets up with a grunt and swings her fist forward sloppily. Izuku doges it by pivoting his also bare feet (they must've stolen his shoes when he was sleeping). Knowing it would probably be the least painful way, Izuku jumps onto her back and hits a pressure point on her neck. She's out like a light and they both fall to the hard ground.

"Number eighty-eight wins and moves on to the next round! It seemed like this was pretty easy for him, I wonder what the next round will be like for him?" The announcer speaks like it's an annual football game and not an illegal fighting arena.

Izuku gets up from on top of the lady and moves back to the tunnel. He still feels the rush of adrenaline from that fight that couldn't have been more than a minute. He finds the adrenaline welcoming because it keeps his mind away from the onslaught of worries that have been consuming him endlessly since he got here.

It scares him how much he's willing to do to see him mom and Kacchan again. Because he's willing to do everything if it means he can even get the *chance* to see them again.

He wants to save, but he won't hesitate to kill the people that get in his way.

"That was fast." Tomura says with a light voice. He wasn't so sure about this kid at first. He just looked so weak and fragile, but Hato just keeps on surprising him with all those tricks up his sleeves.

Hato shrugs, "I just got lucky. She was clearly new and lacked the experience of fighting. Things are probably going to get harder during the Beta stage."

"So you know how to fight? How did you learn?"

"I started martial arts right when I turned three; I want to be a hero and thought it would be helpful. I ended up mastering several different types within *months*. I know the easiest to the most painful ways to take someone down. I can analyze and find their weaknesses in mere *seconds*, and I *will* use that to my every advantage." Izuku's eyes hardened with wisdom that spoke years beyond his supposed age. Tomura could feel goosebumps raise up and down his arms at the aura surrounding the kid; a kid that could probably take Tomura, someone who has trained himself to speed up his reflexes and show no mercy, in seconds.

Tomura hates to admit it, but he's glad that Hato is here. It's incredibly selfish, but Tomura believes that this kid, who's eyes shine with the most determination he has ever seen, will be the one to help free everyone. Tomura swears that he will help Hato with everything he has, because no matter how long it takes, they will escape. He's certain of it.

"Hey Tomura?" Izuku says from across the cell. It's nighttime and all Tomura wants is to sleep since he has a match tomorrow, but this kid is obviously an insomniac who can't contain his curiosity.

"What, Hato? I want to get some sleep."

"Oh! Sorry about that, you don't have to answer my question. You should go to sleep since you have a match tomorrow and I'm so sorry about bothering you and-" Izuku muttered in a hushed voice.

"Hato! Just ask the damn question." Tomura hoped that this is only because Izuku is still panicky about the whole being kidnapped and forced into an illegal fighting arena, but something is telling him that Hato is like this even without the added kidnapping part.

"Okay! I was just wondering -you don't have too, of course! But I just wanted to ask if you wanted to stay with my mom and I after we escape. Unless you have somewhere safe you can go to after this. And I bet my mom would love you and spoil you lots."

"Hato, I'm a downcast to society. I was abused by my dad and then my quirk came out late and I lost all control of it. I killed my family; I doubt you want someone like me living with you."

Izuku wasn't even phased by this. He had learned Tomura's history years ago. "Well, technically, we're staying in the same cell. Which means that we're *also technically* already living together. And you lost control of your quirk, so it *wasn't your fault*. You must've been really scared, upset and probably even angry."

"Nobody would accept me. People would probably fear me with the kind of villain quirk I have. A quirk that kills people."

"I was diagnosed as quirkless." This might've seemed to have nothing with what they were talking about to some people, but it had *everything* to do with what they were talking about. And Izuku wasn't lying. He was diagnosed as quirkless.

"... What?" Tomura knew how the quirkless was treated. He had seen it himself.

"And yet I have people who accept my and love me for who I am and not for what I don't have. Tomura, there will always be people who will accept you for who you are. And for those who think you're better off to be ignored, you'll just have to prove them wrong. To show them that you are *worth it.*"

Tomura has never heard anything so beautiful before. No one had ever been like this to him. No one had ever treated him with such pure-hearted kindness. Tomura let a small smile grace his lips at the thought at someone finally believing him.

"I'll think about it."

"Really?! That's great! Sorry again for keeping you up, but I thought that I had to really say that, ya' know?" Tomura nods, even though Izuku can't see it. "Goodnight, Tomura. If for someone reason I can't say it tomorrow, I want to wish you good luck on your match."

Tomura closes his eyes and drifts off to perhaps the most peaceful sleep he's had in years.

Izuku was interrupted from his sleep by a loud thud. He opened his eyes to see Tomura on the ground breathing heavily and hugging his stomach.

"Tomura! Are you okay? What happened?" Izuku questioned while helping the blue-haired boy sit up against the wall.

"Got punched..." Tomura said while in between gasps, "in the kidney." Izuku winced. He's been punched in the kidney before, definitely something he didn't want to experience again. "But... I won. I'm a knight now."

"That's great! It doesn't really matter if we're on the same level for now. The only one we need to be the same on is the last one. Whatever that is." Taking in Tomura's look of exhaustion, "You should probably sleep. I'll wake you up when they serve us food. They do serve us food, right?"

"Yeah, it's not a lot though. Probably just enough to keep you stable." Tomura said as he passed out from over-exertion. The fight was difficult, and like all the other times he had done the Hunter stage, he had almost died. He was one more step to freedom, and he knew that Hato would help him. It scared him how much he trusted the kid when they barely even knew each other. But something about Hato was welcoming and friendly.

He knew Hato would live up to his name.

Chapter End Notes

Hello everyone and Happy New Year! We can finally throw 2020 in the trash where it belongs!

I hope everyone had/has a good day!

Smothering the Light

Chapter Summary

She was only a child...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As soon as everybody got to their places in the cement-wall maze, Hato ran. He ran with the soul purpose to be the one to find his way out first. He knew he couldn't climb over the walls, they were too smooth and he was pretty sure he would get killed if he tried to do that. So he decided to just wing-it and take random turns in the maze. He made sure to keep track of all the ways he's gone so he doesn't do any repeats, but it was hard to concentrate on anything else other than the need to survive and win.

"The maze is filled with traps, so you have to always be aware (like Izuku already wasn't). One wrong step and your dead."

He needed to get out, and soon. Each second he wasted was another second he could be one step closer to getting out. He had to be the first one out, or he would have to do this again. Izuku couldn't afford that, he needed to move on to the next stages.

Izuku tripped from a piece of pavement that had gotten pushed down due to his weight. Acting on natural instinct, he tucked and rolled towards the ground, nearly getting his head cut off by a swinging axe. At the corner of his eyes he saw a body laying on the ground with his head barely attached to his neck. Hato looked away quickly, but the image was already ingrained into his mind.

Having the extra adrenaline from another near death, he surged forward; engraving himself more into the maze. If at all, the near death seemed to motivate Hato; for he was numb to the fear of dying. The feeling excited him, in a twisted, sick way.

"They don't care if you die or not. This is all for their entertainment. Your pain is their laughter. Always remember that."

He was seated near a corner to take a short break. He couldn't afford to mess this up, because if he did, Izuku would be failing so many people that needed him to escape. The maze was a mix of dead ends and turns that just made you fall deeper into the maze. Izuku must've already ran a mile from how his short legs were starting to ache. But Izuku was used to ache, he was used to pushing past the pain.

"There is something you must always swear by." Tomura waited for Hato to nod before continuing, "You must never try to form connections with anyone here. I am the only exception to this rule. Everyone else will either die or betray you. In the Arena, we can trust only each other and no one else."

Izuku almost fell into a pit of spikes before skidding to a stop and swiftly turning toward the other direction. As he was turning into the opposite side from before (he went right and almost died, might as well go left), he saw a little girl around his age with dark purple hair go in the direction of the spikes.

"Stop!" The word was ripped from his throat before Izuku could even register what he was doing. The yell had worked, and the girl looked over to him with her pearl eyes. She had a plain magenta dress on that was ripped throughout the bottom and one sleeve kept falling off her shoulder. Her messy hair was just passed her shoulders in delicate waves. She also had a white ribbon tied around her wrist.

This was so fucked up. She looked like she was just a little younger than him, meaning she was four to five years old. And here she was, *fighting for her life.* She was far too young to deal with this shit. Hell, no one should have to deal with this, but here they were.

Izuku somehow found his voice again, "It's a dead end with a pit of spikes. Trust me, you don't want to go in there." Not to mention the impaled body he had seen.

The girl beamed and Izuku almost cried at how innocent she looked, "Thank you!" She than ran up to him and hugged him. Before he could even register the hug, she let go. "People call me Madoka here! May I ask what your name is?" Hato noticed how malnourished she looked and wondered how long she had been here.

He tried his best to smile, "It's Hato. How long have you been here?" He knew he shouldn't be talking to her. He's just going to get attached, but Izuku will protect her. It'll be okay. He couldn't let her be alone.

"About a month. What about you, Oniichan?"

"O-oniichan? Where did that come from?"

Madoka just shrugs, "You saved my life. And you remind me of my older brother before he died. Is that... Okay?" She looked so hopeful that Izuku couldn't bring himself to say no.

"No, It's perfectly fine. I've been here for about three weeks." The people who controlled the Arena made it so that you had to wait weeks before moving to the next level after you had finished the one before. Izuku hated it, it just added to all of the frustration. "We should get going. You can follow me, if you want. I promise I'll protect you, Madoka-Chan." He hoped they were close. It's been about thirty minutes and he knows there are a lot more people with more experience on this stage than he was.

Madoka nods and then they set off to a light jog. Izuku makes sure to always be aware of traps and to go first when changing directions before letting Madoka follow.

They settled at a fast walk since Madoka was starting to get tired. Izuku made sure to hold onto to her hand so she wouldn't fall behind and get lost. He hardly knew her, but she reminded him so much of Eri. He's already seeing Madoka as a little sister just like he saw Eri as one.

"Where were you? Before you got brought here." Izuku asked while peeking around a corner to make sure it was safe. He saw a women pinned onto the wall with a spear through her chest. He covered Madoka's eyes and made sure to avoid the parts of cement the stuck up a tiny bit.

"I was at an orphanage. They weren't very nice." Hato frowned as he uncovered her eyes. He knew the system was messed up, but how could no one love someone as sweet and innocent as her?

"And why weren't they nice?" Could it have been her family? She did say her brother died, maybe something happened. Or was it her quirk?

"I'm quirkless." Madoka whispered as she hunched up her shoulders and winced as if preparing to get yelled out. Izuku barely contained a growl. He knew *perfectly* well what it was like to be quirkless. He knew every single statistic by heart. He *knew* how cruel people could be.

"So? They should treat you with just as much respect and care as they do with the other kids with a quirk." He saw as her shoulders relaxed and how she looked surprised at his words. He would be, too, if someone had said that to him when he was quirkless. "Can you tell me what they did to you?" Suddenly, the ground around them started to crumble. Hato gripped Madoka's hand even tighter and ran fast enough that she was lifted off the ground for a split second.

They made it to solid ground right as the ground gave out to reveal a tunnel that was too deep to see where it ended. Midoryia gripped his knees as he gasped for air. He looked over to see Madoka trembling and trying not to cry.

Izuku smiled over at her, "We're fine, see? We're both alive and breathing." Madoka nodded but clung to Izuku's arm in a tight hold.

After they had calmed down enough, they continued to walk through the maze. Seeing more dead bodies along the way, Izuku wondered just how many more people were still alive in this maze.

"At first, I guess they didn't really do anything." Hato was confused as to what she was talking about until he remembered the conversation from earlier, "They didn't really pay any attention to me. I was fine with that though. But then the other kids started to tease me and the caretakers made me do all of the harder chores. Then they slowly forgot to give me my portions of a meal so I had to eat from the scraps." Hato waited patiently as she sorted out her thoughts. All of the sudden, her pearl eyes looked so much older than they should have looked, "Then a man came. The care takers said he was there to take me. I was so excited. I thought I was finally going to get adopted, that someone might love me again. But instead, the man took me here."

"I promise that once we escape, I'll bring you somewhere safe. Somewhere where you'll be loved." Hato soothed the now crying girl.

"Thank you, Oniichan." She than lifted up her wrist to show the white ribbon. "I don't remember much of my family before they died, but I know they gave me this as a present. I couldn't put it on myself and no one at the orphanage would help me, so I decided to tie it on my wrist instead."

"If you want, I can tie it in your hair." The way Madoka's smile radiated light almost blinded Midoryia. She quickly untied her ribbon from her wrist and handed it to him. She turned around and waited patiently for Izuku to put it in her hair. Once he did, right in the center of the back of her head, she smiled again and did a little twirl.

"Does it look good? Does it, does it?" Izuku giggled at her childishness.

"It looks wonderful, Madoka-Chan."

"Thank you so much, Oniichan!" She hugged him tight, and this time, Hato returned it. Midoryia heard Madoka gasp, "Look! That must be the end!" In her excitement, she ran forward- releasing Izuku in the act.

Izuku reached an arm towards her, "Wait-!" But before he could say anything else, Madoka stepped on a trap. Before she could turn around, spikes jutted out from the ground and pierced Madoka. She was lifted off the ground with her arms, legs, and head dangling while her back had multiple different spikes go through it. She looked like a rag doll, like she hadn't just been smiling and laughing a second ago.

Her blood coated the spikes and the ground like a nightmarish painting. Her eyes were wide open and that innocent light that had shone through them? Gone.

Izuku stared at Madoka in horror. He had promised. *He had promised to protect her.* He failed. This shouldn't have happened. He was doing so good and then he had to mess it up. He should've been more careful. He should've hugged her tighter, because if he had, she would still be by his side.

"M-Madoka." It was a broken whisper. Filled to the brim with the feelings of sadness and failure. It wasn't right. This wasn't real, it couldn't be. Life wasn't *this* cruel to him, right? But it was, and no matter how much Izuku wished against it, this was reality. *But if he had just held on tighter-*

A white ribbon slowly landed next to his feet and all Izuku could do was sob. He gently picked up and tied it onto his wrist, making sure that it would never fall off.

"I'm *so sorry.* I couldn't save another person. I could've saved her, and yet-!" Izuku slowly made his way to the end. With each step, a sob escaped his mouth. *It wasn't fair.* It wasn't okay. *This wasn't okay.* And it *never* will be.

"The winner -and the only survivor- made it through stage two! Eighty-eight has yet again gone through a stage with ease!" Ease? This wasn't- this was far from easy. This was *hell.*

He had promised. And he broke it.



Chapter End Notes

My amazing friend drew this drawing of Madoka for me! If you want to see more of her art work, her Instagram is drawingkoi_uwu

I know that I'm being super evil with all of this angst, but I can't help it! Hopefully you didn't get too attached with Madoka (jokes on you if you did lol)

I hope everyone had/Has a good day!

What They Would Do

Chapter Summary

They’d do anything to have everything be okay again.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki's world was a blur. Nothing seemed to be right anymore. Everything was chaos. *He* was chaos. He wished there was an on and off switch in life because right now, everything was just *too much*. He wondered if he could just disappear until everything was okay again, until he could finally see his Izu again.

He opted to just stay in his head as much as he could. Reliving all the memories he had with Deku. He would make anything count, even the not-so-good memories.

But sometimes his mind would ignore his pleas to just drown in his memories and would spiral down thoughts that he didn't want to have. What was that scary man doing to Izuku? Was Izu safe (of course he wasn't)? Did they *kill him?* He always wanted cried when he thought about that. The thought- the *possibility* that Deku could be dead, it seemed preposterous. Deku was too stubborn to die, but that doesn't mean he could beat it.

They're only *five years old.* They're not supposed to be dealing with this shit. They are *supposed* to be playing heroes and adventuring out into the woods to catch bugs. Katsuki isn't supposed be wondering if his friend is dead or alive. They should be playing out in the playground and trying to see who swings the highest. Deku shouldn't have been kidnapped by that-that *monster*. Katsuki was supposed to protect him. But he shouldn't have had to protect him from being kidnapped, but maybe the bullies instead.

Oh the things Katsuki would do to have things back to *normal*.

Mitsuki and Masaru Bakuguo were at a lost. It seemed like it was going to be like that for a while now. They knew that if Izuku never came back, their son wouldn't either. Not really, not *fully*. He may learn to accept it, if it may turn out to be that way (they sure hoped not). He might even learn to move on. But they knew for a fact that their son will never be the same unless he sees his best friend again. The Bakuguo's knew right when the two kids met each other that they were two sides of the same coin. Yin and Yang.

Izuku was a part of Katsuki just as Katsuki was a part Izuku. One couldn't be themselves without the other; it just wasn't possible.

And its only been three weeks and they know they should be patient but they're *parents* and its their job to be *worried*. They can't bare to see their son like this. They couldn't bare to see how he would ask to go to see Izuku and then see the excitement leave his eyes as he remembers. They couldn't *stand* to hear his shouts from a nightmare that is certainly about *that* day. They hated to see Katsuki, someone who rarely ever cried, burst into sobs every night because every night he relived the worst day of his life *over* and *over*.

They were his parents, and they were worried.

Inko Midoryia never thought that she would have to deal with this. She thought -*hoped*- that she would be one of the lucky ones. But she was wrong and as much as she tried to be positive and think -*know*- that she would see her son again, it was impossible. Because he could be hurt, bleeding, crying, *dead* and she wouldn't be able to do anything about it. All she could do was talk to the police, but it was *so hard* to find one that would willingly do a good job to find a *quirkless* child. And then she did, but then the food in her fridge got smaller.

She told herself that that was okay. Izuku was more important. Even though a part of her brain whispered to her that her son would be mad that she wasn't taking care of herself. But what else was she supposed to do? It was her *job* to protect him, and she had failed. So screw her health, she needed her baby back. Even if that meant she would have to tear herself up from the inside to do so.

Izuku was Inko's entire world. The only one that could bring a smile onto her face even when she thinks it would be impossible to do so. Izuku is her diamond in the rough; her purpose. Without him, the house is too cold, too quiet, too *empty*. Inko hates it. Hates how sometimes she swears, *swears* that she hears her son's cute little mumbling or the quiet pitter pattering of feet. And when she realizes that it's just her mind playing tricks on her, Inko cries until she's too dehydrated to cry anymore.

There's only so much she can do, but she's willing to do everything.

Midoryia Izuku. Son of Hisashi and Inko Midoryia. Five years old and diagnosed as quirkless. Last seen at Strawberry park July 15th around the time 18:24 to 18:30. Was dragged into a black van and was non ambulatory due to a paralysis quirk being used on him.

People working on the case: Tsukauchi Naomasa, Aizawa Shouta (Pro hero: Eraserhead), Yamada Hizashi (Pro hero: Present Mic), and Kayama Nemuri (Pro hero: Midnight).

Naomasa had never seen a case like this one before. And the fact that so few were actually willing to give this case a chance to be solved made it only that much more difficult. Not to mention that the only witness was a five-year-old boy who was clearly traumatized from the whole ordeal. Still, Tsukauchi was mildly impressed by the information the young Bakugou had gathered. A man who looked to be early to mid thirty's with black shoulder length hair and icy blue eyes. And one of the most important factors: his quirk, which allowed him to paralyze people. They didn't know he did it or how many people he could paralyze at once (although the theory is only one).

All the other heroes were either to busy with other missions or just straight up didn't think there was any hope to save this kid. It angered Naomasa to no end seeing how ones bias is effecting Izuku's chances on being saved.

They had *one* piece of video evidence showing the car moving out of Musutafu and then it just disappears. Not a trace what so ever. They were able to track the car using someone's quirk that could track a specific car as long as they had a license plate number. All they found out is that the car was driving out into the middle of no where and then the tracks just... stop. It was like the car took off flying.

Tsukauchi wasn't willing to give up, he just had to be patient and hope that new evidence comes to light sometime soon. Something was telling him that he was missing a big piece to this puzzle, something critical. It was just buried in between the lines waiting to be found.

He knew he had to find it, a kids life was at stake.

Aizawa and Yamada didn't know why they felt so drawn to Midoryia Izuku. All they knew is that they had a connection with this kid and that they needed to save him.

It was like they knew the kid, but they also knew for certain that they had never met the boy before.

Nemuri, Yamada, and Aizawa all agreed that this wasn't a normal kidnapping. The kidnapper left no indications that they wanted something. That meant that the most reasonable explanations for the kidnapping was either that they wanted to kill the kid (they surely hoped that wasn't the case) or they wanted to sell Izuku. Of course, there could be other reasons, but so far, those were the most probable. It was nefarious; to kidnap a kid.

They wanted -*needed* to save this kid. It was a desire that went far beyond there job as heroes, something they couldn't quite fathom yet.

They hoped it would be soon, but no matter how long it was, they would save Midoryia Izuku.

Izuku, for the first time in a long time, felt numb. It was a coping mechanism he long since abandoned once he got into U.A. He nearly forgot about it, but the sensation of not feeling anything was gladly welcomed. Izuku would much rather be dull than to break into millions of pieces.

He hardly registered the guard shoving him into the cell; Izuku could barely feel the stinging of his knees that had scraped against the ground.

"So? Did you win?" The rough yet young voice of Tomura was muffled to Izuku. Midoryia wished he listened to Tomura when he told him not to get close with anyone. Maybe he wouldn't feel like this (whatever he was feeling. Was being numb even a feeling?), but if he had listened, what would he feel? Either way, Madoka would have died. Would he feel the same, even if he hadn't promised? Promised that he would protect her?

He could barely get himself to nod at Tomura's question. Yes, he had passed. Shouldn't he feel happy about it? *Would* he feel proud of himself if it wasn't for the death of Madoka? Or would he still wallow in sorrow at the fact he was the only one to make it out alive?

Izuku had so many questions but no answers.

"You don't seem happy. Shouldn't you be happy?"

Izuku didn't know.

"Something happened, right? What was it."

So many things happened. But was it really that big of a deal? Shouldn't Izuku be used to death by now?

He didn't think he wouldn't ever get used to it. All the blood- the blood that seemed to never leave his skin.

He clutched onto his wrist with the white ribbon tied to it. His knuckles were turning white and there will no doubt be a bruise there tomorrow. Izuku clutched tighter.

"I should've listened to you."

Chapter End Notes

I'm really proud of this chapter! Sorry that it was shorter than usual, the next one will be longer.

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

The Harsh Truth

Chapter Summary

Izuku tries to get over the death of his friend.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It's been a month since the maze. Every night Izuku looked at the white ribbon on his wrist. It reminded him of not just the sparkle of Madoka's eyes (how that light slowly faded as the blood emptied from her body), but how many people he might not be able to save. It's almost been over two months since he was brought to the arena and he's only on stage three, The Hunters.

He's always hungry which makes his exhaustion ever more present. Izuku says it's okay, though. Because at least he's being fed, right? He can survive off of one meal a day until he gets everybody out. Besides, he's been through worse. *Others* have been through worse.

(He tries to ignore the hunger pains that slowly eat away at him in the night. How his movements are getting slightly slower and weaker.

But it's okay. He'll get use to it. Just give him another month or two.)

Today is his first day as a Hunter. Izuku looks over to Tomura who is still sleeping while cradling his arm that had turned an ugly shade of purple. Luckily, it's just a minor fracture and should heal before his next match. Izuku knows (hopes) that Tomura will make it out of the arena. He has too, even if Midoryia doesn't know *how* he got out last time.

Over the time here, Hato has begun to think of Tomura as some sort of big brother. Even though Izuku had never told him about Madoka, Tomura had been extra kind that week. One moment that stuck out was when Midoryia had a particularly bad nightmare and Tomura allowed Izuku to hug him. They snuggled up against each other that night and it was probably the lightest he had felt since he got here. Even now, Izuku craved human affection. So being able to hug Tomura, gave him a sense of grounding which was almost like when Katsuki and him had cuddled.

(Although, he had to favor Kacchan. Tomura was a little... awkward with human affection. Which was totally understandable, since he's been touch starved for who knows how long.)

Hato had to guess it was a little past six in the morning when Keres came to get him. The guard wore his permanent sneer while Izuku kept his face blank. It irritated Keres, Izuku had learned, and it was one of the only bits of fun he got in this place.

As he got closer to the arena he heard the familiar sound of harsh cheers. *The cheers that laughed in amusement as Madoka got pierced.*

"If you get past this round, you'll be thinking that these past couple of months were *heaven*." Izuku doesn't even bother to glance at the man as he walks into the battlefield. He'll just have to deal with it because it'll all be worth it in the end. Just to see everybody's smile.

He has to be patient.

The battlefield had large rocks scattered randomly around the arena; most likely for cover and higher ground. In the very middle was an assortment of weapons that could be used. As Hato looked around, he saw nine other people. All of them were looking at the weapons hungrily and desperately.

"Hunters... Start!"

Everyone but him went straight for the weapons. Izuku thought that the most risk of getting disqualified would be going straight for the weapons. He thought slowly walking towards it while using the rocks as cover would give him the best chances at gaining a weapon safely.

As he was crouched behind a rock about fifteen feet away he saw about four people knocked out cold. One had a knife in their shoulder but seemed to still be breathing. Izuku let out a sigh of relief when he realized that the other three were breathing as well.

Hato saw a women with an axe that had dried blood *covering* it. He thought he might've seen an intestine wrapped around it, but refused to give himself enough time to find out if there really was or not. There was a crazed look blanketed in her eyes that almost reminded him of Toga. He observed how someone knocked her out by knocking a bo staff against her head. She was probably all looks and zero bronze.

Izuku was too busy observing everyone's fight that he failed to notice someone come up behind him. He was just about to move closer to the weapons when the man decided to make his move.

And then he noticed, but his head had already gotten bashed against the ground and he was out cold.

Izuku woke up with his head pounding a painful rhythm against his head. He gently placed a hand there and felt dried, crusty blood.

Izuku looked around with a groan realizing he had just lost his first match and it was because he was being so damn stupid. Midoryia felt like he was going to throw up from how painful his migraine was. *This sucked*. He definitely didn't want to go through this again; he's learned his lesson: always pay attention to the people who surround you.

"Looks like sleeping beauty is finally awake." Izuku groaned again, he really didn't feel like dealing with Tomura's snarky attitude right now.

"How long have I been out?" Speaking was a struggle at the moment, he realized. It hurt to even think about the words let alone speak them.

"Just a few hours. I'm guessing your next chance will be in a few weeks, so you'll have time to recover from your injury." Hato hummed in reply and closed his eyes hoping he could sleep off his pain. At least he could be in top shape when he tried again. Just as long as it wasn't longer than a month. Now all he had to do is wait out the feeling of his head exploding and the urge to throw up what little he has had to eat.

He's exhausted and is thankful for that. It makes it just a tiny bit more easier to fall asleep.

"Oniichan, you'll protect me, right?" Madoka and him were both in a field with startling green grass and an unburdened blue sky.

Izuku was back in his seventeen year old body, and yet, he didn't take any notice of the sudden change. He crouched down next to Madoka's level and smiled at her. "Of course I will! You won't ever have to worry because I will always be here for you. I promise!"

Then, like day turned to night, the field started to crumble all around them, but they did not fall; It was like paint chipping off of walls. Soon, Izuku and Madoka were both in a room that was nothing short of a black void. Izuku frantically looked around because they were trapped and he didn't know why.

The greenette slowly turned to Madoka only to see the white dress she was wearing was stained in splashes of red. Izuku looked on in horror to see that her pearl eyes were gauged out and left in their place were bloody, black sockets.

"You promised." Her voice was vacant, as if she wasn't even there. Madoka's eye sockets started to drop blood; soon her cheeks were stained with the familiar and dreadful color. It made Izuku sick- the blood reminded him of tears, which only in turn made him start to cry.

He began shaking his head and hugged Madoka -not caring if he got any blood on him- as if his sanity depended on it. He clung on to her, hoping, wishing, praying to whatever cruel entity that created this reality, that this wasn't real. That Madoka had somehow made it out alive, that he had succeeded in protecting her.

But it was real. And there was nothing he could do about it.

"You promised. You promised, you promised, youpromisedyoupromisedyoupromised-"

"I know. I know, and I am so, so sorry. I should've saved you. I failed you, but I promise I'll make sure it won't happen again. I'll try my hardest so it will never happen ever again." Izuku was still hugging Madoka as she stayed motionless; she was like a puppet with their strings cut off.

(But isn't that what we all were? Puppets. Something to be controlled by someone and if we disobey, we get our strings cut off. It's a never ending loop that will never end. And once it does, it'll start again and again and again.)

"You will." Madoka didn't state it as a question, but more like a statement that no one could change.

Once Izuku let go of her, Madoka started to crack. In that one moment, she was glass. Seconds away from shattering.

And she did, and so did Izuku.

And he was left to rebuild the pieces.

When Izuku woke up, he did not scream. He didn't even move. He couldn't- didn't even dare to. His chest felt heavy with the guilt ever so present. But he had realized something, realized why he made the mistake he did in the arena.

Guilt.

The guilt of Madoka's death had gotten him tangled in a never ending sea of self-depreciation and disassociation. If Hato wanted to win, he needed to free himself from that. Not to say that he still won't feel guilt (no, he will *definitely* still feel the culpability), but he needed to accept what had happened.

He needed to accept the fact that he won't be able to save everyone.

That didn't mean he wouldn't try, of course not. But there will always be someone you can't save, and if there isn't, then the person you won't be able to save will be yourself.

No one can't save everyone, but they can try. And maybe... maybe that's enough. Izuku will still feel at fault for Madoka's death (for everyone's). He'll probably feel like this for forever. But maybe he can learn to accept it. Maybe that alone will be enough.

Izuku can try and he can hope, but when it all comes down to it, he's not responsible for everyone's lives. Having that burden will only enable him to save the people that he *can* save.

He hasn't fully accepted it, Izuku doesn't know if he ever will. But for now, this is enough.

Even if the weight in his chest hasn't gone away.

Even if there's still something missing in the depths of his heart.

This time, Izuku did not try to get a weapon. He didn't need one. At least, not at the beginning. Instead of thinking on how to get to the weapons, Hato analyzed his opponents. The women closest to him obviously had an injured foot by the way she was carrying herself. He knew it was unfair, but Midoryia would have to take her down first.

The easy pickings always go down first, just like he did last time.

As far as Izuku could tell, she was the only one who was injured. It would make it harder, but Hato's trained for this. All he needs to do is rely on his speed (which hasn't been so great lately) and his years of knowledge in the art of fighting.

He let his feet carry him towards the women who was having trouble even taking a step. He jabbed a few vital points in her legs to make her fall to the ground and then swiftly strikes the back of her neck without even giving her time to process. It might've been an act of pity on Izuku's part. He knew how cruel these people could get for the desperation of winning.

(But the crazed look in some of their eyes unsettled Izuku. He wondered if they gave up on ever escaping and succumbed to their supposed fates. Was learning -pretending- to like hurting and killing other people really helping them?)

Without wasting a beat, Hato delved under the protection of a rock and hid. He saw two other people who were down which meant there were seven more people counting himself. He made sure to glance back behind him every few seconds just in case, even though he could see the others all fighting one another.

Izuku clenched his teeth and tried to ease the churning in his stomach as he saw someone stick a knife in someone's eye and *twisted*. Once he took the knife out, the eyeball had popped right out as the victim of it all started to scream. He was going into shock, Izuku realized, and soon enough, he passed out.

Tearing his eyes away, he saw two other people passed out which meant there were only four people left. Hato looked around to see a young teen being cornered by the guy who had seemed to be obsessed with knives (If the way he licked the knife covered in blood from his last victim was anything to go by).

Quickly, Hato sped towards the man. The greenette grabbed a bo staff that was laying next to someone who was already out and seconds before the knife man could do anything to the teen, Hato jumped as high as he could and *whacked* the staff right on top of the man's head. It caused the light blued hair man to become disoriented but not enough to stop him from lazily slicing Izuku's shoulder.

Izuku ignored the wetness dripping from his shoulder (his first scar, Izuku muses), and swings the staff and hits the man where it hurts. The bluenette collapses to his knee and Hato takes the final swing aimed at his head taking the man out.

Izuku knows the knife man is going to wake up with a headache (maybe a concussion), and he's glad.

After making sure the man won't be getting up anytime soon, Midoryia looks up to the boy he saved only to have the color drain from his face at the image. The young teen is laying on his stomach with an arrow stuck in his back. Izuku quickly checks for a pulse and lets the tension leave his shoulders as he feels one.

Before Izuku can relax, he hears a whistling and quickly moves his head to the side. An arrow flys by him, cutting a few strands off of his hair. Hato swiftly looks to the direction of where the arrow came from and sees a women with buzzed golden hair with a bow and arrow standing on top of a rock.

All he had to do was defeat her and then he could move on to the next round. So as the women shoots another arrow, Hato grabs the knife from the knife man and throws it. Izuku quickly side steps and barely misses the arrow from piercing his leg. However, it does give him another cut that will not doubt be a nuisance later.

Izuku snaps his head up to see if he got the blond haired women, but noticed that as she went to dodge the knife, she slipped and fell. The blonde hit her head on the dirt ground and didn't get up.

Hato -*Izuku*- did it. Satisfaction with himself welled up in his chest as he chugged down air.

He was a knight now, and he was proud about that. Happy to know that he was one step closer to being free from this god-awful place.

But it took him about three months to finish just three stages. How long would it take him to do seven more? Especially when they just get more difficult and *deadly*. And he knew nothing about this place; Izuku hasn't even *heard* whoever this boss's name is!

Izuku tried to quell the anxiety in his stomach at the thought, the *calculation* of just how long it would take to get out of here.

Because with each new difficulty in the arena, each new *stage*. Izuku estimated that he would be here for at *least* two years. That if he somehow got lucky, and escaped the evil that was sure to be lurking, it would still take him *two years* to escape.

Two. years.

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Never Going Away

Chapter Summary

Here’s another chapter! I hope everyone liked it :D

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Izuku wakes up being dragged out of his cell.

Not a very pleasant thing to wake up to, but who is he to complain? Izuku starts to panic when he realizes he can't move. He glances up behind him to see Keres is the one dragging him which means he probably used his paralysis quirk on him. Keres is holding him where he got the cut from yesterday's battle, and it *stings*. He'd be lucky if it doesn't get infected, if it isn't already.

"Where are you taking me?" It's hard to maintain his monotone facade when Izuku knows- *knows*, that whatever this is, isn't going to be good.

Keres doesn't answer. Doesn't even glance at him. The man drags him up stairs, which isn't fun and he will probably have bruises on his back later. They arrive at a door and Izuku can finally feel his limbs again. Keres lets go of him; making Izuku's head thud against the cold cement ground. Hato quickly gets up only to be pushed inside the room.

The room is bigger than expected, and much, much more fancier. By fancier he means that there's just so much stuff cramped in this room that besides decoration, it's completely useless.

(Except for the select few weapons on the walls. Izuku makes a mental note to remember that there are weapons in here. It might be useful in the far future.)

In the far middle of the room, he sees a man sitting at his desk (a desk that Izuku's hand twitches in the need to clean). The man is big and looks to be mid sixties with graying blond hair that goes to his shoulders and a long beard as well. His charcoal eyes aren't empty like Keres's, but replete with evil and the intent to *hurt*. Standing next to the man is a person with electric short blue hair, a black, scruffy beard, and has their face caked with makeup.

The man smiles- it almost looks heartwarming in a wicked sort of way. "Ah, number eighty-eighty. You must be wondering why you are here." Each word that leaves the man's mouth sends cold shivers down Izuku's spine. He tenses his shoulder in attempt to guard himself. "Well you see, you have impressed us with the skills

you have shown." The person that stood next to him began to move to a fireplace and picked up a metal brander with the number *eighty-eight* on it.

Izuku tried to back away, but Keres must've activated his quirk again, because all of a sudden he's on the ground with his cheek throbbing from the impact.

He see's the blue haired person come closer with a smirk as Izuku fails to repress his sob. "And you're like- what?! Six, *five?!* You're a prize to the arena, eighty-eight. And you know what we like to do with our prizes?" The electric bluenette slowly lifts his shirt until his whole back is showing. Izuku tries to move, tries *so hard*, but he *can't*.

"We brand them."

And then Izuku's right shoulder blade *explodes* with pain. It's like his skin is *melting*; which in a way, it is. Midoryia lets out a silent scream at the sheer pain flowing through his body. He hasn't felt pain like this in such a long time; it's agonizing. He smells his own flesh burning. Izuku almost chokes on his own bile at the smell, at the *pain.*

It only makes his throat burn as well.

Finally, they release the brander off of his skin and walk back to stand next to the desk. Izuku feels himself loosing consciousness as the pain had drained all of his existing energy leaving him exhausted.

"Put him back in his cell."

"Yes, boss."

He had heard it. He had heard Keres call this man 'boss'. That means this is the man who controls the arena. The man Izuku needs to defeat.

His eyes were so close to closing, and they did. But before he let himself succumb to the darkness, he caught a glimpse of an old fashioned phone that was connected to an outlet.

Before he could process his discovery, Izuku let himself slip into unconsciousness.

Izuku woke up for the second time that day. His back was throbbing in pain and it was near impossible to move without it feeling like his skin was being raked off with sharp fingernails (It's happened to him before. Long, long ago by a measly middle school bully).

"*What did they do?!*" Tomura rumbles out, his anger flowing into his shaking fists. Izuku hasn't seen Tomura like this in a long time, but even back then, his anger was expressed in a different way. This vexation was silent. Translating into something different that wasn't lashing out on others. Izuku didn't know what the out come of his feelings would be, especially since his anger is new; untrained in ways that make it dangerous yet reliable.

"Trust me, it's not important. I'll be better in a few weeks." Izuku tried to ignore the feeling of- what was it? Something akin to dread towards the future. On the day he looks in the mirror and sees a scar the will never leave him. Never fading away, always brining memories with it.

Hato shakes his head. It's not worth worrying about things that will always be there. "What's important is that I found out who the boss is. And I know where he stays as well." Hato tries to sit up, and he does. It just takes him several minutes to get used to the pain before he could push passed it.

Tomura's eyes widen comically, "Really?! Do you know what his quirk is?"

"No. It's not something based off of appearances as far as I know, but at least we know what he actually looks like now." Izuku contemplates what he's going to say next. It's important, and needs to be told, "Tomura, you do know that it's still going to take a while to get out, right? In order to even have a *chance* at getting out, we're both going to need to be at the final round at the same time. That's going take over a year, probably two." Midoryia didn't want to bring false hope into getting out soon, because that's just not realistic. Not with how dangerous these *games* were.

To his surprise however, Tomura nods. "Yeah, I know." He reaches to scratch his neck, but a glare from Hato makes his hand drop, "We need to take our time with this. It would be stupid to think we could get out of this *cage* so soon."

They were moving slowly, but they were *still* walking. They were getting closer to their goal.

But something came to Izuku's mind today. The fact is that even if they get out, they will always, *always* have the memories of this place. Some will even come with permanent scars.

Some might never fully escape the arena. It will never fully leave their minds.

Haruki Neo. A four year old girl who went missing not too long before Midoryia Izuku. She's diagnosed as quirkless and stayed at an orphanage after her family passed away in a car accident.

Tsukauchi looked at the file as if it had some hidden secret between the words. He has to admit, there wasn't much to go off of. The orphanage got shut down not to long ago due to abuse and child labor, so he couldn't go there to question them about Haruki. They *had* admitted that they would let people illegally adopt kids without any background checks.

Tsukauchi had suspicions that the orphanage sold a few kids to human traffickers since some children were almost impossible to track down and were now deemed missing.

And this is where Haruki Neo comes into place. They had unnamed witnesses say that they saw her with a man that had the *exact* same description the Bakugou kid had given them. That was *huge*, and it could mean so many possible things that it would take a while to limit them.

Naomasa had tasked Aizawa with interrogating past human traffickers to see if they know anything, anything at all. This was their biggest lead and it took them over three months to find it. Naomasa and his team had to hold onto this with everything they had. Now they knew that it wasn't just one child that needed help, but more.

The tired detective took a sip of his third (or was it fourth?) cup of coffee and started to dive deeper and deeper into the connections of the past that could possibly be linked to this man.

It wasn't much, but it was a start.

"So what's this whole process of being a Knight?" Izuku questioned. It's been three weeks since the arena had branded him and his back was only a tiny bit tender. He and Tomura were both scheduled to fight tomorrow. Their first time being in a round together. It was too bad that they couldn't exactly work together.

"Think of it as a game of hide and seek."

Izuku raises and eyebrow, "Really? A game of hide and seek?"

"It's not as fun as you may think it is. There's this big, run down mansion set up in the arena. Seriously, I don't know how they set these things up so fast. You have five minutes to hide, and can even attack the other people as well. That's how I keep on loosing; people gang up on you and beat the shit out of you. If you can get past those people and find a good place too hide, you have to somehow manage to stay hidden for thirty minutes."

"Who comes to find you? What happens if you're found?"

"Quite ya' yapping, I'm getting there. The finder is this huge guy that works for the arena. He knows every square inch of the place and knows the best hiding spots. And what he does if he finds you... Well it's not pretty. I've witnessed people who were found by him, and you'd wish the other players would have ganged up on you instead. This... Guy electrocutes you with his quirk. Enough for you to get burns and pass out. Whoever isn't found by the thirty minutes moves on to the next round."

"Can you attack him?" Hato asks.

"*...What?*"

Izuku goes off to explain, "I *mean*, can we attack him. It would only be fair, right? He's hunting us, so why not hunt *him* instead? Although, I guess it would be hard. Since we don't know how his quirk works and we would definitely need a lot of people so we can jump him."

"*Exactly*. What you're saying is completely nuts. You'd be crazy to go along with it."

But Izuku wasn't done yet, "So that means I'll have to purposely get electrocuted by him, and you'd have to talk to everybody else about the plan. And then we can follow through with it next time. The only problem would be the aftermath, but *technically* nobody ever said that we couldn't just... Switch the roles around."

Tomura nods, "Yeah. You're crazy." He honestly should've already known that Hato wasn't- how should he say it? Normal. No sane person could think of this let alone follow through with it. "But you're right. It *could* work. And I would love to see his reaction once he realizes he's fucked." Yeah, never mind. This was a *great* idea.

Hato smirks devilishly as a sparkle mischievously develops in his eyes. A part of him thinks that this might even be fun. Or at least the most amount of fun when you're in the situation he's in.

Being electrocuted won't be fun; not at all. But who knows, maybe someday he could develop some kind of resistance to it.

Hope Makes Us Stronger

Chapter Summary

Izuku grabs onto hope

And doesn’t let go

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki felt homesick. That was the best way he could describe it. He missed his best friend so, *so* much. It made his entire body physically ache. To him, Deku *was* his home; a part of him that would always be here. When Deku was kidnapped, a part of him had been ripped out, and Katsuki knew that it wouldn't come back until Izu did.

Izu *had* to come back. Not just for him, but for auntie as well. Every time he and his parents visited her, she looked worse. Way older and paler than she used to be. Katsuki was smart, and he knew that she wouldn't last long at this rate. He always made sure to be the sweetest little damn angel that Inko would ever have the pleasure of meeting. If only to make her day just a little brighter. Lately though, it was getting hard to even get her to crack a smile.

School was hard. Sure, he had a few friends but he never let them get too close. That was too dangerous and he made sure to tell himself that every night. Bakugou tried his best to get the best grades possible. After all, heroes couldn't be stupid, but also he knew for a fact that Izuku would scold him for studying too much. The thought made home want to cry and smile at the same time.

No one had seemed to even remember Deku. Not even questioning why the little sunshine wasn't in class anymore. It was like he never existed, like he didn't matter. He had vented (screamed) at his parents about how *angry* he was that no one seemed to care that *his* favorite person wasn't here anymore.

His parents told him that sometimes people, especially children, could be like that. That they can be confusing and unpredictable. His parents told him that the best thing to do was accept that and focus on something else. Maybe something more *positive*.

Here's the thing though, Katsuki didn't *want* to accept it. He didn't get how people (he knew it wasn't just children, but everyone) were so confusing. Why couldn't they be simple? All he wanted was someone to remember his best friend. Was that really too much to ask? The explosion user was smart, and he knew that the invisibility of Izuku was probably because of his status. Of being quirkless. How could they not understand that Izuku was special?

He started going to the dojo Izu went too. He meant all of his teachers and that alone had lightened him. They talked about Izuku like he was a shining star (which he was. The brightest one in the whole galaxy). They told him about how Izuku always puts in his best and how they made him -on multiple occasions- stop for the day before he overworked himself.

Katsuki promised the teachers that he would try his best as well. That he would master every fricken move perfectly no matter how long it took him.

Soon the training wasn't only because he wanted to be a hero, but because maybe if he grew strong enough, he would be able to save Deku someday.

The day was starting off to be egregious.

First off, he was starving and could really use some of his mom's homemade cooking. But now he was in an arena surrounded by people that would rather rip your throat out than trust you, which will only make it that much harder to put his plan in action.

Hato just hoped that Tomura would be able get through to them. After all, he was almost as scary as they were. Except being about ten years old definitely put him at a more innocent appearance.

(Izuku had stopped bothering to remember the date about a month ago. He had no idea what day it was now, and in all honestly, he was unconcerned about it. Remembering only added to the barrel of things he had to do.)

Tomura wasn't kidding when he said that the mansion was huge. It reminded Izuku of those old, scary run down houses that you always see in horror movies. Most of the paint was chipping off and he could vaguely see a few holes in the front porch. The place was most likely a death trap, literally or figuratively, Izuku doesn't know. Hato wondered how they set up these up so fast. It had to be some powerful quirk, maybe even multiple. He remembered back to the maze and how detailed that was; it was like it was fake. And now this fake mansion that had as much detail as an *actual*, hand-crafted mansion.

Taking a quick glance at Tomura, he nodded. Realistically, Izuku knew that he won't get everybody on their side, especially if some people would be moving to the next round. They only needed a couple of people. Hell, even one would make a difference between winning and loosing.

"How do I get them to join us?"

"Tell them the truth." Maybe if people knew that Izuku was planning on breaking everybody out, they wouldn't be as hesitant to join them. Even if they think that getting everybody out would be impossible, they might gain some hope.

And hope was a very, very important thing.

Hato didn't waste a single second to run into the house when the announcer started the round. He nearly fell into a hole when he made his way up the front porch. That only spiked the adrenaline in him as Izuku quickly opened the door and rushed into the house. Hato lead himself to where he thought the kitchen would be. He kept on bumping into useless furniture that had gotten in his way- it was like the boss's office. He swallowed down his irritation when he finally stumbled across the kitchen.

Izuku got to work and rapidly opened all the cabinets in the kitchen. Trying to find anything that was made out of rubber. While looking, he tried to turn on the stove and sink to see if it worked. To his surprise, the appliances did.

He had found one pair of rubber gloves right under the sink. Hato even found some pots and pans; his favorite being the huge iron skillet. Seriously, for such an elaborate fighting arena, you'd think that they would be smart. Turns out that whoever designed this place was pretty damn stupid.

A loud bell-like sound resonated throughout the mansion, probably meaning that the five minutes were up. Izuku didn't even bother to hide (even though every fiber in his body was screaming at him to do so). Hiding wasn't his mission.

Not even a minute after the bell had sounded, he heard the door to the main entrance slam open. It was a wonder how the door didn't fall off it's hinges. The man seemed like he didn't favor that whole 'quiet and sneaky' approach as he seemed to announce his whole presence through out the house. His footsteps were there own thunder as he stomped around. By the sound of his footsteps, the man was getting closer to the kitchen.

Hato mentally prepared himself as the door creaked open, not being slammed like the last one. The man came into view, and boy, wasn't he a sight. The man was almost as tall as the boss, if only a little bit more fit. He had bright yellow eyes and slick back hair that went to his mid back. Just like everybody that worked here, he didn't exactly scream *nice*.

Izuku was standing right in front of the man, impossible to miss. Midoriya mused at the slight confusion in his face; he was probably wondering why Izuku was standing in the middle of a room when he was supposed to *hide*.

The man's confusion turned into a smirk that covered half of his face, "Well, aren't you a stupid one." His voice was full with ignorance. Something that will only make it that much sweeter to take him down.

Izuku smiled back in greeting, "I guess you could say that."

Before Izuku could say anything else, the man was right in front of him grabbing his neck. The man was faster than he expected, and Izuku couldn't help but ponder if that was the cause of the man's quirk.

Hato noticed how the man's hair began to stick up and become much more frizzier. Was he gathering static electricity? Perhaps charging up, making his hair stand up? If so, than that means he wasn't always supplied with electricity and there had to be a charge.

It took exactly fifteen seconds for what Izuku presumed to be the charge. After that, everything *burned*. Hato's muscles were spasmodic as he continued to get electrocuted. Screams tore through his throat at the man's onslaught of pain.

10 seconds... 15 seconds... 25 seconds...

At the thirty second mark the man's black hair went down as the electricity stopped and Izuku was dropped on the ground. His whole body covered in crooked red lines as every few seconds or so his muscles would jerk only causing more pain. His bottom lip was split open, dripping with blood. Some of his skin had been torn up leaving chunks of bright red flush visible. Some skin had turned black and chard, only making the areas where his skin had melted off even more visible.

The man kicked him for good measure before walking off to find more victims. Hato's vision started to darken around the edges as the pain began to numb. Izuku didn't even try to fight it. Once his eyes had closed, he was out like a light. The buzzing in his ears the only thing he could hear.

As he fell deeper into unconsciousness, Midoriya was greeted with an image of a smiling Kacchan and Inko.

(He smiled)

Tomura had gained three people who wanted to be apart of the plan. They were all desperate for some kind of hope to get out of this shitty place, and they thought that this could help. The other five however, did not take it so well. Whether it was because they were afraid of fighting this mini boss or they just thought he was being stupid.

They turned those feelings into anger. And just like the other two times, Tomura got gained up on, as did his team. Tomura's team had tried to fight back, but in all honestly, they were all pretty weak. Tomura had to fight the instinct to fight back as they started to attack him. It was essential to the plan that he would have to loose this round. To hell with his pride (it was already pretty low due to being here for so long). He had to trust that their plan would work. That it would be worth the busted lip and bruises.

He couldn't believe that he had put all of his trust into a kid that was *younger* than him. When *had* he even started to trust this kid (Tomura forgot that he, too was a kid)?

Tomura supposed it didn't matter in the end. It wouldn't change the fact that Hato was the most trustworthy person that Tomura had ever met. And for the first time in forever, Tomura knew that someone cared about him.

Even if it was just some stupid brat.

Izuku disregarded the idea of building a tolerance to being electrocuted. Yeah, he *never* wanted to go through that again. Izuku was out for a full forty-eight hours, not that Izuku was complaining. Who knows when the he'll be able to get a full nights rest again. Although, when he woke up he felt even more tired than before. He just couldn't win, could he?

Tomura, who only attained a bump to the head and a dozen bruises, was *not* happy about Izuku's little break in life. Izuku couldn't tell if he was mad *at* him or *for* him, but either way, Izuku made sure to keep his distance.

His injuries must've been pretty bad, because they had to get their doctor to heal them. Midoriya could tell it was to the bear minimum since everything still hurt and moving too much made it feel like his healed skin would rip.

The greenette took a glance at his right palm to see a star-shaped scar right in the center. He vaguely remembered seeing a glimpse of bone there before passing out. Izuku thought about how beautiful it looked. The shape reminded Izuku of Kacchan's explosions which only brought the familiar feeling of flutters in his stomach.

Hato looked up to Tomura who was studying him carefully, "So, how many people did we get?"

"We got three. They're all pretty weak, though. Hardly even know the basics of fighting. Must've gotten through the other rounds out of pure luck."

Izuku nods, "That's great! Three is more than I expected, and it's okay if they aren't super strong. I don't think they will need to do *too* much fighting anyways."

"Did you figure out what you needed too? Or was being electrocuted a waste?"

Hato lets his cheeks lift, revealing a mischievous smirk. "Oh, I got all the information I needed. It really should be rather simple to bring him down."

Tomura gives a smirk of his own, "So what's the plan?"

Izuku moves into a more comfortable position and begins to explain. He ignores the stretch of his skin and focuses on the new hope settling into his heart.

After all these years, Izuku still finds that hope is one's greatest friend. Hope is often what keeps people going when the odds are stacked against them. It saves people from giving up. If Izuku is certain of one thing, it's that hope is something that will never be evil.

He hopes he'll never forget that.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the semi-late update!

I created a tumblr account. I’m planning on posting updates, art, and just some random thoughts. Plus I would love to talk with everyone!

lushinarose is my account name.

When The Heart Gives Out

Chapter Summary

Izuku decides to break a few unwritten rules.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Inko tried her best. At what, she didn't know. The days were blurring together and it was getting harder to tell left from right. She tried her best to get out of bed, and sometimes that was all she could do. There were days were she couldn't even do that, but Inko couldn't find it in herself to care. She hasn't taken a shower in a week and couldn't even remember when her last full meal was.

She was trying so hard at *surviving* each and every day. Inko had stopped *living* such a long time ago that she forgot what it felt like. Inko had worse bags under eyes than her son did. They just never seemed to go away no matter how much she slept the day away. She was always exhausted and Inko was getting so *tired* of it.

Inko wondered what her son looked like now. It had been a little over half a year since his kidnapping (had it really only been half a year? It felt like an eternity). She refused the thought that her son might be dead; decomposing into the ground with his skeleton being the only remains of him. That was impossible, because Inko knew her son, and she knew that Izuku was one who could spit death in the face without an ounce of fear in his tiny body.

So, no. Her son was *not* dead. And to help her with this belief (no, fact) she imagined what he might look like. Could he be a tad bit taller? Maybe longer hair? Inko wondered if her son would like his hair to be longer. Probably not; it would get in the way and distract him, and Izuku wasn't a big fan of distractions.

Did Izuku think of her as often as she thought him? Again, probably not. She knew that her Izu was probably also thinking of a way to get out of wherever he was.

Was he all alone? A sick part of Inko hoped not. Hoped that there was someone else who fell into the same fate. She hoped that Izuku had someone to talk to, someone who could understand what he was going through.

She never knew that you could miss someone so much that it caused a *physical* ache, and by they way she was looking more and more sick everyday, Inko doubted she would last much longer. She was way too thin. Thin enough where her hair would fall out in clumps like tangled up ribbons. Her body felt weaker and she no longer had an appetite; not that she even had any food on her fridge. The money for the investigation had took up most of her savings.

Inko wondered what her son, her baby, would think of her now. He would probably be so worried and tell her to take better care of herself, but how can she do that when her *whole life* was ripped away from her?!

Inko lasted nine months without her son. She thought she could've lasted longer than that. Longer to finally see her son again, but life wasn't having it.

Inko had a heart of attack because of the lack of care towards her body. By the time the paramedics got there, it was already too late. Inko was dead and nothing could change that. For a mother's heart is always stronger when the love of her life is by her side.

Her funeral was a week later. The clouds along with the Bakugou's (the only ones who truly knew her) had cried for her that day. They wished they could've been there for her more, but they can't bring back the dead. No one can.

They promised her that they would take care of her son once he returns. That was the least they could do. A part of them (all of them) *needed* to do this. Not just for Inko, but for Izuku as well. Izuku is a part of his mother, as was Izuku a part of Inko. Izuku was the last remanent of Mirodyia Inko. The Bakugou's needed Inko's memorie to stay alive. They couldn't loose him no matter what.

Inko was swallowed up by sadness and never found an escape, but the Bakugou's hoped that they could help Izuku escape that fate.

For a heart can only beat so long in the sound of sorrow before it gives out.

Izuku's hair was getting long. It was nothing compared to Tomura's, whose hair was past his shoulders and looked like it did in the last timeline. Izuku's was just long enough where he would have to keep moving it out of the way or it would cover his eyes.

It was distracting, and he wanted to cut it back to it's original length. That was just idle wishing, but maybe he would get lucky and have someone accidentally cut it.

(That would be too risky, though. Especially since the person who would be 'cutting his hair' would be trying to impale him. Probably not the smartest idea he's had.)

"Remember the plan?" Izuku whispered as he saw Keres walk up to their cage.

Tomura gave an eye roll in return. As if to say, *of course I do, idiot.* Hato just smirked at him; it seemed like Tomura will always have that snarky attitude no matter what. In a way, that was kind of reassuring. Something that will never change no matter how many differences Izuku makes.

Once they get to the arena, they both find the people they're working with. They may not know the plan, but it will be easy to explain what they need to do.

As soon as the match started, all of them ran into the mansion and stopped at the living room. Everyone but Hato and Tomura looked nervous and a little scared, but their eyes held determination.

"I need to make this quick. First off, call me Hato and thank you for helping us." Everyone nodded, they're shakiness slowing down as adrenaline overtook their systems, "Now, here's what we need you to do. Find any place where you can turn the water on. Turn it to the hottest temperature you can and leave it running. After that, head to the kitchen." Izuku pointed to the doors to where the kitchen is, "If you need to hide and can't make it to the kitchen, than that's fine. All you need to do is get the steam going and make it through this round."

With that, they all went their separate directions. Tomura and Hato rushed towards the kitchen to get ready. They quickly turned on the sink to the highest temperature and even the dish washer as well, leaving it cracked so the steam from the hot water would escape.

"His power is based off of static electricity. The only thing we can really do to counter it is to make it as humid as possible."

Hato put on the rubber gloves (even though he probably didn't need them, Izuku didn't want to take any chances) while Tomura went off to find a weapon to use. Izuku froze for half a second when the broken bell screeched out the end of the five minutes. It was beginning to get hot and humid in the confined kitchen and was most likely starting to feel like that throughout the whole house if their team had succeeded in doing what they were set to do.

Izuku took to a fighting stance when he heard the familiar thunderous footsteps. He must've looked ridiculous; bright pink rubber gloves that were way to big on him, clothes that were beginning to fall apart, not to mention he must look like an ant to the gigantic man.

Just like last time, the man slowly creaked open the door. He didn't seem to take notice of the humidity, or he did and just didn't care. Once he laid his eyes on Izuku, he let out a laugh that was louder than his footsteps.

"You must have a death wish, kid." The electricity quirk user stated. Hato could tell that he was trying to activate his quirk, but was having a hard time. The strands of hair on his head started rising and Izuku internally cursed. The humidity wasn't enough to stop his powers entirely. Midoryia just hoped it would be enough to weaken him. Once the fifteen second charge was up, he lunged at Izuku. Before the man could grab Hato's neck, Izuku moved his covered hand in front of him. The seeker grabbed onto his arm and activated his quirk.

His quirk was definitely weaker than last time. Izuku could hardly feel the electricity up until the last ten seconds. The man's electricity had started to burn through the rubber, turning Izuku's arm red. By the time the thirty seconds were up, Midoryia's right arm had blisters as the electricity had burned a hole into the rubber gloves.

"Tomura, Now!" Before the black haired man could react, Tomura snuck up behind him and *whacked* the guy in the head with the frying pan Izuku had saw last time.

It was almost comical with how the man's eyes rolled up to the back of his head and fell to the ground face first. Hato and Tomura both shared the same shit-eating grins at their victory. For good measure (and pay back) Izuku kicked the man's stomach before following Tomura out into the living room.

"Stop! The games are over! Everyone who is still conscious will be moving on to the next round!" The announcer seemed angry at the turn of events. Something that couldn't be good.

Hato and Tomura both paled; their fun being sapped away from them. Now came the scary part: the aftermath of their risky decision. As they were both walking out of the mansion, they saw the rest of their team walking out without a scratch on them. Izuku was glad that they got to make it to the next round and hopes that they will survive long enough to make it out of this place. Sadly, it just wasn't something that was in his control.

They both met up with Keres who was so angry that it looked like he forgot how to breathe with how red he was getting. No matter what happens, Izuku will take full blame. It was his whole idea, after all, so it was only fair for him to take the repercussions of his idea. Of course, he didn't tell Tomura this. Hato knew he would try to take the punishment and Izuku just couldn't let that happen.

"The boss wants to see you two." Keres spat at them. It would of been amusing at how irate he was if it wasn't for what he had said. Izuku tried to will his right hand to stop shaking, but the pain mixed with the anxiety made it near impossible. Instead, Izuku just chose to focus on his breathing and try to distract himself from his blistering skin.

They made it to the door that opened up to the boss's room. Keres opened it with a key and shoved both of them into the cluttered room. As Izuku stumbled through, he caught a glimpse of a vase that seemed to *disappear*. It reappeared a second later as if it never disappeared in the first place. Hato made sure to keep that in mind; even if he was just seeing things.

Midoryia glanced to Tomura to see that he looked almost sick. He was about to ask if he was okay until he hears a loud hand smacking a table. Izuku got whiplash from how fast he had turned his head around to look at the boss, his eyes burning. The sight of him sent shivers all throughout Izuku as he got a good glimpse of the man's expression. If Izuku was paying more attention, he would've seen the assistant who had burned him obviously shaking.

The boss looked ready to kill. He looked as if he could barely contain all of that red-hit anger and was *begging* to lash out. Izuku was vaguely aware of the cold sweat running down his neck as he stayed as still as possible. Afraid that one small movement could set the man off. Tomura seemed to think the same thing; Izuku wasn't even sure if he was breathing by how still he was.

They waited him to finally snap. To do anything that would surely scar the both of them, but the boss didn't. He didn't do anything.

That is, until he smiled.

Chapter End Notes

Definitely not one of my most favorite chapter I've written.

Hope everyone has/had a good day.

Rage Tends To Swallow Us Whole

Chapter Summary

The boss, well, he isn’t happy.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"It was me. I was the one who came up with the plan." It had slipped out without Tomura even having to think about it. He needed to protect Hato; the brat had been through a lot more than he did during their time at the arena. He despised how Hato was so willing to sacrifice himself as if he didn't matter. He hates how the scars on Hato's body kept on growing in numbers every time he went to fight.

So this is why he was willing to accept some pain. Just so he could spare the one person who trusted him less of it.

The big man's smile only seemed to grow more. Oh how badly Tomura wanted to run over and turn him to dust, but he couldn't. All he could do was wait for this to be over. "Oh *really?* Or are you just saying that to protect your friend, fifty-nine?"

Friend. Tomura had never really thought about that before. Were he and Hato really friends? He's never had a friend before- were there any special qualifications?

Tomura shook his head, this was *not* the time to be thinking about friends.

"He's lying. I'm the one who planned the whole thing. Blame me, not him." And god damnit, why did Hato have to be so selfless and self-sacrificial? Tomura was trying to do him a *favor*, something he doesn't do often. Hell, he could almost say he's *never* given someone a favor before.

So, yes, Tomura was a little pissed at the fact that he got pushed aside so easily. It didn't seem to matter either way, though.

The boss let his smile slip into a deadly serious expression, "I already knew that. I've been watching both of you for a long time now, and I knew that Eighty-eighty would be able to come up with an idea like that. If this situation were any different, I might be impressed, but it's not. In fact, I'm *livid*."

It was almost like someone had slowed down time. Both Izuku and Tomura watched as the leader slowly opened a drawer from his desk and pulled out on object. That object was a black hand gun, and before either could react, a loud *bang* had echoed throughout the room.

Izuku watched with a trained numbness as the leader's assistant got their brain's blown out. Blood stained the walls and floor. Chunks of brain flew out of the assistant's head, no doubt the rest of it turned to mush by the impact of the shot. One of their eyes had popped out and rolled across the ground hitting Izuku's foot.

But Izuku didn't look down. He maintained eye contact with the boss the entire time; watching, analyzing, the man's movements. Hato wanted to run towards the man, grab his gun, and shoot him himself, but that would be asking for death. Whether it was from the boss, or one of his workers who would bring him to deaths door. So Izuku watched, making sure the graying man wouldn't try to shoot them, too.

"Ha! Aren't you an interesting one, number eighty-eight. You didn't even bat an eyelash! Quite impressive." Izuku didn't *want* any compliments from this man. It made him feel sick and disgusting. "Keres, you're the one who brought this kid here. As an award, I'll let you replace my assistant. The way he wore all that *makeup* was horrendous and unnatural. You'd make a fine replacement." Keres firmly nodded and walked to stand by the evil man's side.

"Thank you, Jude-sama."

Jude. Luck finally came to him; he just got the *leader's* name!

Izuku was proud of Tomura for keeping a stoic face; he knew it was hard, especially since they just watched someone get their brain's blown out.

"Now, eighty-eight. You not only embarrassed me in front of everyone, but you also got one of my strongest men in the infirmary. You need to be punished. I thought for sure that that branding would have given you enough of a warning to not go out of line, but apparently I was wrong." They graying blonde smirked, as if he knew something that Hato did not.

Before Izuku could react, the boss aimed the gun right at Izuku's head.

The second bang was made.

Tomura didn't know who was controlling his body, because it sure as hell wasn't *him*. One second, the leader was pointing a gun at Hato's head, and then Izuku was shoved onto the ground and he was bleeding.

Huh.

Tomura looked down to see blood staining his shirt. That bastard shot him. *He fucking shot him!*

"What *did you do?!*" Hato screamed at him. His emotionless facade falling off as anger (for some reason, Tomura knew it wasn't anger though, but deep-rooted concern).

His first thought was that his shirt was getting dirty- dirtier than it already was. His second thought was that being shot *hurt*. Luckily he got shot in the left shoulder, so he didn't damage any vital organs. Hato ran over to him when he collapsed, catching him right before his head could hit the wooden floor.

"Brat," He breathed out, "making me save you and shit."

Jude's smirk only widened even further, covering half of his face. "Thank you, Fifty-nine, for making my plan a success. Killing this greeny over here wouldn't have taught him a lesson, but if his friend had saved him and got hurt. Well, that would be more effective, right?It's a shame I didn't kill you, though."

Tomura's shoulder was throbbing. Why couldn't that shit-hole just shut up for just one second? He was starting to get a headache.

He wasn't sure if it was because of the migraine, or the blood loss, but Tomura wanted to sleep. He wasn't too worried about dying, he doesn't think Hato would ever let him take the easy way out. With that strange reassurance in his mind, Tomura let his eyes draw to a close.

"He needs medical attention. *Please*." Izuku hated to beg, but he knew that it worked half of the time.

"Have you learned your lesson yet?" Jude's voice was teasing and oh how bad Izuku wanted to *rip his tongue out.*

"*Yes*. Now *help him*." He couldn't loose Tomura, not when they've become so close. Not when he has a promise to keep.

Jude sighed. It was long and overly extended. He was obviously trying to draw this out as long as possible. Izuku hasn't been this angry in a very, very long time. Izuku's hands were shaking and his eyes were watering. All this rage was just too much to keep inside. It was impossible.

"Very well. Keres, bring him to the infirmary. And eighty-eight, since I don't think you've learned your lesson *quite* yet, I'm going to have you participate in the next round today. I'll also put you at a disadvantage as well. Instead of having your quirk restraints turned off, you'll have it on. Which means -oh this is going to be good-, you'll not only be going up against other people with weapons, but with quirks as well. How does that sound?"

Izuku snarled at that. That didn't sound good at *all*.

Hato glared at Keres who roughly slung Tomura over his shoulder, obviously trying to piss him off. Izuku had to do another round in the same day. The thought of it only seemed to exhaust him further. He was already tired and in pain from the last one, and then to add a whole different stage in the *same day*? Not to mention that he'll be at a major disadvantage.

"Here," Jude said walking over to him, "I'll even walk you to the arena myself. This is quite an honor, you know. You should be grateful." Hato had to resist the urge to spit in his face, and instead to grind his teeth together. "I must ask, how did you learn how to fight so well? You're also quite smart for your age."

Izuku's lips remained sealed. He refused to give even the tiniest bit of information about himself. Before Jude could say anything else, they had already made it to the entrance of the arena.

"I would say good luck, but I really don't want luck to be on your side. So, what about *break a leg?*" Izuku couldn't resist to sigh at that. Was this guy serious? For someone with so much power over people, he sure was an imbecile.

Izuku smiled kindly at the man, "And I suppose I should say *thank you*." At Jude's dumbstruck expression, Izuku let out a small risky laugh before entering the arena. He didn't give the man the satisfaction of looking back. Hato glued his face to the front and put one shaky leg in front of the other.

He noticed how everyone in the arena had their quirk restraints turned off. The soft blue glow their cuffs usually had were gone. All of them looked thirsty for bloodshed; something Izuku wasn't keen on being apart of. He noticed how one person looked like they were made out of *knives*. Their skin covered in small, rugged

edges that looked like they could easily draw blood if set out to do so. He noticed a women who had something akin to lizard skin, presumably a camouflage quirk. Izuku was not able to distinguish the other five contenders quirk's since none of the other ones were mutants for as far as he could tell.

Just like a few rounds ago, there was a mountain of different weapons is the center of the arena. Midoriya wasn't sure if it was the exhaustion getting to him, but he could have *sworn* he saw a few guns as well.

Turns out, *Izuku* knew how to shoot a gun. It was apart of his... training when he was kidnapped by the League. He hated them, hated how much power a small machine could hold. How easily it could *kill*.

Although Izuku had to admit, if his eyes weren't playing tricks on him, and there were *actually* guns in the arena, that could be really useful.

Izuku's legs shot straight forward when the sounder had went off, his only hope to possibly win this round was in the middle of the arena. He just had to *make* it there first. Hato ducked and rolled when a series of feathers flew right past him at razor sharp speeds.

He shot straight back up and continued his descent towards the weapons. He was so close. Hato could see a shiny black hand gun not even ten feet away from him.

Right as he was about to reach out for the gun, the ground from underneath him began to turn into sand. In a few seconds, he was waste deep into the ground. Izuku turned his hand to see a women with half of her hair buzzed off staring right at him with her hands into the ground.

Izuku grabbed the gun that was right in front of him (he noticed it was a tranquilizer gun. That's good; he didn't want to accidentally kill anyone) and shot it right at her. It hit her shoulder and almost instantly put her to sleep, making the ground stop sinking. He hurriedly pulled himself out of the sand, his limbs shaking with strain.

Right as Izuku got up, shards flew into his back. It stung for only a second and then his entire back was *numb*. He felt the same shards hit the back of his legs, and just like before, a numbing sensation came over him. Hato collapsed to the ground getting a mouth full of dust, bitting the inside his cheek in the process.

He heard footsteps running towards him; he looked up to the best of his ability to see a women glaring at him with a scowl. Her finger tips were bleeding. Most likely a side effect of her quirk. Izuku spit out some blood onto her shoes, making her face scrunch up in disgust.

Izuku didn't have time to regret his action before a foot made contact with his face, slamming it to the ground officially knocking him out.

When Izuku woke up, he was being dragged to his cell by the collar of his shirt. He hastily clawed at the shirt, trying to stop it from choking. Keres gave a harsh tug nearly making Izuku gag.

"You have no idea how pissed off I am right now." If Izuku could breathe, he might have actually cared (that was a lie. He wouldn't really care unless it had something to do with him). "Because of *you*," Hato nearly rolled his eyes; everything just had to be about him, didn't it? "I have to be the boss's *assistant* now." Like every other time, Keres roughly threw Izuku into the cell.

Hato gasped and coughed, his throat aching. He looked up at Keres who was glaring daggers at him, "You're welcome?" Because honestly, Midoryia had no idea what else to say. He didn't necessarily feel bad for him, why would he?

Keres was about to bite back until echos of footsteps could be heard. Izuku sent Tomura a wary glance who seemed to be doing okay besides being paler than he usually was. As the footsteps came closer they could see who it was.

Jude.

They had never seen him here before, and a lot of the other people trapped in the cells were clearly confused as to who this was. One person however, was not. The man -maybe late thirties with long brown hair and a bushy beard- made the connection within a second.

"You fucking son of a bitch! I'll *kill* you!" The man had pressed his forehead so hard against the metal bars that it started to bleed, but he didn't seem to care. Or maybe he just didn't notice.

Jude stopped in his tracks right in front of the angry man's cell. He didn't give the man the satisfaction of saying anything, and from the looks of it, he didn't even give the man the time of day to even look in his eyes. "Keres, bring him Demetrius. I'm sure he's getting pretty hungry." Izuku doubted he was talking about the man being hungry, but who ever this 'Demetrius' was.

Keres's eyes widened at the request, "Yes, Jude-sama." He ran over to the cell and activated his quirk on the brunette so he wouldn't fight back. The entire time the man was screaming and yelling profanities until his face turned purple.

Something told Izuku that he wouldn't be seeing him again.

The leader continued his descent down the hallway before making brief eye contact with Hato. "Tomorrow you'll be going down there as well, but don't worry, I'll make sure you don't meet the same fate as number twenty-five."

Izuku collapsed to the ground, just realizing that the numbing quirk had worn off. He turned his head to Tomura who was eyeing him with worry. Hato put up a strained smile, "Don't worry, I'm fine. How are you?"

He gave Izuku a skeptical look before answering, "I'm doing fine. No longer bleeding out, so I guess that's good. Do you have any idea who that Demetrius is?"

Hato shook his head, too tired to form any words. He guessed he'd just have to find out tomorrow.

But for now, he was *exhausted* and craved sleep. Midoriya let his eyes close trying to ignore the distant screams of pain in the far background.

Izuku tried to brush away the image of the man getting tortured, being pulled apart, being eaten *alive*.

"I'm sure he's hungry."

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone is doing well :)

We’re Getting Somewhere

Chapter Summary

Izuku makes a phone call.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku walked out of his cell at the very early hours of morning. For once, Keres wasn't the one dragging him around like a rag doll. It was a different guard, and he looked *new*. He was a lot more tense than the other guards and he always glanced wearily at Izuku as if he might try something.

Midoryia eyed the keys that were bouncing lightly on the man's hip. Izuku thinks the man does have a right to be worried, after all, this was too much of an opportunity to pass up.

They walk for a long time. This place is a Labrinth of its own (not maze. Mazes are tied to bright smiles and white ribbons. They're connected to nightmare after memory after nightmare of unblinking eyes and a waterfall of blood), with twists and turns and an infinite number of steps.

The guard and time traveler make it to the designated area. Izuku notices the door leading up to the boss's room is right across the huge metal one they're standing in front of right now. A new spark of irritation rises as Izuku realizes that they just about went in a full circle. All of that sauntering was only to tire him out. Not that he even needed it; Izuku was already severely debilitated from everything.

He wanted his mom.

He wanted her sweet smiles and warm hugs. He wanted her loving eyes directed towards him that always made him feel at home. He wanted to hear her beautiful soothing voice whisper reassurances to him.

Izuku knew he was selfish and stupid to wish for such a luxury.

Hato watched as the guard pulled out the key ring and grabbed the smallest silver one. He put the keys back to his hip and opened the big metal door. The inside of the door had gigantic claw marks and had dry blood smearing half of it. It looked as if someone had roughly collided with the door and was dragged down against it.

As Hato tentatively started to walk towards the door, he pretended to run into the side of the man. With how short he was (was he five or six now? It's been so long since he's seen the world. Was it possible to feel claustrophobic in a space so big?), it was easy to snag the keys from the man. Izuku swiftly tucked the keys underneath his shirt and fastened up his paste towards the inside of the room.

The sound the door made when it closed made Izuku flinch. His ears picking up a soft click of the door automatically locking. Izuku attempted to cease the rising panic that was building up in his chest, but the lone finger and splattered brains next to him did nothing but escalate the feelings of consternation.

The room was medium size; the only light were the torches dimly lit on the walls. None of that mattered, though, because the biggest dog Izuku had ever seen was sleeping in a corner of the room with skeletons surrounding it like stuffed animals. The dog was clearly one of those quirked animals. The dog being at least ten times bigger than himself. The giant hound had a scar the shape of an 'X' over it's left eye. The claws looked razor sharp, no doubt used to tear people to shreds.

Izuku stayed as close to the door as possible. Cautiously taking steps backwards in order to manage a fast escape. He needed to get out and run as fast as he could to Jude's office. He needed to make a phone call, and this may be the only chance he could do that.

Right as Izuku was about to turn towards the door, Jude's voice spoke up through the invisible speakers. A spike of fear ran through him when the hound's eye snapped open to reveal a bloodthirsty orange color.

"Ohhh Demetrius~," Jude's voice sounded playful and excited, "I got you a new toy! Don't worry, Eighty-eight. I won't let him kill you. After all, how would you learn your lesson if you're dead?" Right as Jude finished speaking, the hound bolted right towards Izuku. Hato jumped to the side, missing Demetrius's charge by a landslide. The dog slammed into the door before going at Izuku again.

As Hato was trying to run and dodge the animal's onslaughts of attacks, he tried to find the small silver key. This distracted him, however, and gave the dog a chance to slash at the his right shoulder. The skin tore and red, inky blood started to ooze out. Thankfully, the wound wasn't deep and would only cause a disturbance for little while.

Izuku didn't even notice the pain as he ran towards the metal door, correct key in hand. Demetrius was charging at him again as Izuku struggled to unlock the door. No one had seemed to notice what exactly he was doing, and right before Demetrius could snap his neck, Hato opened the door and slammed it right in front of the hound's face.

Right after the door was shut, Izuku *ran*. Even when his lungs screamed for air and his shoulder burned, he continued to sprint up the steps to the leader's office. He opened the door, and shut it as quietly as he could. Midoryia's eyes instantly locked onto the phone on the boss's desk. It was his only hope to get everyone out of this hell-hole. There was only one person that he knew without a doubt would help him and *succeed* when it came to situations like these.

Detective Tsukauchi.

The man had given Izuku his phone number in the last timeline; he thought it would be good to have since Izuku was always finding himself in sticky situations. Midoryia had never been so thankful for a handful of numbers in his life.

It rung three times before a click was heard. Izuku was switching between feet, trying to find a way to distribute all the anxiety and adrenaline. He didn't have a lot of time- it wouldn't take long for them to find him.

"This is Detective Tsukauchi."

Before the man could say anything else, Izuku started to talk as audibly and fast as he could, "This is Midoryia Izuku." He heard a choking sound on the other line but quickly continued, "I'm a child that went missing who knows how long ago. Now, I need you to listen to me very carefully because I don't have a lot of time and I don't think I'll get a chance like this one ever again. The person's name who kidnapped me is Keres and he has some kind of paralysis quirk that can only affect one person at a time. He drove us about ninety-five minutes away from Musutafu. I, along with many, *many*, others are trapped at an illegal fighting arena with a man named Jude being the leader of it all. I haven't figured out his quirk yet, but I think it's something really powerful. He's big with blond graying hair and-"

Izuku heard the door open to reveal a out of breath Keres and Jude, glaring daggers at him. Before he had to let go, Izuku quickly spoke into the phone one ever again, "Please tell my mom and the Bakugou's that I miss them so much and that I promise I'll see them again." With that, Izuku hung up the phone just as the familiar numbing of his limbs came over him.

Jude's scrunched up face looked down on Izuku. Even if he got caught (it was inevitable, and just about impossible to do what he just did without getting caught) Izuku still felt proud. Hato smirked at the boss, not needing to say anything. The smile alone sent enough messages to Jude.

I won this round, Jude.

The leader turned to Keres and harshly pointed to Hato, "Put him in the night room. Three months."

Izuku knows he shouldn't close his eyes, but the zero sleep and the mental and physical exhaustion of today (it was still the early hours of morning. He wondered if Tomura was awake. Wondered when he will see him again.) had finally caught up to him.

All he needed to do was close his eyes, and everything could fade away. If only for a little while.

"Did you find the location?" Naomasa asked one of the police officers. The women had a quirk that could trace anyone from a phone call; it turned out to be very useful in certain situations. The officer nodded and scrambled to write it down on his notepad.

His eyebrows furrowed once he saw the location, "Thank you. You may leave now." She nodded and left his messy office.

He couldn't believe that the kid called. How did he even know his phone number in the first place? He supposed it didn't matter, the boy had clearly risked his safety to make the call.

"Tell my mom and the Bakugou's that I miss them so much and that I promise I will see them again." Tsukauchi sighed for the up tenth time that day. He wasn't looking forward to breaking the news to the kid that his mother died. He had lost count of how many family members have died because of a love one gone missing or killed.

It was hard to save everyone. Especially from the monster called loneliness.

The detective sat up right and began to get back to work, but first, he had a few phone calls to make.

The Bakugou's were not expecting the detective to be at their door this morning, but here he was, asking to come in. They ushered him in and prepared some coffee for all of them and a cup of water for Katsuki. The Bakugou's were all still mourning the death of Inko, who had passed away just about two months ago. They all looked rough around the edges, to say the least.

Now, with the detective sitting across from the Bakugou's, he pulled out his phone. "I have something to show you. This is major and even gave us an estimate of a destination." He presses play on the recording and lets the family listen to it.

When Katsuki heard his lost best friend's voice, he wanted to cry and punch and smile all at the same time. His friend sounded different from what he remembered, dry and scratchy with less feeling woven into it. He's

been angry for such a long time; not knowing how Deku was doing was tearing him apart and the only way he knew how to deal with it was to turn all of that *hurt* and *pain* into anger.

It was especially hard on his birthday. His first birthday without Izu. That day was filled with tears and a destroyed room (he had been holding in his anger for *so long*. The bottle of rage had opened with full force and his bedroom had to pay the price for it) and a wish to see his Izu again.

When he heard Izuku's rushed voice promise him that he'll be with them soon, that he misses them, Katsuki wanted to shout at the phone and say that he'll be waiting. He wanted to pretend that Deku was still on the other line so he could talk to him and reassure him that everything will be okay.

When Izuku came back, Katsuki will hug him for as long as possible. He needed to be there for his best friend, especially since (Oh, dear god, Izuku doesn't *know*) auntie passed away. Katsuki will save his Izu in any way he can, no matter how hard it is.

The recording stops and Tsukauchi puts his phone back into his pocket. "Midoryia-kun risked his safety for this phone call. He not only gave us enough time to find the perimeter of his location, but he also gave us information on the boss. Although, it's not much, it's still going to be really helpful. Going by what he said, there's a lot more people held there than we thought, so the rescue plan will take longer than what was originally planned."

They all nod. Katsuki was already making up scenarios in his head about the moment he's finally reunited with his best friend again. "And what does Midoryia mean by 'fighting arena'." Masaru asks warily. His eyes going back and forth between the detective and his son. He wanted to make sure that his son was handling this as well as he could. Masaru couldn't imagine how hard this has been on his son, and is restless to finally get the other half of his son reunited with him.

Naomasa pales slightly before speaking up, "I don't think Bakugou-Kun should hear this part." Katsuki's eyes narrowed at the detective, as if he was daring him to make him leave.

Mitsuki nods, "Brat, go up stares. It's grown up talk time."

Katsuki just crosses his arms and sinks further into his chair, "No! I'm going to find out sooner or later anyways. Might as well know it now." For being seven, Katsuki was ingenious. Putting all those hours of studying had really expanded his cognitive thinking, which only made his argumentative skills even sharper.

Mitsuki and Masaru didn't know if they should be proud or irritated at their son's growing skill at winning arguments.

The Bakugou's didn't say anything else, so Tsukauchi decided to continue on, "The illegal fighting arena... well, it's not good. It's when they force people to fight each other and tons of people watch. Usually the people who are fighting are kept in poor conditions and are given minimal food and water. It's not rare for people being forced to fight to the death, either." The family gasps at that. No one could imagine sweet little Izuku ever killing anyone, but they knew that other people were capable of that.

Katsuki knew that the boy would cry over a dead fly, but he also knows that Izuku *had* seen a dead body before. A long, long time ago.

The explosion user didn't want to think of his best friend having to see *more.*

His palms crackled and sizzled at the thought.

Naomasa takes his last sip of coffee and begins to stand up, "I've only seen one other fighting arena and that was the whole rundown of how it worked. However, I'd do know that fighting arenas can become a lot more complex and dangerous as well, and something's telling me that this may be one of the more... *complicated* ones."

The Bakugou's stiffly nod. The family oddly quiet for being known as loud people (not including Masaru). "When do you think you'll get Izu back? It has to be soon, right?"

"I hope so, kid. I hope so." The detective bows and makes his way towards the door, "Thank you for letting me talk to you. I thought you would have wanted to hear his voice and know about the progress we made."

Masaru and Mitsuki smiled tightly at the man. Katsuki however, didn't pay attention to the detective. Getting lost in the ideas of what he could do to help Izuku when he finally comes back home.

"No, thank you, Detective Tsukauchi. If anything new comes up, please, call us." Masaru expressed gratefully, showing Naomasa out.

Once the door was shut, the parents looked at each other before staring at their son. He was the calmest that they had seen him in a long time, and they didn't know what to think. They didn't know if they should be worried or concerned or if they should do anything at all.

They were nescient about a lot of things these days. They used to be so sure of themselves, but now, now they were at a lost.

So they did the one thing they knew was right and sat next to their son, talking about all the things they could do to support and aid Izuku once he gets back.

Even with the severe lack of sleep, Aizawa wasn't tired. His eyes burned from staring at his screen for hours on end and he couldn't feel his legs from Hizashi sleeping on them, but for the first time in awhile, Shouta wasn't tired.

He had just gotten off of the phone with Nemuri about the newest discovery. She had been in charge of finding info on Jude and finding cases of other missing people that might be linked to the fighting arena. His and Hizashi's jobs were to help find the exact location of the arena (a tracer quirk could only go so far) and help find other people who may be working for the arena.

Of course, they were all going to be apart of the rescue mission. All of them having reliable quirks for this raid.

Shouta couldn't believe that this *kid* had risked his safety and potentially *life* for the sake of this one phone call. He didn't even know this problem child, but he felt a deep rooted connection with him they day this case had started.

It felt like he had a personal connection with the boy, and for the love of *god*, Aizawa had no *fucking* clue why. Shouta doesn't like not knowing things, and he absolutely *despises* being uncertain. The feeling is rare and unwelcome.

Aizawa sighs and lays down next to his husband. He still wasn't tired, but he'd rather sleep than think about the fact that he *knows* this problem child even if he's never actually *met* him before. He wants to avoid the sure to some migraine for as long as he could.

Besides, he's been living off of coffee and jelly pouches for the last two days, and he deserves to sleep. He can continue with his search tomorrow, when his mind isn't buzzing with questions that always go unanswered.

Shouta hopes he'll get to meet this kid soon.

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone has/has a good day!

Developing While Regressing

Chapter Summary

It’ so cold and dark and Izuku just wants it to end.

But it doesn’t.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Night Room is pitch black and insanely quiet. Izuku decided that he doesn't like it. At all. It's isolating and the quietness is killing him with how *loud* it is.

At least with the cells, he could briefly tell what time of day it was. He knew when the night guards switched with the day guards and vice-verca, but here he has no *clue*. Jude said he was supposed to be in here for *three months*. Which, in Izuku's mind, was absolutely *insane.*

His arms were covered in scratch marks, not that he could see them. It was the only way to keep him grounded and not have a panic attack. It was just so dark and there were times where Izuku didn't even know if he had closed his eyes or not. He couldn't tell how big the room was, but it seemed so *small*. It was always so hard to breathe, but no matter how hard he clawed at the door, ripping off his own finger nails out in the process, he couldn't get out.

He needed to get *out*.

Hato never knew he would miss Tomura's snarky comments so much, but he did. A lot. He wondered how he was doing, if he had fought in the assassin stage yet. Would Tomura use his quirk? Or was he too scared of what would happen if he did?

How long has it been?

Izuku rubbed a thumb over the white ribbon tied to his wrist. It calmed him down and made him focus. Izuku tried to only let the good memories of Madoka play through his mind, but sometimes the bad ones (covered in blood, always covered. Red red red, so much red-) would slip through and play in his mind as well. That's when Izuku ripped his hand away from the white ribbon like it had burned him.

He needed to talk to someone, or else he *swears* his own mind will swallow him whole.

It's been about a month since Tomura has seen Hato. He doesn't know where his friend is, and it's starting to freak him out. He doesn't even know if Hato is even *alive*; the thought always sending him into a mild panic (he can't loose his first friend. If he does he might just go crazy. The urges of tearing up his skin raw are back stronger than ever now. His skin itches and all he wants to do is scratch and scratch and scratch-).

Today's his first day fighting in the Assassin stage. He doesn't want to go -he never wants to go-, especially without Hato their to encourage him or even fight with him. Tomura feels like he's been spoiled with Hato's kindness, and now that it's been ripped away from him, he feels empty and fragile.

Before Hato was brought to the arena, Tomura was closed off towards everyone. No one had ever been even remotely kind to him, so as a coping mechanism, he convinced himself that kindness made you weak. It helped in a toxic sort of way. Made it easier to accept that no one has (and ever will) be kind to him. After all, he couldn't afford to be weak.

Then Hato came along. His bright determined eyes and warm smile (the brat's hand were shaking. He said he wasn't scared. Tomura knew he was lying.) made it hard to ignore him. The kid was practically enveloped in kindness that had blinded Tomura before he even had the chance to turn away.

Tomura tried his damn hardest to run away from it (he *can't* be weak. People get mad when he shows a hint of fragility), but it was futile. He let himself sink into the warm blanket of affection throughout the months that they had known each other. What was surprising, was that Tomura didn't feel weaker, no, he felt *stronger*.

Now, stepping into the arena with his power coursing through his veins freely (its been aeons since he's felt his quirk. It both comforts him and terrifies him). Tomura thought that he would feel more powerful before, and in a sense, he does. But the confidence he used to have when Hato was here was gone, nowhere to be seen.

He looks around and analyzes his surroundings. What he doesn't expect to see is Hato, right across from him. The sight of him makes him want to cry in relief and throw up at the same time.

Hato is standing -barely-, his whole body is shaking in panic. He looks so small and frail; Tomura had now doubt that a leaf could knock him over. His arms are covered in blood and most of his fingernails are messing (for some reason, Tomura knows that none of the guards or Jude did this. The thought only makes the idea of throwing up more appealing).

Izuku forgot how painful his quirk was. Having gone almost a whole year without it created over stimulation with how sudden the quirk came rushing back. He was already blinded by the light from being in the dark for so long, and now his ears were ringing from all the sounds he could hear and every movement felt like he was scraping his skin against concrete.

He knew he was in the arena, which meant Hato was practically a dead man walking. He was struggling to stand and couldn't open his eyes. All Izuku could do was sit there and try to hone in his senses; he had to rely on his sixth sense to tell him when danger was coming while *also* trying to control his quirk.

His heart was beating out of his chest as Izuku tried to remember how to control his quirk. He had to calm his breathing, but his body wasn't listening to him.

You're going to die here.

This is it.

Might as well give up. Maybe death would be enjoyable. Infinite sleep. Doesn't that sound nice?

"Why won't you give up?" A corrupted man asks, almost pleadingly. His neck and hands bleeding from all the picking and scratching. "No one's going to save you. Face it, brat, You're a lost cause."

Izuku snaps out of his panic attack (*Really Izuku?* Just *had to have a panic attack in the middle of a battle*) when a hand lands on his shoulder with one finger avoiding contact with him. Hato instantly realizes it's Tomura and tries to regain his breathing again.

It gets better, and his breathing becomes more even. Midoriya's eyes finally readjust and is able to open his eyes without being bombarded with overwhelming light. He regains some control of his quirk and is able to even sort out all of his senses just like he used to. Soon enough, handling the quirk becomes like second nature as the muscle memory kicks in.

"Thank you." Hato's voice is rasp for not using it in so long, but he manages so get his gratitude across to Tomura.

"Sure thing." Izuku and Tomura separate to bring down as many people as possible. This is a stage they can't win together and might even have to fight each other.

As Izuku is fighting two kids that look to be in their mid-teens, he see's a man with an axe as an arm creeping up on Tomura. Izuku tries to gain his friend's attention but Tomura was busy fighting a women who's skin was *literal* fire.

He takes down the teenager with relative ease, grateful that their quirks weren't helpful in the fight. He turns around to see the man with the axe quirk raise his arm right above Tomura's back.

Hato doesn't remember much of what happened after that. All he recalls is him screaming out Tomura's name and then everyone on the ground passed out near the walls of the arena. He see's the man who was trying to attack Tomura with a knife sticking out of his mouth and poking out at the back of his head.

"Eighty-eight wins with startling ease! He even managed to kill someone, how impressive is that?!"

Kill?

Suddenly the blank splotches of his memories become clear again. He remembers feeling light as he grabbed onto what seemed like multiple threads in his mind. Hato remembers pushing everyone back (including Tomura.) into the wall and levitating a knife. He remembers throwing the sharp object into the mans head.

Izuku unlocked another quirk.

He hurt Tomura.

He had killed someone.

The very little food he has eaten is deposited as Izuku throws up. He let's the guards turn on the quirk represents and throw him back in the night room.

Izuku is still in shock as he squeezes his knees tight to his chest, making it hard to breathe. The burn in his chest grounds him, but that somehow makes it worse. He becomes more aware of what happened- of what he just *did*. He had lost control and *killed* someone. Hato represses the urge to throw up again and opts to let out choke sobs that only limit his breathing further.

New memories of the time before this one come rushing back before he could even comprehend them.

"Since you handled the last one so well, I decided that I am going to give a new one. This one much more powerful than the last." Izuku turns away from Dabi who had previously been training him to meet All For One's face.

"Please," Izuku begged. He hated how weak he sounded, but it was the only thing he could do at the moment. "Don't give me another one. I'll do anything else."

The villain smirked, "like it or not, you will get another quirk. You should be happy I have taken such an interest in you, son. Soon enough you'll become the perfect puppet."

Izuku is meant with blinding pain as his supposed father forces another quirk on him. The process lasts only ten seconds but it feels like hours to Izuku.

He receives the quirk, and it disgusts him how good it feels to have a new quirk. It's hard to describe what it exactly feels like, but it's similar to having a warm blanket cover you while you sit next to a fireplace after a long day of playing in the snow.

Midoryia doesn't know how to control his new quirk, and because of that, he sends himself flying into the wall and knocks himself out.

Midoryia takes big gulps of air as the memories come to a halt. He's dangerous. Izuku has always been a danger, but it took him this long to find out. He just unlocked a highly powerful telekinesis quirk and has very little time to practice it. He doesn't know anything about this quirk. Not if there's any possible drawbacks or if there's any requirement in order to use it. He just took someone's life with it. He's a *monster*. The man didn't deserve death.

(The image of the man laying on the ground with blood leaking from his eyes. A puddle of blood forming around his head. Why couldn't Izuku pushed him back like he did with everybody else?)

Izuku had almost forgotten the feeling of fearing himself, but now it was fresh. The sentiment rushing back in wave, each one bigger than the one before.

He just couldn't do anything right, could he? Maybe staying in the night room was for the best. He wouldn't have to watch Tomura's trusting gaze get twisted into one of fear and disgust.

It hurt Izuku to be alone, but at least it didn't hurt anybody else.

_____

What. The. *Fuck*.

Tomura expected a lot of things from the Assassin stage. Being thrown into a wall by his friend? Not one of them.

His entire body throbbed and his head was beginning to pound from an oncoming migraine. It wasn't from the collision with the wall, but from all of the *confusion*. It had entirely rattled his brain to a mess of incomplete thoughts and worries.

He found himself being scared *for* Hato. Something wasn't right, something was *never* right with the kid. Tomura shivered at the memory of his friend's panicked eyes and shaky limbs. Wherever Jude is keeping him is not fairing well on Hato's mental health (not to say it was good before). Then for some reason, he had lost control of his quirk. Even Tomura, who hadn't been able to use his for a lot longer, controlled his with relative ease. Although, it did shock him at the power of his own quirk. It had seemed to grow in power (he was going to hurt someone again. What if he hurt, no, *killed* Hato?) even when he hadn't used it in over a year.

The last thing he remembers is Hato yelling out his name and then being slammed into the wall. When he awoke, he was back in his cell with Hato no where to be seen. Tomura was growing more and more restless as the days passed on with no sight of Hato.

What if they were making him do extra rounds in the arena? Or torturing him? He hated not knowing where the brat was. His mind gifted him with new anxieties every time he thought about the greenette. Tomura humors himself by being thankful for having grayish hair, or else he was sure he would have half a head of grey hairs from all the stress he's endured.

Tomura wanted all of this to be over. He wanted to find out Hato's real name and meet his mom that he so fondly talks about. Most of all, Tomura wants to have a normal life with Hato as his little brother.

He doesn't think that'll ever happen. At least, not for a very long time.

Tomura will wait. After all, some things are worth waiting for.

Chapter End Notes

I am so sorry for the late update! I caught a cold and haven't been sleeping well. So in short, I've been exhausted. I hoped everyone liked this chapter, though.

Want to wish everyone a good day! Thank you so much for reading!

The Beginning of an Evolution

Chapter Summary

Aizawa wants some decent sleeps, All Might is confused, and Izuku talks to ghosts.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He was standing in his classroom, only it was filled with unrecognizable faces. These weren't his kids that he was teaching, he had expelled all but two this year. All of their faces were blurry but he could still make out some of their features. One had pink fluffy hair, while someone else had red spiky hair. He could see angry but warm red eyes that confused and bothered Aizawa. There was what seemed to be a floating uniform and another kid had heterochromatic eye that seemed to be freezing.

Out of all of them, one stood out the most to Shouta. He wasn't blurred like all the others, but instead crystal clear. The problem child (where did that nickname come from?) had green curly hair and the biggest most determined eyes the hero had ever seen. His smile was bright and wide, as if he was still getting used to it.

Aizawa felt a special connection with the child -with all of them, really, but that didn't make any sense. He had never met these students before, plus he had sworn to himself that he would never get close to his students. It was too perilous.

He didn't get to ponder it for much longer because the room started to blur and turn and soon he was somewhere else. When everything stopped turning, Shouta realized that he was in a middle of a war zone. The sky was red and the smoke could be mistaken for rain clouds. It smelled like blood, death, and the foul smell of decaying flesh.

A hand suddenly grabbed his right arm and he was face to face with a man. He had a hand covering his face but Aizawa could distinctly see the almost black red eyes. The eyes were replete with detestation, but Shouta strangely didn't think it was directed towards him.

As he was slowly starting to decay (the pain was unbearable. He couldn't handle it. It was crawling up his arm and oh shit he was going to die wasn't he?) he made eye contact with the problem child. The teacher's heart all but broke at the sight of the child. The greenette was dressed in an all black baggy jumpsuit that almost looked like it came from sort of army. His face was as blank and empty as his eyes. The kid was standing there as Aizawa slowly died, but something in Shouta *knew that the kid was trying his hardest to move,* to *save.*

Right as the decaying was about to reach his heart, Aizawa woke up with a startled gasp. He gripped the side of his shirt where his heart was until his knuckles turned white.

He was still trying to regain his breath when Hizashi woke up, "What's wrong, Sho? Bad dream?". Shouta released his hand from his shirt and opted to hold his husband's hand in a vice-like grip.

The memories of the night terror were already fading. The only things he could remember was the kid's (problem child, he had called him) bright smile and how connected he felt towards all the students.

It just all felt so *real*. Like it wasn't a dream at all, but a jumble of memories. That couldn't be possible, though. He had never seen a smile like the teen's and he definitely had *not* been disintegrated before.

Aizawa tries his best to forget about the dream and snuggle closer to his husband for comfort. He was still slightly shaky and his hand throbbed (did nightmares really cause phantom pains? Shouta supposed it was a possibility).

"Something like that."

_____

He was chasing something. Some sort of villain. He had to hurry, his time was running out.

Time? Since when did he have a limit?

He dashed through a tunnel to see some sort of sludge villain suffocating a plain looking boy. Like his body was being controlled, All Might used his power to blow the villain into two empty plastic water bottles.

Yagi looked over to see the boy had passed out next to a notebook of sorts. With the villain stuffed in his pockets, the hero walked over and signed the greenette's notebook before slightly slapping and shaking him. He knew it wasn't the most adequate thing to do, but he was going to transform back soon.

The kid's eyes immediately widened at the sight of him, sputtering out a thank you. They had exchanged a few words before All Might had to leave.

Except... The boy grabbed onto his leg and now they were hundreds of feet in the air. Did this boy had a death wish or was he just some crazy fanboy?!

They landed on a roof and All Might had to explain his injury (when did he get that? He's pretty sure he still had his stomach a few hours ago). He also got to have a good look at the antsy teen now. For some reason, he felt oddly protective of this kid. He seemed so familiar that it was driving him insane.

A few hours later, he had given the kid his quirk. Young Midoryia was a ray of sunshine and practically any other thing that was warm and kind. Yagi felt as if he knew every corner of this boy, but he had just met him today. So why did it feel like he had known him for a few years instead of a few hours?

Toshinori closed his eyes and once he opened the again, he was face to face with his mortal enemy. Isn't he supposed to fight him in a few days? And why did All for One not have a face?

The most shocking of it all was the boy standing next to him. It was young Midoryia who had one of the most pained yet empty expressions he had ever seen on anybody.

Yagi knew he had lost his power a long time ago (had he? When?), which meant he was already dead. Right before All for One could do anything, Yagi smiled at the kid who he thought of as a son (Toshinori had never felt that way about anyone. Why was he feeling this connection towards somebody he hardly even knows?)

He wakes up before the multiple black spears could pierce his chest. For some reason, Yagi tries to cling on to the boy with the vibrant green hair.

Young... What was his name again? Again, it seemed so familiar, but in a different sense. Hadn't he met a kid with green hair a few years ago? He had told Toshinori his name, but he couldn't remember it. Didn't the kid say something to him? It was important, like a hidden warning.

He had felt the same connection towards the young kid as he did with the teen in his dream.

Why couldn't he remember?

Today was the day Izuku would be brought back to his cell. It had been two months since he gained his new quirk, and ever since then he's been dissociating on and off. It was the only way to keep the panic at bay. Whenever he was in the right mind, all Izuku could think about was how he was a *monster* and how he had taken away someone's life like it was *easy*.

(It *was* easy. That man hadn't been the first one Izuku killed. Midoryia lost count of how many people he killed during his last life, but it had been *so many.* What he did remember however, were their faces right before they took their last breath. Some terrified, some heartbroken, some telling him it was *okay. Everything will be okay.*

He never believed them.)

When Izuku woke up from his sleep (He didn't even remember closing his eyes. He let himself be vulnerable. He was so *weak*-) he was back in his cell. Even though it was dark, the small flicker of the torches hung up on the walls burned his eyes. He hadn't seen light in *so long*.

"Hato? Is that you?" Tomura rasped, his voice dry and scratchy from having just woken up. Midoryia slightly cringed at the blood he could see dripping off of the other's neck.

Izuku crawled away from Tomura as far as he could, bumping his back in to the wall (he had to get away from him. What if Izuku hurt him-).

Tomura either ignored his friend's panic or was too tired to notice as he got up to sit next to Izuku who was beginning to shake.

"Hey? Are you okay?" No, he wasn't. He didn't know what to do, he just felt so *stuck* and he wanted help *so much.*

He didn't deserve help. Not after all the things he's done.

"Please..." Hato's voice was small and quivering, something that Tomura has never heard from his usually strong friend. "Don't. Don't come any closer. I- I don't want to hurt you."

"Well now you're just being stupid." Izuku didn't say anything after that, and neither did Tomura. They sat in empty silence, both secretly enjoying each others presence.

"I past the Assassins a few weeks ago. We're both serpents now. Have they let you play yet?" Izuku shakes his head, his now longer hair covering his eyes. Tomura sighs in disappointment when Hato doesn't talk.

"You have a really powerful quirk. Didn't you say it was complicated?" That doesn't seem to be the right thing to say because the greenette's shoulders hunch up higher than they already are and his breath hitches.

"I didn't know I had it." The brat talking is almost more surprising then the words that spewed out of his mouth.

"Yeah? And how did you *not* know about your super powerful quirk?"

Izuku shrugs, he's never told anyone before about the other time. Knowing someone's potential death is scary enough, telling the *actual* people (that he killed-) is a whole other story that he isn't ready to tell. "Like I told you, it's complicated. Maybe... Maybe someday I'll tell you. Just not now."

Izuku lets the arms of his friend and practically brother wrap around him in a comfortable embrace. Hato hugs back quickly; being touch starved for three months did more to him than he would like to admit.

They both fell asleep like that; taking enjoyment in each other's solace. They were each other's encouragement and determination. Without the other, well, neither would like to think what would've happened to them in this place.

They kept each other from loosing themselves.

Izuku stood on what seemed to be a grey planet surrounded by a pitch black sky. He immediately recognized it as the place he had met the past One For All users. His eyes quickly landed on all of the past users standing in front of him, all looked so loving and proud (proud? How could they be proud?).

The seventh, Nana, walked up to him and hugged him. Izuku felt tears spring into his eyes; the hug felt so much like his mother's.

Nana released him from the hug all to soon and squeezed his shoulders. "We are all so proud of you. We know it's hard, but you're doing great. Just remember, you're never alone. We'll always be there for you."

Izuku only sobbed, because how could that be true? How could anyone say he was doing great when every time he tried to help, it just got worse.

"Think about it this way, kid." The sixth user assured, "You're not only planning on saving the heroes from the future, but you're also trying your damn hardest at saving all of these people, too. You're not a monster, kid.

You're a hero."

"And heroes can't save everyone." The fourth added.

Izuku eventually stopped crying, and nodded. The thing is, is that he knew that. It was just so hard to accept it, so instead of doing that, he tried to save everyone anyways.

All the past users, including himself, began to dissolve as disappear. Nana being the first one to fully leave, sending him a motherly smile as a goodbye.

Soon, it was only the first and Izuku. "There's something we need to tell you, something that could help you get out of this place." They were almost completely gone and were running out of time. "You're smart, and we know you'll figure it out. Just remember all of the things you've seen here that you've questioned."

Everything turned pitched black, but before he woke up, he heard all of the user's voices say at once, "You may not have One For All right now, but you are still a part of it. ***We*** *are still apart of you."*

When Izuku wakes up, it's still the early hours of morning, but he feels refreshed. He looks at Tomura who's sleeping not to far from him and he smiles.

Yeah, maybe he isn't as alone as he thought he was.

Chapter End Notes

I honestly love this chapter :)

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Waiting in the Wings

Chapter Summary

The serpent level.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The serpent level had Izuku in disbelief. The entire arena was one, big humongous pool filled to the brim with water that was as dark as the night sky. The arena was deeper than before- at least fifty feet deep now, if Izuku were to guess,

How were these stages set up so fast?

He and Tomura were raised far above the water, hunched up and anxiety-ridden. The signal was announced and both were harshly pushed off of the platform by Keres. They twisted and spun until they collided with the cold water, both bodies stinging from the harsh impact the water had brought them. Right as they entered the gigantic pool, a tiny air bubble formed around both of their heads.

Even so, Izuku struggled to will himself to breath as the ice cold water tickled at his skin. Hato swung his arms around and lightly kicked his legs so he wouldn't sink even further down this black hole that lead to who-knows-where.

"My quirk won't work where we are now, not unless we get to a wall."

Wall...

An idea -or half of one- slams into Izuku like a train. "We should wait for you to use your quirk until the next time we do this."

The young teen dramatically sighs and rubs his temples with one hand, "You have another one of your crazy plans?"

In the distance, but quickly approaching, Izuku hears large ripples getting louder and louder. Izuku squints his eyes to see a women with pearly scales and fins on the sides of her legs and arms. Hato could barely see her legs at the speed they were kicking at. In a surge of panic, Hato feels for the imaginary string and raises his

right hand once he finds it. With a small whoosh of the water, he slams his hand down as fast as he could with the water resisting. After the action, Tomura gets forced a few meters below him.

Hato doesn't even get a chance to send him a pitying glance as the women *rams* her body into him. The air is knocked out of his lungs at the impact and he struggles greatly to get out of the women's hold. They are going so fast that the force of the water isn't letting him move his arms. He's flopping around like a rag doll waiting for whatever this will bring him to.

The women all but *throws* him into the cement wall (*How far had they traveled?*). Hato's back meets the brute of the force, cracking the cement behind him. If he hadn't completely lost his breath before, he had now. Izuku was in too much of shock to move, and even if he did, it would've been fruitless with how painful it would be. He let himself sink further and further, the only focus was trying to get air back into his starving lungs.

Breathing hurt. It *burned* and was almost no better than having no air at all. Izuku let out a silent scream as his back landed on the ground, the little contact sending another shock of pain run up and down his spine. Everything began to get dizzy and light as the pain became secondary.

I really have to stop passing out like this.

"Remember all of the things you've questioned."

When Izuku wakes up he is cold and in pain. He can't move without his back sending a jolt of agony throughout his body, so he stays still and breathes. It's the very early hours of morning, and Izuku thinks he might hear the melody of birds outside.

He knows his ears are only playing games with him; he hasn't heard the sound of morning birds in what seems to be an eternity. Instead of dwelling on the silence, Hato starts pondering what the first user told him.

The things he's questioned? About what? The arena? Izuku contemplates All For One's brother's message until his brain starts to pound against his skull.

He thinks about how the stages all got set up so quickly. The maze, house, and pool appeared as if they had always been there.

The memory of the vase in Jude's office played in his mind. It was a few months ago, and Izuku had nearly forgotten about it. The vase had disappeared for a split second, so fast the Izuku could've mistaken it for a blink. The more Izuku contemplates about, the more odd and skeptical got.

It was almost as if it was an-

Illusion.

It made perfect sense, but who's quirk was it? Could it be more than one? Judging my how detailed everything was, the quirk was immensely powerful.

The quirk had to be Jude's. He had the power to make the arena dangerous, and more *entertaining*. That one time when the vase disappeared, the leader could have been so overwhelmed by rage that he had lost control. All Izuku had to do was find out the weaknesses of his quirk. Angering Jude wasn't going to cut it; he needed *everything* to disappear.

This just lead to another question. What was real and what was not? There had to be something that wasn't an illusion. There was no way his quirk could handle all of that strain.

Hato hastily crawled towards Tomura. Ignoring the sharp pains that his black and blue back gave him. Grabbing Tomura's shoulder firmly, Hato shook him awake.

"Hato, what they fu-"

Izuku easily cut him off, not having the patience or time to deal with a grouchy Tomura (he was always in a bad mood. Bit the amplified ten fold when he wakes up). "I think I found out what Jude's quirk is."

This seems to wake him up as he jolts up into an up-right position. "You *what?!*" His voice roughly whisper shouts.

Hato slowly sits up and starts to explain the puzzle that's finally starting to come together. He leaves out the part of One For All- not wanting to explain how ghosts sometimes talk to him in his sleep.

"And I'm guessing you're already articulating a plan to use this to our advantage, right?"

Is he? Izuku thinks he has bits and pieces of the plan, but is it enough to get everyone out? Izuku had planned the escape when they reached the final level, but was now the best time to do it? He decides that it'll have to be. Hato refuses to let anyone else die.

This needs to end, and it needs to end now.

Hato firmly nods. The small sections of the plan mending themselves together into a form that was more complete.

"Yeah, I do."

It was the first time in months that Aizawa and Hizashi were called to meet at the last known place the trucks was. They had both been too busy with researching suspects and other victims to help and search for the arena.

Midoryia was highly admired around the crew for making such a risky decision by calling them. Shouta just hoped that the repercussions weren't to costly for the boy. God only knows how much the kid has been through. He tries not to think about how they're going to tell Izuku that his mom is dead. Aizawa savvy's that life isn't fair. It gets repeated in his head over and over. A never ending mantra in his head that will never cease. In this situation, Shouta thinks that life could be a lot more that "not fair", but torture. Because damn, has this kid been through hell.

As both Yamada and Shouta arrive to the sight- a empty, dry land that stretches beyond the horizon with small mountains every now and then, they walk over to Nemuri. She's talking to a police officer when she sees them, Kayama beckons them over with a wave of her hand.

"How are you guys doing?" She looks exhausted, but full of determination. Ever since the phone call, the crew has been filled with something they almost gave up on: Hope.

"Have you found anything new?" Aizawa questions tonelessly. Not bothering to ask the question. How *they're* doing isn't as important as finding Midoryia and multiple other people trapped in the arena.

"Not exactly-" Midnight starts, but is cut off by a soft rumble from the ground. It makes everybody struggle to maintain balance and some even fall over in surprise.

Eraserhead tenses and looks on in absolute shock at what appears to be only a mile away. He vaguely hears Nemuri give out a cuss, but any sound is mostly drowned out by his heart pounding in his ears.

There, just a few thousand feet away. Is an arena with gigantic stone walls surrounding it. It's not the arena that surprises Shouta the most though. No, instead its the large amounts of water spouting from what seems to be in the very center of the structure. It looks like a geyser spouting from the ground, but that can't be it.

All at once, all of his senses are brought back. He lets air flow into his lungs and let his ears take in the sound that is akin to a waterfall.

"That's where Midoryia is; it has to be." Shouta is already sending a message to Naomasa before Hizashi even gets a chance to speak.

"We found him." Present Mic's voice squeals with excitement and seriousness, but Shouta doesn't think what he said is true.

Aizawa shakes his head, "No. I think he found us."

It's not long before the other heroes and reinforcements arrive.

They're finally going to save Midoryia Izuku. The kid who went missing almost two years ago.

Chapter End Notes

Almost at the end of arc two!

Thank you to everyone who reads this. It means a lot to me!

Hope everyone has/has a good day!

The Destruction of Hell

Chapter Summary

It's finally time.

Only -like it always does- it doesn't go as planned.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Six hours earlier…

His theory was that Jude's quirk's primary weakness was the knowledge of its existence. It was far fetched, but if enough people knew about his quirk, it might be enough to cancel it out.

Not even the guards knew about the leader's quirk. A few months back he had overheard them talk about the theories of his quirk, and what it could possibly be. Izuku even took some into consideration, such as the manipulation quirk. It had been a good idea, especially since he had so many loyal followers.

Tomura and him knowing isn't going to be enough. Their goal is to gather everyone in the serpent stage together and tell them. That has to be enough.

It has to be.

"Once we escape from the stage, we'll have to separate. It's not ideal, but your quirk will help free the other prisoners faster than if it was me. I don't think the cells are an illusion, and finding the right keys and then unlocking every single cage would take too much time. It'll be best if you just disintegrate all of the cells instead." His voice was barely above a whisper. Izuku could hardly see the black outline of Tomura, but he knew the older boy was listening.

"And you? What are you going to do?"

Izuku smiles sheepishly, "I know this is selfish, but while you're freeing the prisoners, I'm going to pay Jude a little visit. I want to be the one to take him down."

They both lay down to try to get some sleep. Hopefully the last night they'll have to spend in this sordid place.

"What if plan A doesn't work?" The grey-haired boy questions.

Plan A was to destroy the walls of the arena in hopes of it to collapse on itself. It would serve as a good distraction and get rid of a lot of the possible obstacles.

"Well, we have a plan B for a reason. Remember to meet up at the entrance of the arena once we do what we complete our parts of the plan."

They're going to escape tomorrow. Izuku will get to introduce Tomura to his mom and Kacchan. He'll finally be able to start on fixing the timeline once again. All he needs to do is survive and fight with every fiber in his being.

The weight of the ribbon on his wrist is the only comfort he needs to be lulled into the shadow of sleep.

The rest of the night is silenced. Even the rage of Izuku's dreams are quited into a fragile whisper.

One hour before breakout...

"Rise and shine sons of bitches." Keres wakes them up (and the rest of the prisoners) by slamming their cage door open. Hato jumps to his feet swiftly, who is soon followed by Tomura. They walk out of the cage, both briefly catching the other's eye and nodding furtively.

Once they get to the platform, Keres turns off their quirk suppressant cuffs. Hato takes a deep breath, trying to detach from himself. This is part of the plan that he didn't practically like, but leaving him just unconscious would be too risky. He had to do it this way.

He reached for the invisible string and imagined snapping it in half. The string broke, and so did Keres's neck. Hato made sure to keep the evil man standing so they wouldn't draw attention to themselves. He'll let go of the string once he makes Keres walk back to the dungeon into their cage.

The signal is blared and they both jump into the water, both insticulaly holding their breaths. As soon as they make it into the water, Hato searches for the strings of the other players. It's difficult to control one person

while looking for others, but right when he let go of Keres's string, Izuku grabbed the handful of strings and harshly pulled towards him.

A few seconds later, Tomura and Hato both heard the swishing of water as the dozen other people came rushing at them. As they got closer to them, Izuku stopped them but made sure to hold them still just in case they tried to attack. He could feel a headache coming on from using his quirk more than he's used to, but it was okay. He could deal with that.

"Everyone needs to listen *very* carefully." Tomura's scratchy voice announced, sounding almost like a warning. He turns to Hato and nods.

"We're going to escape, and we're going to do it today." He doesn't have time to address everyone's shock as he continues, "You need to work with us, and that means you have to trust us."

"Bullshit. The only known way to escape is to finish the Crows. The last level." A man with a missing arm lashes out.

"Do you want to get out or not?!" Hato yells out. His stress and frustration seeping out. "You really think they'll let you out? My guess is that they kill you off or sell you to some other horrible place. Think, Idiot! This is possibly your only chance at getting out. Now, *listen."* At the stunned silence of the man, Izuku sighs and takes yet another deep breath.

He readies himself to tell the group of people about Jude's quirk, but he hears something in the distance that makes him stop.

He strains his ears and puts all of his sensory quirk into them, trying to listen further away. Izuku hears heartbeats, chatters of people who are watching the arena, the breaths of the guards and prisoners in the dungeons. Hato tries to tune all of them out and try to look for the similar voice he could've *sworn* he had heard.

"Have you found anything new?" The voice was gruff and clearly sleep deprived. A tone that he hadn't heard in literal years.

Izuku freezes before turning towards Tomura. "We're switching to plan B." He doesn't even give his friend enough time before he's pulling everyone down to the bottom of the pool.

"Does anyone have a quirk that is telekinesis or can control water?" His voice leaves no room for questioning as they finally reach the bottom of the arena.

“I do!” A teen girl with hair that looks like water exclaims.

“Good. You and I are going to lift the water until it reaches past the height of the arena. Think you can do that?”

The young teen enthusiastically nods her head and smiles. Izuku smiles back, happy to see someone with such a bright personality.

“Okay. Right before we lift up the water, Tomura is going to use his quirk on the ground, which will hopefully get to the water pipes. This will be essential since we’re going to need the extra water. When.. what’s your name?”

“Aqua.” Not surprising.

“When Aqua and I lift up the water, Tomura is going to tell you something that you *have* to believe. If you don’t trust him, this whole plan will go up in ash. Does everyone understand?”

With everyone’s confirmation, Izuku kicks his legs up so he isn’t standing on the floor. Thankfully everyone follows him. Tomura leans down to the ground and puts his hands onto the floor. The ground starts to crack but thankfully not completely disintegrate. His quirk wasn’t that powerful quite yet.

He lifted his hands once the ground was covered in deep crevices. By now, Izuku’s head was pounding and it’ll no doubt be worse after this step. Especially since he’s only used his quirk on living things.

He needs to reach them. He has to give them some sort of signal that *they are here.*

The water isn’t a string, but a gigantic, heavy rope that takes all of his strength to lift.

“Ready, Aqua?” His voice is strained and tired. He can’t imagine what he’ll feel like once this is all over. It *will* be over.

“Yup!”

They both lift their arms up. Izuku having a much harder time than Aqua. The water movement is slow at first, but after a moment of silence, the water goes barreling up wards. Shooting far past the walls of the arena.

"Tomura, tell them!" There's fifteen of them. That has to be enough to do at least some damage towards Jude's blasted quirk.

"The leader's quirk causes illusions. A lot of this is fake!" It's hard to hear him over the running of water, but they do.

And they believe him.

Hato doesn't notice any major changes, but the closer he looks the more he sees. Now, the arena looks a lot more run down and moldy. The weight of the water seems less and easier to carry.

It worked. It actually worked!

"Aqua, help me remove all the water out of the arena!" As soon as they get the water out of the prison, they both nearly collapse in exhaustion.

Hato stands up with shaky legs after a few precious seconds of gasping for air. "All of you need to get out of the arena. Try to take down as many guards as you can. The heroes and police should be nearby; probably getting closer as we speak."

"Thank you, for helping us." The one-armed man says before running off with the rest of the group. Hato distinctly sees him throw a punch with an iron fist at one of the guards and smiles.

"I'll see you at the entrance?"

"Damn right brat. Better not mess anything up." Tomura warns. Izuku knows what he means. He had said the same exact thing before he went back in time.

"Better not mess anything up." Izuku liked to think it was his own special way to show that he cared about him.

Izuku turns around to leave, but before he does, he gives Tomura a teasing smile. “You too!” After that, Izuku’s feet barely touch the floor as he sprints to Jude’s office.

Izuku can’t wait to taste the sweet, sweet, relief of getting revenge.

———

Hato felt powerful standing in front of Jude’s door. His will to survive strumming through his veins as he slammed the door open.

He saw Jude in the middle of the room, shaking in his boots. A useless gun pointed right at Izuku who only stared blankly at it. The gun went off, but Jude’s hands were shaking so bad that the bullet missed Izuku by an inch.

The way Izuku didn’t flinch only made him quiver more.

“You take pride in being a monster, do you?” Hato didn’t attend it to be a question.

Jude straightened up, his eyes looking cold and rotten. “Of course I do. It’s who I am. Don’t you?”

Hato flared up in rage. He didn’t dare to argue false facts about that accusation being wrong. “No, but you are right about one thing. I *am* a monster.” Izuku didn’t know what his face looked like, but it must’ve been horrifying judging by how the leader drained of color.

Hato eyed the pristine sword hanging on the wall behind Jude’s cluttered desk. He didn’t allow himself to think about what happened next. All he saw right before running back out was a sword piercing Jude’s throat. Red dripped from his eyes as he collapsed onto his knees.

Hato was running down the staircase when he noticed something in the distance. His eyes widened once he noticed it was Demetrius, the dog that had tried to *kill him* .

“Oh shit.” Izuku turned tailed and *ran.* Vaguely noticing how all of the cells were empty of prisoners. Izuku’s small legs pushed against the ground as fast as he could, trying to get away from the man eating animal.

He rounded a corner and was met with a dead end. Izuku couldn't use his second quirk anymore or he would suffer from more overuse than he's already dealing with. Fear crept up his back as he came face to face with the giant dog.

Out of the corner of his eye, he saw a familiar pink fog moving it's way closer to them. After years of teaching himself, Izuku covered his mouth tightly with his hands. He hoped it was what he thought it was. The greenette watched in relief as the dog's eye rolled up, but it was replaced with dread when the hound started to fall towards Izuku.

Before the dog could crush him, something wrapped around his waist and yanked diagonally forwards so he wouldn't run into the animal. He was met with warm arms wrapping around him and his face squished into a scarf.

He would've cried if he had time, but all Izuku did was look up into the familiar black eyes.

Eyes that had been gouged out. Revealing unending emptiness.

The man smiled. A smile that Izuku hardly ever got to see. His usually guarded eyes replete with warmth and relief. Hato looked around to see two other people he hasn't laid eyes on in years.

Ears cut off. Throat slit. Choking on his own blood as he weeps his final tune.

Skinned. Pale, red flesh everywhere. Slowly tearing up from the inside out. Intestines falling out. Hands trying to keep them inside. Forever failing. Fading into an eternity of sleep.

He knew they would be alive, but it felt so *good* seeing them *breathing* .

"It's good to see that you're still alive, problem child." That nickname was special and to never be forgotten by the small boy. It was a part of him. It felt like home when he heard it.

"I need to meet up with someone. Everyone should've escaped by now, but you guys should check just in case. I'll meet you at the entrance." His limbs felt as if they were going to fall off, but he ran his fastest anyways. He needed to reunite with Tomura as soon as possible.

"Wait- Kid!" Izuku made an effort to ignore Yamada as the trio tried to get him to stop.

He couldn't stop. Not yet.

Once he got to the arena -half way to the entrance-, he saw Tomura standing in the middle of the arena with another man. Hato skidded to a slow pace and honed in his vision.

What he saw- *who* he saw made bile raise up his throat.

Standing in front of Tomura, was a man with no eyes, no hair, and a black mask covering half of his face. They were talking, but the blood pounding in Izuku's ears made it impossible to focus. The villain (it was *All For One.* Oh no. What if he remembered? It was *ALL FOR ONE-)* was waving his hands around, no doubt making something look more extravagant.

Breaking out of his stupor, Izuku started to make his way over quietly. He needed to get Tomura (his friend. His *brother)* out of here now. He couldn't let him ever fall into the clutches of All For One. Hato won't allow it. He *can't* .

He saw the older boy slowly shaking his head at whatever offer the villain had offered, but the stress didn't leave Izuku. A putrid sensation began to overtake the area as AFO's rage towered up.

Izuku looked in horror as AFO (his *father*) put his hand on Tomura's shoulder.

Izuku was so close. Just a mere two feet and he would've been able to grab Tomura and escape. They would've escaped and Izuku would've introduced him to his mother and they would've had their first warm meal in ages and-

"Tomura!" The scream tore through his mouth, leaving it to ache.

Before anything happened, Tomura turned around with his face being filled with true terror. An emotion that Izuku had never seen plastered onto his face so clearly.

"Hato!"

And then, they were gone. Both Tomura and the man Izuku hated with all his heart.

His tired legs failed him and he face-planted into the hard dirt, not even registering the pain in his face. Slowly, the tears started to slither down his face quietly but oh so loudly. He didn't know what to do. Izuku had failed at keeping another promise.

He failed. Why can't he do anything right? WHY?

Hato, Izuku, he did nothing but stare at the empty space where his friend once was. He refused to let his mind scream at him for any longer. It wouldn't make a difference. He forced himself to stay strong (He wanted to be the one to show Tomura video games, a loving family, a happy childhood. Now… *That hope was as good as dead)* but his body wouldn't move, no matter how much he willed it to.

Izuku would see his brother again, he had too. The reassurance was the only thing that was keeping him from breaking down. He tried not to think that Tomura might become Shigaraki again, but the thought stuck there like glue.

It was inevitable, but that doesn't mean he still couldn't save him.

He didn't register being picked up, nor did he hear the soft murmurs of reassurance from his heroes. All he felt was the burn of his exhausted eyes, but he refused to close them. He refused to do anything. His mind was blank, so why was it screaming at him? He didn't get it. He didn't understand anything. It felt as if he was everywhere and nowhere at the same time.

Who was he again? Who was he *really?*

"It's going to be okay, Midoriya." No, it wasn't. Not for a while. Perhaps forever.

"Please… don't lie." It was all he bothered to say. All he needed to say.

It was silent for the rest of the walk. Izuku didn't even think about how it was the first time in ages that he's seen the outside world.

He didn't see the difference.

Mitsuki and Masaru were cooking breakfast when they got the phone call. Masaru taking off his apron and answering the device.

It wasn't until even a minute later when the phone clattered to the ground, startling both Mitsuki and Katsuki who was watching cartoons.

"Masaru, why the fuck did you drop the phone?!" Mistuki yelled, prepared to berate him about how he could've broken it. The plan quickly halted once she saw her husband's face. A serious and pale expression adorning it.

"He escaped. Izuku… He- he escaped."

The household was silent for what seemed to be like the first time before it erupted. Katsuki bolted to the door and started to get his shoes on.

"Katsuki, wait." The father softly demanded. The young Bakugou's face snapped up in furry and impatience.

"What do you mean 'wait'?! We need to go see Izu!" No one addressed how the kid's voice cracked in anger (or perhaps in longing to see his only friends again).

"They told us to wait here. The detective will come visit us -with Izuku- after they make sure he isn't injured, okay?"

"He's… okay now, right? Deku is going to be okay, right?

The two adults shared a look. Truth be told, they didn't know if Izuku would *ever* be okay after this. All they know is that he's not going to be the same little boy they once knew and that no matter what, they would still love him.

Mitsuki was the one to answer her son. Her harsh voice soft and consoling,

"We don't know, honey. We don't know."

Chapter End Notes

End of Arc Two: The Arena
Arc Three: Blissful Chaos

He finally escaped. Yay! I hoped everyone liked this chapter. I tried to make it intense and descriptive, but I don't know if I did a good job or not.

Sadly, I have some bad news. I want to start planning the next step in this story, and I don't want it to seem rushed. So in order to do that, I'm going on a two week hiatus. I'd rather have good quality, well thought-out chapters than rushed ones. I'm so sorry about this, but I promise I'll work hard and not slack off!

See you in two weeks! Hope everyone had/has a good day!

My Body is a Painted Canvas

Chapter Summary

Izuku is finally free.

But he still aches.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When the police had told him that he would have to go to the hospital first, Izuku threatened them. He didn't need a hospital, he needed his *mom* . He needed his family.

Izuku's empty threat was taken seriously by the police and they escorted him into Detective Tsuchauschi's car with Aizawa next to him. The time traveler's eyes were burning with exhaustion, but he refused to close them for anymore than a second. He was terrified that this was all a dream and as soon as he closed his eyes, he would wake up back in the cell that was supposed to be his home for two years.

The ride was silent. Izuku took that time to observe his surroundings; the outside, the car, how Aizawa and Naomasa kept exchanging worried glances.

Soon enough, the silence became claustrophobic. "What's happening to them?" Izuku let out a sigh when confused looks crossed both of their faces. "The other prisoners. What's going to happen to them?"

"They're going to get checked up to make sure they're okay and will be given mandatory therapy- that includes you, and then they will be sent back to their loved ones." Aizawa explained, his voice younger than he remembered it to be.

"What if they don't have anywhere else to turn to? The only two people I formed any connections with had no one before they were kidnapped."

Anxiety crept up in his stomach when they started to enter neighborhoods. What would Kacchan and his mother think when they see him? He's a stranger now.

"We're still trying to figure that one out. Don't worry, though. We'll make sure they get some place safe." The detective's voice was as soothing as it had always been. The underlying stress from hours of constant work is still there.

“Two? Who was the other one?” Aizawa asked. Izuku gripped his ribbon for comfort.

“We didn’t go by real names in the arena. It doesn’t matter anyways. She’s dead.” The silence that fills the stiff car is worse than before, and Izuku hates it. Hates every part of it. His eyes caught onto a familiar house, but it wasn’t the house he was expecting to see. It wasn’t his house, but the Bakugou’s. “My mom.” He tries his best to ignore the way the two adults stiffen in their seats, but all it does is threaten to choke him with dread. “How is she?” Izuku can distinctly see Kacchan next to his parents, jumping on both of his feet. The blonde doesn’t seem to see them quite yet.

Aizawa sucks in a breath and Izuku clenches his arm tighter. They grow closer to the house and the greenette can see how his best friend’s eyes light up. It’s refreshing to see such a young face, but Katsuki still looks older. Taller and smarter, his eyes blocked by something he can’t quite distinguish.

“Your mom’s dead.” Shouta spits out.

In that second, Izuku goes numb with the overwhelming need to *get out* . He doesn’t think he’s in shock. No, he’s too used to death to be in shock. He has to be used to it-

But it’s his mother. His mother is *DEAD***.**

DEAD DEAD DEAD DEAD DEAD-

He was holding her by the neck, Her face red as she claws at his gigantic hand. All he could do is stand and gaze and glare at him. Frozen, paraliyzed, completely unable to move.

He was useless. All he could do was wait for someone to save them. To save her. He had to withhold his hope and trust that someone would help them escape this awful scenario.

“I really did love her, you know? But now she’s just a useless pawn.” He face crinkles where his eyes used to be. An invisible, bone-chilling smile.

His hand tightens and a resonating snap is heard. It rings in Izuku’s ears like a broken record. A tune that he never wanted to hear. Inko’s hand drops and her beautiful, bright eyes hollow into black holes. Her head dangles to the side as her green hair softly dances with the wind.

So useless.

Without blinking, Izuku unbuckles his seatbelt and opens the car door. Letting gravity take control, he leans sideways.

And topples out of the moving car.

_____

He vaguely feels the gravel scraping and digging into his skin. He rolls until he comes to a stop in a kneeling position. Grabbing his hair so tight that his knuckles turn white.

Nothing matters at that moment. Not that he's finally escaped, or Tomura is with AFO again, or his childhood best friend running towards him with his explosions behind him to make him faster.

The only thing that's coursing through his mind right now is the fact that he'll never get to see his mother's smile again. He had been offered a second chance to save her, and he completely blew it. Izuku would never get to see her again, never get to hug her again, never get to have late night conversations with hot cocoa ever again.

Small arms wrapped around him, but he didn't take any notice of it. His head was pressed against the other's chest, but all Izuku could do was blink blankly and silent tears cascaded down his cheeks.

"Izu…" Katsuki's arms tightened around him. Comforting and not suffocating. And that, for some reason, broke Izuku out of his muteness toward the world around him. He slowly snaked his hands around the other and clutched to him as his one and only lifeline.

A shattered sob fled from his mouth as he clawed at his friend's shirt. *Nothing* was okay. For the second time, he had lost his mother and could do nothing about it.

He held on to Katsuki tighter. Needing something, *someone* to be next to him. And never leave.

He was sick of people leaving.

"Kacchan…"

Deku fell asleep in Katuki's arms with elbows and knees bleeding and red stained cheeks. The blonde continued to hold on to the smaller boy. He was so small and frail, but so damn strong. Tears fell from the boy's ruby eyes as he finally got to hold his one true friend for the first time in two years.

Bakugou is adamant to ignore the soft hand landing on his shoulder, but he can't for long. "You need to let go, Katsuki." His mother speaks softly as she crouches down next to him. In response, Katsuki only buries his head in Izuku's soft green curls. His friend smells like dirt, sweat, and blood but he doesn't care.

He wonders how his hair is still so soft.

"We should fix his scrapes while he's still resting. In order to do that, we'll need to get back to the house." Her arms slowly wrap around Izuku and Bakugou slowly loosens his grip on him. The older woman nearly cries when she realizes how small and light he is. She holds him tighter to remind her that he's really here and not a figment of her imagination.

Katsuki stands up, his legs cramping with being on his knees so long. Gravel is sticking to his legs, but he doesn't care and continues to walk back home with his mother. He gazes at his long lost best friend and notices how much he's changed. His hair is to his shoulders and is in much need to get a haircut, his skin is dry and cracking, and the most noticeable feature is the scars. There's a starburst scar on his palm and a few other jagged silver lines on his arms and legs. The sight makes him want to be sick, especially since he has a sinking feeling that there's probably more he can't see.

"Is he alright?" The man with black hair asks. Katsuki recognizes him as one of the people who helped retrieve Izu. His voice is laced with concern and stress that seems to be long-lasting.

His mom whispers, careful to not wake the sleeping boy in her arms. Katsuki would never admit it, but he loved his mother's voice. Especially when it was calm and soothing. It always brought a wave of comfort and security when she used that voice. It was special. It's only ever been used for Izuku and Katsuki and no one else.

"What do you think? He jumped out of a car. Physically, he only has a few scrapes and bruises, but mentally? Well that's a whole-fucking-other answer." The hero and detective both wince at that. Mitsuki takes a deep breath and continues walking before stopping and turning to face the two adults again. "Well? Aren't you going to come in? Dinner is going to be ready in an hour and I doubt you two haven't had anything decent to eat recently." Katsuki knows she's not just inviting them in for dinner, but something else. Mistuki has a stern and determined feature on her face that could only mean she wanted something from the two other adults.

They all make their way to the door where Masaru stands. His smile is strained yet real as he looks at the sleeping form of Deku. He looks at Katsuki and changes his smile into something more positive.

"How about we make Izuku some Katsudon for when he wakes up?" At the mention of his best friend's favorite food, the blonde smirks and feverly nods.

As the two head to the kitchen, Mistuki takes Izuku to the bathroom and gets his scrapes cleaned and bandaged. She refuses to acknowledge the few lone tears that glide down her cheeks as she notices how much the boy she sees as a second son has changed. How he's so young yet so worn. Scars that no child should ever have.

Not for the first time does Mistuki think how unfair the world is.

Right as she finishes, the boy starts to stir. His green eyes open and even throughout all that despair, the mother could still see some fight sparkling in them.

"Hi Izuku." The tiredness disappears and he smiles. It's small, but dazzling.

"Auntie. How have you been?" His voice is hoarse and tired but still filled with the kindness she remembers oh so fondly.

She helps him off the counter and smiles at him, warmth blooming in her chest. "Better now that you're here." Izuku doesn't say anything, but follows her down to the kitchen where everybody else is.

Once they get to the kitchen, Izuku lets go of her hand and walks over to the detective and hero. They're sitting stiffly on the couch and tense when they see Izuku.

He stands in front of them and addresses Aizawa first. Izuku finally gets to appreciate seeing his teacher once again, never having the chance to do so before. He must look creepy with how he stares into Shouta's eyes for what seems like an eternity before wrapping his arms around the man in a short hug. It's so short that Aizawa doesn't even get a chance to return it.

"Thank you. Both of you. The plan wouldn't have been nearly as successful if it weren't for you and the other heroes and police."

They smile and it seems like Aizawa is about to say something before Naomasa beats him to it. “We should be thanking you. If it wasn’t for that phone call, we wouldn’t have been there. That was a real risky move you pulled there.” They both ignore the fact that he would have obviously faced repercussions for his stunt. Izuku visibly shudders at the thought of those three, long months in the night room.

Suddenly, Izuku gets knocked over by a hug. He instantly knows who it is and hugs back with equal force.

The blonde hides his tears in the time travelers shirt, not caring if his friend knew about them. “Idiot. Doing stupid crap like that. Better never leave again.”

Izuku doesn’t reply.

Dinner was wonderful, if not a bit awkward. Having his first warm meal in two years was incredible. It was a shame that he couldn’t get even half of it into his stomach. He was too accustomed to being hungry and making the best on the little he was given that a normal serving was too much.

“Izuku, honey.” Mistuki asks after dinner. All of them are still sitting at the dinner table, basking in the moment that they are finally together again (one person is missing. No, *two* people are missing. It’s a thought that lays in the back of his head quietly). Naomasa and Shouta left not too long ago, having to help with paperwork on the other prisoners. “Why don’t you go get washed up. I’m sure you want that. Katsuki can pick a pair of clothes for you to wear. If you want me too, I can clean that ribbon.”

The white ribbon is stained with dirt and specks of blood, but Izuku can’t take it off. He’s afraid of what he’ll feel if he didn’t have it. He trusted Mitsuki with his life, but he couldn’t afford to lose this. Who knows, maybe it’ll get cleaned while he’s taking a shower.

“Sorry, Auntie, but I can’t take this off. It’s too important.”

He’s thankful no one questions him.

The shower scolded his skin, being at the hottest setting. It makes his skin red and bumpy, but the burning is better than the hollowness in his chest.

Izuku makes sure to lather his hair with what seems to be like half a bottle of shampoo and conditioner. Taking extra time to take his chipped fingernails through his scalp. He does the same with washing his body as well, scrubbing his skin raw.

It's about an hour later when he steps out of the bathroom. He's wearing Katsuki's miniature skull shirt and some cargo shorts. The comfort of them makes his eye ache and body relax. He hasn't felt like this in a long while. Izuku engulfs himself in the feeling; afraid it'll be ripped away from him.

The outfit shows off most of his scars (the number eighty-eight is hidden. Shiny white and red sticking out from his skin never to leave.), but he doesn't mind. Scars have never bothered him before, and he doesn't think they ever will.

Knowing the route by heart, Izuku walks toward Katsuki's bedroom. His footsteps are silent and impossible to hear. When he makes it to the room, the greenette softly knocks in the door. Gentle yet announcing.

"Come in, nerd." The nickname gets a soft giggle from Izuku. He steps into the room that he's spent just about the same amount of time in as his own (was the house still there? Was it vacant, or was there someone else living happily in it?).

Kacchan's bedroom hasn't changed much from what he remembered it to be like. There's a futon on the ground next to his bed. Compared to the cell, it looks like a cloud. Izuku basks in the normalcy of it.

Not being able to ignore the ruby eyes staring at him any longer, he looks back at Katsuki. The blonde's face is endepth and too serious to be on a seven year old.

Izuku claps his hands together and stretches his face into a wide, slightly forced, smile. He goes to sit next to Katsuki on the bed and almost falls over at how squishy it is. Forgetting what he was going to say for a moment, Izuku runs his hand over the soft comforter and almost melts. He forgot what *comfort* felt like.

"Where did you sleep?"

It slips before Izuku can stop it. He's always been truthful with Kacchan. Perhaps the only person he couldn't lie too, or at least, without being caught.

"A cell."

Katsuki stiffens visibly. Izuku almost forgot that that was something to be concerned about, but sleeping in the cell never became something he had time to think about. It just was. Sure, some nights his back would ache and it was so cold that it would be impossible to sleep because he couldn't stop shaking, but it was fine. Compared to the other things that happened, it was neutral.

But Kacchan didn’t need to know the details. Especially at this age. “So, tell me what happened when I was gone. Make any new friends? Discover more aspects of your quirk? I bet you’ve learned a lot and have lots of stories to tell me and I can’t wait for you to tell me all of them. Oh, what were your birthdays like? I can’t believe I had to miss *two* of them. I’ll make sure to give you the best present ever on your next birthday, and-”

Katsuki starts to laugh until his eyes water, and even though Izuku has no idea why he’s laughing, he still decides to join in.

“You still mutter. I missed that.”

Izuku hasn’t muttered in a long, long time. It was too dangerous. He had begun to think he had lost that habit forever, but it turns out being with his best friend was all it took.

The air begins to turn more solemn as the laughter dies down. Not exactly sad, but not happy either. It was longing.

“I’ve really missed you, Izu.”

“I’ve missed you too, Kacchan.”

Chapter End Notes

I'm alive! Yes, I know it's been a bit longer than two weeks. Sorry about that! I'll be back with my usual weekly updates for a while before my next break (I'm planning for it to be late June).

I hope everyone liked this chapter! I myself loved writing it.

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

The Beauty of Stars We Can't See

Chapter Summary

Izuku can't sleep, so he sneaks out.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku couldn't sleep. His mind was buzzing with bees and his legs twitched with the need to move. The futon was perhaps too comfy; he was so used to sleeping on cement that resting on something more comfortable felt weird and forieng. He was tempted to crawl into Katsuki's bed and snuggle with him, but didn't think that was a good idea. He didn't want to anger his friend, and didn't think his bed would do anything to differ from his trouble of sleeping. He craved physical touch, but just couldn't bring himself to ask for it. He certainly didn't want to wake someone up for being just a *little* touch starved, either.

He decided that going outside would be the best option of course. Izuku had so much energy because his body had become so accustomed to the constant need of adrenaline that it was sure to take a while to get his body to stop relying on his sympathetic system almost 24/7.

With his mind made up, Izuku quietly crawled out of his futon and walked over to the window. Opening it just enough to slip though, he swiftly stepped onto the roof and closed the window. Without much worry, Izuku jumped off the roof and landed gracefully. His eyes adjusted well to the dark due to his sense quirk, so he didn't have any trouble with observing his surroundings.

As he started to walk, he basked in the cool, early summer air. He took in his surroundings, drinking it in. Everything was so *open* and breathable, and it was *amazing*. Izuku was walking past Strawberry park- the one he got kidnapped at-, and strangely didn't feel scared at all. Instead, he felt complete. A swell of pride rose in his chest as he walked through the park, as if to announce to no one but himself that he had *won* . Hato wasn't trapped anymore.

A bush of Hydrangeas caught his eyes as he was walking. An idea came to mind as he slowly reached over and picked the best ones he could find. By the time he was done picking the flowers, Izuku had a dozen or so in his small hands. Carefully, he carried them to the log Kacchan and his group of friends used to hang out in the last timeline. At one of the trees near the log, Izuku softly put down the flowers and began to pick small rocks. He placed the rocks so they surrounded the flowers next to the tree he had picked out. Next, Izuku found a pointed stick and carved words into the tree.

"Tribute to the fallen fighters of the arena"

By the time he was done, Izuku had a few splinters in his hands. Nonetheless, he was proud of himself and promised to come by and replace the flowers when needed.

Izuku's last stop was Dagobah beach. He frowned at the pile of trash that had started to pile up. He would have to wait a few years before he could work on that if everything went according to plan. Sitting on the luscious grass and looking at the miles and miles of ocean, Izuku couldn't help but think of All Might.

He needed to talk to him.

The sky was dark and clear, but the stars were hardly twinkling. The beauty of them hidden behind the light pollution and the soon to be rising sun. The sky, the ocean, the neverending streams of *what ifs* made Izuku feel so small. A part of him wished for a moment and a moment only that he didn't have a crushing job to do. That he was a seven year old quirkless boy with a loving mother and no friends, but that was okay because he knew that he could still be a hero.

But he wasn't that boy anymore, and no matter how little he thought about it, it crushed him every time. He was a stranger to himself. The one person that will never leave.

Before he left, Izuku screamed. Covering his head with his hands and squishing it in between his knees. He screamed because he couldn't talk about it. Not yet, anyway. It was crushing his lungs and the only way to let it out was to rip his throat and let his scream fill the lonely void.

Once Izuku got back to the Bakugou's (should he call it home? Is it his home now?) and snuck back in through the window, the sun was just beginning to peak. Clouds dusted with pinks and oranges. He tiptoed back to his futon before changing his mind and gently crawling into Katsuki's bed, careful to not wake him up. God knows the blonde is a beast when rudely woken up.

For just a moment, Izuku allows himself to close his eyes. His mind finally quiet but not at peace. He gets enveloped by the too comfy bed for a second and rests.

Katsuki wakes up hugging something. He soon discovers that that "something" is actually a "someone". He hugs the sleeping figure closer to him, still finding it hard to believe that Izuku is back in his life again.

Katsuki hates feeling useless. Yet that's what he's been feeling as of late. So useless that he couldn't have been there for Deku any sooner.

It made him angry.

He didn't *understand.* Couldn't fully comprehend what Izuku exactly went through. Doesn't think he ever will. He hates the scars on his friends body. Despises how much pain Izu must've gone through. It enrages him that they're just about the same age but seem centuries apart.

Katsuki wishes his dreams were a reality. Blurry images of more friends he's ever had, a quirk that is always growing stronger with each passing day, seeing a familiar greenette smiling regularly as he talks with people who seem to care about him. Those flurry of dreams seem so reachable but so incredibly unlikely.

The thoughts dwell on him, and it's hard to focus on the present. On the *now* . Not the past, or future, or the distant dreams. The blonde hugs his best friend gently but reassuringly and drags his mind to what he has *now* , and what he can do to make every second better than the last.

That thought led him to fall asleep again, not even noticing that it was his first peaceful rest in forever.

All he knew was that he felt whole again.

The first thing Izuku registered when he woke up were the voices of Aizawa sens- (no. He's not Izuku's teacher anymore. Hasn't been for a long time.) and Tsukauchi. The fact that he was wrapped in Katsuki's arms didn't even cross his mind as he used his quirk to spy on the adults.

"How did he do last night?" The detective asked what he was assuming were the Bakugou's.

"Izuku did well. It was almost scary. From my knowledge, he didn't panic or even cry." Mitsuki answered.

"I want to say he's just in shock, but something doesn't feel quite right about that." Masaru added, his voice timid and worried.

Midoriya assumed that this was probably when he should get up and announce his presence. He gently wiggled out of Kacchan's hug- careful not to wake him. His footsteps were undetectable as he walked down the stairs to see all four of the adults talking and drinking what he thought was coffee.

(God, he missed coffee. Izuku couldn't *wait* to get hooked on that stuff again. Maybe he could sneak some in tonight.)

Aizawa was the first one to notice him, Mitsuki being the one to announce his arrival. "Ah, Izuku! How did you sleep?"

He didn't exactly sleep, but they didn't need to know about his little nightly adventure. Izuku guesses that the one hour nap he took would count as something, especially since it was nightmare-free. Something he wasn't expecting on his first night back, but he's pretty sure that had something to do with Katsuki.

The young time traveler sent them a soft smile before joining them on the couch. Mitsuki and Masuru scooting closer towards the edges of the couch so he could sit in the middle.

"I slept pretty well! Thank you for asking." That seemed to ease the creases in Mistuki's forehead, and Izuku was glad that he could make her worry less.

"We were just talking about you." Tsukauchi says, smiling warmly at Izuku.

Of course, Izuku already knew this and decided to get right down to business.

His simile falls instantly, a serious expression taking place. He probably would have laughed at they're shocked expressions -except for Aizawa- if he wasn't so busy getting his words put together. "So, what questions do you have for me?"

The detective gets into working mode almost immediately, back straightening while Shouta's remains hunched. "Well first we're going to need to discuss your mandatory therapy sessions -which will be starting next week- and school."

"I don't need school." Izuku was probably just as smart if not *smarter* than Shouta. He remembered back to his last life and how Todorki would speculate if he was smarter than Nezu himself.

"And why's that?" Aizawa speaks for the first time. After reading his expressions for so long, Izuku could see the spark of curiosity in his coal eyes.

“I already know everything that they can possibly teach me.” Izuku shrugs as if it was the simplest answer to the easiest question.

“Oh? Do you have some IQ quirk?” Naomasa questions. Izuku tosses the idea of telling him of at least one of his quirks around before deciding now is not the right time. He would have to wait to upackage all of *that* at a later time.

He doesn’t worry about the detective seeing through his lie since he *was* quirkless after all.

“I’m quirkless. I don’t have a quirk.”

They gladly don’t bat an eyelash at that revelation, and continue being dragged by their curiosity.

“If you don’t believe me, let me take one of Nezu’s tests. I hear that they’re nearly impossible to pass- with or without a quirk. If I pass, you let me do homeschooling. If I don’t, you can put me in class with Kacchan. No exceptions.”

Izuku internally smirks when Aizawa shivers at the mention of the principle. He’s the only person that could ever possibly make Shouta scared at just the mention of him.

His internal smirk makes it to his face once he knows that he won the two over. The both hesitantly nod, both hoping the Nezu won’t get an apprentice.

They didn’t even want to begin to think about the chaos that might ensue.

Aizawa gives a long, suffering sigh before nodding his head, “Alright, Problem Child.” Izuku’s smile grows wider at that nickname, “I’ll talk to Nezu about it and try to set up a date for you to try out the hell tests.”

“Thank you, Aizawa.”

The detective and hero both get up, “Whatever, kid. Just make sure to take care of yourself. And for the love of anything holy, get some *rest* .” Izuku winces at that, knowing that his logical ruse didn’t work on his former teacher.

He bows his head down and mutters, “Yes Aizawa.” before waving the two out the door.

Awkward silence fills the room only to be brushed away by Izuku's stomach grumbling. He pays no mind to it, as he's used to being hungry and learned to ignore the sounds that came along with it.

However, the Bakugou's do not ignore it. "Oh! You must be hungry. Why don't you wake up Katsuki while Masaru and I cook you guys something."

Automatically, Izuku shakes his head. "You don't have to cook me anything. It's okay." Because really, it's okay. Being a little hungry doesn't faze him anymore.

Mitsuki fiercely shakes her head, "Nonsense! Besides, I'm sure Katsuki will be hungry once he wakes up, anyway." Not being able to fight that logic, Izuku nods and makes his way back upstairs into Kacchan's room.

The boy crawled on to his friend's bed and immediately jumped on him. The blonde startled awake with a shocked scream that was almost comical. On instinct, Katsuki pushed Izuku off of the bed, causing him to land on the ground with a loud thump.

Izuku wasn't fazed by the hard landing and immediately jumped up; excitement that this is the first time in forever that he'll be able to hang out with Katsuki for a full day (he won't let himself worry today. He'll try to have fun, and the only way he could think would help is to spend time with the explosive child).

"Kacchan, get up! I want to spend the whole day with you!" He doesn't want to think of the skeptical look Aizawa gave him, and the reasons behind it. He doesn't want to worry about therapy or how his mother is gone forever. *Again.* Izuku doesn't want to think about the next, or when, but the *now* . Just this once.

"Damn right! We're going to have the best day ever!"

Izuku hoped he was right.

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Dancing With Our Laughter

Chapter Summary

Izuku gets to have some fun.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The first thing they did was have breakfast. Mistuki made red bean pancakes that seemed to melt in your mouth. It slightly overwhelmed Izuku at how fluffy and sweet they were, and he wished he could have eaten more.

The morning was silent as they took the time to wake up (well, that was mostly just Katuki); Izuku enjoying how the sun shone from the windows and seemed to illuminate the whole room. He forgot how beautiful simple scenery was.

He eyed Mistuki and Masaru drinking coffee, his mouth watering at the thought of the bitter beverage. Before he could stop himself, his mouth was already moving, “Can I have some of that?”

The older Bakugou’s looked confused while Katsuki had a look of disgust, “You want to try coffee? It’s so bitter and disgusting!”

Izuku was slightly insulted with the accusation, but quickly remembered that he used to loath coffee as well. He watched with a hopeful gaze when the two adults shared a look, hoping they would accept his request.

Masaru smiled apologetically, and that was all he needed to know that his request had been declined. “I’m sorry, Zuku, but you’re a little bit two young to be drinking coffee. How about you wait a bit longer, okay?” Izuku nodded, albeit disappointingly. He guessed that he would just have to sneak some during the night.

“So, what do you two want to do today?” Mitsuki questioned, making Izuku’s mind drift away from the coffee.

“I want to give my mom some flowers.” In the dampened mode swallowing the room, Izuku quickly waved his hand in front of his face, “Only if that’s okay! I understand if you don’t want to. I can always go by myself later.”

He was about to continue with his talking, but stopped once he felt two soft hands enveloped one of his own dried and cracked hands (he really needed to start using lotion). Katsuki lifted their hands with a determined look that made his face heat up in remembrance of the older version of Kacchan.

"No! Let's go and visit Auntie Inko. I'm sure she'll be happy to see your nerdy face again."

Tears balanced at the edge of Izuku's eye before a smile lit up his face and he nodded.

"Well, I guess it's settled. Maybe we could eat somewhere for lunch after." Mistuki suggested. The thought of another meal made Izuku feel queasy; not being used to more than one meal a day. He needed to eat more to get stronger, so he supposes that he'll just have to try his best.

The drive to his mother's grave is more than less a peaceful drive. He doesn't miss the worried looks shown between Mitsuki and Masaru, nor the worried glances that Kacchan is sending him. Izuku doesn't acknowledge any of this, doesn't even know how. Instead he opts to stare outside. It's summer, just a little after his seventh birthday. The sun is gradient and the leaves are happily green.

He grows antsy once they pull into the entrance of the graveyard. He wants to see his mom, even if it'll just be a grave.

His grip on the white lilies they bought tightens as the car slows to a stop. He's out the door before the vehicle even has a chance to fully stop. Izuku doesn't even stumble as he paces his feet in front of him quickly, nearly forgetting about the others that came along with him.

It's not long before the Bakugou's catch up to him, Mitsuki looking angry.

"You can't just walk out of a moving car. It's dangerous!" A part of him wants to ignore her, or maybe say that compared to the other millions of things he's done, walking out of a moving car is safe compared to the others.

Instead he opts for the more civil reply, "Sorry Auntie." She doesn't seem satisfied, but thankfully decides to leave it at that and starts to lead the way to his mother's grave.

It's not long before they make it to the grave. Inko's is similar to a lot of the other ones, nothing too special or unique about it. It's a stone monument and lying on the ground next to it is a bouquet of dried up flowers.

Izuku walked to the very front of the grave with Katsuki close behind him. Just close enough to give comfort and it not be suffocating.

The greenette stared at the monument and gently replaced the dying flowers with the fresh ones. He stared at the name engraved onto the stone for a few moments, letting the chirping of birds fill in the silence (he almost forgot what it felt like to hear the sound of nature. Serene).

Izuku misses his mother. So much that it pulls at his heart and enables him to breathe. All he wanted was for her to live a long happy life with love and company, but she never got that. She deserved that world and so much more, and it broke his heart that he could never give that to her.

“I’m sorry I couldn’t have been there any sooner.” His voice doesn’t waver even when the words are heavy. No one makes a move to say that he should never feel guilty for this; it’s too soon. Right now, it’s his time to pour out his thoughts into words with no corrections. It’s his moment to feel every bone-crushing achiness that comes with losing a loved one, and no one can take that away from him.

“I love you, mom.”

_____

The walk back to the car is solem and Izuku hates it. This day wasn’t supposed to be depressing, and he’s determined to fix that.

With a flame of determination in his eyes that Katsuki doesn’t fail to miss (Katsuki loves that look. It gives him the belief that he could take on the world. Just as long as Izu is by his side), Izuku asks, “Hey, can we visit my martial arts teachers? I really miss them!”

Katsuki’s face breaks out into a grin, “Yeah! I forgot to tell you, but I’ve been training with them. I bet I could even surpass you, nerd.”

Izuku smirks and hooks his hands behind his back, “Well I guess you’ll just have to prove it!”.

They start racing towards the car as the blonde screams back, “Oh, your on!”

All the adults do is share a slightly stressed look before smiling nervously and chasing after the two boys, not wanting them to get too far away from them.

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They get to the studio not long after. Katsuki had dragged him out of the car and into the building, buzzing with a rare excitement. They stepped in to see teachers and students alike training and learning. Falling on mats only to get up again with more determination than before. It was awe-inspiring to see all these people work together to get better and stronger. It reminded him of his class in U.A. Right now, Izuku feels at home with the smell of sweat at the buzzing of the air conditioner.

“Midoriya-kun? Is it really you?” Snapping out of his trance-like state, Izuku looks up to see the face of his teacher. Asa-Sensei has a look of disbelief and blooming happiness as she gazes at him.

His face brightens and his hand slips from Katsuki’s as he runs over to his teacher, Asa meeting him halfway. They didn’t attack each other in a hug, but did something else considered a lot more… violent.

Asa went for a right hook, aiming for his side. If it was two years ago, Izuku might have been hit, but he was different now. His hits sharper and instincts faster. Izuku ducked to the ground and swiped his right leg underneath Asa’s. She fell down onto a mat while huffing out a laugh.

Soon, Izuku was on the ground next to his Sensei, not even registering that she had tripped him before he had hit the ground. His back hit the ground as he started to laugh at the semi-surprise attack.

Katsuki ran up next to him and didn’t even try to contain his laughter pointed at his friend. Izuku playfully glared at his friend but silently enjoyed the sound of the blonde's laughter. The young Bakugou held out a hand for the greenetter to grab, and Izuku was forced to withstand the memories that tickled up his spine.

Kacchan smacking his hand away.

Over and over again.

Until he didn’t anymore.

And then, there was no hand left to hold.

He grabbed onto Katsuki’s hand harder than he had attended to, but he desperately needed to be grounded. Katsuki lifted him up, and Izuku was impressed with how much stronger he had gotten. Katsuki must’ve

trained here a lot to have been able to gain the strength that he seems to have now.

“It’s good to see you again, Midoriya-kun. Are you doing alright?” He wasn’t, but Izuku was pretty sure everybody knew that. Afterall, no one could immediately be okay after coming from what he just did.

In response, Izuku shrugs. “I’m doing okay. How are you? It’s been so long!” He knew that Asa caught onto change of direction in the conversation, but thankfully she didn't address it.

“Better now that I know you’re safe. It’s good to see you again, kid.”

“You too.”

Asa nodded before looking in the direction of the older Bakugou’s, “I’m going to talk with your parents for a bit. I trust the both of you to be responsible.” With that, she started walking over to where Masaru and Mistuki were standing, waving a quick goodbye.

“Deku, let's spar!”

Without giving any words of confirmation, Izuku swung around and raised his right foot up. Aiming for Katsuki’s side. Even though the blonde had a couple of inches on him, Izuku was flexible and fast. Plus it’s not like he hadn’t gone up against people twice his size before.

To his delight, Katsuki blocked it with his hand. He was just about to grab onto Izuku’s leg with his other hand when Izuku reached over and grabbed his hand, flipping him onto the mat. The small ache in his back was briskly forgotten once he heard Izuku’s laughter. It reminded him of a cool, gentle breeze on a hot summer day. It was quiet, just like the summer wind, but it *existed.* It was there, ringing in Katsuki’s ears wonderfully.

Izuku’s cloud-like giggles brought out his own thunderous laughter. They fed on each other’s happiness, making it seem never ending. It was the most joyful Katsuki has been since his friend went missing, and by time they were done with their giggle-fest, tears were streaming down faces and stomachs ached.

Izuku soon sat on the mat close to Katsuki. Just close enough for their shoulders to be touching. Neither said anything, content on observing the other people in the studio.

Not meaning to do it on purpose, Izuku’s ears caught on to the Bakugou’s and Asa’s conversation and wasn’t able to ignore it.

He couldn't. Not when they were talking about him.

"How is he doing?" Asa question. He tried to block the spike of irritation bubbling in his stomach at that question. Didn't she already ask him that? Why couldn't she just take his word for it and leave it alone?

"I don't know, and it makes me so angry. He shouldn't be *this good at- well, whatever he's doing."*

"He's acting like nothing is wrong. That he didn't just go through something fucked up." Masaru didn't say anything, but Izuku was sure he was nodding along.

"I'm sure he just needs some time." He hated how everyone assumed that time fixed everything (ha, how ironic is that?), and they had infinite amounts of it. The fact was, was that in the time it takes to blink, everything can be stolen from you. *That's* how fragile life and every other thing was.

Nothing is unbreakable.

"Nerd?" Izuku's downward spiral took a halt at Katsuki's voice. He turned his head to make eye contact with ruby eyes that were swirling in barely concealed concern.

"Do you think uncle and auntie would let us get some ice cream?" In all honesty, he wasn't feeling that hungry, but he really missed getting ice cream (the same exact place, same exact flavor) with Katsuki. Plus, this would help get his mind off of things.

The smirk that took over half of his friend's face made it a hundred times more worth it. Katsuki didn't even need to say anything and they were already running towards his parents. It was only a few seconds later and they were standing in front of Mistuki and Masaru. Asa left a few minutes prior to help some students. "Can we get some ice cream at that one place? It was Izuku's idea!"

The greenette started twiddling with his thumbs at being called out, "We don't have to, of course! It was just an idea and I totally understand if we can't but I just thought it would be fun since Kacchan and I haven't gone there in a while-" his mumbling was cut off by Masaru ruffling his hair.

"Sure, why not. Lets get some ice cream!"

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Thank you for all of your support!

Blood Dripping on White Roses

Chapter Summary

Izuku sees a therapist.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku wasn't sure if Katuki was asleep yet or not but his thoughts were spinning and he was afraid that if he snuck out in the state he was in, trouble would catch up to him like it always does.

"Kacchan?" They were sharing his bed again, both still having the reminiscent feeling of homesickness from not seeing each other for so long.

Katsuki hummed in response as he opened his eyes to meet Izuku's, even though he couldn't see them.

"Sorry, did I wake you?" They both rolled over to face one another. Their eyes adjust to the darkness, Izuku's more so. While Katsuki could see his outline and the most noticeable features, Izuku could see him with as much detail as he did during the day.

"No, you didn't. What is it?" The time traveler moves to his back to stare at the ceiling.

"There was a boy I met. At the arena." He wasn't able to get his mind off of Tomura, and what might be happening in his life right now. What they could've been doing if everything had gone the way it should've.

"What about him?"

"He was my cellmate. Only a couple years older than us. Without him, things would've been a lot more difficult."

Katsuki didn't know what the nerd was going on about, but he knew it was important. This being the first time he's ever talked about the arena. He decides to gently push him to talk more about this boy, "What was he like?"

“Moody.” Was Izuku’s first thought. It made Katsuki snort at the fast answer. “Sarcastic and always knew how to push my buttons. He was cold, but once I got to know him I realised that he was just afraid to trust.” Izuku’s voice cracked at the end, his throat heavy from the trapped sob. “Tomura trusted me. He trusted me *so much* . Just as much as I trusted him. Yet I- I let him slip through my fingers.” He buried himself into Katsuki’s chest, trying to get his breathing under control.

“You’re going to see him again. I just know it.” Izuku didn’t doubt Katsuki for a second. Something about how he had said those words were so reassuring and truthful that he couldn’t not believe him.

“He was like my brother. I wanted him to stay with us so he could finally get a real family, you know? I wanted to introduce him to you, too. Although, I don’t think you two would get along so well.” He lightly chuckled at the thought of their two brash behaviors clashing. It would be a disaster that Izuku wasn’t too keen on dealing with.

“Hah?! And why is that, nerd? I can get along with anyone!” The reaction only made Izuku laugh more, and that was all Katsuki needed. He wished that Izuku could just smile forever, but Katsuki was content taking all the chances he could get to make his best friend smile and laugh. “Now get to sleep, Izu. It’s late and you need as much of it as you can get.”

Izuku begrudgingly nodded, “Goodnight, Kacchan.” Then his eyes were slipping close and the need to sleep clung onto him, refusing to let go until he fully succumbed to it.

———

The rest of the week passed by relatively smoothly. Most nights he would sneak off and go outside to let air fill his lungs and stretch his restless body. He got to see the detective and hero again, solidifying the idea of being homeschooled for a year before going back. Izuku is even going to be able to see Hizashi and Nemuri in the upcoming weeks, something that he’s really excited for.

Today was the day of his first therapy session. In all honesty, Izuku didn’t understand the big deal of having to go. Half of the stuff that was wrong with him he couldn’t even talk about, especially to some person who he’s never met before.

Yes, he was irritated that he would have to talk to a stranger about his problems, but the sooner they claimed him as “better” or “healed” the better.

The four of them sat in the waiting room with tense shoulders. Izuku with a scowl he wasn't even tempting to hide.

None of them thought about addressing it. Already trying and failing at bringing some positivity into therapy.

"Midoriya Izuku? Hi." A lady with a stone gray pixie cut and professional attire greets. She appears to be nice and open, but Izuku doesn't let his guard down. She has given him no reason to trust him. "I'm your therapist, Dr. Shelin. It's really nice to meet you."

"You too." Izuku's voice isn't as kind as her's, but he can't bring himself to care. He's running on limited sleep and doesn't even want to be here in the first place.

"Do you want the Bakugou's to come with us? Or would you rather have them stay here?" Izuku's first response was to say no, but something his old teacher said to him made him rethink.

"Problem child, you need to let more people help you." Aizawa-sensei tells Izuku. His teacher found out about an injury he had tried to hide.

"But it wasn't that big of a deal. I didn't want to bother anyone." Izuku tries to ignore the frown barely etched on to Shouta's face and pushes down the fears settling in his spine at the thought of upsetting his teacher.

"You wouldn't be bothering anyone. People care about you, and are here to help you. In order to be the best, you're going to need to learn that no one- not even you- will be able to go through everything alone. Understand kid?"

"Yes, Sensei."

"They can come with us. Probably going to find out someday, so might as well make it now."

Shelin smiles again, and Izuku can't tell if it's fake or real. He decides that thinking about it will only make him feel more irritated than he already was.

They walk into her office stiffly. Katsuki is right next to him and he brings some ease into his steps, but not by a lot. Her office is plain with greys and brown. A few couches on one end of the room with her desk and another chair in front of it and behind it on the other side.

"Midoriya, you can sit in front of my desk. Is it okay if you three sit in the back?"

“I want Kacchan to sit next to me. The seat is big enough for the both of us. If that’s okay.” He adds quietly, not knowing how she would react to the request. Afraid of being declined since he needed someone familiar close to him while doing this.

She smiles again. He doesn’t know why she does that. Maybe it’s to look more open or kind. Either way, she’s only doing this because it’s her job. Shelin wouldn’t have bat a single eyelash at him if it weren’t for the money she’s making.

It’s true, and they both know it.

“That’s fine by me. As long as it’s okay with Bakugou.” Katsuki thankfully nods and they walk up to the chair, sitting close enough that their shoulders are touching. Izuku absentmindedly looks back at the people who’ve looked after them and they send him a reassuring smile. He turns to face forward and makes sure to make eye contact with the lady.

She isn’t affected by the hard stare and settles her notes onto the desk with pen in hand. “So, Midoriya, I’d like to get to know you first. I’ll ask you questions about yourself, and you can ask anything you want to know about me as well. Remember, you can always skip a question if you do not wish to answer it.” With a nod from Izuku she continues, “Okay. So do you have any hobbies? Something you enjoy doing?”

He doesn’t not anymore. Sometimes his hands itch to write in a notebook, but he can’t do that anymore. It’s too dangerous. *Deadly* , even. Izuku has had to learn that the hard way.

“No. Not really.” Maybe he should’ve said martial arts, but he doesn’t really count that as a hobby but more like a necessity. He gives her a moment to write some random crap down before asking a question as well, “What’s your quirk?”

“It’s an empath quirk. It allows me to feel a small dose of another person’s feeling after I get to know them.” It’s an interesting and useful quirk; specifically for this kind of work field. “What about colors? Do you have a favorite?”

Izuku crosses his arms and slouches further into the chair, leaning slightly closer to the blond. “Ruby.” He thinks for a moment before asking his next question, “What makes you think that you’re trustworthy? We both know you’re just doing this for the money.” He hears the sharp intake of breaths from the others in the room and hears the raise in heartbeat coming towards the doctor. Did he shock her? Maybe even spike some irritation?

He’s having fun with this game. Even though he knows he shouldn’t be.

“You want to be a hero, right?”

“You didn’t answer my question.”

That stupid smile is still plastered onto her face and calculations run through his mind on how many times she had to pratice that damn smile in the mirror to make it unbreakable. If it was as many times as he had to do.

“You don’t want to be a hero for fame or the money. You want to become one so you can save people. That’s why I’m a therapist- so I can help people.” The reasoning is a good one, but having mistrust in new adults (more specifically the ones he’s never met before) is so ingrained into his mind that it refuses to leave.

“That still doesn’t give me a reason to trust you.” It was getting hard to keep his composer. Half of him was screaming at him to completely block everything out and pretend to be nothing; just for a little while. But he knew, he *knew* , that this was supposed to help him. And *god,* did he need help.

“Let more people help you.”

Shelin must have noticed his internal battle because she kept quiet. Izuku’s chest was burning from the lack of air, but with a soft nudge from Kacchan, he reminded himself to breathe again. “First, can you *please* drop that smile? It’s not doing any good in calming me down.” Her face instantly turned into a neutral expression. Much better than that plastered smile that made Izuku want to scream. “Thank you.”

Truth be told, Izuku wasn’t ready to talk about the arena. It’s only been a week since he’s escaped and he still feels so detached from reality. It’s a defense mechanism from the trauma, but knowing what it is doesn’t make it any less enjoyable. He wasn’t ready to talk about the violence, or the number on his back and splattered brains. He’s not ready to talk about the night room and definitely not Madoka.

He doesn’t want anyone to know the three people he killed. Izuku doesn’t think he’ll ever want to talk about the lives he’s taken. In either of the timelines.

“We don’t have to talk about it yet, you know. This is your session, so you’re free to talk about anything you want. Or nothing at all.” It’s probably the first soothing thing she’s said. The realization that he doesn’t have to force words out makes it less stressful.

Right now, Izuku just wants to get to know the person who’s supposed to help him. He’ll think about talking about the arena during another session.

“What’s your favorite color?”

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the late update. It’s been a rough week, but I’m better now.

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Sweet Lavender Turning to Acid

Chapter Summary

Izuku sneaks out.

Again.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Weeks go by and the words that speak the truth about the arena are still caged. Most people say to start from the beginning, but what beginning are they talking about? Everybody has multiple, and Izuku has countless.

He feels like a failure. He should be trying harder to talk to Shelin about the horrors he had endured (nothing before the arena. She can't know about that. No one can. Not yet. It's not the right *time* yet). It makes Izuku restless, and perhaps that's why he sneaks out for the second time since he escaped.

Now being able to eat three small meals a day without getting sick, the greenette is more awake and energetic. Finally having fuel to add to the ever growing determination to get stronger. The boy jumps out of the window like the wind and breathes in the petrichor air. It's late at night and very few are awake. The heavy silence is music to his ears and that's all he needs to start his descent down the street. The slow walk fastens. His feet moving in front of another soundlessly and efficiently. The walking turns into jogging and the jogging turning into an all out run.

The sprinting continues for a mile. Ending when he hears a harsh, panicked, voice. A flashback of the day when he saw the lady all grey and shriveled up comes to mind. The only color standing out was the bright red on her stomach. By now, Izuku legs are at a full stop. The voice is joined by one laced with anger and desperation. It's a man, and he's dangerous.

The tone of voice jump starts Izuku's legs as he slowly makes his way to the alley. He peeks inside and sees a woman with a knife to a throat by a man twice her size. The man has tattoos covering his entire body. Even his fingernails are replaced by inky illustrations. It's unclear as to what he wants but if Izuku had to guess going from the women's expensive looking jewelry, it was money.

Thankfully, the tattooed man is facing away from Izuku; making it all the much easier to sneak up on him. The thrill of adrenaline is once again being pumped through his veins. At times like these, he feels the most like himself.

The orange haired woman spots him, but before she can do anything to signify his arrival accidentally, he puts a finger to his lips. She's smart, and doesn't so much as glance at his direction again.

Izuku gets within reaching distance of the two and balls his right hand into a fist. Relying on his quirk to warn him about danger, he punches the man's knee pit. The leg collapses right from underneath the man, and he drops the knife in surprise. Taking his shock to his advantage, Izuku lunges for the knife and grabs onto it tightly. He won't use his quirk unless absolutely necessary. Not only is it illegal, but Izuku wants to be as unknown and mysterious as he can be.

The bald man recovers faster than Izuku (he feels like Hato again- doesn't really know what to do with that) thought he would. His eyes are psychotic, but they (Izuku. Hato. *Izuku. Hato.)* is used to those eyes by now. Could even say that they're numb to it.

Confidence surges through him as *He* shifts his body into a fighting stance. What he doesn't expect is for the snake on the man's arm to come alive. Slithering down his arm and hissing ferociously at Hato.

This is when the woman screams, and he hears footsteps running across rooftops. They're getting closer by the millisecond, so Izuku (he notices how Hato fades away into the back of his mind. No longer needed anymore) decides to test his luck and flees around the corner of the alley. He peeks around to see that the man he heard was Eraserhead. The moment the hero lands his eyes on the tattooed man, is the moment the snake disappears back onto his arm.

Knowing that Shouta wouldn't need any help with this, Izuku turns around and heads back to his home. During his walk back, Izuku realizes just how much he craves saving people again. It's only been a month since the arena, but saving has been long-since ingrained into him.

He wants to become Hato again. Fighting and saving people in the shadows.

It's a thought that sticks and refuses to leave like gum stuck to a shoe. A broken record that refuses to be fixed even when he's in bed with Kacchan. Izuku wants to go back and save more people- even if it was illegal.

For the past few weeks, Izuku has been forced to live something akin to normalcy. But Izuku didn't do *normalcy* . He's never had the chance to. When Izuku was diagnosed as quirkless the first time, any chances of a customary life were stripped away from him.

And like any other human, Izuku had learned to adjust. He made it ordinary. So now, when he was forced to act like the way he was now, it made him claustrophobic. Tonight, however, he finally got a chance to be a part of himself that had been locked away for the time being.

Someday he will go back again and do what he did tonight. Only he wouldn't do it with anybody's help.

“I miss the fighting.” It was the first time he had spoken about the arena to his therapist. Or to anyone, really.

She raised an eyebrow, but otherwise kept a neutral expression. “Fighting? Do you want to elaborate on that?”

Izuku shakes his head, “Not really. I just wanted someone else to know. Hey, did you know that animals can have quirks?” He was feeling motivated today, and was determined to talk about the arena.

“I’m aware.”

He continues on with the subject, “Well, there was one at the arena. I don’t think Kacchan or Auntie and Uncle should be here for this, though.” Izuku sends an apologetic look to Katsuki who looks slightly irritated about being kicked out but otherwise doesn’t say anything.

He waves goodbye to them as they leave the office with a smile before letting it drop and turning back to face Shelin. “I thought you wanted them to hear about this?” She questions, but it doesn’t sound accusing.

“I did, but the more I thought about it, the more I realized that it wasn’t such a good idea. Kacchan’s too young, and Auntie and Uncle might overreact.”

She nods before gesturing to him to continue, “His name was Demetrius. He was a giant man-eating hound. Probably the size of this room.” Izuku notices how Shelin pales at the imagery he was laying out for her, and he tries to ignore how the claw-shaped scar on his shoulder aches as he starts again, “One time, a man was yelling at the boss. Well, let's just say he got punished and I never saw him again.” He doesn’t count the spattered blood and fingers he saw, and doesn’t really want to mention it either.

“Did you know his name?”

Izuku angrily shakes his head and scowls, “No. Never take your name for granted. It should be something you hold close to your heart, and never let it be taken away from you.” He had taken the right to have a name for granted, and having it taped away from him felt wrong and empty.

He was glad he could be called Izuku again.

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The session was more tiring than he thought it would be, but a little exhaustion didn't stop the excitement for what's to come. Today, Izuku was finally going to meet with Kayama and Yamada again. They were coming by the house with Aizawa and some mysterious guest. Not knowing who the person was made him nervous, but he also trusted these adults with his life.

It was close to the time that they would be arriving and he was buzzing with uncontained eagerness. He wished Kacchan was here and not at school. His presence always made things better, and Midoriya would have loved to introduce him to more of his future teachers.

Maybe some other day. Izuku can wait. He can always wait.

While he was waiting for them to arrive, he along with the older Bakugou's were watching TV in the living room. It was peaceful and quiet with the faint buzz of the television. The quiet was soon broken however when Masaru decided to speak, "So did everything go well during your therapy session?"

"It was fine. Nothing too special. Sorry that I kicked you out." He did feel a *little* guilty about shoving them out, but he was afraid that they would treat him like glass. But Izuku wasn't glass. Glass can break, and he doesn't have the option to do that.

Mitsuki dismissively waves him off, "Oh don't worry about that Zuzu. It's completely fine." Just about as they were going to continue to talk, they heard a knock from the door. Scrambling to get up, Izuku ran over to the door and opened it.

He smiled as he saw Hizashi, Shouta, and Nemuri. Then his eyes landed on someone he hadn't expected to see for a very long time.

"Principle Nezu?"

Chapter End Notes

I'm back!

Hope everyone has/had a great day!

Discussions From the Now

Chapter Summary

Izuku gets to play a game of chess.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Ah, Midoriya-kun! It's so nice to see you in person!" the being says as he clasps his hands together. "I've heard so much about you, and I wanted to ask you something. But first, there's a few people who are excited to see you."

Izuku can't do much but look at the principal in shock before directing his gaze at the other heroes. His stomach flutters in warmth at seeing the people who have saved him far too many times to count. More than they would ever know.

"Little listener! It's so good to see you again!" Hizashi's smile is as bright and loud as his voice. Izuku can tell by the twitch of his hands that he's holding back from crushing the life out of Izuku with a hug.

Nemuri doesn't even bother to hold back, "It's been so long! How have you been, Zuku? Wait, is it okay if I call you that?" He can barely manage to nod and Nemuri squeals while squeezing all his air out of his lungs before finally letting him breathe again.

It doesn't take long for Izuku to collect himself, "It's nice seeing all of you again, and It's nice meeting you Mr. Nezu. You're all welcome in." He opens the door wider to let the four come in, Aizawa ruffling his hair affectionately when he walks past him. Mitsuki and Masaru greet them before they all sit on the couches.

"Thank you again for saving me. I'd probably be dead or still rotting in the arena if it weren't for you." The concept of death shouldn't be that easy for a seven year old, and Izuku almost feels bad for making them wince. Not quite, but almost.

"Oh, kid, we'll always be there to help you. You don't need to thank us." Izuku is glad that Present Mic still has that fatherly kindness to him even now. "You'll probably be seeing us a lot more often. I don't know if you've noticed, but everyone's taken a liking to you. Even Shouta here." Yamada nudges Aizawa playfully and winks. It makes Izuku grow flustered and giggle at the same time. He doesn't think he'll ever get used to having adults like him and care for him.

Not when so many of them have let him down.

“So, Mr. Nezu. What did you want from me?” Nezu smirks, and everybody but Izuku visibly shivers from it. Izuku had never been scared of Nezu or his intelligence. He’s *amazed* by it.

“You’re the one who articulated the escape plan, am I correct?” The sparkle in his eyes grows into a sharp glint as Izuku nods.

“I guess so. I had lots of help though.” A cackle escapes the being’s throat and the tense air the adults are bringing about is annoying Izuku. There’s no reason to be afraid of the principle of U.A.

It’s illogical.

Out of nowhere, Nezu pulls out a chess board. It’s fancy, and Izuku knew just by looking at it that it cost an unnecessary amount of money. “Well, Midoriya-kun. Let’s play some chess, shall we?”

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Izuku to the surprise of himself and everybody in the room (besides Nezu. Because Nezu *knows* , and he knows, and knows, until he doesn't know what he *doesn’t* know), he wins. He looks up from the chess board to see Nezu scaring at him with a smirk that shows his fangs (Izuku didn’t even know he *had* any fangs. They look so *cool!*).

“No one has beaten me in a game of chess in a very, very long time, Midoriya-kun.”

The boy shrugs, missing the gapping looks the teacher’s are giving him. “It must’ve just been luck. Besides, it’s just a game. A pretty simple one at that.”

“Trust me when I say this Problem Child. That wasn’t luck.”

Nezu pulls up tea seemingly out of nowhere and sips out of it while cackling. Izuku and the heroes aren’t fazed by this. Both have witnessed the principal's addiction for tea first hand, but the Bakugou’s weren’t faring so well. Their faces were pale in a way that was almost comical, and even Mituski looked at a loss of words. A snicker escaped Izuku before he had a chance to hide it, but thankfully no one noticed. Except for maybe Nezu who only started to laugh longer.

“Getting straight to the point I want you to become my private student. I’ll teach you things no one would think to teach you at your age -or any age-, and depending on what you want and your potential, you’ll be guaranteed a spot at U.A when you’re old enough.”

Izuku thought that if this was the first time, he would have immediately said yes. The thing is, if this was the last timeline, Izuku wouldn’t have this chance. Sure, he was smarter than the average kid his age back then, but nowhere near this level of education. The problem with having this proposition *now* was that Izuku wasn’t planning on sticking around here for long. Soon, something will lead him away and he’ll have to leave. Being with Nezu will heighten the chances of getting caught, plus it would be a waste of the being’s time if one day Izuku just up and left.

So he had to say no, but maybe… Maybe he could still ask for something.

He shakes his head and Izuku actually sees Nezu’s face flash with disappointment. “I’m sorry, but I can’t accept your offer. However, would it be okay if I accepted it at a later date? I want to take the entrance exam without any guarantees as well. It’s not fair to everybody else and I need to prove myself that I’m good enough to be a hero.”

Nezu sighs, and takes another sip of coffee. “Very well. How late are we talking about?”

“Fourteen. There’s one more thing, and I understand if you refuse to give me this. But I need your trust.” Interest perks throughout the room, but Izuku doesn't move his eyes from Nezu.

“Seven years from now… I suppose I can wait. And why are you asking for my trust? That is a very hard thing to gain.” Izuku can’t say, and he has a feeling Nezu knows he can’t. Neither says anything for a long time, but Nezu must see something in him that makes him understand.

“Okay. You have my trust.”

“Woah, that's easily! Zuku, you really are a special kid!” Midnight burst out with excitement and aw.

“Thank you Nezu. I promise you won’t regret it.”

“I’m sure I won’t.”

Soon it’s time for them to go. Hizashi tells him that someday he’ll have to show Izuku around U.A.

“Only if Kacchan gets to come.” Was Izuku’s response. Hizashi didn't even need to think about it before accepting Izuku’s condition. This time, Yamada hugged Izuku with no hesitation. Picking him up off the ground for a short second.

“See you soon, kid.” Aizawa yet again ruffles his hair. Izuku won’t even deny the fact that he might have leaned into the touch.

“See ya, Zuku! Make sure to come and see me when you visit U.A!” Midnight yells as she hops out the door with a beaming smile.

“I hope to see you soon, Midoriya-kun.”

Izuku nods and smiles brightly, “Thank you for coming over! See you guys soon!” When the door shuts, Izuku is met with curious stares by Auntie and Uncle. They were both strangely quiet throughout the whole visit. It made him kind of worried for Mitsuki since she was rarely this silent. “Umm, are you guys okay?”

The question seemed to break their silent state, both looking like they wanted to say something. Mitsuki was the first person who spoke, “Why didn’t you take up Nezu-San's offer? I’m surprised you didn’t say yes.”

Masuaru nods along with Mistuki, “Yeah, I’m surprised too.”

“I just don’t think I’m ready yet.” Although he could have told Nezu about how he was a time traveler right now, something about that didn’t sit right with him. Izuku knew in his gut that he would need to wait until he at least had one for all first. Starting the final battle right now, it wouldn’t go correctly.

It was instinct, and over the years Izuku has learned to trust his instinct above all else.

It was the same day. Katsuki and Izuku decided to hang out at the park together and try to find the log that was over the river. Katsuki has never been there before, so Izuku wanted to show him the log that holds so much meaning. A beginning to a story Katsuki will never know. They were just starting to walk into the woods

when Izuku saw it. It was a glimpse of red and white hair. Instantly, Izuku stopped walking and zeroed onto the familiar head of hair. Katsuki was holding his hand and stopped right after Izuku did and looked at him curiously.

"Why did we stop?"

"That boy over there," Izuku points at the boy who has to be a younger version of Todoroki, "He looks lonely. We should invite him to come and play with us."

Kacchan pouts, "Why? We don't need him."

"He might need us. Besides, the more the merrier." Izuku grabs onto Bakugou's hand again and starts to drag him towards Todoroki. He slightly frowns at the burn scar on his past friend's face. It looks newer, too. Probably less than a year.

They walk right up to him and Izuku gives the boy the biggest smile he can muster, "Hello there! My name is Midoriya Izuku, and he's Bakugou Katsuki. What's your name." Midoirya slightly winces at the coldness in Shouto's eyes. It's just like the beginning of U.A.

"Todoroki Shouto. What do you want?" It's obvious that he's trying to sound rude, but Izuku doesn't care.

"I was wondering if you wanted to join Kacchan and I. We were going to go into the woods if you're interested. Of course you don't have to if you don't want to, I just thought you looked kind of lonely and could use some friends, but really, you don't have to-"

"Come on, Deku. He clearly doesn't want to play with us." Katsuki says as he starts dragging Izuku away from Shouto.

"Why…" Upon hearing Todoroki's voice, Izuku digs his heels into the ground and stops Kacchan from dragging him away.

"What did you say?" Shouto looks up in surprise, most likely due to thinking he wouldn't be heard. Izuku makes sure to make direct eye contact with the heterochromic boy. Not looking at his fresh scar, or the bruises on his arms. No, he was looking at Todoroki. Listening to him.

"Don't you think I'm ugly? My scar is gross and it's impossible to *not* stare at it. Why would you even want to play with me?" He looks like he's on the verge of tears, but Todoroki has always been a master at keeping a

neutral face, so only a trained eye would catch the extra water in his eyes.

Izuku smiles again, “We don’t care about your scar! Right, Kacchan?” He turns to look at Katsuki with a look that clearly says ‘say anything mean and you’ll regret it”.

The blonde gulps and nods his head, “Yeah, who cares what people think of your scar. Everybody gets them.”

Izuku turns back to Todoroki who’s starting to look more hopeful, “Yeah! Besides, I have lots of scars. See?” He shows Shouta the electricity scar on his palm and the one he got on his leg when somebody tried to shoot an arrow at him. “I have more, and they don’t bother me.” Except for the branding one, but Shouto doesn’t need to know that. “They prove that I’ve survived. Todoroki, your scar shows how strong you are.”

With that, Todoroki’s eyes start to show some light in them. A small smile grows on his face and he stands up. “Well, I guess I could join you two for a tiny bit.”

Izuku turned and started to run towards the forest, waving his hand to motion for his two friends to follow. They all ran, sharing giggles and smiles as they went.

“Great! Let's go then!”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for all the love and support! Hope everyone has/had a good day!

The Illusionary Path of Happiness

Chapter Summary

Izuku and Katsuki chat with Shouto.

It’s not hard to become friends.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They were all sitting on the log. Izuku is in the middle of the other two young boys. Todoroki had just told them about the events that had occurred that resulted in boiled water poured over his face. While already hearing and knowing the story, it was still fresh to Izuku. It raised fury in him everytime he heard about what one of his close friends had to go through so early on.

“I’m not mad at my mom. It’s my father. I’m going to be a hero and only use my ice to spite him.” Shouto announced confidently.

All Izuku saw was a kid trying to deny a part of himself. He wasn’t going to spite his father. All Todoroki was going to do was become more closed off to everybody. Even himself.

“Hell yeah! I would be mad at him too. I *am* mad at him. I’ve never liked that Endeavor guy anyway.”

“Bakugou, we should team up and conspire against my father. Will you join us Midoriya-kun?” He almost forgot how funny Todoroki could be, and how serious he is while being comical. It was refreshing in a weird sort of way.

“Maybe someday. One thing I don’t get is why you’re denying a part of yourself. That won’t do any good for you, trust me. I mean- It is *your* power, right? No one else’s.” He hears Shouto’s breath hitch at Izuku’s ever-so famous words. He optimizes that saying this now will have the same effect it did when they were older.

Todoroki remains blank-faced, while something clicks for Bakugou, “The damn nerd is right. You should be giving it your hundred percent if you’re going to be a hero. If you weren’t it would be like spitting in everybody's faces and telling them you’re better than them. It won’t get you really far.”

“Todoroki,” Izuku says sternly. It must’ve shocked Shouto because he looks up at him, his eyes clearing slowly, “If you don’t use your full power, you *will* die. Holding yourself back won’t only be a liability for everyone else, but for you as well.”

It was mean, especially for how young Shouto was now, but it was also necessary. Maybe if he started training both sides now, Shouto will be more ready for what's to come. Was it fucked up to condition kids that have barely tasted life for a possible all-out war?

It was.

(Wasn't it the same, though? They had to go to war at sixteen to seventeen years old. They had to endure trauma after trauma with little training. And… that didn't go so well. So isn't it better to secretly start training them? Even if it's just a tiny bit?

Although Izuku will fight tooth and nail to make sure they don't have to fight. Class 1-A doesn't need to witness the same things twice.

He hoped they won't have to fight, but that won't mean they will.)

"You're smart. Do you have some intelligence quirk?" Todoroki is listening to him, even if he doesn't explicitly say it. That's all Izuku can ask for. The power of listening can move cities of people, but most importantly, it can help change Todorki's mindset.

Katsuki laughs. Actually *laughs* . It startles the birds from the trees and the previously croaking frogs quiet. Izuku joins in as well. Mostly because Katsuki has always had that effect on him, not because of the question.

"No, it's not. Thank you, though. I take it you'll think about what I said?" Shouto nods, albeit a little reluctantly. "Good. That's all I can ask for."

"Listen to the nerd. He may be a clutz, but he has a big brain. If he gives you advice, then take it." Todoroki doesn't give any response towards Bakugou, and the blonde almost looks offended at that.

"Are you sure you don't have some intelligence quirk?" Even at eight years old, Shouto is still blunt and theoretical. It makes Izuku chuckle.

"I'm sure. Trust me, I was diagnosed quirkless a few years ago." For the first time, Midoriya feels slightly guilty about lying about having no quirk. Todoroki told him about his struggles with two quirks, and Katsuki would've been the first person to know (Kacchan never asked about if he ever gained a quirk during the arena, so Izuku never told him. Not like he would've anyway.)

Thinking about it, Izuku had never told Shouto in the last timeline that he was quirkless. It raises unstoppable anxiety in him at not knowing what his reaction would be. The fear of losing his friend or anyone close to him over the fact that he used to be quirkless haunted him all throughout his time at U.A. Guess it never went away.

Katsuki was tense as well. Probably mentally preparing to get into a fight if deemed necessary.

“Wow. So you *are* just some naturally mad genius. You would make a great member of the ‘take Endeavor down squad.’”

Soon, tears are streaming down both Izuku’s and Katsuki’s faces as they clutch their stomachs and laugh until they can't breathe. Shouto only stares confusingly at the two at the sudden laughter. Shouto liked these two boys, and the more he thought about it, the more he was okay with calling them his friends.

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Just like every day, the sun sets and it’s time to part ways. Shouto stands with his sister while giving his last goodbyes to Midoriya and Bakugou. Todoroki almost feels sad about the sudden departure, but is mostly surprised when Midoriya notices.

“Don’t worry, Todoroki-kun. We’ll see each other again.” Todoroki never asked about his scars, and to him it didn’t really matter. It almost made talking to Izuku easier because he knew that he would understand him better than most. Bakugou was fun as well. Brash and easy to temper. He had a good time teasing him.

“Yeah. I’ll try to listen to your advice, Midoriya-kun.” In response, Izuku gives him a blinding smile that makes him feel reassured. “I’ll see you two agian sometime.”

“Bye, Todoroki-kun!”

“See ya, Half-n-half.”

It was the best day Shouto had since before the incident.

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Izuku was spending another night out, making sure to cut it short since he and Kacchan are touring U.A the next day.

At least that was the plan before he caught a glimpse of a very familiar red scarf. It was ripped and frayed at the edges just like he remembered it to be, if not being a morsel cleaner. It was stupid to follow him, especially since Izuku didn't even knows if he was the person he was thinking of. It was stupid and idiotic, but Izuku's legs still walked closer to where he saw a glimpse of the red scarf.

It wasn't long until Izuku had a glistening knife to his throat. That being the only thing he needed in order to prove his hypothesis correct.

He could hear him lick his lips, putting pressure on his neck to make its presence ever more clear. "What are you doing out so late, little boy?" Stain's voice was as dry as a desert. Terrifyingly rached.

Before answering, Izuku grabbed the arm that was holding the knife and lifted it up and behind him, slipping the knife into his free hand while doing so. He didn't want to pose as a danger to Stain, so he tossed the knife back to Stain who caught it swiftly.

"Just going out for a stroll. What about you? Looking to kill someone?"

Again, Stain licked his lips. "Depends. Guess'n you know how to up a good fight?"

An idea pops into Hato's head. Sure, he'll be alone again without his best friend. But this could work for the better. "You could say that. But I'd benefit you a lot more if we worked together. It's obvious you're a vigilante."

He needed to start gaining allies. It was time Izuku stopped being blissful and continued his journey of changing history. It didn't matter if he wanted to or not. Losing Kacchan again will be more painful than a stab to the gut, but it has to be okay. Izuku will be able to see Katsuki again. Fate had them intertwined, so even if it seemed impossible at times, they will always be reunited.

"So you're an observant kid, but not that smart if you want to work with me. Tell me, how would I benefit?"

It was a question he was expecting to answer, "You said it yourself, I'm observant. I also know how to analyze people in seconds. I can bring down whole gangs by ripping them apart using their own weaknesses. Not to mention that I look pretty innocent. I'd be good bait."

“And your quirk?”

“I’d rather not tell anyone. Besides, it won’t be of any use to you. I’m not planning on using it. After all, it’s not illegal if I’m not using my quirk.”

It’s silent for a moment. The loud choir of croaking frogs makes it non-sufferable. All of a sudden, Stain’s eyes gleam dangerously. It would’ve been impressive if Izuku hadn’t seen it in the future. Half of his face is overcome by a pointy smile.

Hato knows he’s won him over.

“My name is Stain. What’s yours kid?”

Hato matched his smile, but it probably wasn’t as scary with his chubby cheeks, “Hato.”

“If you want this to happen, meet me here at exactly midnight tomorrow. Got it?”

He doesn’t get a chance to answer before Stain disappears, not that it would matter either way. Izuku’s eyes are just beginning to sting with exhaustion, and he supposes that he should head back by now.

Swinging his hands behind his head, Izuku begins walking back to his temporary home. Ignoring the strings being pulled at his heart.

He had one more day with Kacchan, and he needed to make it count.

Chapter End Notes

I'm back! *dramatically raises from the ground like a zombie*

Sorry for the late update, I was on vacation. I also wanted to tell you that updates won't be as consistent for a while. Don't worry, I'm not going to take forever to update or anything. At most it'll take two weeks for an update, but that should be all. I'm trying to focus on improving my mental health, so that's why I won't be doing consistent updates.

Thank you for reading! Hope everyone has/had good day!

Waking Up to Reality

Chapter Summary

Bakugou and Izuku get to tour the highschool.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shouta picks up Izuku and Katsuki at around nine in the morning. Both Katsuki and Aizawa are grumpy at having to be awake so early in the day. Both slouching in the car seats with Aizawa chugging a thermos filled with coffee and Katsuki grumbling inaudible sentences.

Izuku -even with no sleep from the night prior- was full of energy. Bouncing in his seat and talking non-stop. It could've been the first cup of coffee he's had in years that he somehow managed to sneak in, or visiting U.A. The highschool will always be a home to him, and everyone in it. It had to be a big reason as to why he's still fighting. U.A was his world.

(And then there was his Kacchan. His entire *universe.* Without him, Izuku wouldn't know what love was. That's why it hurts. Throbs and aches *so much* that he'll have to leave him again.)

"Deku, how do you have so much energy?!" Katsuki grouches out.

"The kid's right, it's too early to be bouncing off walls."

"But it's *U.A.!* You should be just as excited as I am, Kacchan." He chooses not to tell them about his little intake of caffeine this morning. They don't have to know. Izuku snickers to himself about his little mischievousness.

This seems to bring Katsuki out of his tired state, a fire growing in his eyes, "Damn right! It's about time I wake up!" He then proceeds to slap himself in the face. It leaves his two red handprints imprinted onto his cheeks, and while Izuku should've been worried, he instead thought it was absolutely hilarious.

"Hey, problem child. I've been meaning to ask you a question." Aizawa says as he shows a security guard his ID at the school gates. It was as big as he remembered, if not more so. Katsuki's mouth hung open in awe as he finally got to see his dream school in the flesh. To the blonde, it was everything he's dreamed of.

The fact that Izuku was right next to him made it a hundred times better.

"What is it?"

"Did we meet before you got rescued?" The question makes Izuku stiffen in his seat. Because no, they had never once crossed paths until the rescue, so why? Why would he be asking that question? It made him internally freak out for reasons that he didn't know.

He shakes his head, and then realizes Aizawa wouldn't be able to see him, "No. Why?"

They step out of the car -Katsuki practically jumps out of it- and start to head towards the building. Izuku and Katsuki take it in with sparkling eyes.

"Izu, someday we'll get to go here everyday," His voice was awe-inspired. Laced with excitement for the upcoming future. Izuku smiled sadly at Katsuki.

"You just seemed familiar. Guess it was just my mind playing tricks on me," Something wasn't right with this. Aizawa never questions his instinct, and this *definitely* has something to do with his instinct. It sends Izuku into a near frenzy. The feeling he got way back during the beginning is coming back. There's still something *missing* .

He hopes it comes back to him, and soon.

Right as they enter the building they are greeted by Nezu and a tall man with bright yellow hair. Eyes sunken in but brighter than the blue ocean. Izuku's face lights up at seeing Yagi, but a quiet part of his mind latches onto the information that he looks weaker and so much more tired than when he last saw him.

"Toshinori-san! Do you remember me? My name is Midoriya Izuku and we met at the park a few years ago!" It would make his entire day if Yagi remembered him (from this time, because there was *no* way *anyone* could remember him or anything else from the other timeline), but he doubts the number one hero would remember a short little encounter with a kid barely older than a toddler.

Katsuki walks next to him curiously as Izuku looks at Yagi expectantly, and something must register to Toshinori since he smiles, "Ah, Young-Midoriya. It's been so long. How have you been?"

"I've been doing great!" He chooses to ignore Aizawa scuff in the background, "This is my best friend, Kacchan."

“Hey, old-man. Only Deku can call me that. My real name is Bakugou Katsuki.”

Toshinori doesn’t seem fazed by Katsuki’s brashness, “Nice to meet you, Young-Bakugou,” He makes the bold movement to ruffle Katsuki’s hair and winks at Izuku who laughs quietly.

Nezu claps his two paws together, “I’m glad you’ve already met! Now let’s get on with the tour!”

_____

They’re walking in the hallway. Katsuki, Yagi, and Aizawa in the front and Nezu and Izuku in the back. Izuku takes a deep breath, still not sure if what he's about to do is the right option.

“Mr.Nezu?” He whispers so the others don’t hear them.

“Yes, Midoriya-kun?” He’s glad that Nezu keeps his volume at a down low as well.

“Toshinori-san. He’s injured, right? All Might… He got hurt, didn’t he?” Nezu’s plastered smile stretches into a manic grin. Izuku’s shoulders hunch up; scared that he already revealed too much.

“Yes, he is. He’s probably got another fifteen years left as the symbol of peace,” Izuku would have laughed at that. Fifteen years? *Ten* is stretching it. All Might's career ended the night he fought All for One for the second time. He *died* the third time he encountered the satanic villain. “Oh, do you not believe me?”

He shrugs and glances down the familiar hallway where his class used to be. Is *going* to be, “You’re smart. fifteen years is the best possible outcome. The world isn’t fair enough to offer us another decade and a half of the symbol of peace. You should know this, Mr. Nezu,” Izuku knew he was being disrespectful, but the truth wasn’t always nice. He had a suspicion that the only reason Nezu said that was because in this world, he was only eight years old. When the truth was that he had the brain of a twenty-five year old.

Nezu nods, but looks troubled which is a rare expression to see on the hero’s face. It doesn’t bother Izuku much because he gets distracted by a huge metal door. It’s a door that he’s seen thousands of times and knows every little scratch and indent of it like the back of his hand.

Katsuki looks behind him to see Izuku staring at it, “Izu, why are you staring at a door? He comes to stand right next to him and stares at the door. “1-A. What’s that?”

“It’s a classroom for the first year hero students. I teach that class.” Aizawa speaks with a rather monotonous voice.

“Kacchan,” he turns his head to look at the blonde, “we’re going to be in this class together. I just know it,” This is where they are going to reunite again. In a few years time, they will be by each other's side again. They’ll fight (with and against each other), learn, and struggle together the moment they walk into this classroom.

It doesn’t take long for Katsuki to make up his mind, “Yeah, this will be the class where we become the best hero duo ever!”

It was a child’s dream. Yet Izuku believed it with all his heart. Yes, they would become the greatest hero duo. He was certain of it.

_____

They get to visit Present Mic and Midnight and even get to meet some other heroes. He sees Recovery Girl from the distance but doesn’t make a move to introduce himself. Their relationship was always strained, to say the least. Yes the heroine would get worried about him, but she also made it clear that she wouldn’t treat him unless absolutely necessary on multiple occasions (after the sports festival was only one of many). Izuku cared for her. Of course he did, but that didn’t make the decision to smile or grimace at the sight of her any easier.

They were walking back to the entrance of the school, the tour now being over. Nezu hasn’t spoken up about his little slip up (if you could even call it that) and Izuku doubts he will. And to get time travel out of that one sentence- that one piece of knowledge? Well, even the Principle would have a rather difficult time figuring that one out.

“So, Young Midoriya,” Yagi starts, “What have you been up to these past couple of years?” Everyone but Tohsinori and Nezu grow tense, even Aizawa shows a hunch of his shoulders for a split second.

Luckily, lying in situations like these has become easier than breathing, “Oh, nothing special. Mostly focused on school right now. What about you, Toshinori-san?” He switches the subject to Yagi smoothly and makes an attempt to ignore the look Katsuki is giving him, but he can’t. So instead Izuku sends him a look himself, trying to convey that everything is okay. It seemed to do the trick, because Katsuki smiles and nods. Grabbing onto his hand as they walk together.

All Might coughs, obviously trying to come up with a lie of his own, “Oh, I’ve been busy. I toured America not too long ago, so that was definitely an experience.”

“I bet it was!” A near deadly experience.

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Before they leave, Izuku makes sure to give everyone hugs. Making sure to give Yagi an extra long one. He won’t see him until hopefully the slime accident, if that even happens that is. Him going rogue with Stain (and wow, wasn’t that a thought by itself? Iida would sure give him hell for it) might alter that event entirely.

“Remember our deal, Mr. Nezu?” Nezu would be the only one to truly figure out where he disappeared, but only if he had the right clues to guide him along. Izuku would be working with the future Hero Killer, so having Nezu’s trust to back him up is extremely important.

The principal chuckles and takes a sip of his tea that appeared from absolutely nowhere, “Why, of course I do. I will attend to uphold it.”

Izuku nods gratefully before going into Aizawa’s car with Katsuki by his side.

Not too long after they start driving, Katsuki’s fight with sleep ends; soft snoring filling the car. Shouta looks calm, but Izuku glances at his hands holding tightly at the steering wheel. So tight that it turns his knuckles white.

It’s not long before the hero speaks, a rare worry covering his words, “You’re acting different. Tell me, what’s going on, Problem Child?”

Sometimes, Aizawa’s talent at observing is more of a curse than a blessing.

“Nothing’s going on, Eraserhead-San.”

“Just call me Aizawa kid.” Izuku nods even though he knows Aizawa can’t see him.

It’s silent for a few moments before Izuku decides to add something, “If anything happens, promise to look after Kacchan? Auntie and Uncle, too.”

Shouta's hands clench the wheel tighter than Izuku would think possible without breaking it, "I can do that while looking after you too. Sorry, Problem Child, but you're stuck with me."

"Didn't you say that I was stuck with you?! You can't leave! That'll be lying, and- and you said lying was 'illogical'!" He's crying, how is he crying? Izuku thought he ran out of all his tears a lifetime ago.

His teacher smiles, *fucking smiles, "Sorry, Izuku. You'll be okay, I promise."*

Like hell he was.

Instead of crying, Izuku chuckles. "Aizawa-San, I can't be stuck with you forever. Wouldn't that be illogical?"

"Maybe, but it isn't now."

He can't laugh at that.

It's late at night, even the birds are asleep. Izuku is still warm from his last dinner with his family. He so terribly wants to cling onto that warmth, but the longer he holds on the more painful it'll be to let go.

He has to meet up with Stain in an hour, so he has thirty minutes to get everything laid out. Izuku already packed everything he needed in his brand-new yellow backpack. It's not a lot; clothes, safety aid, and some notebooks. Everything else he'll have to find along the way of this new 'adventure'.

Izuku gently hugs the sleeping form of his best friend and kisses his forehead before he could stop himself. It's then that the tears fall. He makes no move to wipe them away and lets the salty droplets fall quietly. He removes a letter from his pocket and places it on Katsuki's desk. It's simple and short, but it doesn't make it any less meaningful. Izuku begs his cursed luck that Kacchan won't hate him for this.

He'll understand if he did. Izuku hates himself for leaving, too.

Pulling on his purple sweatshirt (it reminds him of Madoka's ruffled up hair), he takes a last look around the room that brought him the most comfort in two years. He takes his last breath as Izuku, and jumps out the

window.

As soon as his feet hit the ground, he’s Hato.

Chapter End Notes

I'm baaaaacccccckkkkkkk

I'll keep this short. Thank you again for all the support everyone has shown. It means everything to me and I'm so incredibly grateful. These past few months have been hell, and I'm so happy that I'm finally posting again. I hope everyone is doing something that's better than bad, but know that it's okay if you're not doing well.

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Red Eyes Blazing

Chapter Summary

Katsuki is not happy.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki knew something was wrong before he opened his eyes. The dread was clawing at his chest, making everything feel dull but panicked at the same time. He almost didn't want to open his eyes, afraid of what the outcome would be.

Katsuki doesn't fear, though. So he opens his eyes and regrets.

The room is empty. It usually is since Deku always gets up earlier than him, but this is different. It's the kind of empty that was present when Izuku had been at the arena. Stale and cold. With Izuku here, the emptiness of his room was snug and warm.

It made him panic himself out of his half-awake state. Tears were already gathering at the corner of his eyes at the mere thought of the situation that he hoped wasn't true. Getting increasingly frustrated with the blankets tangled around him, he rolled out of bed and crashed onto the ground. After finally getting detangled from the blankets that he almost blew up, Katsuki wildly looked around his room. He noticed how the yellow backpack next to his desk was nowhere to be seen, but most importantly, he noticed an envelope sitting on his desk.

He runs over to it and tears the envelope open. His hands are mini earthquakes and his lips tremble with a heartbreak seconds away from happening.

The handwriting is amazing, and it's Izu's. Katsuki doesn't want to read in hopes of delaying reality for as long as possible, but his eyes are already devouring the too pretty words.

Dear Kacchan,

I'm not going to say much. The more I write, the more difficult it will be to leave. It's already going to be near impossible, so this is going to be short.

I know you figured it out already. You're so incredibly smart Kacchan, but being smart isn't always a good thing, is it? I'm saying goodbye. No, that's not right. I will never say goodbye to you, Kacchan. How about "see you later"? Yeah, let's settle on that.

I have a few things to take care of, but I promise someday I will tell you why. I'm sorry I can't give you a solid reason. World knows that you deserve at least that.

Thank you for being there for me with every step I took. Could you thank Auntie and Uncle for me too? They've done so much, and I wish I could say it in person.

Enjoy your childhood and have fun. There's plenty of great people who are waiting to meet you. Could I please be selfish and have a special place in your heart? Even when I'm gone? I know I don't deserve it, so I understand if you hate me. You can hate me, just please don't forget me.

I have to go. Thank you, and I'm sorry.

See you at U.A.!

Izuku Deku Midoriya

Katsuki drops to his knees and silently sobs. He wants to tear up the paper, or explode it. Make the evidence of his best friend's departure go up in smoke. He doesn't, because it's the only thing that proves that Izuku was *here* and that he's going to come back someday.

Katsuki wants to hate him, and for a second he thinks he might. The thought burns away because it's impossible to hate the one person who can light up your day with a smile. That doesn't stop the acidic rage and hurt burn its way through his heart though. He's felt rage and sadness before. He's even felt remorse and loss, but this is unlike anything he's felt before. It's like someone ripped open a wound that was only just starting to heal.

Before he could process what he was doing, Katsuki got up and ran outside. He ignored his parents' shouts, ignored the weird looks people gave him, he ignored everything. At least, he tried to. The one thing he couldn't ignore was his heart breaking.

What was Deku even thinking? Leaving Katsuki like that. They both knew that they needed each other, so why leave?

He doesn't want to be alone again.

———

Katsuki didn't return home until sunset. He was drained to the bone and ravenous, but he didn't want to eat or sleep. It didn't seem right. *Nothing* seemed right. Izuku was the one that filled his life with righteousness, and now, his world was grey.

"Katsuki, where the hell have you been?! You can't just run off like that, and where is Izuku?!" Mitsuki yelled out, dropping the knife she was using to cut up some vegetables. Masaru was sitting next to the counter looking at his son worriedly.

"Son, is everything alright?"

Katsuki couldn't form any words. Saying something out loud will only solidify the truth. He shook his head, frustrated that tears were already beginning to form for the hundredth time that day. The frustration only guided the tears from his eyes until they came gushing out along with a choked back sobbed.

His parents came rushing towards him and quickly checked him over for any injuries. When they didn't find anything, they both turned to look directly into their son's eyes, "Honey, you gotta tell us what's wrong. Where's Izu?"

The word came out cracked and ugly. Perfect to match the distasteful truth, "G-gone."

That was all they needed to hear.

———

Aizawa didn't know what he was expecting when he got a call from Mitsuki, but it wasn't this. And god, it was probably the worst phone call he has ever had to endure.

He didn't know what the damn Problem Child was thinking. He never knew, but Shouta thought the kid was at least smart. Under any circumstances, how did running away come across as a good idea to the kid? It didn't make any sense, and the hero would be damned if he didn't find out why.

Neither Hizashi or Nemuri were taking the news well, and he wasn't faring well either. All of them had a soft spot for the kid before they even met him, and all they wanted for Izuku was his safety. They were heroes for fucks sake! Keeping him safe shouldn't be such a failure.

Midoryia had to be somewhere, and Aizawa was certain that he would see him again. After all, the kid did say that he was going to U.A. But that was too far away. A million tragic, gruesome, things could happen just within the month, but seven years? That is to say if Midoriya was even alone.

Shouta dug his fingers into hair and thumped his elbows on his desk. There would have to be some leads sooner or later, right? It's not like Izuku could go off to another country, but you never knew when it came to him.

"Damnit."

_____

Izuku looked at his reflection through the cracked mirror. He was wearing black cargo pants with his red platform shoes. A purple hoodie engulfed him (it was the same color as Madoka's hair. It was in perfect shape, yet he found it in a dumpster) and a black and red kitsune mask was clenched tightly in his hand. The abandoned warehouse he was in was icy and barren. The air was stiff with dust and spiderwebs yet when Izuku took in a deep breath, it felt like he was being deprived of oxygen and was just now realizing it.

He broke out of his stupor once his phone buzzed, signaling that it was time to get a move on. Hato put on his mask and took one last deep breath before jumping out of the open window and onto the roof. As he ran to his destination, Hato couldn't help but wonder what a sky full of stars would look like instead of it being filled with bustling city lights and smog. Flourishing under those stars felt like a fantasy that Hato wished he could flourish in.

Once arriving at an alleyway (it was the same in he fought in to save a foolish friend. What a coincidence) he jumped down from the roof with no fear in a single bone (wait. Wasn't he always afraid?) and landed perfectly. He wasn't surprised when a sword found it's way next to his throat, glinting his reflection.

"Must you always put a sword to my throat when we meet?" He voiced teasingly.

The sword was put away and Hato turned to face Stain, "Well what if it wasn't you and an imposter? I would need to slit their throats before they even have a chance to breathe in my direction."

"You're paranoid."

"I'm surviving," and Hato couldn't exactly argue with that.

“Is everything still going according to plan?”

The “plan” was a chain of luck, yet unfortunate, events over the span of the last two and a half weeks. The whole process was quite boring, but necessary. It was a repeat of tracking people down, spying, and gaining any reachable information; useful or not.

They didn’t even know if any of this was just a hoax or series of coincidences, and a part of Hato hoped it was. For if all of this was what he feared to be, it would only make things all the more tangled.

It was the start of the Nomus. Or, at least that’s what he has hypothesized. It wasn’t even a hypothesis, and more of an intuitional guess- a gut feeling. And his gut never betrayed him, even when he wanted it to.

“Of course it is,” It’s not like they were planning a rescue mission or anything of the sorts. They were following cases of kidnappings, but if this all led to what he thought it was, then he would be surprised if there was even a body left to find (It wasn’t right. *Nothing* about this society- this *world* was right. Where had the beauty gone? Was there even any to begin with?). All of the victims were last seen with people wearing the same symbol: a purple print of a cheetah's head.

The symbol was familiar.

Izuku just couldn’t remember. Just like everything else that has seemed so important. It was so excruciatingly irritating that it ached in his chest.

“Well, get your shit and let’s get a move on.”

Hato forced out a giggled, sounding so carefree, “Yeah, yeah, whatever.”

It’s only been two months since he ran away and things are already beginning to unfold to reveal more tangles

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone has a nice day! Explanation on why I was gone is in next chapter :)

Stars Emerging Like Memories

Chapter Summary

Hato's first mission

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They moved quickly and silently. Moving at a steady pace. Jumping roof to roof. They were following a white moving truck that carried the group with the tattoos and possibly victims of them as well.

Hato gritted his teeth as he glared heavily at the van. Memories from a few years back resurfacing without his permission. He didn't need this now (or ever). Hato had a mission, and a severely important one at that.

He needed to focus.

All of a sudden the van stopped. Both he and Stain stopped in confusion. And that's when Hato saw him, a boy with red wings protruding from his back. It was Tsubasa, his old friend from the last timeline. He remembered that around this time, his friend (more like Bakugou's) had gotten kidnapped and was never found.

It was the alleyway where they fought Stain.

All of a sudden a Nomu with large wings grabbed him.

Those wings… Izuku recognized them.

It was Tsubasa. Tsubasa got turned into a Nomu! Simmering rage built up in his stomach. He made a step forward, in order to intervene, but Stain held out one of his swords in front of Hato before he could make another step.

"They're going to kidnap him!" He told Stain quietly in order to not reveal their hiding spot.

“Don’t. We’ll rescue him along with the others. We can’t let them know we’re here,” Stain argued back. Hato knew he was correct, but the stirring in his stomach didn’t cease. It laid there waiting to be released in a fight.

So they watch and observe. A man hops out from the van and starts working his way towards Tsubasa. It takes everything within Hato to not scream out. To tell Tsubas to run. The man gets closer with a cloth in his hand that Hato hypothesizes has chloroform in it.

The man makes a move and bunches the rage up to Tsubasa’s face, and swiftly knocks him out. The villain has trouble picking the boy up with his wings in the way, so he gives up and just ends up dragging him by the arms instead.

Hato digs his fingernails into his palms. He hates not being able to help. Especially a little kid who has no idea what the future beholds for him. He hopes that Stain and him can rescue everybody in time. Before they get turned into mindless monsters.

Nobody deserves that.

Nobody deserves this. Especially not him. Not Kota.

Izuku is sobbing, his knees barely able to hold him up. He can’t believe he has to do this.

He tells himself that Kota isn’t Kota anymore. The Kota he knew is long gone and the least he can do for him is take him out of his monstrous misery.

Kota was like a younger brother to Izuku, and what kind of older brother can’t protect his younger sibling?

Kota is now a nomu. A nomu with tears streaming from it’s red eyes (it’s the same color as Kota’s hat. The same color as those goddamn shoes. Izuku wants to throw up) and water hoses as arms.

Izuku sobs as he powers up 100% and closes his eyes. He moves and with one swift punch, Kota- the nomu, is dead.

This is the day where Izuku finally stopped resisting and let the league take him with them. This was the day that Izuku Midoriya truly broke.

“Hato, where are you?!” Stain whisper screams. Izuku is knocked out of it and is surprised that he isn’t crying.

“What do you mean? I’m right here.” He was looking at Stain like he was crazy, which he very much was.

Stain’s face is full of shock. A rare sight to see on the vigilante’s face. This only increases Hato’s confusion even further. Did one of the Purple Cheetah’s find out they were being followed and used their quirk on him?

“Hato, I can’t *see* you. Where the hell did you go?!” That’s when Hato looks at his reflection from a puddle. Well… he could see himself, but Stain sure couldn’t. This had to be a work of a quirk; yet he didn’t feel any different. If anything, he felt more *whole* than a few minutes ago. As if he’s been missing pieces (he’s been feeling this for so long. He feels so *empty)* and he just gained a piece back.

That’s when it comes rushing back.

“Deku-kun~ guess what we’re going to do!” Toga said as she bounced up and down like an excited child.

To Izuku, there was nothing to be excited about. Only dread.

Shigaraki steps in, “We’re assigning you to spy on U.A. But you can’t do that with your assets now. Especially since you’ve betrayed them-”

He betrayed them? His family? Why the hell would he do that?

“- So we’re just going to have to add another… asset, if you will,” Izuku’s breath hitched. This meant another quirk. He didn’t know if he could handle another one. They were far too painful. It was pure torture. Worse, even.

“Please, there has to be another way. Humans aren’t meant to hold more than one quirk, and I already have three! There’s no way.”

All For One steps in at that moment, “There isn’t any other way. You will do what we say. Got it, son?” Izuku wanted to scream that he was not his son. Not in a million years. Izuku would rather die than ever call this man his father.

All For One showed no mercy as he gave Izuku the new quirk: Camouflage.

Izuku screamed.

The memories were still painful, but Hato was getting used to them. His new quirk, camouflage, allowed him to appear invisible to people (he wasn't. More like blended in). The drawbacks were that if the person figured out about his quirk, they would be able to see him. Same held true if anyone new entered the vicinity while this quirk was active.

Telling Stain it's his quirk is risky since he initially said he wanted to keep it private, but what choice did he have? Only one, and that was telling him the truth.

"Stain. I'm here, it's just my quirk," Telling Stain should allow him to see Hato, which is good because he has no idea how to switch the quirk off quiet yet.

Stain steps back in surprise at Hato's reappearance, "I thought you said you wanted to keep it private you little shit."

Hato grins underneath his mask and shrugs while making sure to stay quiet, "Yeah, well, now you know, so no need to fuss about it," He just has to make sure to use his other quirks when Stain isn't in view. He continues on, "Hurry, we have to catch up to that truck before we lose them."

They start running across rooftops keeping up with the truck. Eventually, they end up in a tight Alleyway that can barely fit two people together. The Purple Cheetahs go in one by one. Dragging their prisoners in front of them. There they go inside what looks to be a very tiny tavern.

"We have to get in there. I bet this is where his base is," Hato speaks, grabbing his phone that is non-traceable.

"I can taste the blood bath waiting to happen," Stain giddies. Hato gives him a stern, cold glare.

"We're not killing anyone unless absolutely necessary, got it?" Sometimes he forgets that he is eight -almost nine- and that it's weird to be bossing a full grown man around. A dangerous one at that.

Stain snarls and licks his lips, "I don't take orders from you, little shit. If I deem them unworthy of living then they get their throats slit," Hato knows better than to continue one with the argument. They may be

working together, but that doesn't mean that it can't change in a split second, "What are you doing on that anyway?" Stain gestures to his phone.

"I'm texting a friend. If this is truly their base, then we're going to need backup," Hato says as he puts his phone away, "Ready to kick some butt?"

Stain doesn't even say anything, and jumps down the alleyway and busts the door open.

Hato sighs and jumps in after him. The room is full of people. All with the tattoo on their arms. As far as Hato can see there are no signs of prisoners, yet he can hear soft crying right underneath him.

"Stain! You deal with them while I free the prisoners. We have to go quickly and leave before our backup gets here. Do you understand?!"

"Sure do!" Stain yells back, already jumping into fighting multiple people. Hato runs away from the swarming crowd while having to take some people out with his bo staff. He turned multiple corners trying to find a place that would lead him downstairs. He opened the door only to find a couple… doing stuff. Without a second thought Hato slammed the door with haunted eyes. He never wanted to see that ever again.

It takes a while, and a few more knockouts, but Hato finally sees a spiral staircase that leads to where the cries are. He doesn't stop to catch his breath and slides down the staircase's railing. There, he sees jail cells all lined up together illuminated by broken, cracked lights. Hato almost throws up at how eerily similar the prison looks compared to the arena.

"Hey, you! What do you think you're doing down here, huh?" A bulky man says, metal spikes protruding from his elbows.

Using his leviton quirk, Hato slams the guard into the ceiling while simultaneously unlocking all of the cells. The prisoners he notes are all fairly young, just a few years older than him. He fails to see Tsubasa in the crowd, but they're running out of time and he can't waste it.

Shouta is going to be here soon.

Hato waves his hand toward himself and yells, "Hurry! I'll lead you to safety," and then he runs up stairs with everyone following them. Once upstairs he trips over something, but catches himself with his hand. He looks behind him to see a member with their throat slit. Rage fills him and it's all pointed at the vigilante that he's working with. He's going to have a stern talk with him once this is all over.

They all make it to where Stain is and run outside. Right as he steps out in the crisp night, Eraserhead wraps him up in his scarf.

“Woah, there. I’m on your side,” Hato explains while cutting the scarf with one of his hidden daggers. Before the pro hero can say anything, Stain and him are already out of sight. Tears drip from Hato’s face at finally seeing Shouta again after so long. He hopes that he can work with him someday.

Actually, that might be really fun.

Running across the rooftops with Stain, Izuku can’t help but smile through the tears. Eraserhead is unpredictable, and he has no idea what his reaction will be to vigilantism.

The good news is that Izuku is unpredictable as well.

He smirks. This is going to be fun.

Chapter End Notes

Guys, can't you believe it?! I'm back!! I'm going to be honest as to why I haven't been active on here. I'm not saying this for attention, but so you readers know why I'm having a hard time posting regularly. Currently, I am being treated for an eating disorder. I've been trying to recover from it for quite some time now. It's very exhausting. If you're struggling with the same thing, I want you to know that you are sick enough. You are enough period. You are deserving of recovery. You have nothing to be ashamed of because you did not choose this. No matter how much you think it is. Please, live.

As Anger Embraces Me

Chapter Summary

Honestly a shit ton happens in this chapter

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Aizawa was not in the mood for this fuckery.

It was his day off for christ sake! He should be in bed with his loving husband, but *no* . He just had to get a text at two in the *goddamn* morning from a random stranger asking for backup. This could be a prank for all that he knows. His instinct, however, told him it was real, and he never went against his instincts.

So here he was running across rooftops to the location the rando sent him. Right as he arrived at the destination he saw a masked figure in a purple sweatshirt come out of a door into a small alleyway. Not too long after was *Stain* . A vigilante that had been gaining popularity among the heroes and police. Then came out a dozen or so kids. They all made it out of the alleyway into the main street, lit with barely working lampposts. Shouta didn't waste a second more and wrapped the short vigilante wearing this kitsune mask in his scarf.

"Woah there. I'm on your side," The vigilante said. Sounding like a kid. He broke free from his scarf from a knife, which was a surprise for Aizawa. To be able to break free from his scarf there was a very specific cutting technique that needed to be done. How on Earth did that kid know the technique?

"Come on, Hato. We need to go," Stain called out.

His name was Hato and he was working with a very well-known vigilante. Aizawa could already feel a migraine coming on.

One month later…

Izuku's in the same place where they had rescued those prisoners a month ago. He doesn't know why he's here again. Izuku knew nothing would be inside, but he was curious. So he shifted by the throng of people returning to work from lunch hour and entered the alleyway. He was alone with no one to back him up -Stain was doing whatever he does when they're not being vigilantes-, so if something did happen, he would be in a sticky situation.

He opened the door just a crack to peek inside- and what did they say?

Curiosity killed the cat.

His eyes widened to see All For One and… Tomura. Tomura was on the ground hugging his knees, looking smaller than he ever has. AFO was smiling down at him with a glint of proudness in his eyes. Laying in the middle of them was a pile of ash.

Izuku could barely contain the gasp etched in his throat. Fear trickled into his veins at the sight, but so did anger. At seeing his friend looking so vulnerable.

“You have done well, Tomura. Now the evidence of our little failed experiment will be erased. You should be proud of yourself,” All For One says as Tomura shakes.

“Why did I have to kill the man? He wouldn't have said anything. He’d be too afraid,” Tomura’s voice was so vulnerable and nothing like it was at the Arena. What had Hisashi done to him?

“You should know better than to question me, boy. Soon you will be thanking me for training you and taking you under my wing.”

Izuku wanted to run in and hug Tomura with all his might. *Run. Run. Run.* He felt horrible for having a tiny part of him want to run away. He wasn’t ready to face AFO yet- his father. He still has nightmares of the monster (he has nightmares every night. Exhaustion has etched itself into his very *soul)* . Even right now his knees are shaking like mini earthquakes. He felt so weak watching the two of him. Izuku hated feeling weak.

But he was always weak. Always afraid.

When Izuku awoke from his self-deprecation they were gone. Not a trace of them left besides the pile of ash. He cursed himself. Izuku should have been more aware. He was lucky to even be alive right now. If AFO caught him while he was spacing out then it would be game over.

He knew Tomura was alive, but a wave of relief came at seeing that fact with his very own two eyes. He wished that he could have saved him, wishes it everyday, but he knew that he couldn’t have done that today. It would have gotten both of them killed.

Izuku turns and walks away.

_____

Bakugou pushed a kid to the ground. Anger consumed him. It had been doing that much more recently as of late. Bakugou couldn't find it in himself to care.

" *What* did you say about him?" Bakugou snarled. The little kid beneath him quivered.

"I-I didn't say anything," The kid says. Trying to lie his way out. Bakugou was smarter than that. He was the top of the class. He was above all of these *extras*.

"Don't lie to me, Chio-san. Now tell me what you said," Bakugou yells out. He doesn't care if the teacher's catch him. They wouldn't dare mark him down for his behavior. Not with his quirk.

The girl -Chio- Gives in, "I said that I'm glad Midoriya is gone," her tone gains confidence as she continues, "He was so annoying. I'm just saying what everybody was thinking."

Sparks burst out from Katsuki's palms. He can imagine Deku telling him to calm down. That she isn't worth it, but he isn't *here.* He *left.* And Bakugou is *Angry.*

"Don't you ever talk about him ever again! Not even a whisper, or I will blow you to a pulp!" Chio heavily nodded and scurried away.

Bakugou falls to his knees. How was he supposed to deal with these feelings? He missed Izu so much. It hurt. He wanted to hear his voice- especially his laughter. He wanted Izuku to scold him for letting his anger get the best of him. He wanted he wanted he wanted.

But he was alone.

_____

"Shit!" Aizawa says as he enters the door to his apartment.

"Is it Hato again?" Hizashi asks, handing a cup of tea to his husband.

“You damn right it is,” Shouta sighs and rubs his nose, “He’s getting on everybody's nerves. *Especially* Naomasa. We can never even catch a glimpse of him. He just leaves a criminal and a sticky note at the front of the police station. And the *memes!* He keeps sending me these cat memes! How on earth did he even get my fucking number?”

“I’m sorry, babe. But he hasn’t done anything bad. It seems like he’s trying to help.”

“He shouldn’t be though. Hizashi, he’s just a kid. He should be laughing with kids and not fighting criminals. “

Honestly, it was heartbreaking. No kid should ever be in this situation, but reality is cruel. It doesn’t care.

Hizashi smiles warmly. It still makes Aizawa’s stomach flutter. “I know that once you talk to him and gain his trust, you’ll be able to help him. I have no doubt that you will.”

Aizawa gives off a rare smile, “I sure hope you’re right.”

_____

It was raining. The earth is crying with the heartbroken people here tonight.

Young Midoriya was missing. It was Kota’s funeral and he wasn’t there. In fact, Yagi hasn’t seen him since the death of Kota. Worry fluttered where his stomach should have been.

Everybody was in despair. They have lost many great souls these past few weeks and it was beginning to take its toll. Yagi wondered how much more of this they could all take.

They have lost loved ones, teachers, heroes, friends. What more is there that could be lost?

Yagi looked over to Eri who was holding Bakugou’s hand (that two had gotten close since Young-Midoriya introduced them). She was crying. Yagi sniffled. These days Eri never smiles, and now that she has lost another friend… He wasn’t sure what to do.

Aizawa wasn't faring too well, either. Seeing Eri in such distress made worry seep into his bones as well. Yagi watched as Shouta tightened his grip on his husband's hand.

Today will be a day full of despair. Not even an echo of laughter will appear for the next few days. Yagi wondered if the students even knew how to laugh anymore.

Things couldn't possibly get worse.

Then a portal appeared.

Toshinori snapped up with a gasp. He was soaking the sheets in his sweat. That dream felt so vivid. So real. The anguish from his dream- no, nightmare, made tears well up. This wasn't the first time he had a dream like this. Once, many years ago.

His hands were still shaking and an onslaught of flashbacks from his dream continued to attack him. Knowing that he won't be getting any more sleep, Yagi got out of bed and made himself a cup of tea. Just in case it was due to some weird quirk, Yagi got out a journal and began to write about his dream. He thought back to the affliction he felt. How it was so raw and present. Like he actually went through the whole ordeal in real life.

He continued to write. Ignoring his tears dropping onto the pages.

Hato was sitting at the edge of a roof in a nasty part of town overlooking the city. He and Stain had finished their patrol not too long ago, and instead of going to his home (could you even call it that? It was more of a shelter. Home was red piercing eyes and warm hands) he decided to sit and breathe. Just for a moment.

Hato never let his guard down. His ears never missed a footstep. That's why he wasn't surprised when someone jumped onto the building he was on.

The vigilante turned and greeted Aizawa, "Good evening, Eraserhead. Surprising seeing you here," it really wasn't. He knew that Shouta patrols around this area. In fact, he was hoping to see him sooner or later.

"Kid, it's freezing. You need to go home," It was comforting to have someone care for him. He hasn't had comfort in what felt like forever.

Hato got up. While he trusted Aizawa as Izuku, he couldn't trust him with Hato. Not yet. Being a vigilante was uncharted territory. He had no idea what to expect. "While I'm sure It's nice chatting with you. I gotta go. Afterall, if you're going to capture, I might as well make you work for it," There was no way in hell that he would ever let Aizawa capture him.

"Kid, wait. I'm not going to capture you," Shouta says. Slowly walking towards Hato like someone approaching a wild animal.

"Have to work harder than that in order to gain my trust, Eraserhead," Hato says back. Then jumps off of the roof.

_____

A week later Hato is on the same roof, waiting. He's had a couple of rough days. Stain is starting to develop his mindset of heroes and it's near impossible to try to turn him towards a different path, but Hato won't give up. He'll keep on trying. But he has a feeling that if things continue to go south with Stain, their little "partnership" will be broken. Maybe that's a good thing. If they separate, the timeline will be more aligned with the one before.

The true reason as to why he was here is that it was his birthday today! He was turning nine (again). Izuku was all alone, so he decided to venture out as Hato in hopes of seeing his favorite teacher (no hate towards All Might).

However, the person he wants to see more than ever (other than his mom. *God* he misses her so much) is Kacchan. He thinks about him everyday. Aches to see his fiery eyes and snarky smirk. He wonders how Katsuki is doing. Is he maintaining his anger? Or has he succumbed to it? Izuku fears that it's the latter, but hopes for the former.

He was muttering about all of his thoughts when he heard a light thump. He turns, a fond smile under his kitsune mask.

"Ah, Eraserhead! Fancy seeing you here!" Hato beams at the hero. Somehow, Hato thinks he catches a glimpse of an uplift of the man's cheeks. That alone makes his day better. Making the infamous Eraserhead smile is a rarity. Some may consider it impossible.

Good thing Izuku doesn't know the meaning of "impossible".

“Hello, brat,” the hero greets. He then starts walking toward him and for a moment Hato tenses, but then forces himself to relax. Just this once he will let his guard down. Only because he misses having someone to talk to (the murderous vigliante doesn’t count. Sorry Stain). Eventually Eraserhead is sitting at the edge of the roof with him.

“It’s peaceful up here. I see why you choose to travel by rooftop,” The city is twinkling in replace of stars. It’s beautiful.

“I don’t do it for the view. I do it for efficiency. Now Hato, how old are you?” Wow, this man never slacks, does he? Hato sighed and got up. It looks like this little meeting is over.

“Sorry, mom says not to give personal information to strangers,” and then, unlike last week, he decides to take the stairs down the building. Not even sparing Aizawa a second glance. Izuku takes off his mask and breathes out another sigh. He was really hoping to spend some time with his old teacher, but his identity was more important than his need to socialize.

He walked out to the cool crisp breeze wondering when he'd let Aizawa get closer to Hato. A part of him thinks he never will.

Two years later…

Chapter End Notes

Hi hi hi! How’s everyone doing? Feel free to answer in the comments! It’s okay if it’s a sentence or a whole paragraph. I’ll try to reply to all of them!

The Suffocation of Loneliness

Chapter Summary

Izuku meets an interesting person while grieving over his mother.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hato is sitting on the edge of a roof with Stain. It's been over two years since they joined forces and became something akin to partners. They have formed a friendship that only they can form. Built upon similar interests and fondness over each other.

Today, however, is different. Today is the day that they will go their separate ways.

"It's been tolerable working with you, Little Shit." Stain says. Still using those dumb nicknames all these years later. Hato doesn't think he's ever used his actual vigilante name before. Always "Brat" or "Kid" or Hato's personal favorite, "Klutzy Fucker".

"Tolerable?" Hato replies, "You think over two years of working together would wager something more than 'tolerable'. Even 'nice' would be good."

"That's the best you're going to get, Brat. I need to go to Hosu city. The heroes there are fucked up. I have to be there to teach them what a true hero is like. To punish them."

Hato scrunches his eyebrows together, "You're not going to kill anyone, are you? Heroes need to learn and grow from their mistakes, not have that chance ripped away by you killing them."

"You know that's not how I work, Kid. Life isn't fair. You can be the savior, but the only way that *I* can fix my problem with heroes of today is by killing them."

Hato sighs, "I might have to fight you in the future. I won't hold back."

Stain gives off his sadistic grin and barks out a laugh, "I wouldn't have it any other way." Then he jumps off the roof, and that's it. No goodbyes were given, and Hato is okay with that. Besides, goodbyes were for forever, and this definitely won't be the last time he saw him.

They've been through a whole lot these past couple of years. They gained up against sex trafficers, kidnappers, rapists, and even quirk trafficers. They never ran into a Purple Cheetah after that one attack a few years ago. Maybe they've all turned into experiments for punishment of being found out. Hato didn't doubt that AFO would do that.

It was so frustrating. He had no idea where Tomura and his father were. He was terrified that All For One was watching him with his all-knowing eyes. A fear that has seeped its way into Hato's bones. What if his blasted father knew about all of this time-travel business? What if his plan was already ruined before it started?

Hato sighed. Tomorrow will be a good day. Filled with worry-free thoughts. After all, tomorrow is his birthday.

Today is Deku's birthday, Katsuki thinks as he stares up at his ceiling. He has a present for him. Just like he has a present for his ninth and tenth birthday as well. Someday he will give them to him. If the idiot ever comes back.

Don't be stupid. Deku will come back.

The last two presents were both the newest All Might figures of the year. This time, however, he decided to take it up a notch. Bakugou bought him a notebook. He remembered back to a time before everything turned sideways and how Izuku was always writing. And when he wasn't, his hands were moving as if they were. Katsuki's cheeks lift up an inch, but he quickly smothers it. He should be angry. Not buying the Stupid Damn Nerd birthday presents.

He should be angry at Izu, but he can't. Instead, he's angry at everybody else. Lashing out at people left and right. He can't control it. Not without his best friend by his side. He yells and yells. His voice is always rough and scratchy, yet he still yells.

But he's still praised. As he grows, his quirk grows as well. And it will continue to grow. It will become greater than anyone, even he, will imagine.

Katsuki throws himself off of his bed and goes to his drum set that he got a few months ago. He only asked for it because he remembered that Izuku suggested that he should try it. He thought that Bakugou would be good at it.

Damn right he was. He was good at everything (besides processing his emotions). Now whenever he plays, he feels a flutter in his stomach. Actually, that happens whenever he thinks about Deku. Which is a lot.

Katsuki has done a lot of thinking over the past few years. He's had a lot of time for it. And he's been thinking about this feeling in the pit of his stomach. And how his heart always flutters and aches at the same time when thinking about his best friend.

Katsuki knows that two people of the same sex can love each other. And he considers this. Could he be among these people? Katsuki has never liked anyone before. Not like *that.* But he notices that he thinks about Izuku in a different way than other people think about their best friends. Katsuki thinks about Deku's eyes as they hit the sunlight just right. And his laugh, especially his *real* laugh. It's a song that Bakugou can't get enough of. If it were possible, Katsuki would spend every waking moment with Izu.

This is why he thinks there is something more with the feelings that he has for Deku; yet, he's afraid. So he will choose to ignore them. It will hurt, but Katsuki doesn't know what else to do. It's still, what? Another four years until Katsuki will get to see him? Another four years until U.A. It seems like an eternity.

His head hurts from all the thinking. So he decides to go on a run before school starts. He hopes Deku has a good birthday.

Even if it's without him.

———

Izuku is sitting in front of his mother's grave. He knows it stupid to be around where so many people who know him live, but he has to see his mother on this day. Even though he just spends the time here crying and whispering how much he loves her and misses her. So much that it feels like his heart is getting stabbed over and over again. Not a day goes by that he does not think about her. So here he is, on his eleventh birthday with nothing but a few hand picked weeds and his tears to give her. How shameful is that?

"Hey, you! Kid, over here!" He's shaken out of his one-sided conversation with his mother by the sound of a girl's voice. He turns his head to the direction he heard the voice and sees a girl no older than eighteen with electric blue hair buzzed on one side showing multiple piercings on their ear and an eyebrow piercing waving frantically at him. All Izuku does is stare at this total stranger. Has he met her before? He doesn't think so.

Eventually the girl gives up and starts running toward him. Izuku has half the mind to run away. Who knows what this stranger wants? The woman makes it up to him and puts one hand on their knees and the other one holding up one finger while they breathe heavily. Izuku only curiously watches while putting his guard up.

Out of breath, she starts to talk. “My… My name is Arai Hotaru, but you can call me Ru!”

Izuku was beyond confused. He had no idea why this Arai Hotaru was talking to him. Was she okay? Did they need help? They seemed okay. Was this some sort of prank? Anxiety crawled up his spine at the thought.

“I’m sorry, but do you need anything? I was kind of having a private moment…” Izuku didn’t want to sound rude, but he did want some privacy. Especially on this day. Looking at the determined glint in the women’s eyes, he figured his wish would not come true.

Ru’s cheeks pinkend, “Oh! I’m very sorry, but you see, my quirk tells me how lonely people feel. I can’t control it. And… How do I put this? My quirk was screaming at me that you were lonely. It was heartbreaking. So I figured we could help each other out.” They smiled bright like the sun. It reminded him of Madoka. Both of their smiles held such hope.

He doesn’t think he could bear to see another person’s smile fade away at his expense.

“Help each other out? How so?” Izuku was still very skeptical, but his danger sense wasn’t going off, so she couldn’t be *too* bad. “I’m…” He almost said Midoriya Izuku, but realized he couldn’t. Not with his missing posters. Maybe he could just use his first name instead? Afterall, it was a pretty common name. “Izuku. Just Izuku”

Ru smiled again and held out their hand. He shook it and smiled as well. “Alrighie, Just Izuku. I have a proposition for you. How about we take a walk?” Izuku nods and lets Arai take the lead. She starts talking while gesticulating her arms, “You see, I’m opening a cat cafe. I think it will help people be less lonely, you know?” They wait for Izuku to nod before continuing, “But I need help. I have everything set up, and it *is* open. I’m just the only one working, soooo would you like to work for me? There’s conveniently two dorms above the cafe that you could stay in.”

She looks so hopeful and happy talking about her cafe. Izuku has to admit, it would be nice to have some company. And they seem like such a pleasant friend. Plus it would be a major upgrade from the abandoned building he’s been staying in for the past two years.

Then things got gloomy. Hotaru put their head down, a shadow casting over their eyes. “You know, I’m lonely too. My parents died a long time ago and the foster home I used to live at was horrible to say the least. I ran away and I doubt they even noticed. I think it would benefit us both in more than one way if we stick together. Unless my quirk is wrong (which it never is) and you have family and friends to go back to?”

He sighed, “No, I don’t. I think you're right when you said it will benefit us both. It’s very tempting, I have to admit. Can I have a day to think about it?” He *was* lonely. Maybe, just maybe, he can do this one kind thing for himself.

She beamed at him, “Of course! Just walk into my cafe anytime you have your answer! It’s called Kaiteki Cafe and is on Mila Street.” She looked down at her watch and her eyes widened, “Crap! I gotta go. Cafe’s opening in T minus ten minutes! Hope to see you soon!” Before Izuku could even nod, she had already turned the corner. It was only eight in the morning and so much had already happened. This was going to be an interesting day for sure.

———

Hato was sitting on the roof of his favorite building. It was dark outside, the air warm and blanketing. Instead of stars, there were city lights twinkling. It was a beautiful night. Hato waited patiently for Aizawa to arrive. They always meant up once a week to give a status report. There’s been a few times where the hero mentioned Izuku, his eyes crinkled with worry for Izuku. It made him feel guilty, but it means a lot to him that Aizawa is still searching for him.

While he was waiting Hato thought about the offer that he was given earlier. Arai seemed very pleasant. He feels like they would make good friends. However, as usual, there were a million questions swarming his mind. What if she was a spy sent from villains? What if she would just throw him away after she was done with him? What if what if what if-

No. He had to stop this. Hotaru seemed like a genuinely caring person. They don’t seem to be the type to betray or give up on. Besides, how would he ever know if he doesn’t try?

Trusting people gets you and everyone you love killed. You out of everyone should know that.

But maybe he won’t get his trust squashed by this energetic person. Maybe he could even eat the pastries served in the cafe as well. It would be better than the scraps he’s been managing to find. Plus it would be a stable home. And Hotaru was right; Izuku was lonely. He has always been a social butterfly, even though he doesn’t let that side show that much anymore. He craves being around people. And without them, he always feels like something is missing.

Maybe nothing bad would come out of the deal. Except for having to hide his vigilante persona. That should fairly be easy. Hato made up his mind. He would take the deal. Besides, he could always leave if he wanted to. It’s not like Arai would be confining him to the cafe. At least he sure hoped not.

That's when he heard Aizawa. He turned and gave a small wave to the tired hero.

“Hello, Kid.”

Hato smiles even though Eraserhead can't see it from underneath his mask. "Ah! Eraserhead! Fancy seeing you here." The underground hero scoffs and moves to sit down with him. "You know, Mr. Hero, today is a special day." Hato's legs start swinging in giddiness from getting to mess with Aizawa.

Speaking of which, he looks intrigued and maybe even hopeful. Hato almost feels bad. "And why is that?"

"It's a secret!" He can't help it, a mischievous laugh escapes him.

Eraserhead sighs and Hato swears he sees his soul escape him. It's hilarious. Sadly, Shouta's despair dies out quickly, "So, kid, what have you been up to?"

Hato thinks. Nothing much. There suspiciously hasn't been a lot of crime lately. This worries him. He remembers back to a time where all of the sudden the crime rate dropped in Hatsu, but that's when the League of Villains made their first attack at the school

"Not much. Which is worrisome. It's never this quiet."

Aizawa nods, "I agree. Something's up. And I'm not excited to find out what." He looks grim. Hato is, too. Whatever this is, it can't be good. The thing is, He can't remember back to the last timeline if anything happened. Was this something new? Or was there really nothing to worry about? Maybe it was just one big coincidence. Yeah, the villains all just simultaneously decided to take a break.

Hato speaks up, "We need to be prepared, just in case. You never know what's going to happen in a world full of quirks." He stands up and stretches, putting his arms way above his head. "I better get going. I'm planning on visiting someone tomorrow."

Aizawa looks up at him, "Who?"

"Ha! It's a secret. Have fun with your husband~" He starts to run to get momentum to jump to the next roof.

"How did you-!" But Hato was already on the next roof. Then the next. Now that he thought about it, he had to visit two people. Ru (and hopefully move into the dorm if he was lucky) and a certain icy person.

Chapter End Notes

Hello! How's everyone doing? I hope everyone liked this chapter! What do you think about Aria Hotaru? Speaking of which, would anyone like. To draw them? I would really love that!

Here's some info about her: They use she/they pronouns and identify as genderqueer. They are pansexual and fantasize about having someone to have as a partner. She loves crystals and always wears at least two. Her hobbies are making weird but delicious drinks for her cafe, crocheting, and doing their makeup. They also love picking stray cats off of the street and adopting them because they remind her of herself and make them feel less lonely.

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Memories are Mirrors to Our Present

Chapter Summary

Izuku moves in with Ru and memories he tries to suppress come back running.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku takes a deep breath and looks up at the pastel blue building. It's cute. The windows are big and the design on the door is unique. The design is a black cat facing backwards with a wreath of blue roses encircling it. At the bottom of the design is the name of the cafe in cursive, "Kaiteki Cafe". There's frilly black drapes to help protect people from the rain with crystal charms dangling from the ends.

Izuku knocks on the door, hoping that Arai is here even though the cafe hasn't even opened yet. He adjusted his backup and tightened his grip on his pink suitcase that had a *My Little Pony* character on it. Yet another item he's found near the trash. It's definitely not his style, but it'll have to do.

Just as he was about to give up, the door opened to reveal a disheveled Hotaru with crazy bedhead. It was almost as bad as Izuku's. She even had drool running down her chin. They were wearing an oversized lavender shirt that said "Karens are wannabe MILFS" and sport shorts. It honestly made Izuku's mood brighten. It would be good for him to be around Ru. He needed some humor in his life. God, when was the last time he laughed? Actually laughed? It's been so long. Izuku feared that he might have forgotten how to.

"Izuku! I'm so glad you came. Sorry I look like, well, this," Hotaru said while gesturing to herself.

He waved his hand in dismissal, "Don't worry about it." Ru opens the door wider and invites Izuku inside the cafe. Izuku can't help it, he gushes. The inside was even more adorable than the outside! The walls are plain with plants hanging off of them. The area that made up the drink and pastry area is made up of blue rustic wood. Tables were white marble with wooded gray seats. Then there were the cats. There had to be at least six of them. Izuku noticed water bowls next to each of their beds. The cats had to be close to kittens. They were so small and big-eyed. He didn't know what two of the cats were, but he knew that two of them were Munchkin cats, one was a Bombay cat, and the last one he knew had to be a Persian cat.

Izuku thought for certain that he would die of cuteness overload. Not that he would mind. He could think of much worse things to die from other than cuteness. Much, Much worse.

Getting turned to ashes by your own quirk.

Having your neck slashed and choking on your own blood.

Having your best friend stab you because they were being controlled and they couldn't stop their hand from sinking into flesh. No matter how hard he *tried. The quirk wouldn't wear off.*

He killed his best friend.

He forces himself to get out of this hole he's digging himself and tells himself to come back to the present. "Wow. This place is amazing. How did you even get it to look like this?" He said in awe. Izuku couldn't believe he would be able to live here. Did he even deserve this? Was it even okay to be working at the age of eleven? He puts his finger to his chin and begins to mutter, "Wait, is it okay to be working? I'm underage. Well, I suppose that a lot of people my age help work out at their families' shops, so maybe? And I'm going to be living here- if that's still a part of the plan, that is! However, if I can't live here then what will I do? I guess I'll just have to move back to-"

He's cut off by Ru putting their hands up to tell him to slow down. "Woah there, Silly Goose! Who knew you could talk so much! That's awesome!" She said, leaving Izuku shocked. No one has ever said anything good about his muttering before. It makes his heart swell in his chest. Ru continues, "First off, I got the cafe to look like this because I had a friend of a friend who said that they'd do it for me as long as I pay them back… Still don't know what that is, but oh well. You're right about the working situation. However, since you're living here now and doing it voluntarily, it'll be okay! Besides, I'll have you be working in the back until you're old enough to work out here in the front. How does that sound? Please tell me if you have any questions!" They stop to breathe for a moment before their eyes widen. "Oh! I almost forgot. Yes, of course you can stay here! I even got your room ready. Even though I didn't know you would *actually* accept my offer. I just wanted to be prepared!" Izuku was overwhelmed by Arai's warmth. She was so nice and had this pep to everything that she does. It was refreshing. Like breathing in freshly bloomed roses.

"Wow, okay! Sounds like a plan," Izuku says as he smiles, "When do you want me to start? And where should I put this?" He gestures to his suitcase and yellow backpack.

He has to keep on reminding himself that he's not the age everyone thinks he is. Izuku is eleven. Just a kid. *He was just a kid when villains attacked his school for the first time.* This means that he has to act like one. Something he's never been good at, not even in the last timeline. The sad truth was that Midoriya Izuku had to grow up way too fast. He doesn't know the innocence of being a kid. He could never fathom looking forward to each tomorrow without even thinking about anything fearful. It should make him sad, but it just leaves him feeling empty.

Without noticing his inner turmoil, Hotaru points upstairs, "I was thinking you can start tomorrow? You can put your stuff upstairs. Your room is the first door to the left. After you're done getting situated I'll prepare you a nice hot meal. We need to get some meat onto those bones of yours! Anything in particular you might like? I make a spectacular Kimchi Nabe~"

That was one of Kacchan's favorite meals. Izuku remembered eating it in the last timeline to try and impress Kacchan. It was so spicy that it gave him hiccups the rest of the day, but he got to hear Kacchan's laugh, so it was totally worth it. He could use some of those good memories right about now.

"That sounds great. Thank you! And yeah, tomorrow works for me!" Izuku tells them before going upstairs. It's a spiral staircase, so it's a tad bit difficult to get his luggage up the stairs, but he manages. As he makes it up to the second floor he sees that there are two doors on either side of him. One has stickers covering it head to toe and the other is plain except for a paper that says "IZUKU" in red sharpie. Before he went into his room Izuku walked further down the hall where the space opened up to a big circle. There was a cute little bay window on one side and a Tv on the other end opposite from it. Bean bags were spread all across the room along with a comfy-looking gray couch. The walls were each painted differently in fun colors. Such as a flushed peach, fuschia, periwinkle, and lavender.

He smiled. It seemed like such a relaxing place to be. He wondered if he'll ever get the time to chill here. Wouldn't that be nice? But no, he didn't have the time to relax. He doesn't remember the last time he wasn't on edge. Izuku sighs and makes his way back to his room and opens the door. For the most part, it's plain. There's a closet on the right side of the other room and a bunk bed with the bottom part left open for more space. His thoughts wonder. It would be so *cool* to put hero merch in here. Now that he's a vigilante there are *so* many heroes he never even heard of until now. Heroes that he actually gets to *mess* with. Not as much as Eraserhead, but still! And of course he'll need All Might merch. He hopes he can find some Gran Torino things as well! He helped Izuku so much during the last timeline…

Right, Izuku can't have that stuff anymore. He doesn't have birthday presents anymore or chores to do to earn money. Besides, Izuku simply doesn't have *the* time for stupid things like collecting merch. He still allows himself to do quirk analysis, but that's because it's useful. Hero merch is anything but. Life isn't fair. He can't engage in mindless hobbies. Not anymore.

He ignored the tears that slid down his cheeks as he put away his minimal clothing and other necessities. Toothbrush, toothpaste, and first aid kit (gifts from Eraserhead) in his own personal bathroom (he has a bathroom! How awesome is that?). And clothes in the closet.

The smell of kimchi nabe swifts through his nose so he hurriedly rubs his cheeks and runs down stairs. His stomach is rumbling, but he's gotten good at ignoring the pains his stomach sends him. He's been good at it ever since the arena. But that doesn't mean he won't deny food when there's a chance. And it smells delicious.

He slides down the railing of the stairs and jumps off of them. "Wow, Hotaru-san! This smells amazing." Izuku says as he makes it towards the kitchen down the hall. Finding the way with his nose.

Arai grabs two bowls and pours broth and other ingredients into them. Izuku can physically smell the spice from here. He's going to be suffering through the whole meal, but it'll be so worth it! Just the thought of a warm home-cooked meal makes his stomach rumble loudly.

They laugh, “Ha! You must be hungry. Good, good! There’s plenty to eat. And, please, call me Ru.” The correction makes Izuku think about Asui, or -damnit- Tsu-chan. She was one of his best friends. One of the only ones who always listened. Not fixing, not offering advice, but just listening. And she gave some of the *best* hugs ever.

He sits down on the stool and eyes the bow placed in front of him hungrily, “Thank you for this delicious meal Hota- I mean Ru-san!” And then, with Arai next to him, they both dig in. Izuku knows that he should slow down and show some manners, but it’s so good! Not to mention how ravenous he is. Izuku doesn’t stop to breathe until he’s got every last drop of the food and his mouth is as hot as the sun.

Ru grabs their bowls and asks for seconds in which Midoriya happily nods his head. He’ll take as much as he can get.

While eating his second bowl Izuku asks, “Hey, is it okay if I go out for a while. There’s someone I have to visit. I’m sorry! I know I just got here, so I totally understand if you want me to stay here.”

She finishes her second bowl with a satisfied sigh. Izuku can’t help but notice how at ease they look. They must have been so lonely being by themself. Izuku can relate. Hopefully they can get closer to each other. Maybe they could be something akin to siblings. That’s probably just wishful thinking though. Izuku doesn’t think he would allow himself to get so close to them. They're probably going to need to go their separate ways eventually, anyway.

“Of course! Just be back by seven. That’s when dinner will be ready. Oh! Today’s Friday, so it’s movie night. Wanna join?” Ru asks with excitement. Izuku can’t bring himself to say no. It’s like when Kacchan and him would have sleepovers and binge watch All Might movies until they were too exhausted to keep their eyes open.

“Sounds like fun! I’ll try not to be too long. Do you need any help with anything before I leave?”

“Nope! I did all the chores before you arrived. If you want, you can start helping with that tomorrow. I usually clean before the cafe’s opened and after it’s closed, so feel free to help!”

Izuku would love to contribute, so he nods and says his goodbyes to Arai. Thanking her again for the fantastic meal.

Izuku makes his way to his friend's house. He finds it easily and sneaks around to the boy’s window. Thankfully he’s in there, doing some training by himself.

Izuku knocks on his window and prepares to see a long-time friend.

Todoroki Shoto.



This lovely picture of Ru is made by @calebsfreckle . They were so nice to do this for me, and look! Look how absolutely beautiful and lovely Ru looks! It’s amazing. Thank you so much!

Chapter End Notes

Hey hey heyyyyy. I hope all of you amazing readers are doing well. I want to thank you again for ,well, you know, reading my story and being so patient with updates! I love all of you so, so, so much!

Getting to Know you

Chapter Summary

Izuku gets to see Shoto!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku Midoriya uses his invisibility quirk to sneak through Shoto's window. He wanted to get some fun out of this. So he leapt through the open window to Shoto's plain room and landed silently. While the young Todoroki was practicing his punches (he was a little sloppy, but he was only twelve. Maybe Izuku could train him? No. He gets enough of that from his dickwad of a father) Izuku snuck up behind him.

At that moment Izuku released his quirk, jumped up with hands up and yelled, "Surprise!" And instead of falling to the ground or screaming like Izuku thought he would, Shoto turned around and tried to punch Midoriya right in the stomach. In a quick second Izuku sidestepped the punch and swapped Todoroki's feet from underneath him. Izuku grinned and put his hands behind him innocently, "Relax, Sho-kun. It's me, Izuku! We met a few years back, remember?"

Recognition adorned Todoroki's face, "Iz… uku?" he said as he got up. He was looking at him as if Izuku were an alien. Knowing Shoto, it probably wasn't far from the truth.

"That's me! I just was in the area and wanted to pop in and see how you were doing. Plus I need to talk to you about something."

"Midoriya, you've been missing for over *two years.* " Todoroki says. He couldn't believe his eyes. Why was Midoriya visiting *him* ? He's not unhappy per say. He's glad that he gets to see the kind little boy again. Their last meeting had an impact on him. One that led to him accepting himself more.

"They're not ugly. See? I have scars too!"

"It shows how much you've survived."

"But it's your *quirk, right?"*

"Do you have any idea how upset Bakugou is? Even after all this time… He's still hurting."

Izuku's heart breaks. He was not expecting any mention of Kacchan. But what Shoto said made Izuku want to run and run and run until he reached his best friend. He wants to apologize and hug him until all the pain has faded away.

But he can't do that. Because then he would just have to leave again. When he sees Katsuki again it's going to be because he has no intention of leaving him ever again.

Izuku's smile drops, "You've been seeing him?" He can't help it, but he's jealous. Izuku wants to be the one seeing Kacchan, but that's just being illogical. Izuku *can't* see him.

Maybe if he just dropped by once-

NO! He'll never be able to leave again if he visits his best friend. Either Katsuki would lock him up in his house and never let him leave or Izuku just wouldn't mentally be able to handle the torture of leaving him again.

Todoroki sees the inner turmoil Midoriya is having, but doesn't mention it. Instead, he nods, "Every once in a while we sit on that log together. We don't usually talk, but it's nice. We keep each other company. He misses you, Midoriya. You better have one big explanation for him when comes back."

For a while they just stare at each other. An explanation? Having any of his actions makes sense would mean having to tell him that he's not even supposed to be here. He's supposed to be *dead.* Along with everybody else.

Izuku smirks, trying to bring out Hato's confidence. "Enough talking about me and my drama. I came here to see how *you* were doing."

Shouto's dull eyes become duller, but for some reason, Izuku sees trust in them. Does he really trust Izuku already? They haven't seen one another in over two years, but that look in his eyes… It reminds him too much of Todoroki from the other timeline.

The boy that has faced too much smiles at him. Izuku tries to help. Tries so *hard, but he can't snap out of it.*

Shouto's eyes are full of trust (and pain. So much pain. AFO made his own quirk turn against him. And now it's killing him. One of his best friends. He can't do anything) and he smiles. Izuku could cry, but he's frozen. He's useless.

“I know that somehow, you will *fix this.”*

And then he burns.

Izuku turns around very quickly so his tears don’t become noticeable. He wipes his tears away with his sleeve and turns around again to face Shouto.

Todoroki looks at him oddly, but Izuku just smiles. The young Todoroki sighs and begins talking, “My brother is dead.” Izuku winces. He was hoping that he would arrive here on time to save Toya. To save him from becoming Dabi. But he was too late. Guilt swells inside of him. Izuku could’ve stopped this. If only he were faster, better, stronger-

He realizes that he hasn’t said anything yet. Izuku won’t apologize for Todoroki’s loss; Shoto hates pity. *Loathes* it. But Izuku, as always, needs to send comfort to those who might need it. The trait is a part of him. It’s what makes Izuku *Izuku.*

Midoriya takes a step forward and opens his arms. He doesn’t know if Shoto will accept the offer of a hug, but the young boy has to be touch starved. Izuku remembers back to his time at U.A before shit hit the fan and how Shoto always craved physical touch. He would never explicitly ask for it, but once he realized that it was okay to draw comfort from others, he became the ultimate snuggle buddy.

Todoroki was shocked. He hasn’t been offered a hug in *years* . A part of him feared that this was all a joke, but then he thought about the bushy-haired kid in front of him. Midoriya was serious. His warm smile that could blind him said it all. All Midoriya wanted was to be there for him.

Todoroki slowly walked into the hug, surprised by the warmth behind it. They stood there for a while. Izuku rubbing soothing circles on the other’s back. He didn’t think Shoto would accept his offer, but he was glad that he did. Izuku desperately needed a hug as well. Just a little piece of security to keep him going.

Still in the hug, Izuku whispers, “Your brother didn’t deserve whatever happened to him. You, your mother, or your siblings don’t deserve the way you’re treated by Endeavor. *Please* never doubt me on that.” Izuku pulled away and put his hands on Shoto’s shoulders. “I promise you that someday things will get better.”

“How do you know that?” Todoroki questions. What Midoriya said seems impossible. How are things going to get better? Seeing his friend again is the best thing that’s happened to him in two years. How is it going to get any better than this?

Izuku grins, “Because I’ll make it better, Sho-kun!” He then looks at his watch and widens his eyes, “Shoot! Sorry, but I have to get going! Take care for me, K? And please don’t tell Kacchan about this.” Before Shoto can get a word in, Izuku is already out of the window and out of sight.

Todoroki can’t help it, but he laughs. It’s small. Barely a chuckle, but it feels light. He’ll have hope for the future, but only because Midoriya said things will get better. He has nothing else, so Todoroki has to believe in his friend.

He wishes that he would have offered Midoriya some sort of comfort as well.

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Izuku forces himself to walk to the cafe. Even though his legs are practically begging him to walk in the direction to Kacchan’s house. He misses him *so much* . But he can’t. Not yet. Since he’s gaining popularity as a vigilante now, it would be putting Kacchan in danger. Especially when things seem as if they’re tipping over the edge. Something is going on with the villains. Patrols have gotten quiet, and quiet is *never* a good sign.

So he walks into the cafe, almost crying when he smells the food. It reminds him of home- of his best friend. Ru walks in with a blue apron that says “No Bitches?” in sparkling rhinestones. Their face brightens up, “Zuzu! Welcome back! Dinner just finished. How was your outing?”

He takes off his shoes and walks into the kitchen, the smell of spice burning his nose. “It smells great! It was fine, thank you for asking.” He didn’t question the nickname and wasn’t bothered by it. The name made it feel as though they were already best friends. And Izuku craved a friend.

The kitchen was near spotless, even with the cooking. Izuku was surprised by Ru’s organization with cooking- he thought she would be more of a chaotic cooker with pans and spoons flying everywhere. “Do you need any help?”

Hotaru waved in dismissal as they dished up the food, “Nah. I’m done anyway. But I would *love* you to help with the dishes once dinner is over!” Ru put the dishes on the table along with napkins and chopsticks. There was the main dish and then there was a small bowl of rice and steamed broccoli. It was the most food presented in front of him in what seemed like forever. He doubted that he would be able to finish it all since his stomach was so used to receiving minimal food, but he hoped he would be able to save it for leftovers. It would make for a great snack-break while he was doing vigilante work.

Before he met Arai Izuku was surviving off of Eraserhead’s bentos that he made for him and convenience store food. A while back, Hato saved an old lady named Mrs. Chiba from a violent robbery and this woman happened to be the owner of said store. She insisted that the food the store had to offer would be free for him. He tried to take as little as he could, and would even help around the store because he would feel guilty for not

paying. Izuku, or Hato since that's what Mrs. Chiba knows him by, should pay a visit since he hasn't gone there in a while. One time Izuku didn't go there for two whole weeks because he caught a really bad fever (wasn't fun and wouldn't be recommended). When he finally visited the store again, Mrs. Chiba wacked him in the head with a newspaper.

At once, Ru and Izuku expressed their gratitude, "Thank you for the meal!"

Izuku took a small bite of the food and almost melted. It was delicious. His taste buds were burning off, but it was so worth it. Even the rice tasted like pure happiness. Izuku dug in with his stomach thinking nothing of manners. Too soon did he begin to feel too full. Even when it was hardly even halfway done. He looked up to see Arai looking at him with a twinkle of amusement in her eyes. That's when Izuku became embarrassed. His cheeks heated up, and it wasn't from the spice.

He was mortified, "Oh my gosh! I'm so sorry for not being polite." Thoughts started swirling in his head. What if they hate him now? No one wants to house a slob. Maybe he should just go get his things and leave.

Ru barked out a laugh, it was loud and boisterous. The sound reminded Izuku of a tweety bird. "Don't worry about anything! I take it that you like the food?" She questioned.

Izuku nodded, "It was delicious! I'm sorry that I couldn't eat more. Could I maybe save it for later? Sorry for the trouble!" If they weren't able to save it, Izuku would just force himself to eat everything. It would definitely make him sick, but he *hated* wasting food. Being deprived of it during the arena and when he was out on the streets made him come to the realization that food is a privilege and shouldn't be wasted.

"Of course we'll be able to save it. Now come on and help me with the dishes. After that we have some things to discuss." Arai stated as they started to gather the dishes, putting Izuku's leftovers in containers.

He paled. He never liked to "discuss things". Those kinds of topics were never good and always ended up with Izuku having a storm of anxiety course through him.

"Midoriya, we need to discuss some things about your quirk," says Aizawa-sensei. It was right after class ended. They were prepping for the battle against the LOV. Izuku had muttered that he had to be the one to bring down All For One, that his quirk was made for it. No one heard it, except for Aizawa of course.

It was not a fun discussion.

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He was captured by the LOV. Arms and legs chained, suppressing his quirks. He's already been forced to endure three more quirks. The pain gets more intense each time. He didn't know how much more he could take.

All For One walks into the room (more like a cell) that Izuku is in. Even after being in their captivity for weeks, he still quivers at AFO's presence. It probably made him look pathetic. Weak.

Maybe he is.

"Ah, Izuku, my dear boy. We have some things to discuss." His face stretched, seemingly trying to form a smile. It only made the villain more terrifying.

"What? What more could you possibly want?!" Izuku knew it was stupid to scream at the most powerful man in the world, but he was tired *and so, so angry.*

"You know very well what I want, Son. For you to join our cause. But you refuse and refuse and refuse. It's getting quite irritating. Maybe I'll just have to… Tweak your mind a bit."

Izuku felt a cold pit in his stomach. He knew he wouldn't be able to resist whatever quirk AFO had up his sleeve.

He was screwed.

After finishing the dishes, they walked up stairs and sat on the colorful bean bags. Midoriya was practically engulfed by the beanbag, but it was warm and cozy, so he didn't mind. It felt like a hug.

"So," Izuku says while twiddling his thumbs, "What did you want to talk about?"

Ru clapped her hands together, "Why do you look so nervous? It's nothing bad, I promise! I mostly just wanted to get to know you and talk about you living here."

That… didn't seem too bad. Hopefully. It should be fine, right? But Izuku always had his suspicions. He had to in order to survive. "Okay. Ask whatever you want." He really didn't want to regret this.

They nodded, “Well, I know that you’re eleven -and I know these questions might get personal, so just tell me when you get uncomfortable-, but when is your birthday? I love giving gifts and throwing parties. You should see the dance moves I can pull off!” Arai then started to move her hands around like a robot.

Izuku laughed, trying not to think of- no. He stopped himself before he went further down that rabbit hole. “My birthday is July fifteenth. When’s yours?”

Hotaru gasped, “Oh my gosh! Your birthday is only a week away. Why didn’t you tell me sooner!!! Uggghhhhhhh I have so much to do!!” Izuku laughed at Ru’s whininess. He didn’t really like celebrating his birthday without his family (without a shining smirk and red twinkling eyes. Loving hugs and steaming Katsudon with his mother), but he didn’t want to let Arai down, so he feigned excitement. “My birthday is January ninth. I’m eighteen at the moment.”

Izuku felt another twinge of jealousy. He never made it to eighteen. Neither did Kirishima, Mina, Asui- Tsu, Ochcao, Todoroki, Kacchan… Nobody in Class 1-A did. Or Class 1-B. No one got to be an adult. No one got to graduate U.A. or get married or create more memories.

No. He’s told himself this a thousand times. He can’t dwell on what could’ve been (but how can he stop when his own mind gives him nightmares about the past?). *This* is why he time traveled. Practically made a whole new timeline. To save his family with a smile.

Izuku brought himself back to the present and plastered on a mischievous grin, “Woah, you’re really old. Shouldn’t you be put in a senior home sometime soon?”

Ru’s jaw dropped to the ground in shock, but then their face turned red and scrunched up like she just bit into a lemon. “You little brat! I can kick you out, you know! Show your elders some respect!” Ru yelled with a glare that made Izuku shivered. He knew now that Arai had the capability to be terrifying. It won’t stop him from teasing her from time to time though.

Izuku snickered as Ru’s eyebrow twitched in irritation, but they eventually calmed down. In a quieter voice than before, she asked, “I’ll ask you one more question and then it’s off to bed for you. You look like you haven’t slept in days. Movie night can wait,” they waited for Izuku to nod before continuing, “You obviously still need to be at school. I can homeschool you if you want. I might not look like it, but my IQ is pretty high.” A wave of pride washed over her as she bragged. Izuku had to admit, he hadn’t thought this far into the *Moving in with Ru* plan yet.

So he said the first thing that popped into his head, “I don’t really need school. I self learn with books, and my knowledge is already past college level. I haven’t been to school since the third grade.”

He expected Ru to brush him off and assume that he was over exaggerating, but she nodded seriously. Most people wouldn't believe his intelligence unless he proved it to them over and over again. It was nice to have someone believe Izuku so whole-heartedly.

"Even if you don't need school it's important to keep you enrolled in case you *do* want to go back to public school. Plus I think it would be good for you to be homeschooled to keep your memory fresh, and who knows, I might teach you something you've never even thought about."

Of course . Izuku couldn't believe he hadn't thought about having to be enrolled in order to be able to attend hero school. Hopefully it will be easy to put him in grade level six since he has to stay in the same grade level Kacchan and everyone else from class- 1A. And Izuku loves learning new things, so he wouldn't mind being taught by Ru.

The only tricky thing would be to get him registered without anyone finding out that he's the missing "quirkless boy" from two years ago.

His face lights up, "Okay, I agree with that. I need to be registered into the school system in order to go to U.A., anyway. But when they register me for the sixth grade -I don't want to skip any grades please- could I use your last name?"

Arai ponders for a moment, wondering why an eleven year old boy would be so secretive. Now that she thinks about it, Izuku does look familiar… Izuku's different, and it's going to be hard to get him to fully trust them, but that's okay. Ru was patient. She offered to support him so it was her job to make sure he was safe. "I can do that. It'll be tricky, but I have my ways."

Izuku visibly relaxed. He hadn't realized he was so uptight, but then again, he was always tense. With that, came a humongous yawn. He needed to get a quick nap before he went out on patrol tonight. Hato needed to talk to Eraserhead about his suspicions going on with the sudden eerie vibe going on within the city.

Ru giggled, "Okay, sleepy head, it's time for you to go to bed. Sleep in tomorrow, you need the extra rest. I'll have breakfast ready soon after you wake up and then we can open up the cafe! Usually I open it at 6:30, but I think it's okay to open it up a bit later."

Rubbing his eyes, Izuku bid farewell to Hatoru, "Thank you Ara- I mean Ru-san. Goodnight." Exhaustion was suddenly hitting him in waves and he was just about ready to drop. Like a zombie, Izuku brushed his teeth and washed his face. Changing into a new shirt and sweatpants that Ru must've gotten him. He made a mental note to thank her in the morning.

He told himself just an hour of sleep then he would get up for patrol. He could get plenty of rest in one hour (if he wasn't plagued by a nightmare, that is).

He was asleep before his head hit the pillow.

Chapter End Notes

Hi! Sorry for the late post. I tried to make up for it by making it longer. Anybody Else getting their ass kicked from finals? I am. Ha... ha

I love all of you and I promise I'll make next chapter spicy.

Hope everyone has/had a good, fantastic day!

Mizpah

Chapter Summary

Dreams are a fickle thing.
Warning: Small mention of self-harm

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bakugou was in a stream. His body ached and he wanted to cry but the extras were there (what extras? Where the hell was he?) . *He rubbed his head and smiled it off, but then a familiar voice spoke. It made him so angry and annoyed. He* hated *this voice.*

"Kacchan! Are you alright?" Katsuki was face to face with Deku . *His little stubby hand reaching out for him. Rage filled Katsuki* (Why was he so angry? This was Izu. Shouldn't he be happy to see him?) *and without a second thought, he slapped Izuku's hand away. The moment that the string always tied them together strained.*

But it didn't tear. It would never tear.

Katsuki watched as the years went by and the hatred in his heart grew to a wicked degree. It was confusing. These events -pushing Izuku away, away, away, and burning and bruising him, saying awful, cruel things to him- never happened. He never sat back and watched as people gave Izuku permanent scars or pushed him down the stairs only to laugh at his tears. So what was this? It was far too real to be a dream, but what else could it be?

Izuku never got kidnapped and Auntie never died. Izuku never left him, either. Everything was so different, but they seemed so much like memories. It didn't hold the fog that dreams carried. Katsuki preferred this to reality because even though he was so convinced that he hated Izuku (He could never hate Deku. No matter how much he wanted too. Besides, even in this… realm? Fragment of his imagination? He could sense something underneath all of the fear of weakness and loathing. Katsuki could feel warmth. Whenever this version of himself glimpsed at Izu's smile, he felt a flutter of fondness and serenity. Katsuki came to a conclusion that this terrified the other version of himself.) *he would forever prefer this version of the one where Izuku has endured kidnappings and the death of his mother. At least this way, Bakugou could see Izuku everyday.*

They were in their last year of middle school now, and he had gotten worse. So had everyone else. Even the teachers, while not directly, still found ways to make Midoriya's life more difficult. Class had finished and while not the most important detail, Bakugou noticed that he had gotten taller and could make out his quirk thrumming through his veins. Stronger than ever.

He knew it would only continue to grow.

Izuku was small, like a twig. He had eyebags under his eyes, not as bad as the Izuku he knew two years ago, but still concerning. His shoulders are hunched to an impressive level and he's shaking, always shaking.

He regrets what he's about to do before he even knows what. Soon he finds out as the Katsuki-that -isn't-him-but–is-him walks towards the poor boy and starts tossing his notebook around with the extras (Katsuki vaguely recognizes them from his elementary school. Although they have matured in looks, he can tell that they are still a bunch of idiots) . *Then, with a hollow sensation in his chest, he uses his quirk* (it's meant for good, he wants to yell. Not this.) *to damage the precious book and throws it out the window.*

Bakugou wants to go over and hug his Izu, but he can't. He's not in control. And when he thinks it's over he opens his stupid mouth again.

After years of bruises, burns, and scratches. Name-calling, ridiculing, and demanding Midoriya to give up on his dream, Katsuki thinks nothing could be any worse than what's already been said and done.

But he's wrong.

"If you want a quirk so bad, why don't you do us all a favor and take a swan dive off the roof and pray for a quirk in your next life?"

Katsuki hates himself.

_____

His eyes don't snap open, but slowly flutter. He's clutching onto Izuku's All Might plushie that he left behind when he left with all his might. Trying to stop the tears before they gather, but it's too late. For the first time in months, Bakugou Katsuki unravels. Months of bottling up his emotions towards… towards *everything* illustrate themselves with his sobs and stuttering breaths. The ache, the *stab,* of not seeing Izu in so long and the loneliness he's felt have been weighing on him to the point where it's hard to stand at times.

The dream only made it worse. To imagine a reality like that was awful, but he wished that was the one he lived in. Through all the tears and gasps, Katsuki comes to a realization. The dream felt so real. Just like a memory. It couldn't have been a dream. Not when it felt like he actually said those awful things to Izuku. The guilt of that final sentence before whatever-it-was ended is so present and non-fleeting. In fact, hadn't he had a dream like this one before? He can't remember the details, but he did remember something like this happening before.

Katsuki's tears slowed and then ceased. He was still furious with Izuku for leaving and livid with everyone else (besides his parents) forgetting about him- his best friend. Katsuki is twelve now and has been in middle

school for a few months. Which meant he was older and smarter now. He understands, while not fully, the feelings he has for Deku. It was more than a crush. Something as precious and important as Bakugou's perception of Izu couldn't be labeled with such a silly word as "crush". He just didn't know what.

All he knew was that he cared for Izuku. More than a best friend. And before some idiot gets mad (Katsuki doesn't care. They can shove their attitude up their ass) he doesn't care that Izuku is a boy. That doesn't matter. Why should that matter?

The not-a-dream was slowly fading to the back of his mind, but he promised that someday he would revisit it. He knew that for some reason it was important. But for now, his eyes were burning and a fresh wave of exhaustion settled over him. He closed his eyes, holding the plush close to his chest, and went into a *real* dream-filled sleep.

On his desk is Izuku's twelfth birthday present. Waiting for him like the other two.

Aizawa walks into the common room of Class-1A dorms to get himself a cup of coffee when he sees the kitchen light on (Dorm rooms? Since when did his class have dorms? This must be another one of those dreams. How strange, thought Aizawa. It was an out of body experience. So real. He could feel his capture weapon rub against his face and the lack of sleep that was always burning him). *He sighed. What could one of his students be doing at one in the morning? Maybe it was (* the name blanked out before Aizawa- the *real* Aizawa could figure out who it was *) who had woken up from another nightmare. Aizawa wouldn't be surprised. The tough kid has just been through a kidnapping.*

As Shota walked closer he saw a head full of green curly hair (If Shota remembered correctly, it was the same kid who was in his last dream several years ago. The boy that seemed so familiar.) *and immediately wanted to drag his hand down his face. Of* course *it was his number one problem child. The sunshine and hope of class-1A. It looked like he was just drinking a cup of tea, clenching the mug so tight that Aizawa thought he would break it.*

He made his presence known, "Problem Child," the kid flinched, making him swarm with guilt, "What are you doing down here so late when you should be sleeping?" He made his way toward the kitchen to grab the instant coffee.

Instead of answering Izuku softly said, "You shouldn't be drinking so much coffee. Especially this late at night. Not only does it keep you awake while you should be asleep, but also increases anxiety and your heart rate. I'll make you some tea instead. It'll help you get a few hours of sleep tonight. Something that overdosing on coffee wouldn't do." The boy's face, just like the other dream, was blurred. His voice was kind and soothing, but so, so drained (it reminded him of Midoriya Izuku, right after they rescued him. But this couldn't be Midoriya. Not when he went missing two years ago. But the thought stuck, leaving Aizawa to ponder).

Shota grumbled and put the instant coffee back. As much as he loathed to admit it, the problem child was right. Tea might be a good change. Just this once. Besides, once the kid was determined, there was no way to stop him.

So he sat down next to where his student sat and watched him make some peppermint tea. He didn't even have to tell him that he liked his tea without anything in it, he already knew. Not that he was surprised, the boy was aware of everything. His problem child set the mug down (His favorite cat mug. Good to know it was still around. If this is what he's starting to think it is, anyway) *and sat back down.*

"You never answered my question," Aizawa calmly stated, waiting for his tea to cool down.

"Oh! I didn't, did I? I couldn't sleep and my room was beginning to feel too cramped," his student said with an awkward laugh. But something felt different. His voice was strained, like he wanted to cry. Over the last few months of meeting his student Aizawa has seen him cry on multiple occasions. He seems like the type of kid who was comfortable with expressing his emotions. Shota thought it was an admirable trait. Sure, it was a little risky if he wanted to be a hero, but it was a characteristic that would do plenty of good if harnessed in the right ways.

So why did it seem like (the name blanked out again. It was beginning to frustrate Shota. Why couldn't he see the kid's face? Hell, why couldn't he even know his name?) *was putting in a great amount of effort to hold back whatever he was trying to hold back?*

They were both silent. For once, no muttering could be heard. That was probably the most worrying thing. That and the fact that his problem child was staring at his arms (So scarred, Aizawa notices. Too young to have that many scars. Again, it reminded him of Midoriya and the scars he had adorned. But Midoriya had a star-shaped scar on his palm. Not jagged, long scars along his arms) *with longing and sorrow. So much despair were in those eyes. Shota had never seen that look before on his face. It was always scrunched up in either a smile or deep in thought. Never an empty shell.*

The green-haired boy lets out a sigh and begins to rub his forearms. The teacher watched and noticed for the first time straight, precise, white lines across his wrist.

Shota's gut twisted (So did the real Aizawa's. He's had student's who have self-harmed before, and it never got any easier to know that his kids had felt like they had to harm themselves for whatever reason). *He was surprised and worried.*

"Mid–" He was about to say before he got interrupted (Shota couldn't deny it. It had to be Midoriya. It sounded like he was about to say that name. It was the only logical explanation. Although, this whole thing was illogical).

Midoriya turned his wrists over and faced Aizawa. This time, his face was not blurred. He had the same freckles as the Midoriya he knew and the same bright green eyes. It really was him.

"Don't worry Aizawa! I'm fine, see?" He says it a little bit too cheerfully and flashes a smile to demonstrate how "fine" he was. Aizawa frowned, trying to think of something to say that wouldn't make the child enclose more on himself then he already was. "Besides, I'm just having a rough night. I'll be as good as new in the morning. Promise!"

(He sounded just like the boy he rescued. So determined to keep on going without a break. Apparently, this Aizawa seemed to think so as well.)

"Kid, it's okay to take a break and assess how you're feeling. Your struggles are just as valid as everybody else's," Shota tried to explain. But Izuku's face was already full of disbelief.

He expected an argument, but instead the Problem Child said, "Whatever you say, Sensei. I better get back to my room. Have a goodnight. And please *try to get some sleep."*

Aizawa woke up confused. He had no idea what these "dreams" were, but they had to mean something. Every fiber of his being was screaming at him that this was important. It's like a part of him, hidden deep inside of him, already knew what was happening. Already knew what these visions meant.

And that sort of made sense. When he was first on the case trying to find Midoriya shortly after his kidnapping, he felt like he knew the boy. Izuku was strikingly familiar in ways that Shota had never accounted for. It was bizarre because here was this kid who he had never met before, that seemed like someone he had known a long time ago.

Shota snuck out of his husband's arms and went to his desk. Sitting down, he grabbed a pen and a piece of paper. Then he began to write about everything that he witnessed that night.

He wouldn't let himself forget.

Izuku woke up a little over an hour after he fell asleep and got into his vigilante uniform. His body protested against every movement. Oh how he earned to fall back asleep, but this patrol was his weekly meeting with

Eraserhead. He couldn't miss it. Luckily there was a window in his bedroom leading to a fire escape. Within three minutes, Hato was out in the bustling city dressed in his vigilante attire.

It wasn't until a little while that he realized he forgot to bring his leftovers with him. It was disappointing that he couldn't have a little snack, but maybe he could sneak down to the kitchen once he got back to the cafe in a few hours! That would be a good reward for the draining patrol.

He continued to leap roof to roof towards their usual meeting spot. Eraserhead and him never really spoke about how the old apartment building became their designated meeting spot, it just did. It didn't take too long to arrive, maybe fifteen minute tops if the vigilante had to guess.

Hato could see that Aizawa was already there sitting at the edge of the roof. He went to join him. Landing silently and sitting no closer than six feet from the hero. Hato never went any closer just in case Eraserhead tried to capture him or tried to find out his identity. Which could *not* happen. That would be a total and complete disaster.

"Hi kid," Aizawa greeted. Sipping on a cup of coffee looking more tired than usual.

Hato waved, "You okay, old man? Don't tell me you're overdosing on coffee. Maybe you should try tea instead. It *is* a lot better for you, you know."

Hato watched as Aizawa's head snapped up and his eyes widened in surprise. It shocked Hato and he jumped to his feet in response. Putting his hands to his hips Hato asked again, "I'm serious. Is there something wrong? Am I missing out on some big mission?" before he could stop himself he started to mutter, "That would make sense, I guess. It has been so eerie recently. Usually when that happens it usually means groups of villains have banded together. Of course there are multiple scenarios that could be at play here. Maybe some mass murder of villians that we don't know about? Or what if someone's controlling them! That definitely wouldn't be good, but if we find out who's controlling them then it would be pretty easy to attack and win. Or who knows, maybe there's some villain vacation we don't know about?"

Aizawa shoots him an unamused glance. Hato feels his face heat up underneath his mask. "I'm fine. You're right though. Something's up. I doubt it's a vacation though."

Hato shrugs, "Hey, you never know." His eyes cast downward to the people walking around on the side walks. A lot of stores are still open even though it's way past midnight. With his enchanted hearing he listens to the laughter of teenagers and the flirting of adults. He can see tired workers finally get off and parents struggling to keep their family in check. "I hope we find out what's happening soon. It makes me feel antsy not knowing what's going on. Plus there could be people who are being silently killed or controlled and we wouldn't know. It's funny how people can be so ignorant and blind to such awful things."

“People believe what they want to believe, kid. They tend to ignore what they don’t want to know. Torture, rape, murder, war. People are a lot more content convincing themselves that those are only shown in the media or aren’t relevant.” Aizawa chugged down his coffee and put his goggles on. He stood up to face Hato.

It was so frustrating how people were just so oblivious to the world’s faults. And maybe he was a little bit envious of them as well. He knows the scent of blood and pain filled screams all too well. It’s practically engraved into him. He had convinced himself that it was normal to have nightmares every night and sometimes think you see blood stains on your hands that never come off.

It wasn’t normal. Was it? Was he messed up? Worse, was he *unfixable?*

“But that’s why heroes are here. To preserve the light and control the dark. And right now all we can do is keep an eye out and do some research as to why the villains have gone silent. Think you can do that?”

Heroes weren’t the light or dark. They were the gray. A balance to try and keep everything equal. Protect, save, help. That was the essence of being a hero.

Hato nodded, “Yeah, I can do that.”

“Good. Try not to get yourself into too much trouble before our next meeting,” Aizawa jokes. A very rare thing.

Hato forces a laugh like he always does. “Okay, now your expectations for me are getting impossible,” he backs away a little toward the corner of the roof, “but I’ll try!”

As they take off towards their different directions, the vigilante remembers something said to him a long time ago. By his idol, mentor, and father-figure.

You are two sides of the same coin. Win to save and save to win.

Maybe that’s part of being a hero, too.

Chapter End Notes

Are you guys proud of me for updating in less than two weeks?!

I love all of you and please take care of yourselves! Even if that's just drinking a glass of water. Hope everyone has/had a great day!

Birthday Wishes

Chapter Summary

It's Izuku's birthday!!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku woke up and groaned. He hated this day for so many reasons that some have gotten lost to him. He wanted to sleep the day away, where he wouldn't have to think about everything he had to do. All the pressure that he put on himself. So much that it felt like the world was the one reminding him of all his responsibilities and stress. Today only made it worse. A reminder of the ticking time bomb. Getting closer and closer to going off.

His birthday.

He despised this day. Sure, the few birthdays he had when his mother was still alive before he got kidnapped were lovely. Yes, he was still new to the whole "going back in time" thing so he was really overwhelmed, but at least he had his family. The birthdays after he escaped from the Arena were just sad, but he had tried to put a happy face on for the Bakugou's.

Izuku could hardly remember his birthdays from the last timeline. He knows for a fact that he stopped celebrating them after his six birthday (although his mother would still sneak in some new merch into his room). And the first and only birthday he had during his time at U.A. was not a good one.

"How did you know it was my birthday?"

"That's a secret!" Said Ochako. So bubbly and happy. So very strong.

He had suspected that it was Kacchan who told everybody about his birthday. He remembered being angry- he didn't want to celebrate his birthday. It held nothing but bad memories. But everyone was so determined to change that. To make at least a few pleasant memories from his birthday.

"You're the traitor?!"

"I'm sorry, Midoriya. You have to come with me or we will make you regret it."

He didn't doubt that. People were already severely injured. Those who could move were helping those who couldn't.

"I trusted you. You're one of my best friends."

"You shouldn't have trusted me then."

Not wanting to think of those tragic memories anymore, Izuku jumps from his bunk bed and goes to the bathroom. He washes his face and brushes his teeth so hard his gums begin to bleed.

Izuku has been at Kaiteki Cafe for a week now and he couldn't be more grateful. Hotaru was Satan in disguise, but also a sweetheart. They helped teach him how to make all sorts of drinks ranging from cappuccinos to Italian sodas. They served just about everything in between as well. Milkshakes (Izuku would make some for himself on occasion), lattes, coffees, americanos, teas, you name it. Izuku thoroughly enjoyed working behind the scenes. It gave him something to learn and it was a fun hobby that kept his mind off of things. He got to live here *and* he got to do something that he really liked! It was a win-win. Not to mention the cats. He loved snuggling with the cats, and they seemed to bring in a lot of business as well.

Izuku slid down the railing of the stairs expecting to see Arai just beginning to open up, but what he saw instead were colorful streamers hanging from the ceiling and a big "Happy Birthday!" Banner hung right above the glass door. For a second, Izuku's feet stayed glued to the floor. It took him a while to process that this was for *him* . He remembered Ru mentioning how they were going to celebrate, but he didn't really think she meant it.

But Ru did *mean* it. Obviously.

He walked towards the back where the kitchen and dining room were and noticed a large bag that was decorated with heroes. A card was lying next to the bag with his name addressed to it.

"Surprise!" Ru shouted, startling Izuku. She came out of the pantry holding an assortment of ingredients. Flour, baking soda, vanilla extract, etc. "Happy Birthday Zu Zu! Now I can make pancakes or waffles for breakfast. Or both! Obviously I'll be making eggs and bacon as well. You're a growing boy so that means you need lots of protein and other nutrients!"

Arai was all smiles and sunshine. They had no idea how happy they made Izuku. Before he knew it, he was tearing up. They've barely known each other for a week and yet Hotaru was shedding Izuku with kindness.

“I…” He couldn’t seem to process any words. It took him a few moments to gather himself, but Ru was patiently waiting with a soft smile. Nothing mocking, just loving. He wiped his tears away with his arm and tried to speak again, “pancakes please.”

“You got it!”

Of course, Izuku helped them in any way he could. Stirring the batter, cracking the eggs, and setting the table. The whole time he felt a buzzing in his chest that he couldn’t place. It didn’t seem bad, so Izuku let it be. Only when they were sitting at the table did he realize what the feeling was.

Happiness.

Once both of their stomachs were stuffed with hearty food did Izuku express his gratitude. He had been thinking during the entire meal of what to say and he finally knew what.

“Thank you,” Izuku started, “this means more than you know. I’m so grateful that I met you and I can tell that we are going to be life-long friends. You’re like a sibling to me. I hope you know how much I appreciate you and I already know this is going to be a great birthday.”

Ru wiped a tear from her eye, “I’m so glad you like all of this. I wasn’t sure if you would. I promise that you will always be welcomed here no matter what. I appreciate you, too and view you as family. Happy birthday, Zu,” She then clapped her hands together and exclaimed, “Now let's get these dishes over with and open some presents!”

After dishes, which only took a few minutes because they’ve gotten so used to working together that they’re like an oiled machine, they were back at the table with the birthday bag and card in front of Izuku.

“Go on,” Ru said, pushing her hands forward in a shooing motion, “open it!”

He went for the letter first. He gently used his fingers to open it, not wanting to tear even the envelope. It’s the first letter he’s gotten in a little over two years which means everything about it is precious.

The card design was silly and it was entirely something Ru would pick, but it also held a semblance of *him* as well. The front of the card was like something out of a comic book. With bright yellows and blues. A spiky bubble with the words “HAPPY BIRTHDAY LITTLE HERO!” was smack dab in the center of the card. It made Izuku blush at how childish it was, but Izuku couldn’t help but feel cheerful at how young this made him feel. His past self would have loved to have gotten this card.

His cheeks lifted and his eyes found Arai's. She was smiling, her eyes twinkling. They looked proud of their choice of card. Putting his focus back on the card, Izuku opened it to be greeted with a giant pop-out "POW" right in the middle card. Not only that, but rainbow glitter exploded as well. Getting all over Izuku. He yelped and stumbled back. Glitter was *everywhere.* In his hair, on his shirt, on his face, and Izuku felt a tickle in his nose… Soon he was *sneezing* glitter.

Meanwhile Ru was on the ground punching the ground. Laughing so much that it started to sound like wheezing. "Oh my God. I can't- that was so damn funny! You *sneezed* - Ha! I can't breathe," Ru gasped out. The wheezing continued as Izuku sneezed another puff of sparkles.

Soon he was laughing too. Cackling so hard that he was crying. Soon he was on the ground too, the sound of Hotaru's strangled laughing only making him laugh harder.

And then she lifted her phone and announced, "I got that on camera."

He gasped. Trying to take the phone away from them to erase the embarrassing monstrosity, but his body was betraying him. Izuku couldn't stop howling. He gave up trying to delete the cursed photage and decided to be grateful for it. This was one of the funniest moments he's ever had. Izuku doesn't remember the last time he fell from laughter. Doesn't even know if that's even happened before.

Ru got up first and pulled Izuku up with their hand. Izuku would worry about getting the glitter off of him later. Izuku was about to grab the birthday bag when he noticed hand writing on the inside of the letter. He stole a glance from Ru who chuckled nervously before reading the note. Ru's handwriting is in all caps and is always tilted to the side.

Happy birthday Zu-Zu! I hope I can help you have a good birthday this year. Sorry that it's nothing grand and luxurious. Do you think this should suffice?

You are such a treasure and I am so glad that I've met you. You have fought off my loneliness and make me smile with your presence alone. I hope I can at least do half of that. When I first sensed you with my quirk, my entire being was screaming at me to go up and talk to you. I'm glad I did. Zu-Zu, you are the little brother I never knew I needed.

You deserve more than I have to offer, but I promise I'll do my absolute best to protect and care for you. That's what big siblings do! Remember that you are kind, important, and special. No one can take those things from you.

Yours,

Ru

P.S: Sorry not sorry for the glitter bomb!

Izuku went up to Arai and hugged them. There was a big height difference since Izuku was pretty short (a good seven inch difference since he was a measly 5'1" and Ru is 5'8'') so Hotaru bent down so they were leveled when they hugged. It was the first hug Izuku allowed since he met Ru; not liking any sort of physical contact unless it was someone he trusted. And he decided that he would trust Ru.

"Thank you. You have no idea how much this means to me," Izuku whispered. He was afraid that anything above a whisper would push him back to a cruel and cold reality.

"I meant every word of it. Now open your present! I'm getting antsy."

Midoriya laughed and went to the hero-themed bag and took an endless amount of green and red tissue paper. Right when he thought it was the end of the tissue-nightmare more would appear. Finally he found something and pulled it out. There, in his hands, was a light blue composition notebook. He was stunned into silence. It was just like the notebooks he used to have. Way back when none of this timeline even existed.

"What-?"

Ru –bless them– offered an explanation, "You're always muttering about the heroes we see on TV. You have a great talent for analysis, so I thought it would do you some good to write them down. Keep on looking in the bag. There's two more items, and one is related to this."

Izuku was dumbstruck. He had given up his analysis thinking it would be too dangerous. Afterall, it was used against him right before the war broke out.

But Izuku didn't code it back then .

Maybe if he created his own code that only he understood, Izuku could finally go back to his favorite hobby! That would be amazing. He still caught his hands twitching as if they were writing even years after giving up his analysis. Maybe he can even write all his plans and ideas he has for the upcoming future. That would certainly help sort out his jumbled, wired thoughts.

Izuku set the notebook down with as much care as possible. Treating it as if it were a newborn baby. Then he dug into the bag once again. There he found an array of colored pens and mechanical pencils (along with a huge stash of lead). And to his deepest surprise, an All Might figure.

This whole time Izuku had been holding back tears, but upon seeing this last present, they began to fall. Midoriya missed his All Might merch dearly. It was just something that he couldn't concern himself with this time around, but seeing this old Silver Age All Might relit that part of him. The figure even came with a small poster! How awesome was that?!

He hugged the figurine and whispered thank yous like a prayer.

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Katsuki's legs dangled from the log as he watched the small river slither beneath him. It was midday and his stomach was rumbling but he remained glued to the log. Just a while longer. He wanted to reminisce as many memories of his time with Izu at this place as he could. To be able to feel the log that they've walked on countless of times, gaze at the same river that they trotted in to find fish and frogs. Here, Katsuki felt closest to Deku. He wondered if Izuku visited this place. Maybe he even sat where Bakugou was sitting to think back on all the fun times they had.

Why did Izuku have to leave him? Is he not good enough? Where even was Deku? Was he with someone else, or all alone?

Both thoughts twisted his gut. He hated to think that Izu was all alone, but also despised the idea that he had chosen someone else over him. *They* are best friends. Only Katsuki could have the label as Izuku's best friend. He should have been able to go to Katsuki when he needed help. Not run away.

They were supposed to be a team.

"Hello, Bakugou," a bland voice greeted. Bakugou swerved his gaze from the water to find that it was Todoroki who had spoken. Katsuki hadn't seen the boy in a few months, not that he partially cared. He was kind of annoyed that his quiet place had been disturbed.

(Katsuki would never admit it, but he liked seeing Todoroki. He was the only other person who he could relate to. That relation being through Midoriya).

"Sup, Half n' Half," Bakugou responded. Neither said anything when Shoto sat down next to him. No one spoke anything for quite a while, actually. Both basking in the peaceful scenery enveloping them. It was Katsuki that broke the silence, "It's his birthday today."

"Who's?" Todoroki said while tilting his head. This only made the blonde tick with irritation. Controlling his anger had been proving more and more difficult as the time without Izuku went on. Deku was his confidant and while he knew at least some of his feelings towards his best friend, it was still so *confusing* . He was just so *hurt* and *alone* . All of the pain transformed into anger. They fire in him growing each day without Izu.

“Deku, you idiot!” He didn’t know why he was so mad, but at this point he was seething. Who else would he be talking about?! Did Todoroki forget about Izu just like everybody else did? The thought only made his lungs heave with fury.

“Oh.” Todoroki didn’t say anything else, only stared out into the forest. Bakugou forced himself to breathe. They were deep and ragged but it helped put his mind to focus on something. He knew that Todoroki was thinking about what to say next. Even though Shoto seemed to not express a lot it was easy to figure how he conveyed things. Bakugou was always prideful in that: being able to pick out details so thoroughly and quickly.

“I saw Midoriya about a week ago.”

Bakugou froze, his words focusing on a question before his brain had caught up, “What?” His voice was a mere whisper, but Shoto listened. And he heard.

“I was training in my room and then… he was there, saying hi to me like he didn’t disappear two years ago,” Todoroki explained. He knew Midoriya had asked him not to tell this to Katsuki, but he deserved to know.

A crack was sent through Bakugou’s heart. Izuku had visited someone he had only meant *once* but never went to see *him?* His best friend since before they could talk?

For once, Bakugou was stunned into silence. Todoroki continued, hearing the unspoken demand to elaborate further, “I told him how much you missed him, and I could tell how much Midoriya wanted to run right to you after I said that. I could tell how much he wanted to see you. I think it’s slowly breaking him.”

So why didn’t he? It would’ve been so easy for Izuku to just knock on his door, but he chose not to. Katsuki knew that Deku was complex and had to have a reason for not communicating with him whatsoever these past couple of years, yet his chest still *aches* at Izuku being so close but so far away.

Katsuki’s voice was raspy when he spoke, “How did he look? Is he okay?”

Shoto shrugs, “He looked bone-tired and as if he hadn’t had a proper meal in weeks, but he seemed like himself. If not a bit more grown and maybe even more confident. He just had this new energy to him.”

Katsuki clenched his fists. He was beyond grateful that Izuku was doing okay (obviously not taking care of himself. Bakugou will have to force him to start doing that as soon as they’re reunited), but why couldn’t that Stupid Deku come to him. Why choose IcyHot who he’s only met once?

At least Izu was alive. That calmed at least the worst fear that always settled itself in the back of his mind. “Do you know why he came to you? Did he give any indication on when he’s going to come back or if…” Katsuki didn’t finish it, but Shoto knew what he was about to say.

He’ll visit me?

The young Todoroki shook his head, “No. He didn’t give anything away. He said he came here to see how I was doing and then left. Like he was never even there to begin with.” Deciding to add one more thing, “I don’t think Midoriya will come over again.”

Hope began to drain from Katsuki. It was agonizing to know that Deku didn’t visit him, but at least he could hear how he was doing from Todoroki, but if this was the only time, then how would Bakugou know if he’s still surviving in this cruel, unforgiving world?

“How can you be so sure?”

Shoto shrugs, “I don’t think he would risk being caught again. It was something Midoriya would only allow himself to do once; to see how we’re both doing.”

The rest of the time was spent in silence. The only sound was the music of the rustling trees and steady dance of the river. Not long after, Todoroki got up saying he had to go. They bid their farewells as Shoto left and Katsuki was once again by himself.

He left a while later. Once he was confined in the safety of his room with the comfort of his blankets over him, did he allow himself to cry.

Two weeks later…

Izuku walked into Kaiteki Cafe with groceries in both hands. It was early in the morning plus a Sunday, so the cafe wouldn’t open until a few more hours. As Izuku walked in, the bell jingling that happy tune, he took a swift look around the cafe.

The bags slipped through his hands crumbling to the ground. He forgot to breathe as his eyes swallowed everything they could take in. Mind buzzing with all the possible reasons for the room to look the way it did.

The cafe looked like a tornado had come in and wreaked havoc on everything it could. Chairs were on their sides and glasses had shattered. There were hints of blood on the ground and the corner of the counter. Izuku slowly walked around. His eyes seeing but refusing to believe. He started to become frantic, running upstairs to look for Ru. Once he looked everywhere he came back downstairs to the kitchen and dining room. There were no signs of them. No laughter or glitter or bright blue hair.

As he walked around the room, a slip of paper sitting innocently on the dining table caught his attention. Izuku picked it up delicately, as if it would shatter at any moment. It was Ru's handwriting. The ink used to write was brownish red, smeared and messy.

Izuku knew that this wasn't ink, but blood. And on the napkin were four words that struck Izuku with panic and horror.

Don't come for me

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone has/has a good day!

Desperation

Chapter Summary

Hato plans to save Ru with everything he has.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku fell to his knees, not caring that he landed on shattered glass. Glass that was now digging itself into his legs. He should've been here. He could have protected Ru from getting kidnapped. If only he was faster getting the groceries or did his other chores first. Why does he always fail? No matter how hard he tries, Izuku is never there in time to save the ones who he cares for most.

He springs to his feet, wincing at the sight of his legs. Shards are still embedded in his skin with blood covering most of his legs. It's going to be a nuisance to clean up, but he can't bring himself to care at the moment. Somewhere Ru is out there. He doesn't give a damn that Ru said not to save them. Like Izuku would ever listen to that.

There has to be *something.* A hint or clue that the attacker (or attackers, Izuku think begrudgingly) left behind. There can't just be nothing. Izuku looks everywhere. Tries to smell for something that would lead him to a clue. His eyes search every single crevice in the entire building. His ears stretch for any sound that might indicate that someone is still here. Watching.

He finds nothing.

Izuku goes to his bathroom to work on his still bleeding legs. While taking out his emergency kit and getting to work, Izuku forces his disoriented, panicked mind to think. Was Ru acting worried at all? Was there any hint that someone might be after her? Did Ru owe anybody anything?

(He tries not to feel the satisfaction he felt so long ago when looking at his red legs covered in cuts. He urges himself to forget about his past habits. Those nasty coping-skills that always stuck with him. The urge to do *it* whenever he failed or proved to be useless. He struggles to ignore them, even now. Especially now.)

He bites his lip in pain as he pulls the last shard out with a pair of tweezers. Everyone has a reason for the things they do. So there has to be a motive to kidnap Arai. An action that they're (whoever they are) going to regret. Izuku won't fail again. He *will* save Hotaru.

He continues to brainstorm while cleaning up his injuries and bandaging them (Ignore, push aside, disregard the familiarity. Why are these urges coming up *now?!*). There's only one thing that Izuku keeps coming back to. The only person that Izuku has met during his time working at the cafe that sent alarms through his head.

Chinen Yaku. For the three weeks that Izuku has lived and worked at Kaiteki Cafe, Chinen has visited every Sunday. He's the guy that helped Ru build and design the Cafe. The one who wanted something from Arai. Izuku hated when the tall, dark skinned male stared at Ru. It made him stand on edge. Arai seemed to not notice, or if they did, they ignored it. The gaze wasn't seductive or dark per say, but whenever Izuku thought about it the word "possessive" popped up. The man's eyes always sheared over with a predatory essence whenever he looked at Ru.

And whenever Ru asked when she could pay him back, Chinen always said the same thing.

"You'll find out soon enough."

It *has* to be him. Izuku is so stupid! How could he not see it sooner? Why did he have to ignore his instincts (that were enhanced by one of his *quirks*) that this man was dangerous? Because of course Izuku couldn't bask in even a ray of happiness before it was stripped away from him.

But he would get it back. Izuku will save Ru no matter what. He wouldn't be able to bear the loneliness any longer than he already has. Ru has been his lifeline, and he'll be her's as well. He swears it.

Izuku will protect the ones he loves this time. He has too, or he might as well die.

Izuku waits until night to put his vigilante outfit on and hop out into the lit-up city. Waiting all day was painful, but he couldn't be Hato during the day. It would be too risky since he would be sticking out like a sore thumb- leaping across roofs and whatnot. Getting arrested by some hero wouldn't help him rescue Ru. He kisses the ribbon around his wrist for good luck, knowing he'll need all the luck he can receive.

The burning sensation on his legs while he runs with all he has is terrifyingly grounding. Hato pushes forward, it being too easy to ignore pain these days. He has to go to the police station. Yes, It's an incredibly stupid idea since the people who work there are the very same people who want him apprehended, but Hato can't think of anything else. He has to find out if they have Chinen Yaku's file. It's the best chance he has of a clue as to where he might be holding Arai.

Hato prays that he's not interrupted by an underground hero tonight. He doesn't have time tonight. Hotaru could be in pain right now or even staring blankly with empty, soulless-

Hato releases a sob. Only one, but it's filled with a plethora of horror and desperation. There's no way Ru is dead. They're too stubborn to even let death take hold of them.

(Hato, Izuku, they both know that death doesn't care whether someone is stubborn or not. If it wants, it gets. There's nothing else to it. Once that heart stops, it's over.)

Hato hears quick footsteps to the right side of him through his enhanced hearing. He curses his luck. He knows those footsteps that would be impossible to hear if it weren't for his quirk. It's Eraserhead. Hato doesn't even bother to look over at him. He only speeds up because he simply can't deal with a chat with the hero tonight. He pumps his legs faster, his lungs fighting harder to supply him oxygen. Hato's so close to the station, but he can't go there with Eraserhead right next to him. That would practically be begging someone to capture him.

He's still trying to analyze the situation when he catches a glimpse at Shouta's capture weapon heading straight toward him. He easily ducks and turns to face one of his favorite heroes. Panic holds onto his chest. He's already waited an entire day and now there's this obstacle.

They stand at a stare off. Only, Hato isn't really looking anywhere. Actually, he's having a pretty hard time breathing. His legs are like pins and needles at this point, shaking like a tambourine. Aizawa must notice because he takes his hands off of his weapon. Hato hates the concern in his eyes. Hates that this is taking an eternity even though it's only been a few seconds.

"Kid-" Aizawa starts.

"Don't call me that!" Hato has never snapped at the hero before, and he's horrified. But anger and dread are welling up inside of him and he has nothing to take it out on. He's not a kid. He can't be. Not with everything he's gone through. *Is* going through. And God forbid, *will* go through.

Aizawa blinks and then nods. As if he was the one in the wrong. Even though Hato really is just a kid. He's calm, something Hato wishes he could be at this moment.

"Are you okay?" The concern and worry in Aizawa's voice is almost too much for the vigilante to bear. No, of course he's not okay, but he has to be in order to save his friend, his family. Hato can't keep the volcano of burdens and worries in. It has to erupt. He has to get help.

Hato can't do this alone.

"Please," Hato begs. Aizawa blinks in surprise, never seeing this side of Hato before, but he doesn't say anything. "My friend. I- She's been kidnapped and I need to save her. *Please* let me save her. Let me do what I have to do," Hato pleads again. In order to get to Ru, he needs to get through Eraserhead.

“Ki- Hato, I can’t let you go alone. Do you even know who you’re up against?” Aizawa is still maintaining his peaceful demeanor. It sort of pisses Hato off at how in-tune Shouta is with his expressions. How can he act calm when Hato is buzzing from being so overwhelmed? He’s even forgetting to breathe. With that, Hato does take a breath in. Although it’s tremoras and provides hardly any relief.

“That’s why I need to break into the police station. To find his file,” Hato elaborates like it’s a completely sane idea. To Hato, it is. Aizawa has to give him some credit, the idea is smart if not insanely reckless.

“What’s the name of the person you’re looking for?” Aizawa wants to help. He really, truly does. But it’s difficult when the vigilante always wants to do things alone (or maybe doesn’t want to, but needs to do everything alone. There’s a difference).

“How do I know you’re not just going to turn this into the police? For them to ignore it or have it take weeks for them to find them.” There was an unspoken question that wasn’t said, but both knew what it was.

How do I know I can trust you?

Izuku has always had trouble trusting people. Even now, knowing Aizawa for years (although that doesn’t really count when it’s two separate timelines), he still had trouble trusting him. Especially Hato, who’s different. He’s Izuku, but at the same time, he’s not. Hato is a shield for Izuku. A persona he can get enveloped in whenever he needs a break from himself.

“I’ll help you find your friend, I promise. Just give me the name so I can find the file.”

“Take me with you,” Hato announces before he can think it through. He immediately curses his stupidity.

Aizawa blinks, “What?” Izuku would have found it humorous if it wasn’t for the situation that they were in

“You heard me.”

Eraserhead rubs a hand over his face, “You do understand that they can arrest you, right? I don’t have any power to stop them from doing that if you come with me.”

Hato shrugs. He needs to be there in order to see if he can find any clues. Hato’s the only one who’s met Chinen, not Aizawa. But what if he’s in the way? He wanted to do this alone, thought that was the only way, but then Eraserhead showed up. Hato sighs, knowing that the earlier statement was idiotic. Aizawa could find

the file and bring it with them without any raised suspicion. If Hato stole a file it would only put more of a target on his back.

"You know what? Forget what I said. I'll give you five minutes to get Chinen Yaku's file. If you go even a second over I'll forget about you and do this by myself," He ordered. He knew it probably wasn't the best idea to be ordering a pro, but he was the one that knew Ru. He was the one that let them get kidnapped. This was his mission. Aizawa just happened to cross paths with him.

Shouta starts talking again, "Okay, then what? What if the file has no useful information?" Hato wants to punch a wall. They're wasting time, but he forces himself to understand that in order for Eraserhead to help him, he'll need to be on board with the plan.

"If there's no good information then tell Tsukauchi that he needs to teach the police to write better records. Chinen, from the times I've met him, seems like a pretty empty-headed man. If there's anything on his criminal record about where he likes to go, such as hideouts and where he lives, then that should help us greatly," the vigilante explains. Chinen Yaku seems like a hollow shell, from what he's gathered. He always seems drunk or high, but never gives off the scent of someone who does either of those things. Maybe it's a disability? Or an effect of his quirk? Either way, Hato hopes that analysis will make this recuse mission all the more successful.

The sleep-deprived hero (seriously, he needs coffee. Or tea, as Hato so thoughtfully pointed out) nods, knowing this was going to be a long night. He tries to keep in mind that this is the most trust the kid has shown him in the year or so that he's known him. Aizawa wants to save the kid's friend, and hopefully save Hato as well. Someday.

Some of the infinite amount of tension gets lifted off of Hato's shoulders, "Good. I'll be waiting on the station's rooftop. Remember I'll give you five minutes. Seven in total for you to get there and meet me at our spot." He doesn't ask if the hero is capable. Eraserhead is one of the most capable heroes Hato knows, and he knows a *lot* of heroes.

Aizawa can't believe he's doing this. Not to mention it's for a *vigilante.* The most popular and successful one. Meaning, the most troublesome one for Aizawa and the detective. But the kid's grown on him, and now all he wants to do is give Hato a chance to be saved. There's also the very unlikely, but still possible, chance that Hato is also Midoriya Izuku. The kid he helped rescue from The Arena and eventually slipped through his fingers.

Not that he has any evidence for his theory. The only thing being the conversation of *tea* . It had been brought up only two weeks ago. Both in his mysterious memories-that-weren't-memories and in real life. He wasn't going to put any hope into this hypothesis, but it was *something.* The first clue (if you can even call it that) of where Midoriya might have disappeared off to.

Forcing him to stop thinking about his suspicions, he walked into the police station. Shouta had five minutes to grab the files and meet the kid on the rooftop. He didn't doubt that Hato would leave him or figure out an even more reckless plan to save his friend if he didn't show up within the time frame. He had to act fast.

Aizawa made it up to the back of the building and walked into Tsukauchi's office where he found the detective. This would be the most difficult part, but hopefully his friend will realize how important this mission was. Tsukauchi looked at him expectantly with a hint of suspicion. Which was fair, Aizawa reasoned with himself. It was technically his day off from checking into the station plus his patrol ended almost half an hour by now. Everyone knew that he normally would be falling into bed by now.

"Aizawa," the equally tired man greeted, "what are you doing here? Shouldn't you be off by now?" Naomasa got up to refill his mug with coffee and grabbed Aizawa's mug (he always left one here. God knew how much he needed it) and filled it with the heavenly liquid as well.

Aizawa grabbed the mug gratefully while reminding himself that he was running on very limited time. Skipping the detective's questions, Shouta started to say, "I need to borrow Chinen Yaku's files. It's important. I'm also on a timeframe. I have to be out…" He looks at the clock hung up next to the door, "three minutes at the very most." Aizawa then takes a huge gulp of the black coffee. Half of it down in one swallow.

"Woah there. You know I can't give out someone's criminal records all willy nilly. I need more info, Aizawa. You know that." Shouta cringes. He really doesn't have time for the whole run down.

Hastily, Shouta finishes his coffee in another gulp and explains as quickly as he can, "It's Hato. His friend was kidnapped and is sure that this Chinen guy did it. He was going to sneak in here and steal it if I didn't persuade him into letting me help. If I don't give it to him in two and a half minutes, that reckless kid is going to go back to doing this on his own. So, *please,* I need the file."

Naomasa sighs. Shouta would feel bad for him if the situation wasn't as serious as this. But it *was* . Hato would risk his life without a second thought, and he needed the vigilante to trust him. Aizawa would not fail another child by not being able to protect them.

Tsukauchi chugs down his coffee and slams it down onto his desk, "You better make sure that kid gets through this with minimal injury. Got it? I expect to have the files back tomorrow as well. I'm really not supposed to be doing this, Shouta. But Hato is good, and I want to help save his friend," he orders. Shouta lets out a sigh of relief as Naomasa goes to his stacked cabinets and finds the file. Before giving it to Shouta he waits for a confirmation. Aizawa nods sternly and grabs onto the files.

He doesn't have any more time to say anything else, So the hero runs out of the station and jumps onto the roof just as he saw the vigilante start to leave. He yells out, "I got it!" Making Hato stop and turn around.

Aizawa can’t see Hato’s face behind his mask but somehow still knows that the kid is smiling. Hato gives him a thumbs up and says, “I knew I could count on you, Eraserhead!”

Shouta stops and smiles because hearing that from the kid, well, it means that a fundamental step to trust has been taken. He can’t mess this up, or he’ll never be able to find out who Hato is underneath that kitsune mask and help him. Afterall, everybody deserves to be saved.

He just needs the kid to believe that.

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Hell's Comin' With Me

Chapter Summary

Aizawa and Hato break into an apartment.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They're at Aizawa's house. Izuku is currently covered with the underground hero's three cats. A Tabby, British Shorthair, and a Bombay. All fighting for attention. He and Aizawa were sitting on two separate couches. Hato on a feathery soft fuchsia loveseat and Aizawa on a plush-looking black armchair (Shota said that Hizashi, who's out doing his radio show, picked out the pink chair, but Izuku knew that Aizawa held a soft spot for that bright color as well).

When Hato had suggested to go to his house to look over the file, Aizawa wasn't willing. The vigilante thought that if he mentioned he already knew where the pro lived, he would be more reluctant. Hato was wrong, it didn't help, but here they are! So Aizawa couldn't be too annoyed. Hato will just hold back the information that he broke into the apartment every once in a while to feed some of the leftover sardines that were at the cafe for customers to feed the cats.

Hato doesn't have the energy to fight Eraserhead at the moment. He's devoting all of his vigor towards finding Chinen Yaku.

Aizawa sighs, "Everything is pretty vague, but at least it's something."

Hato nods. It's not a lot, but he's survived this long by finding the secrets of the cracks in the walls. He gazes down at the photo. Chinen has brown eyes that are almost black, swarthy skin with barely faint red lines climbing across his entire body like veins, and he's completely bold. The one thing that catches Hato's eye is the scars covering his arms and neck, no doubt having some on his chest as well. Izuku knows without a doubt that these are burn scars. Yaku's skin where the scars are is paler and shriveled. Parts of his neck were very obviously treated with skin grafts, the patches of skin not looking like his own.

"It must be an effect of his quirk," Hato points out. The file doesn't offer a lot of information on the kidnapper's quirk, but it's plenty for him. Chinen's quirk is called Melting Point. The quirk is exactly what the name suggests. He can increase anything's temperature to the point of melting, boiling, and evaporating. There's no analysis of any potential side effect, but Hato bets the man's scars had to be some connection to his quirk. He guesses it also could've been an accident from when he first developed his quirk or something else entirely.

“That could definitely be the case,” Aizawa agrees. He then points out to Chinen’s last known address, “Do you think he would be stupid enough to bring the hostage to his house? There’s no way it’s going to be *that* easy.”

Aizawa’s right. Even though Hato’s first impression of Yaku is that he’s not the brightest, that doesn’t mean he lacks common sense. “Maybe, but there might be some clues we can find there that will lead us to Ru. I can sneak in and see if there’s anything of use. It would take me less than ten minutes.” The night was still young. He hopes that they can save Hotaru in the next couple of hours. The less time Ru’s in Yaku’s grip, the better.

Hato stands up, already preparing to leave, and attempts to not feel guilty at moving the cats off of him (he knows it’s against the law of the universe, but he has to get moving). They have all the information that the criminal record layed out for them. Yaku lives in an apartment complex a few blocks south of their current location, so it won’t take up too much time to run over there.

“Kid,” Hato sighs at the nickname resurfacing once again, “you don’t have to do this. This is bigger than stopping a burglary or attempted rape. There’s a lot of unknown factors. I can do it and call in for backup,” Aizawa argues, standing up as well and putting his yellow goggles back on.

Hato swelled with ire, Shota should’ve known better, “ *Yes* , I *do* . Chinen made a great mistake taking someone precious from me,” he knows that’s information that Aizawa can use to find out his identity, but can’t bring himself to worry about that at the moment, “I’m going to save Ru, and I’m bringing hell with me. Chinen Yaku is going to regret ever thinking he could get away from this,” he seethes out. His face is unbearably warm underneath the mask. His chest heaving from all of the stress, worry, and anger.

Aizawa doesn’t give any reaction to Hato’s rage, not that he was expecting him to. Eraserhead remains calm and undeterred, slowly nodding and releasing a small smirk, “You got it, Problem Child.” Hato can barely hide the flinch at the old name. The name for Midoriya Izuku, not Hato the vigilante. It must’ve been an accident. Either way, Hato can’t stress about that right now.

“Then let’s go.”

Aizawa never does anything without purpose, and that use of “Problem Child” was no accident. He’s called the Midoriya that he knows in real life and the visions of his older self that same exact nickname. He only uses it for Midoriya because it fits him painfully well.

He wanted to know if he could throw his suspicions away, or let them fester. And while that flinch Hato gave off was very well conceived, it did not pass Aizawa who’s trained his eyes to catch the subtlest of movements.

So he tucks that information in the back of his mind for the time being and focuses on running with Hato to Chinen's house. One task at a time, he reminds himself.

———

Hato started his rescue mission at ten, and now it's a little past twelve when they make it to Chinen's apartment. It's planted in a hidden corner of the city where not many people roam. Perfect for people who want to get away from sound pollution, and an even more ideal spot for criminals.

They stand outside on his balcony, trying to hide in the shadows while observing anything that would indicate that Chinen was inside. Hato used his enhanced hearing to see if he could pick up any footsteps or breathing, but there were none.

He sighed in relief and disappointment. On one hand, this would let him investigate the apartment without having to deal with Yaku, but on the other hand, he was really hoping he could fight Chinen as soon as possible without going on an even longer manhunt. Another reason was because if no one was here then that meant that Hotaru was somewhere else.

"No one is in there," Hato whispers to Eraserhead who's trying to get a better look inside. He thinks that Aizawa should upgrade his goggles so they provide him with night vision. It would be extremely helpful and convenient, but maybe he can try to make one for him? Izuku had never had an opportunity to tinker with things like Hatsume had. He knew he would never get to her level, but maybe it would be a good skill to pick up. It would be awesome to-

His running thoughts get interrupted, "How can you be so sure? He could be lurking in another room or be right behind the curtain for all we know, waiting to put a knife to our throats."

"I made hearing aids that allow me to hear what other people can't. I can't hear so much of an intake of a breath- he's not inside," Hato lies. Even though no one knew of his quirks as Izuku (except Tomura. Tomura who is somewhere with that *monster* being manipulated and twisted with lies-) he still doesn't want anyone to know them as Hato. Only in a state of life or death will he ever reveal his quirks. If heroes know of even one, they could exploit it and grasp onto his weaknesses. And the absolute chaos that would ensue would be horrendous. People might think he's related to All for One and working for him. That would be a mess he really didn't want to get tangled up in.

He tests the door to see if it's locked. To both of their astonishments, the door slides open. They look at each other in surprise and Hato shrugs as he walks in. Eraserhead following close behind.

There's a TV area with couches in the middle of the room and in the right corner is a small outdated kitchen. It strikes Hato as surprising at how *normal* everything is. No one would have ever guessed this was the home of a kidnapper and God who knows what else.

They skim over the living room first and then walk into a carpeted hallway with a door on the right and another one at the very end. Hato finds the light switch easily enough and turns it on. He notices that all of the walls are bare- no pictures or art or even simple decorations. Just a disgusting greenish brown painted on the walls.

"I'll check this room, and you check the one at the end of the hallway. Sounds good?" Aizawa asks. His voice is still in a whisper. Hato gives him two thumbs up and continues down the hallway. Just to make sure, Hato listens closely once again and still hears nothing. Taking that as an all-clear, he twists the nob and walks in.

It's a bedroom. There's a lamp next to the bed on a nightstand lighting up the room. The first thought that crosses his mind is that it's a mess. Clothes are scattered everywhere and the dust is layered thick, making him want to sneeze.

He doesn't find anything important immediately, but still looks through the pockets on the clothes on the ground and bed. He finds nothing but a pack of cigarettes and gum wrappers. He looks underneath the bed and finds nothing but dust bunnies. He's about to start looking somewhere else when his hand brushes against the side of the mattress where the bedding is lifted up. When he inspects further, he finds a slit in the mattress.

Hato digs his fingers in and grabs onto a pile of photos. As he looks through each one, his horror grows along with his simmering anger. All of these photos are of Ru. In the cafe, grocery shopping, and at the park. He wants to light the whole goddamn place on fire, but instead counts to ten and takes a deep breath. He gets up on shaky legs and heads out just as Aizawa exits the room he was searching.

"I didn't find anything. It was a small bathroom with nothing but toothpaste stains and a repulsive shower," Shota explains. Hato, who can't seem to form words at the moment, holds up the photos. Shota takes a good look at them and nods grimly. "It seems like Chinen has been planning this for a while. We should search the kitchen and get out of here."

They speed walk to the kitchen and find a big sticky note with a childish rainbow on it sticking onto the fridge. Aizawa pulls it off and reads it, eyebrows furrowing.

Finding his voice Hato again, "What does it say?" he questions, but it also comes out as a demand on accident.

“It’s another address. It’s called The Cherry Pop. I’ve heard of it before. It’s a club that’s next to the park where all the drug dealers hang out. It’ll take us half an hour to travel there by foot,” Aizawa tells Hato. The vigilante frowns, thirty minute is a very long time. A whole masacre can begin and end in that time frame. Plus they would exert more energy that could be precious while saving Arai.

His eyes light up once they catch onto an object. Shota doesn’t miss the mischievous energy rolling off of Hato and it gives everything he has not to drag a hand across his face- a daily ritual.

“What is it?” Aizawa questions. Wanting to get whatever this was over with.

Hato looks up at Shota and points behind him. He turns around to see a pair of keys hanging onto a keychain holder right next to the door. He doesn’t even need to ask the vigilante what he’s thinking.

“It’ll save us time and energy! Traffic isn’t too bad at this time of night, and besides, they’re *right there.* Why not arrive with some flavor?” Hato really hoped he would get to drive. He’s never been able to drive before! It looks easy enough. Just don’t run over animals and certain people.

Aizawa draws out a sigh, “Fine,” and seeming to know what Hato was thinking he adds, “I’m driving.” Even though he can’t see the kid’s face beneath the mask, he just knows that the young vigilante was pouting.

They grab the keys and head out (the front door this time because they hoped it would lead to a public garage) while Hato muttered, “whatever”.

Luckily, the only people they stumbled across were people who had a couple of drinks in them and didn’t even seem to notice a short masked kid with throwing knives tucked into a belt around his leg. The damn luck of this kid, Aizawa thought.

They took the stairs to the very bottom and found the parking garage. Locating the car didn’t prove to be difficult once they unlocked the car and heard a loud beep straight ahead from them. Neither of them knew much about cars, but both could tell that this was an expensive one. The bright red was something that Izuku immediately fell in love with and the black seats were so plush. It even had seat coolers!

It turned on, and Hato winced at how loud it was. Aizawa seemed to know exactly what to do as he put the gear into reverse, backed up perfectly, and then changed the gear right before zooming forward so fast that Hato’s head was forced against the headrest. He had the urge to put his hands up like he was on a roller coaster. Something else that he’s never been able to do.

“They’re going to have a Hero *themed amusement park, Kacchan! We have to go as soon as it opens up!”*

“You taking me out on a date, Nerd?”

Izuku’s hand flies up to cover his blushing face, but then smirks, “What if I am Kacchan?”

It was Katsuki’s turn to blush.

“Hah!” Hato yells, “This baby will get us there in ten minutes. Tops!”

Aizawa speeds up, going way past the speed limit. Not that either of them care. The sooner they get to the club, the better. “And do you have a plan for what to do once we get to the club?”

Hato sombers up and begins muttering, “No, I don’t. There’s so much we don’t know. We don’t know Chinen’s motive, or how many people are with him, and we have no idea what Ru’s condition is. There’s so many factors… So many empty slots. A thousand different scenarios.” He goes quiet for a moment, analyzing, hypothesizing. He begins to talk again, more clearly this time, “The best way would be to sneak in. A window or back door. My top priority is to get Ru back unharmed. You and the other heroes can deal with the criminals for all I care. Well, maybe let me put a few punches in as a little gift for Chinen.”

Aizawa parks half a block away. The big, bright, neon sign that says *Cherry* in cursive demands attention. Hato glares at it like kicked a puppy. Aizawa almost feels concerned for Chinen and whoever else kidnapped perhaps the kid’s only friend. He doesn’t, obviously. He knows the kid is going to own up to his word.

To bring them hell.

They made their way up to the side where a window was. The club appeared to be closed, but that didn’t mean people weren’t hiding in the shadows. Aizawa sends their location to Naomasa and tells him to bring reinforcements in twenty minutes if Aizawa doesn’t text him back before then. He doesn’t wait for a reply and puts his phone back in his many hidden pockets. Hato mildly wondered how many the hero had.

“Before we go in I need you to promise to not do anything reckless. I’m here to help save your friend, but I’m also here to make sure you don’t get killed,” Shoto stresses. Hato can’t help the swell of warmth at the man’s words. The man seems *concerned* for him.

Instead of promising anything, Hato gives a two-fingered salute. He jumps up onto the metal garbage bin without hardly making any noise then tries to pry the window open. Meanwhile, Eraserhead is on watch. When the window doesn't budge, Hato grabs his kendo weapon and smashes the window. It's loud, but so far he can hear no footsteps, so that must mean they're in the clear. The vigilante motions the pro to follow and he jumps through the window. Eraserhead is right next to him not even a second after his feet touch the ground.

It's quiet. Hato's heart starts trying to rip itself out of his chest. A clear indication that something was awry. An itch started at the back of his neck. Not much later, there's a breeze of a whisper in his mind. His danger sense.

Duck.

He yells those words out loud right as he obeys the command. Barely missing the knife flying past where his head used to be. He panics, not being able to see anyone but knowing that people were there. Possibly arms length away. Was it a quirk? It had to be. Otherwise Hato would have been able to see and hear every single one of them.

Another knife whizzed by him. He took a quick glance at Shota and was relieved when he realized that he could still see him. The hero was faring well and didn't look injured, so at least they had that going for them.

While sidestepping, jumping, and ducking he made it over to the light switch. Not even wincing when a knife grazed his arm. He prayed the switch would work so they could at least *see.*

He manages to flick it on, but not without a knife embedding itself into his thigh. Hato gasps in pain, but adrenaline is already taking over, numbing the worst of the pain.

The lights flicker on. Neither Hato or Aizawa liked what they saw. There, in the empty storage room were about ten other people who all looked like giants. Ru wasn't there; probably in another room.

What really caught his attention was the man only a few feet in front of him. Chinen Yaku.

No one could see Hato's eyes, but even the most oblivious would know that they were burning with the promise of vengeance.

Chapter End Notes

I hope this chapter wasn’t bad. I love all of you!

Hope everyone has/had a great day!

Painkiller

Chapter Summary

Hato finally gets to kick some ass.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The first thing he noticed was not the sound of waves crashing onto the warm sand, or the prideful sunset, nor was it the plain-looking boy next to him. No, it was none of these things. Because the first thing he noticed was the lack of that familiar electrical thrum that always ran itself through his veins. He was in his normal form, nothing but sunken eyes and bones. His quirk that he always huddled around, blowing it gently so it wouldn't go out, was gone.

He felt utterly and entirely empty.

That was until he looked at the young man next to him. His green fluffy hair and scattered freckles seemed familiar. Foggy images of a boy on the swings all alone came back to him. Then he remembered what he had written down all that time ago. The visions he had. This was the third one.

The first one being when he presumably meets and saves the boy (the presage also gave him the very pleasant view of his death, but he doesn't want to think about that. Not how just moments before he woke up he was witnessing black spikes coming towards him. A gruesome death indeed).

The second was a funeral. He forgot who it was. A kid with a red cap and matching red shoes was on a picture next to the casket. He remembers that his successor (he really has one. Or did he have one?) wasn't there. The one person that everyone thought would be there wasn't. Then he woke up before he saw who appeared out of the dark, swirling portal that had materialized.

And just like always, he can't quite control what he does, or even thinks.

Soon he started to talk, or at least the him that's in this vision, "Know that this is not your fault, Young Midoriya. I knew this would happen sooner or later. I'm just glad I got to use the last embers to save." Midoriya's eyes start to water- not that Yagi is surprised. He likes to tease the young hero (yes, Young Midoriya is a hero. More of a hero than many of the pros will ever be) on his waterworks, but in reality, it's refreshing. Yagi appreciates his student's empathy and compassion, and the fact that he's not afraid to show it, either.

Yagi doesn't even know the boy yet. Doesn't even think he's ever met him before (maybe once, years ago. But who knows), but he yearns to protect and guide him with every bone in his body. Midoriya's eyes sparkle with a dream that will no doubt be accomplished. He knows this, and knows that this boy becoming the next holder of One For All was the best decision he has and will ever make.

"Thank you, All Might. I-I honestly don't know where I would be without you. I promise I'll continue to make you proud," Midoriya promises. Yagi believes him wholeheartedly.

It seems the other Toshinori agrees because he rubs the teen's head and says, "I know, my boy."

Yagi Toshinori sits up and looks over to see that it's still dark out. Morning not to come for another few hours. His eyes are already drooping, his brain already fogging with the need to sleep since apparently having auguries doesn't count as rest. But he has to write down what he experienced before he forgets. He can already feel it slipping away. The boy's face turning blurry and muffled.

Young Midoriya.

He repeats the name over and over again while grabbing his journal that holds the other two visions as well. He just needs to get the name down. That's the most important thing. He chants the name until he finally gets it on paper. Yagi tries to add details about the vision, but it's already gone.

He looks down at the paper that holds a single name. Not even a full name, but it possesses great importance. He just hopes that someday he will get to meet his successor.

And remember him.

His leg is on fire. The pain only adds fuel to his rage as he stares at Chinen's near-black eyes. No one moves. The only sound is heavy breathing echoing throughout the cement storage room. Yaku's face is stitched with a crazed smile as he stares back. Hato vigilantly analyzes the other people in the room. All intimidating and desperate. Desperate for what, Hato doesn't know. To get their hands bloody? Only two have quirks that are mutations. A man with two razor sharp horns protruding from his forehead and a woman who has the gigantic eyes of an owl and a beak instead of a nose.

Hato finds people with twelve-inch daggers, steam protruding from hands, and a man hiding in the shadows who hasn't made a noise yet. He figures that's the person who inhibited his sense quirk from working.

Blood boiling, Hato gets right to the point, “Where are they?” His voice has a clear edge to it. Letting all of them know that he *will* make them regret kidnapping his friend.

Yaku’s grin becomes impossibly wider. Shouta, knowing that Hato would hear him, quietly whispers for him to calm down. Hato hears him with crystal clear clarity; however, that doesn’t mean it actually helps.

“Does it matter? Ru-chan is my friend now. I’ve been so lonely, and now,” he opens his arms in front of him and spreads them open. Gesturing to everyone else around them, “I have so many friends! Even with my quirk and scars and *needs,* they’re still here beside me. Isn’t that just lovely?”

Shouta and Hato both see this as an opportunity to gather more information on his weaknesses. Even with impatience running up Hato’s back, he tries to keep a clear head.

“And why would people not want to be around you because of your quirk and… needs?” Maybe Chinen Yaku was like the stereotypical villain who just *had* to divulge their tragic backstory or master plan.

He was.

“You see, my quirk isn’t simple. Most quirks aren’t, I suppose. Mine *makes* me use it. If I don’t I burn and burn and burn. Wielding my quirk always feels *so* good. What’s the word? Ah, yes, euphoria. My quirk is a drug. No one wants to be around me when I can turn their organs to soup. Sadly, that’s what happened to my dear old parents.” He rests his cheek on his hand and sighs, as if he spilled some milk instead of killing his parents. “These people here are my friends,” Chinen repeats, “They’re all leaders of gangs in the city. Sadly, friendship comes with a price, so I had to threaten each of them that I would kill all of their precious lackeys if they didn’t join me.”

Hato makes eye contact with Aizawa. As far as they knew, Chinen Yaku was the most dangerous. Eraserhead would have to prioritize erasing his quirk the most. Chiefly because they didn’t know if there were any limits with Melting Point. Distance, usage, and other factors that might be needed to activate the quirk.

That’s why the city has been so peaceful. All of the notorious gangs have been forced to be quiet. Or maybe they’re all dead.

“Wait for my signal then we will attack. Head for Chinen first if possible,” Aizawa breathes out. No one hearing him but the vigilante. Hato doesn’t do anything to indicate that he heard him, but Shota wasn’t expecting anything.

“Then why did you kidnap Arai?” Eraserhead juts out. Hato was pondering that as well.

Yaku cups his face with his hands and waves back and forth, “Ru-chan has always been so nice to me. Everytime I go to her cafe they always check up on me and ask how I’ve been doing. No one has done that in a very long time. I couldn’t help but take her as my friend,” he answers wistfully.

Anger taking hold, “You can’t *take* someone to be your friend. Let alone capture them!” Hato snaps. He sneaks his hand to his thigh where he holds the throwing knives and hooks a finger through the ring at the top. No one acts, indicating that he wasn’t caught.

Chinen walks closer, his white teeth flashing. “My, my, isn’t someone feisty? *You* weren’t there to prevent me from capturing Ru-chan. You failed her. Now they’re *mine* .” He lifts Hato's chin with his hand, forcing Hato to look at his crazed eyes.

He was trembling, but not because he was afraid. He was *livid.* It took him everything he had not to bash his head against Yaku’s, or grab his knife and stab him.

“Where are you keeping Arai Hatoru? Tell us now or you’re going to have a crew of heroes on your ass in a few minutes and one angry vigilante in even less than that,” Aizawa demands. He sees the kid’s hand on his knife and knows it won’t be long before Hato’s restraint finally breaks.

Chinen faces Eraserhead, letting go of Hato in the process. Shouta’s beginning to think that the smile always on Yaku’s face is permanently plastered on his teeth. It won’t fade. In fact, Shouta thinks it keeps getting wider.

“Doesn’t matter who’s ‘on my ass’. I can just melt the skin off of their bones. Tell me Er-as-er-head, do you know what that looks like? I do, and trust me when I tell you that it’s not pretty.” At that moment, Aizawa activates his quirk. Shutting Chinen Yaku’s quirk off like flicking a switch.

Hato is in front of Chinen milliseconds later. So fast that Aizawa distinctly wonders if the kid has a speed quirk. In one swift movement, Hato grabs his knife and plunges it in Chinen’s shoulder. Yaku lets out a scream of shock and agony as he falls down to the cement ground.

It’s a short-lasted victory because as soon as Chinen’s back meets the ground, the other criminals in the room make their move. All drawing out their weapons and quirks while charging towards Hato and Eraserhead. Both of which take a fighting stance and prepare themselves.

The gang leader split evenly. Five with Aizawa and five with Hato. Not being able to think any further about who Aizawa is fighting, Hato ducks when the villain with the horns comes towards him with his head bowed like a raging bull. He uses the momentum of ducking and turns with the balls of his feet. Mid turn, Hato pulls

his leg up and does a roundhouse kick. Hitting the horned-criminal right in the stomach. The man lets out a choked cough and stumbles, but quickly recovers. Thrill runs through Hato at finally being able to release all of his pent up stress. Besides, he hasn't had a good fight in *weeks* .

He hears a knife whizzing by him and leans his head slightly to the side. The knife flies right by his cheek and penetrates the horned-villain's right arm.

Hato looks, astonished by his luck and lets out a little, "Huh," before pivoting around to face the woman who threw the knife. She looked just the slightest bit annoyed that the weapon didn't meet its intended target. She glares at Hato and snaps her fingers. That's when the vigilante's eyesight goes completely black.

It's terrifying- not being able to see anything. It's suffocating even when Hato knows deep down he's in a large room. That darkness is infinite and he hates it.

He breathes, trying to amplify all of his other senses. It increases the pain in his leg, but it'll give him a chance to keep on fighting to the best of his ability when he can sense the slighted shift of the wind.

"It's my quirk," The woman says. Not that Izuku hasn't already figured that out, "All I have to do is make eye contact with you and snap my fingers. You'll be completely blind for three minutes. Plenty of time for us to take you and your hero friend down." Three minutes is a long time during a battle. It makes him annoyed and agitated, but he's dealt with worse.

Far worse.

His ears pick up the sound of footsteps coming close to him and feels the wind shift as the woman swings his arm towards him. He bends backwards as far as he could, not knowing exactly what was in her hand and how low she would swing.

"Wha-," the woman starts in surprise. Hato grabs his Katsu and estimates where her head might be. From the small glimpse he has of her, she was at least a foot taller than him. He squats down and jumps while smacking her in the head with enough force to knock her out. He knows he's successful when his ears catch the sound of her body thumping to the ground. Sadly, his blindness is still intact.

Hato takes a deep breath when Shota shouts, "Kid, watch out!" He rapidly goes down to the floor and does a somersault. Just in time for a loud *smash* to be heard as something cracks the concrete. Hato does a kip up and aims a fist towards whoever he was fighting next. Instead of meeting flesh his fist comes into contact with metal. Pain erupts from his hand as he pulls back. He wouldn't be surprised if he fractured a couple of his fingers. Possibly even his whole hand; though, he sure hopes not. That would be hard to cover up.

The person laughs, the deepest voice he's ever heard. The adrenaline numbs the pain of his fingers and thigh (which still has a knife in it. He really wants to wrap it, but can't see and really doesn't want to risk bleeding out) as he jumps back. Only to have to do a three-step turn to the side in order to dodge what he assumes to be someone else's quirk. All he knows is that it's really *freaking cold.*

The ground vibrates as the person who's turned into metal starts to attack again. Hato has to jump as the other person (who is really quiet. He can't hear them at all. Only their quirk) attempts another strike. Hato goes for the metal person first, and as expeditiously as possible, fakes another punch before activating his telekinesis quirk. It sends the criminal flying into what he assumes are the empty shelves that were at the other end of the storage room.

"I got her quirk! Quick, knock her out!" Aizawa tells Hato. He can't be more than a few feet away from him. Probably preoccupied with someone else. Hato runs in the direction where he can now pinpoint the now identified woman's breathing. He hits her carotid sinus prompting her to pass out. Hato blinks and when he reopens his eyes, he can finally see again. Hato breathes a sigh of relief before swirling to see how Eraserhead was doing. He seemed to have just finished if the bodies surrounding him indicated anything. Aizawa appears to have only come out of it with a busted lip and a cut on his bicep.

Remembering that he hadn't technically defeated the villain with the horns, he looks for him and finds him crying saying he gives up. Hato sympathizes with him– with all of the gang leaders forced to work for Chinen. They're with him to protect their people, showing that they have heart. Hato can't seem to even want to feel sympathy or even pity for Yaku though. He knows that loneliness can drive someone to do things that are reckless and desperate. Understands better than anyone, but Chinen abducted Ru and threatened to kill entire groups of people. That's not justifiable.

Eraserhead and Hato meet each other in the middle of the room. Both are breathing heavily from the strain of how outnumbered they were.

"Tsukauchi is going to be here in five minutes with the police to escort all of these criminals to the station." Aizawa eyes Hato up and down before adding, "I'll tell him to bring an ambulance. You need medical attention as soon as possible. That knife can't stay in there forever and I doubt you have sufficient medical supplies to tend to it. Any other injuries I should know about?" The tone he uses reminds Hato so much of when he was Aizawa's student. It creates an ache in his chest of longing.

He pushes the thought away. Now's not the time to be remembering. "I'm not going to a hospital. I'm not stupid," Hato tells Aizawa. He faces away from the hero and looks at Chinen Yaku, denoting that the discussion is over. Chinen looks pathetic. His shoulder is bleeding profusely from where he pulled out the knife Hato had stabbed him with and he's trying his hardest to lengthen the distance between the feral vigilante.

Hato walks closer with Eraserhead right next to him. He crouches to the ground right next to the man and sneers underneath his mask.

“Where are they?” he demands. His voice was even and laced with calm malice. The adrenaline was starting to wear off, revealing how exhausted he truly was. The pain was unbearable as well. Black spots were dancing across his eyes, but he had to push through, he had to find Ru.

“They’re in the next room over! I swear I didn’t hurt her or anything. Please don’t arrest me. I’ll disappear and you’ll never have to worry about me again,” Yaku begs as he waves his hands in front of his face.

Aizawa leans down and picks him up by the collar, forcing him to stand up. Hato gets up as well. The brief wish of being taller so he could appear more intimidating crosses his mind, but he immediately dismisses it. Not only is it illogical to wish that at a time like this, but he’s only twelve. Of course he’s not going to come across as super intimidating.

“Bring us to them,” Eraserhead demands. Hato shivers at his iconic “I’m too tired for this bullshit” tone of voice. He swears it could scare the darkest of villains and bravest of heroes.

Chinen nods vigorously and starts walking to the door. Both Shota and Hato are on high alert. Ready for a trap to spring up into their faces like a jack in the box. They exit the storage room and enter into a narrow hallway. Hato can see an entrance to a kitchen in the far back of the corridor. They walk a couple paces before Chinen stops.

“This is where I kept her. It’s the room that the musicians use to get ready for their performance.” They both nod at his nervous unnecessary explanation and signal him to open the door.

He gulps and goes to open the door. Hato’s eyes narrow. Where was the man who was drowned in confidence mere minutes ago? Did Chinen really give up that easily? Or was this going to be another trap?

He supposes that he’ll find out soon enough. Yaku opens the door and there she is, tied to a chair with a rag over her mouth. Besides looking frightened and a bit roughed-up around the edges, Hato can’t spot any injuries. He sighs with relief as he runs to work on the ropes binding Ru to the chair.

While he frees Hotaru Aizawa keeps an eye on Chinen to make sure he doesn’t pull any nasty tricks or attempts to use his deadly quirk.

When Hao gets all of the restraints off and Ru can finally stand up, she asks, “Who are you? I mean- uh, thank you for saving me? At least that’s what I hope you’re doing.”

He releases an airy laugh, glad that Ru was still Ru. He points to himself, “I’m Hato and this is,” he gestures to Eraserhead, “The Erasure Hero: Eraserhead. He’s super cool, right! Not many people get to see him since he’s an underground hero and-” Hato shuts his mouth before he can embarrass himself further.

Shota nods at Arai, “We should get outside. The police should be here any second.”

Hato was beaming with solace. Ru was with them, and they were safe.

Until they weren’t.

It was only a second. Just a blink of the eye, and then there was a gun in Chinen’s hand, a smile on his face. The gun was pointed right at Hotaru.

Time seemed to freeze before everything went into pure chaos. Eraserhead grabbed his capture weapon while Hato reached out to Ru.

It only takes a twitch of a finger to pull the trigger. By the time Aizawa’s scarf was wrapped tightly around Yaku, a loud bang had already sounded.

Hato stares at Ru as shock adorns their face. Blood pooling from their stomach at a rapid rate. Turning everything red red red.

“If I can’t have her, then no one can.” Chinen laughs right before Aizawa knocks him out.

Hato grabs onto Arai before they could fall to the cold, unforgiving ground. He can already feel his breath speed up and tears rush down his cheeks. Her face is contorted in pain. Sapphire blue eyes shone with so much fear.

“I-,” Ru starts out, but then coughs.

“Please don’t talk right now! Everything will be fine, I promise!” How many times has he said those exact words during situations identical to this one? Too many times.

“Everything will be fine, I promise. Just hold on, Kacchan,” Izuku cried out. He wasn’t sure if he was trying to convince himself or Katsuki. There was so much blood. So much agony, but Kacchan smiled at him.

Izuku only cried harder.

She ignores him -he faintly hears Eraserhead request immediate medical assistance into his radio transmitter-, “You seem so familiar. Have we met?”

His heart folds as he shakes his head, “No. I heard from an acquaintance that you needed help.” He sobs and hates himself for it.

Ru smiles (*smiles, smiles, smiles. Kacchan smiled-)* , “I see. Thank you, then. For coming for me.” Then their eyes close so very gently, and Hato, *Izuku,* panics.

“No. Please stay awake. Please. I can’t do this alone anymore. I won’t let you die on me. I can’t do this again. *Please,”* he begs. Praying to the Gods he doesn’t believe in. He won’t be able to take it if another person died because he couldn’t reach them in time. Ru can’t die. He refuses the idea altogether.

Hato notices how Aizawa acts quickly, ripping off a piece of his shirt and tying it around Ru’s stomach. Trying to add as much pressure as possible to get the endless bleeding to stop. Hato’s hands are trembling when he begins to pull his hands back from Ru. One was cradling their head while the other was holding her hand. Just as he was about to pull back to grab some gauze that he has in one of his pockets, Hato feels an odd sensation surrounding his hands. He looked down to see his hands were glowing a pale blue.

It was a quirk. He couldn’t remember how he got it, but knew that it was inexplicably his. With astonishment, Hato noticed Ru’s blood began to fade and her face returned to a healthy color. Aizawa seemed to notice as well (which was just great. A hero was witnessing his quirk manifestation) and undid the swift bandage he made. They both gasped in surprise and wonder when they witnessed the bullet wound stitch itself back together and heal. The only thing left was a small, circular scar.

The cops came down at that moment and started to seize all of the criminals including Chinen Yaku. They put on quirk-represent cuffs on them immediately. Detective Tsukauchi and a couple of paramedics and EMTS entered the room they were in, getting right to work.

Hato was only looking at Ru. Waiting for them to open their eyes so she could continue to laugh and tease each other at the cafe. So they could get to know each other more.

Just as hope began to fade, Ru opened her eyes and sat up hastily. Hato let out another sob, but this time in relief and not in despair. Aizawa’s shoulders slumped in relief.

The paramedics helped Arai get up and together they all went upstairs to the main room. Hato was so tired and desperate to get outside that he didn’t even look around the pub. Once they were finally outside Hato let the cold air envelope him.

He faced Shota and Naomasa, “Thank you for helping me. I won’t ever forget this.”

Aizawa and Tsukauchi looked at each other then looked back at Hato. Both were smiling, although he didn’t know if Aizawa’s smile really counted as one.

“You’re welcome, Problem Child.”

“Perhaps we should get that leg all healed up,” Naomasa suggested. Hato looked down to see that the knife was still lodged into his leg. It was a fiery pain. His hand was throbbing as well. Not to mention he felt like he was about to pass out from exhaustion.

He needed to get out of here and go back to the cafe if possible. Hato couldn’t pass out in front of the two people supposedly after him. He couldn’t risk them finding out who he truly was. Ru was being sent to a hospital for an overnight stay. He will visit her as Izuku tomorrow.

So Hato smiled and saluted to the two adults before running into the crowd of police and medical workers, ignoring the shouts of dismay from the detective and hero. He ducked over the caution tape and blended into the shadows of an alleyway.

A sharp pain in his stomach made him stumble and fall to the ground. He screamed in pain. All of his wounds combining into an inferno. He felt like he was just shot, but no blood was seeping out of his stomach. Was it an effect of his new quirk?

He didn’t have time to wonder before the pain mixed with weariness became too much and he let his eyes close, letting darkness wrap it’s arms around him.

All alone with no one to hold him.

Chapter End Notes

Hello people! This was an exciting chapter to right. Also isn't this like one of the longest chapters so far? Over 4000 words!

Hope everyone enjoyed it. Feel free to comment whatever you want, even if it's a vine reference.

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Warmth of Company

Chapter Summary

Aizawa worries and Midoryia remembers.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Aizawa followed Hato, naturally. The kid had a knife lodged into his fucking leg. He had no idea how Hato even managed to walk, let alone take five criminals down all by himself. Then there was the quirk that he wielded. Hato looked just as surprised as Shouta felt when his hands started glowing luminescent blue. Healing Arai's gunshot wound completely. Healing quirks were rare, especially ones that were that powerful.

Maybe it was a quirk manifestation? One triggered by extreme stress? That would make at least some sense. Everything surrounding the young vigilante was enigmatic to just about everyone who accountered him.

It didn't take long for Eraserhead to find Hato, and once he did, he went straight to work. Picking the kid up, Shouta raced towards the ambulance at the crime scene. He soon came to a halting stop when he thought about how angry the kid would be if he found himself in a hospital. All that trust Aizawa has been trying to build would all shatter to the ground like broken glass. The hospital would likely take off his mask, too. And no matter how much he was tempted to see who was behind the mask (and to see if his suspicions were correct), it just seemed cruel to take Hato's control like that. It should be his choice to reveal himself and not anyone else's.

Aizawa layed Hato on the ground gently and sent a quick text to Tsukauchi that he found Hato and was going to take care of him at his apartment. He'll write his statement later. He picked the vigilante up into his arms, made a mental note of how light the boy was, and began to swiftly run back to his apartment.

Yamada should be home by now, probably already in bed. He'll be ecstatic once he finds out that Aizawa brought the infamous Hato with him.

Izuku can't move. He tries and tries, but barely even twitches a muscle. He's standing in a dark room with stains everywhere. After a moment he realizes that the stains are blood.

All For One appears next to him and his cheeks stretch in what's supposed to be a smile. Izuku knows that expression will haunt him everytime he closes his eyes. He doesn't think he'll be able to ever sleep again after this is all over.

"I still think you can handle more quirks," The villain says effervescently, "do you want another quirk, my son?"

He wanted to yell, scream, shout until his throat was raw. Izuku was not his son*. He never will be, but he can't shake his head or even speak, so he just stands silently trying to convey as much hatred in his eyes as possible. Izuku will not be brought down.*

AFO laughs, his whole body shaking in the process. The hideous smile growing, sending shivers down Izuku's spine. He pats Izuku's shoulders, "Right, you can't speak. I'll let you have that one grace."

Without a second thought (which wasn't such a great idea on Izuku's part. He really should be taking careful steps when this devil is around) he shouts, "I don't want any more of your fucking quirks, and for the last time, I will never be your son."Izuku snaps his teeth together, as if that would intimidate the man.

All For one sighs, "Very well then. Tomura, bring her in."

*Color drains from Izuku's face as he witnesses Shigaraki come waltzing in the room with Uraraka Ochaco with him. Izuku has never been more scared in his entire life. The time when Kac*chan *was kidnapped at the summer camp was terrifying, but he served a purpose to the League. Ochako didn't. She would just be used to getting Izuku to do what they wanted.*

"Ochako!" Izuku says at the same time Uraraka yells his hero name. They haven't seen each other in weeks, if Izuku had to guess how long he's been trapped here. He missed her so much, but God, would he give anything to not see her here.

"Listen here, son, if you're not going to take a quirk then we'll just have some fun with her instead." Izuku is petrified. He looks around frantically, hoping that would somehow help him figure out a way to get out of this hell.

Toga comes bouncing in with knives strapped to her belt. He sees as Ochako puts on her brave face. The one he admires so much because it's so true. Uraraka is one of the bravest and determined person he knows. If anyone can make it through this, it's her. It has to be.

"I didn't know we had a new friend! Ochako-san do you remember me? Do you? Do you? Cause' I remember you! Ah, Ochako-san, you're so pretty. I can't wait to see you covered in blood!" She squeals. Izuku grinds his teeth together in stress.

All For One doesn't even have to order anything. Toga knows what to do. She gets mere inches aways from Uraraka and stabs her right in the stomach. It happened so fast that by time Izuku blinked, Ochako (his first friend at U.A. The person who told him that he could do it. Please, Izuku prays to the deities he doesn't believe in, don't do this.) is on the ground. She lets out an agonizing wail. A sound that he will never forget.

She's bleeding. A lot. Too much blood. Izuku can't watch her die. He refuses.

"*Okay! Okay! I'll do it, just please let me help her," Izuku begs. He can't let Ochako die. He won't.*

All For One puts a hand on his head and rubs it. Izuku despises it. "Good choice," the villain praises before forcing another quirk into Izuku. The process never ceases to draw a scream from Izuku. He doesn't think he'll ever get used to the excruciating experience of a quirk being forced into him.

The ordeal lasts only a couple of seconds, but it leaves Izuku gasping and heaving for air as if he hadn't breathed for multiple minutes. He could already sense the unique sensation of the quirk sizzling through his body. Settling into its new home.

Realizing he's able to move, Izuku stumbles towards Ochako and cradles her head on his lap. Her chocolate brown eyes still sparkled with strength and benevolence, even though she was bleeding out. She smiled, her rosy cheeks hardly noticeable.

"I'm so glad," Ochako coughs, "That I finally found you."

Izuku sobs, "I'm happy too! Just hang on, okay?" He was overflowing with desperation to save his best friend. At that moment, he wanted nothing else.

He must have been blessed, because his hands started to glow a beautiful luminescent blue. Shining like a lone star in the night sky. Izuku panicked, thinking that he might hurt her, but then realized that color was returning to Uraraka's pale face. He looked down at the stab wound that was visible through the tear of her hero costume and notices with astonishment that it was closing.

He let out another cry of relief, "Ochako, it's-it's healing."

The happy moment -the first one he's had since he's been in this hell hole - was short lasting. Soon, he was being pulled away by Shigaraki. He screamed and kicked, trying to use his quirks, but AFO must've done something because he couldn't feel them.

He was useless.

Ochako was forced onto her knees, staring right at Deku. Izuku watched as All For One lifted his thumb and pointed his index finger. It was an imitation of a gun. He tilted his hand so it was pointing right in the middle of Ochako's head.

Izuku thrashed and yelled obscenities that would put Bakugou's to shame. Even when his voice broke and lungs ached, he continued to shout.

Uraraka looked at him with tears dancing down her cheeks, but she was still smiling. Izuku refused to let this happen. Not to his first best friend. Not to the kind girl that had saved him from meeting the ground twice.

"Don't worry, Deku-Kun. The others will save you," Ochoka informs. Didn't she know that he didn't care about any of that?

And then she was dead. All For One's finger smoking as if it were a real gun. It was perennial to Izuku. Rewinding over and over again in his head. The sound of Uraraka's dead body thumping onto the unforgiving ground. Her empty eyes staring right at him void of any warmth that made her, her.

The shock turned into anguish which turned into fury so hot that it burned. His best friend was gone. Dead.

DEAD. She was gone. FUCKING GONE.

Izuku forced his head back, headbutting Shigaraki right in the nose. A satisfying crack sounded as he got out of the older boy's hold.

"You son of a bitch!" Izuku screams at All For one. His pathetic, worthless, excuse of a father.

He was inches away from dragging his nails down the villain's face when-

Izuku startled awake gasping. His body wasn't listening to him and went out of control. His vision was blurry and spotted with black dots. Mind replaying Ochako's dead body continually like a broken record. He was sweating profusely and oxygen seemed impossible to come by.

Where was he even?

He noticed that he still had a mask over his face, so that must mean that he was Hato. He wanted to rip it off so he could breathe, but somewhere deep in his mind told him that was not a good idea. Izuku was too panicked to take in his surroundings and figure out where he was. Izuku felt like he was dying.

Was it bad that he wished he was?

"Hey- woah, kid, listen to me." The voice seemed familiar, but Izuku's (he was Hato. Remember, dammit. He wasn't Izuku at the moment) brain wasn't making any connections. Uraraka died trying to save him. Everyone always dies. His friends, teachers, lover, mother, never got to grow old. The hope of a peaceful death was ripped away from them the second he let himself get captured. Or was it before then? He couldn't remember, yet the pain, the raw agony, was still there. He just couldn't place all the feelings with memories.

Izuku thinks he's going crazy. It feels as though there's poison in his head, spreading toxic thoughts through his mind like a virus. Izuku– Hato slips his hands underneath his sleeves and begins to scratch roughly. It's so hard to think at the moment. He still hears that voice calling out to him. Rough and drowsy, but brimming with concern. For who? Him? Hato doesn't need concern. He's fine without it and the help that it would offer.

He scratches harder.

Uraraka's smile and vacant eyes.

Todoroki burning and burning and burning. The smell of melting flesh never to be forgotten.

His mother's head being held by his father. Gushing blood from where the neck was supposed to meet the body.

He wails.

Nothing Shouta is doing is getting through to Hato. The kid can't hear him, and he wouldn't dare touch him. The risk of causing even further panic (which seemed impossible to Aizawa. He has never seen someone in so much distress. So much *fear*) would be far too high, but he has to do *something*.

He whispers to Hizashi, "He's hurting himself. The kid's injured enough from his previous fight. We can't have him reopen the stitches." Aizawa and his husband tried their best to patch the kid up as soon as he brought him down on the sofa. Bandaging his fingers and cleaning up his stab wound on his leg, but now Shouta could see blood from where Hato's sleeves had rolled up when he first began to scratch himself.

Yamada's voice is stitched with concern, "What about that weighted blanket we have?"

Aizawa ponders for a moment. He's desperate to help the kid, but needs to keep a stable thought process. The weighted blanket could potentially help, or it could have the opposite effect.

He finds himself nodding, "Do you mind getting it for me? I'm going to try to talk to him again." Hizashi softly smiles and silently but swiftly goes to get the blanket.

Shouta crouches next to Hato who is now huddled on the pink couch. He has an urge to hug the boy, but doesn't think that's a good idea. Maybe once they get through this. Who knows how much physical affection the kid gets. He could be severely touch-starved for all that Aizawa knows.

"Kid, can you hear me?" Aizawa questions. Hato only muttered brusquely. Still driving his fingernails into his skin.

He tries again. Not willing to give up, "It's Eraserhead. The underground hero. You're having a panic attack. You're okay. You're safe."

That seemed to grab the vigilante's attention. He snaps his head up sharply and makes eye contact with him. Even with Hato's mask, Shouta knew that he was shooting him an icy glare.

"*Nothing* is okay," Hato convicted. Aizawa's heart squeezes. The boy is so *young*. How could the world be so cruel as to let this kid go through something so traumatizing that he wholeheartedly believes that there is no hope for him?

Hizashi walks in with the blanket in hand. The weighted blanket has a huge picture of a frog frowning in disappointment. Hato would have found it amusing if he wasn't having a severe panic attack, Shouta thinks. He grabs the blanket from Yamada's hand and gently unfolds it.

"Hato, I'm going to put a blanket on you. Is that okay?" He doesn't know what he said that was different from all the other attempts to calm the kid down, but Hato heard his words. He responded by nodding.

Shouta took a deep breath and solicitously draped the heavy blanket around the boy's shoulders. Tight, but not too tight. He wrapped it around him like a burrito, and Aizawa hated to admit it, but the kid looked adorable. Hato seemed so small and childish as he cuddled into the blanket, taking his first real breath since he woke up.

"You're doing good, Kid. Just keep on breathing."

Hato could finally separate his thoughts so they weren't knotted together, leaving him scrambling to find out what the hell was going on. He didn't feel like he was going to die and he was no longer petrified that All for One would burst through Aizawa and Hizash's home with the intent to kill everyone he loved all over again.

It took several minutes after he got the blanket to finally tear his hands away from his arms and get the shuddering of his breath to stop.

"You back with us, kiddo?" Yamada asks. For the first time Hato realizes that the hero is actually *here*. He hasn't seen Present Mic in ages. He missed him and the heroic energy he gave off. Not to mention how utterly caring Hizashi was. Hato remembers a time when the loud hero cried over accidentally stepping on a butterfly.

That might've been partly due to his major fear of bugs though…

He nods, extremely tired. Hato clings onto the blanket tighter and sinks further into the pink couch. It's probably not even noon yet, but he feels as if he hasn't slept in days.

"Thank you," he manages to rasp. He means it. Hato is really grateful for their help. Without them he would probably be still in the depths of the panic attack. Reliving the death of his best friend over and over again.

That's when he notices the throbbing pain in his hand and leg. It's not the most painful thing he's ever felt, and he'll definitely be able to still move around, but it's not exactly convenient.

"We wrapped your injuries and stitched up the stab wound on your leg. You're going to have to take it easy for a bit," Aizawa says.

He doesn't know what to say so he settles for another, "Thank you." The two heroes nod, but fail at keeping their expressions neutral. Hato's chest bubbles up in warmth from being so blatantly cared for.

The thought of Ru crosses his mind and he stands up immediately. Yamada and Shouta take a step back in surprise. He doesn't stand for long because soon a wave of dizziness hits him like a train and he ends up falling back onto the couch.

"Woah, kiddo. You okay?" Hizashi asks, putting his hands in front of him in a worrying gesture.

Hato growls in frustration. He feels so weak. So… so *fatigued*. He needed to get to Ru and make sure she was okay. What if his quirk (he hated it. Hated all of his quirks forced upon them. No matter how much they helped, he despised the way he got them), Painkiller, didn't work nearly as well as he thought? What if they were in a hospital barely hanging onto life?

Ignoring the previous question Hato demands, "Where's Ru?" He attempts to get up again, albeit far more slowly, and succeeds. He ignores how his leg flares, sending pain-filled signals to his brain.

"She's at the Musutafu Hospital getting examined to make sure there weren't any other injuries. Do you want us to drive you there?" Aizawa offers. One of his cats comes up and begins to rub his chin on the vigilante's leg. It makes Hato relax just enough to really consider the offer. He comes to the conclusion that while a ride would be nice considering his wounds, it probably wasn't for the best. Ru didn't know he was Hato, so it would be much better to visit them when he didn't look like a half-dead vigilante.

He starts to move towards their front door, preparing himself for a long journey back to the cafe. It wasn't exactly ideal to be running across roofs in broad daylight when he was a well-known vigilante. Hato just hoped that removing the mask and hood would be enough to make him unrecognizable from, well, himself. Afterall, plenty of people could have a purple sweatshirt and black pants. He might need to put his knives in a pocket to conceal them though.

“Better not,” Hato starts. Already opening the door, “Thank you again for all of your help. I’ll see you around.” He excited the apartment without looking back. Aizawa knew better than to follow him. The underground hero probably expected him to leave as soon as he could. Still, it made Hato feel guilty for not being able to thank them more properly. Maybe he could give Eraserhead a coffee on their next patrol? Hato could even try to bake Present Mic something as well. He has been working on bettering himself around the fine art of baking.

He secretly took off his mask and slipped his knives into his pocket. That’s when Izuku realized that he forgot his staff at Aizawa’s. He was already about to go outside, so figured he could either break in later to get it (and feed the cats) or Eraserhead will give it back to him. Izuku didn’t really care about any of that right now.

All he wanted at the moment was to get cleaned up and visit his only family that he could see without having to hide.

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Rebuilding

Chapter Summary

Izuku and Ru restart.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The bed is too soft and plush. A deep contrast to the light scratchy blanket. Ru hates the smell of antiseptic and how stiff her joints are. Ru's mind is fuzzy with sleep, but just like fog clearing due to wind, their mind clears. She doesn't remember falling asleep. Only being pulled into an ambulance for an overnight stay at the hospital. Hatoru probably fell asleep on the way to the hospital. She *was* dead-tired. Ru has to rub the crust from their eyes before she can open them. When Arai is finally able to blink her eyes open, they're disappointed how there wasn't much difference. It's pitch black in what they can only assume is a hospital room.

Ru's eyes finally adjust to the darkness of the room and the first thing she notices is a slouched body in a chair next to her bed. At first Hatoru panics, thinking it might be someone trying to kidnap them again. Adrenaline spikes through Ru at the thought of being attacked again, but then Ru recognizes the mop of green hair. It's Izuku. Of course he would be here way past visiting hours. They allow themselves to relax once again as a fond smile appears on her face.

Ru would never imagine that this little boy she found crying would be such a big part of their life. Arai had never had any siblings before, but she knows Izuku is a hundred percent the best sibling ever. His friendliness is unmatched to anyone else Ru knows. He is the kindest, most sincere person she has ever met. They can't believe that they've gone their whole life without knowing him. It's only been a little over a month, but Hatoru already feels incredibly protective of Izuku. She knows he's been through a lot, although Ru has no idea what that may be, and wants to provide support in any way possible.

They don't think they've ever seen Izuku this relaxed before. Here, sitting in an uncomfortable-looking chair fast asleep. No hunched shoulders or muscle twitches. Just calm sleep. Ru wishes Izuku could be like this in the waking world, but knows that would be unfair to him. She bets that Izuku has no control over his habits and tics. They've probably been developing for years and years.

All Ru cares about is keeping him safe and loved. She wonders if she's doing a good job at it. Ru likes to think they are. Afterall, Izuku has come out of his shell a lot more these past couple of weeks. It makes Arai so happy to see him smile more and become more social with her. The way he can talk a hundred miles per minute and seems to have infinite knowledge astonishes them. It makes Ru wonder if he has an intelligence quirk.

Hatoru hopes that someday Izuku will make more friends and achieve what he so clearly wants to be.

A hero.

_____

Izuku feels recharged in a way he hasn't been for a very long time. His back hurts and he's sore all over, but the warmth of sleep makes him smile. He stretches his back with a satisfying *pop* and lazily looks around. It takes a while for his vision to clear, but he finally starts to take in his surroundings.

Only for it all to come slapping him across the face once he hears a voice shout, "Good morning sleepyhead! Nice to actually see you resting for once." He turns his head and sees Ru standing just a few feet in front of him. Izuku dumbly looks at the neatly made hospital bed and then goes back to Ru who is still smiling. They look perfectly healthy if not a bit drained. But there's color in her cheeks now and no blood covering her abdomen (he knows that sight will haunt him for days to come. Izuku is not looking forward to it, especially with the added fuel to remembering Ochako's death).

It doesn't take his body long to get up and run towards Arai (he almost falls flat on his face when his leg sends him a jolt of pain, but tries to conceal it). Giving them the biggest hug he can muster. He has to act like he wasn't there last night. That he doesn't know exactly what went down and has no injuries whatsoever. It should be easy–Izuku has gotten good at acting like everything was fine.

"I was so worried about you! I came as soon as I got a message that you were in the hospital. I'm so sorry that I wasn't there when those people came to get you. If only-"

He's interrupted by Ru patting his head, "Zu-zu, don't you dare be sorry. I'm glad you weren't there. Besides, I'm perfectly fine! Bastards didn't even lay a scratch on me." Izuku knows that they're lying on his behalf about not getting hurt. He can see the hidden glint of fear in her eyes at having to not only experience being taken hostage, but also to feel the life drain out of them.

Izuku doesn't know what to say to that, so he just smiles. "When are you free to discharge?" He hopes it's soon. Izuku doesn't want to spend any time alone at the cafe and he also hates hospitals (they remind him of death and blood and salty tears of someone losing a loved one. He hates them, but he's also the most familiar with them).

Hatoru flashes him a thumbs up, "I'm free to go whenever I please, which is now if you don't mind. Everyone here is wonderful and all, but I want to get back to the cafe and see how the cats are doing."

He sighs in relief at the fact that he won't have to be here any longer. Even with that, Izuku still questions, "Really? They don't want to do any last check-ups or anything? What if they missed something?"

Ru grabs his hand and starts leading him to the door, “Don’t be such a worry wart. They looked over my vitals while you were sleeping. Almost had to yell at them to be quiet when I realized that would defeat the purpose,” she cheaply laughs.

Izuku frowns, not liking the thought of being so trapped in sleep that he didn’t wake up to the people entering the room, but nods. “If you say so, don't be surprised when you see the inside of the cafe. I cleaned up most of it, but there was only so much I could do. There’s going to be some things we need to replace.”

Ru frowns at that and stays quiet for a moment while they walk to the lobby. Eventually she says, “That’s okay! It’s good to change things up a bit sometimes. Means we can grow and change as well.” Izuku has never thought about something like that before, but he likes the idea.

They get to Kaiteki Cafe at precisely 11:00am. Izuku can tell that Ru is trying to hide their worry about what the cafe might look like, but he can see the drumming of their fingertips against the steering wheel right before they get out.

“Don’t worry, Ru. It’s not that bad,” Izuku says. Trying to calm them down. He knows that the cafe is Arai’s whole life. She’s worked so hard to build it from the ground up. It’s her home.

They walk to the entrance of Kaiteki Cafe and Ru takes a deep inhale once they see the shattered window. Izuku can see the water building up in their eyes and really hopes that Ru won’t cry. She doesn’t. Instead, Ru lifts her head up and takes another deep breath. They make their way to the door and open it. Slowly, they enter the cozy cafe. Izuku gives Hatoru a moment to look around. It truly isn’t that bad. Izuku cleaned up everything he possibly could, but he couldn’t fix the broken display case or replace the shattered mugs (at least Ru’s favorite was unscathed).

All of a sudden Arai slapped herself. Izuku jumped in surprise at the unexpected noise and looked over to Ru worryingly. They had two red handprints on their cheeks, but their eyes held the luster that was lacking previously. Izuku sighed in relief. Ru was going to be okay.

“Alrighty! We have some work to do! We need to call in someone to fix the windows and display case.” She put her finger to her chin as they thought through everything that needed to be done. Izuku sprinted to the kitchen and grabbed a pen and notepad. He jotted down everything on Hatoru’s listing. They even start to say things that they didn’t even need: New cat toys and beds, rainbow sprinkles (that was random, Izuku thought), poster board, etc. He wrote neatly; writing everything that Ru said.

Ru stops mid thought, “Oh my god! The cats! Where are they?!” Before waiting for an answer Arai starts to peek under tables and run all over the place in a panicked frenzy.

Izuku tries to say their name multiple times, but they’re too committed to completing the mission of finding the cats. Eventually he has to yell, “Arai!” This finally gains Hatoru’s attention. She stops and looks at him with impatience, “The cats are upstairs, and so is all of their stuff. Don’t worry, none got hurt.”

Ru’s cheeks flush as they scratch the back of their neck sheepishly.

“Oh.”

It takes them two weeks to reopen the cafe. It could’ve been done in a week, but Izuku insisted that Arai got at least a week of rest before working full time again. Ru always insisted that she was fine, but that didn’t fool Izuku. Not when he could hear their cries and whimpers at night. They still flinch when Izuku accidentally sneaks up on them. He never says anything about it. If Ru wanted to talk he trusts that she would seek him out. Besides, sometimes people have to sort through things first by themselves before they reach out.

Izuku’s leg and hand are a lot better now. Not fully healed, but getting there. When Ru first noticed the bandage on his hand they mothered over him, but Izuku eventually fabricated a lie and said he cut himself with a piece of glass while cleaning up the shattered window.

It’s a sunny summer day when they reopen. People were lined up before they even opened for the day. It was a sight to see, and Izuku is so happy that he can be a part of this. All of Kateki’s regulars expressed their gratitude to seeing their favorite cafe back in business again. The newcomers were just as excited, especially when they noticed all of the adorable cats just waiting to be bombarded with attention.

Izuku surprisingly didn’t get rusty at being a barista from the break he had. In fact, it was like he had never stopped. He loved being able to make drinks for all of these lovely people. Not only was it fulfilling and gave himself something to focus his mind on, but he genuinely enjoyed it. There were so many different drinks and combinations he could try out. Not to mention the bizarre drinks people ordered. One time someone ordered an italian soda with an espresso shot in it (Izuku made it himself a while later. Ew). He also remembers someone ordering just eight shots of espresso. Ru later told him that the customer drank the entire thing in two gulps without so much of an eye twitch. Izuku didn’t really interact with customers much since he worked in the back, so he usually missed all of the action.

While he was making the drinks and baking the pastries, Izuku tried to ignore the way his hands shook. Neither Izuku or Arai have been getting much sleep these days. Izuku was plagued with images of Ru and Uraraka bleeding out. And when he found himself staring at his blank ceiling, he often put his gear on and

went on a patrol. He had almost fallen asleep while working on multiple occasions so Izuku put his skills to good use and made himself an iced coffee with an added two shots of espresso. Yes, it went against his “tea is better for you” statement, but Izuku needed as much caffeine as he could get.

Just as he was finishing putting a neapolitan cake on a plate and steaming some milk, he felt something rub against his leg. Izuku knew instantly that it was Neko, the cat that often snuck into the kitchen.

Izuku bent down to rub the orange cat’s head, “Neko, you silly cat, you know you’re not supposed to be in here.” He picks him up while cooing at the soft fur that would be perfect to snuggle up against and walks toward the entrance of the cafe. He opened the door and froze.

There, standing in line, was Aizawa, Yamada, and Kayama. Izuku dropped the cat and let out a loud, “Eep!”. He bolted back to the door and entered the kitchen with a speed that rivaled Iida. Izuku ducked to keep his head hidden from the circular window on the door and creeped towards the kitchen.

He distantly heard Aizawa’s voice, “Did you hear that?”

“Hear what?” That was Hizashi’s voice.

“I didn’t hear anything,” Nemuri said. It was nice hearing her voice. It’s been a while since Izuku’s seen her and he hadn’t realized how much he missed the hero.

“It sounded like a dying mouse,” Shouta said. Izuku felt his face warming up as the other two heroes started to laugh at Aizawa. Izuku lay next to the kitchen cabinets hoping they would just go away.

Of course, fate never liked him. Izuku jumps when Ru rings a bell on the counter that connects the kitchen to the cafe and peers over it. Izuku groans knowing he looks like a complete idiot.

“Dude, what are you doing down there? Get up! We have freakin’ *pro heroes* here. I think the one who helped save me is here! You should go say hi. I bet that would make you really happy,” Ru suggests. Their eyes shining at the fact that heroes would stop by at her cafe. Izuku hops back up and starts to work on the orders once again.

“I better not. We’re really busy and I’m sure they don’t want some kid fanboying over them when they’re on their break.” He immerses himself in the mesmerizing task of grinding the coffee and pressing it into a portafilter.

Ru shrugs and looks at him skeptically, “Okay… if you say so.” They walk away and start ringing up more orders. Izuku gets out the mini shortcakes he was making while the espresso machine does its magic. He almost melts at the homey smell of the espresso mixed with the sweet aroma of the shortcake. Izuku makes a mental note to try the two together someday.

He tries to ignore the urge to say hi to the people just a few feet away who don’t even know if he’s still alive.

By the end of the day both Izuku and Hatoru are nearly collapsing on each other. They both laid on the beanbags that were upstairs with cats crawling all over them. Izuku was tempted to close his eyes and grab an armful of cats, but resisted.

Ru groaned, “That was… exhausting. Who knew that many people would want to visit our cafe?” They looked just as tempted as Izuku was to fall asleep on the plush beanbags. Their hair was defying gravity and their eyeliner was smeared. Izuku doubted he looked any better.

“I’m not surprised. Of course people would want to try us out. We’re awesome.” His voice was slurred, but he didn’t have the energy to fix it.

Ru laughed slowly. It was more like puffed out breaths than an actual laugh. She looked to be finally giving into sleep when her eyes widened. Ru hopped out of the beanbag. Making the cats that were on her slide off of them unhappily. Izuku forced himself to be more alert–he never knew what could come with a burst of energy from Arai.

“I just remembered something,” Ru paused to make sure they had Izuku’s attention, “You barely have any clothes and your bedroom is absolutely atrocious. We need to add some flavor, so that’s why we’re going to the mall tomorrow.”

Izuku, now slightly more awake, sat up in alarm, “To the mall? But why? I’m perfectly fine with the things I have right now.” Besides, the mall meant a lot of people. He was afraid he might get recognized.

Ru waves him off, “Three shirts and two shorts is not enough. We also have all that money from the tips people gave us today! Come on, Zu-zu, it’ll be fun!”

Knowing that arguing was useless with Ru, Izuku nodded in defeat. “Fine. We can go, but we’re only getting the bare minimum.”

“We’ll see about that. Now let’s go to bed. We have a busy day ahead of us.” Izuku gets up and walks away grumbling. He’s never been a big fan of the mall. No one liked to have a quirkless person in their store (“we don’t discriminate” my ass). Not to mention all the bullies that roamed around there during the last timeline. Then there was the instance where he met Shigaraki. There was also the chance of running into Kacchan. That would be an absolute disaster.

He tried to smother the speck of hope that bloomed in his chest upon seeing Kacchan.

Izuku sighed as he laid in bed. The mall was a horrible idea, but Ru looked so excited. He found it hard to say no to them. Afterall, Hatoru has done so much for him. If not for her he would still be sleeping in that abandoned building. Always so cold during the winters and incredibly hot in the summers. Izuku remembers one time when he got so hot that he passed out. It probably didn’t help that he was severely malnourished and dehydrated as well. Who knows, Izuku could be dead right now if it weren’t for Ru. Yes, he would most likely be dead by now. It’s hard to think that just a few months ago Izuku was being suffocated with loneliness. He had begun to lose sight of hope and found the will to fight less appealing.

The point is, Ru had saved him.

With that, Izuku closed his eyes and tried not to think of everything that could possibly go wrong tomorrow.

Chapter End Notes

Hi! I am so sorry it’s been a while. School started and it’s very chaotic. Thank you so much for being patient.

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

A Jump in Time

Chapter Summary

Katsuki notices someone at the mall…

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki notices how everyone around him -including himself- is changing. His mom and dad are different. Or maybe it's how he perceives them that has changed. They are no longer people that can do anything and everything. They are no longer perfect (Katsuki would never admit out loud that he once thought his parents were perfect, and there will always be a small part of him that still believes it). No one is. Katsuki is still struggling with this because *he* wants to be perfect. He wants to be the best at everything, and is still striving to achieve this unattainable goal (Katsuki wonders if it's a form of distraction. A way to pass the time by).

His parents are different, and so are the kids at school. He's in junior high now, and it's near impossible not to notice the shift. People have migrated into their own groups, and therefore developing classes of each other. Who is better? Who would they rather be? Who makes them happy that they aren't them? Katsuki doesn't know what group he's in, but everyone seems to love him. He doesn't complain. He loves the attention, but no matter how much he receives, it's never enough. It never amounts to the attention he was given from Deku.

Katsuki has grown taller. He's losing all of the baby fat, and now looks older. His quirk continues to grow as he does. Katsuki loves his quirk. He loves the colors and the warmth and the stinging that comes with the beauty. He has trouble controlling it when he gets angry (which has been happening more and more recently). Small, threatening, sparks erupt from his hands as he feels the anger bubbling up, but Katsuki reminds himself that these small sparks are better than something bigger and uncontrollable. Besides, it helps calm him down. It's like all of his frustrations and pent up feelings are coming out of the small explosions. His quirk fills him with a satisfying relief. Everyone says that he needs a better way to control his rage, but he doesn't care. This helps. This comforts. If his explosive quirk provides him with calm, then isn't that as good of a way as any other?

He's at the mall (he doesn't want to be here) with some kids from school. Katsuki doesn't know why he's here. Only that his mom wanted him to get out more. He *has* been getting out. He goes on walks and still visits that one martial arts gym that he and Izuku used to go to. Katsuki graduated about a year ago, but he still likes to visit. Sometimes he offers to help the younger children with some of the more simpler techniques.

So he's in the mall with people he barely talks to but who cling to his every word. He gazes at the merch stores, but can't bring himself to go in. Katsuki only enters these stores in the beginning of July in search for Izuku's birthday present. This time he got him a case of fountain pens and a variety of ink colors. Katsuki finds it pathetic that he calls himself Izuku's best friend but has only celebrated not even a handful of his birthdays. When they're united again, Katsuki swears to himself that he is going to throw the nerd the biggest party he's ever been to.

“What do you think, Bakugou?” one of the extra’s asked. What they’re asking, Katsuki has no idea. He wasn’t paying attention because nothing they say is hardly worth anything to him.

“What?” He gruffs out. His voice still sounds childish to his ears, and he can hardly wait until he’s older and his voice is deeper- more respectable.

The extras, long nails and big mouth (he hates them. They bullied Izuku. Why is he hanging out with them? He’d rather be in hell) look at him oddly for a second, but quickly turn their gazes when Katsuki glares at them.

Long Nails speaks, “That girl in our class. Hina-san. Everyone but you knows that she has a big crush on you. Are you going to ask her out?”

Katsuki throws up a little bit in his mouth.

“Who?” He says, but doesn’t necessarily ask. The two boys sigh and continue to talk about something that Katsuki is not interested in.

He looks at all the shops around him, and then catches a glimpse of green. He hurriedly snaps his gaze back to the direction where he saw it, and sees green, fluffy hair.

“Izuku…” he whispers. It’s more like a release of breath. So gentle because he’s afraid that he’ll break whatever is happening right now.

“Izuku!” Katsuki yells. He sees the small figure freeze, and he knows. He knows this is Izuku. He’s taller and more built, but he’s Izuku.

His feet are carrying him before he can even process his movements. He pushes past people without caring to apologize. All he sees is Izu.

He gets closer, but then he blinks and Izuku is gone. All Katsuki sees is a lady with short blue hair and a blurred figure next to them. The figure passes his mind quickly, and he doesn’t give a single thought about it. Katsuki looks around frantically. He knows that he wasn’t seeing things. He’s not crazy. He saw Izuku. He did!

He’s having a hard time breathing. Oxygen enters his lungs in short gasps. Tears blur his vision as he whips his head around. He’s never been this desperate in his life. It was the first time Katsuki had seen Izuku in over

two years, and he lost him.

He leaves the mall, not caring about who he left behind. Clouds cover his mind, creating a blanket of yearning and an ache he will never be able to describe.

Katsuki can't stand this. He misses his best friend. He doesn't think he can wait another two years. It seems impossible.

He wants to scream, but instead he walks home and tries not to cry.

"Is it okay if I use the restroom?" Izuku asks Ru. He's trying so hard to not let his voice shake, and he thinks he does pretty well at sounding normal. Ru gives him a thumbs up and goes to look at a store entirely dedicated to selling stickers. Izuku nearly sprints to the nearest gender neutral bathroom (he can't risk someone noticing his labored breaths and stifled cries in the public ones), and slams the door behind him. He locks it just before his legs give up and he slides to the ground.

Breathing seems impossible at the moment. A part of him hopes that he will stop breathing altogether. He was right *there.* Katsuki was right behind him and Izuku didn't even turn around. He didn't allow himself to see Katsuki. To see how tall he was now, to see if he looked older. No, instead he froze up and activated his invisibility quirk (which wasn't even an invisibility quirk, but more like one that makes him less noticeable).

Izuku hates himself more than he has ever hated anybody. He wishes he had never met All Might the first time around. He would rather have stayed quirkless and miserable than to endure this. Urges are coming up that haven't in a very long time. Not since Junior High, before all of this shit happened. He craves self-destruction. It is relentless. No matter how hard he tries to stop it, the destruction always pulls him in. Almost always in different shapes; some so abstract that Izuku can't tell what it is until weeks, months have passed since he's fallen in its grip.

It takes ten minutes for Izuku to calm down. Not long, but long enough that Arai is probably getting worried. He splashes ice cold water onto his face and looks at himself in the mirror. Izuku looks bad- tired and worn. When will this exhaustion stop? He thinks.

He's afraid, but not doubtful, that it won't ever stop.

Izuku walks towards Ru, who's still in the sticker shop, and asks if they can leave. He's tired, he says. Besides, they got him more than enough supplies. Izuku allowed himself one All Might poster, a few sweatshirts, jeans, shorts, shirts (he was elated when he found his "shirt" shirt. Ru wasn't), underwear, socks,

and even a new pair of red shoes (the shoes he had been wearing were found in the dumpster). He tried to be as minimal as possible, but he has a feeling that Hotaru had snuck some extra supplies in as well.

They go to the cafe and cook katsudon together. He knows that Ru knows that something is off, but gives him some space. He's thankful for that. Izuku wouldn't have the words to describe what he was feeling even if he wanted to. It's not like he can tell her about Kacchan, anyway. He hopes that someday he will.

That night Izuku dreams of being older. Maybe sixteen or seventeen. He's happy, and he's surrounded by warmth. In the dream, Izuku is holding Katsuki's hand and smiling at him. There in front of Kaiteki Cafe and when they enter, there is Ru. They're grinning, eyes wrinkling from the force of the smile. Katsuki extends his free hand towards Ru, but that isn't needed because she hugs him instead. And soon, Izuku is joining in and everything is perfect.

He wakes up crying. Izuku loathes how much he's cried today, but his body won't listen to him when he tells it to stop. No more tears, he wants to yell. Stop being such a useless crybaby. But even though Izuku is crying, even though he's sad, he is still grateful that his mind has blessed him with that dream. He wants to make that day a reality, but doesn't dare to hope. He has no idea if Katsuki hates him or not, and Izuku won't blame him if he does.

That dream was enough, Izuku thinks. He can deal with the fact that it will probably never become reality.

He'd give anything to say that he was sorry. Sorry for leaving Kacchan and Auntie Mitsuki and Uncle Masaru. They've done so much for him, and he repays them by running away. What a horrible way to repay someone's kindness.

Izuku closes his eyes and dreams once again. He dreams of laughter and hope. Friends that will last a lifetime.

Two more years.

"ZuZu! Can you refill Moe's cup? I'm a bit busy," Ru calls out as they wind through tables. They *are* really busy. It's spring break, which means teenagers want to go out and hang out with friends. And Kaiteki Cafe has really grown in popularity these past two years. They've rescued more cats than possible to count, and gave the same amount away to loving families.

"Sure thing!" Izuku calls from the back. He grabs the pot of black coffee and opens the door to the public part of the cafe. He's fourteen now, which means he can work in the front. He doesn't do it too often since he's

afraid he might run into Aizawa or Katsuki, but he doesn't mind doing it every once in a while.

Izuku has lived with Ru for almost three years now, and they've become inseparable. Siblings in every way but blood. Ru followed with what they said and started to homeschool him as soon as they got him registered. That was a big stressor, but apparently the school boards don't keep track of the quirkless, so they really didn't have any problems with him getting registered. Ru has taught him things far beyond his imagination. Math theories (axioms have been his favorite), old literature, Japanese sign language, and concepts of space and time are just a few things he's been taught.

Of course, not everything was blissful. They've had their fights, and more will come. There were few where Izuku found himself truly mad at Arai, but that was rare. He remembers an especially bad fight:

"Izuku, can I talk to you?" Ru gently asks. He freezes because Izuku, even after a year of knowing her, hates talking about anything personal. And this, Izuku feels, is going to be personal.

"Sure. What's up?" He sits on one of the beanbags in the living room next to them. A pit grows in his stomach once he sees Ru's frown. Their eyebrows are scrunched together, meaning she's thinking really hard.

"Do you ever wish you could talk to someone?" Ru questions. Confusion swells in Izuku. He doesn't know what they mean, and that scares him. He hates not knowing.

"What do you mean? I have you."

Ru takes a deep breath. Izuku feels as though a lock has been placed on his lungs, prohibiting him from breathing, "I mean a professional. Like a counselor or even a psychiatrist."

It's tense for what seems like forever, but can't be more than five seconds. Izuku? See a shrink? No way. Not only does he not need one, but what would he say? Hi, I'm Midoriya Izuku, and I saw everyone I loved get slaughtered brutally in another timeline. *Hell no.*

He laughs, knowing this isn't a joke but acting like it's one anyway. He wants this to be over. Izuku hasn't even done anything to indicate that he might need to "talk to someone" as Ru put it. At least, he doesn't think he has.

"Zu, I'm not joking. You worry me sometimes," Ru whispers. Guilt envelopes Izuku. He hates worrying people. It makes him feel helpless. How can he be a hero if he worries other people?

They take Izuku's silence as an opening to continue, "Do you notice that there are days where you hardly eat? Or talk? Sometimes you're right in front of me, but I feel like you're somewhere else. And every once in a while you cry so hard at night that I can hear you."

Izuku can feel himself disassociating. He doesn't want this talk. Not now, not ever.

"Are you even happy?"

That strikes something in Izuku. Rage and depression and everything else bubbles up inside him. Is he happy? He honestly doesn't know. Does it matter either way? He doesn't think he does. Izuku has always assumed that once he's saved everybody, everything will be bright again. It's the way things should *work out.*

"I'm perfectly fine. If that's all you wanted to talk about then I'm going to bed." He sounds cold and callous. Izuku can't bring himself to look at Ru as he gets up to go to his room.

"Zuzu, please! I really think you should talk to someone. I hardly know anything about who you were before I met you. Sometimes I still think that you're a stranger."

Izuku whips around, unable to control himself, "And why do you *care? Does it really matter what my life looked like before I met you? I'm not going to a shrink that only wants money," he speaks to Ru in a tone he's never used before. It's loud, but not yelling. He's angry and hates that he's angry.*

"Izuku," Ru sternly says, "Your past is a part of you, and I want to know more than what you choose to show me. Don't you dare *get angry at me for worrying about you."*

He turns away again so she doesn't see his tears.

"I never asked you to worry about me, so stop wasting your time."

They didn't speak for two whole days before Izuku broke and started to apologize over and over again. That's been their only fight that serious. Arai still brings up people that they know that could talk to him, but Izuku always declines.

The two years have happened, and he's meeting All Might in a month.

Finally, he thinks. He hasn't seen All Might in so long. The only times Izuku has heard his voice is when there's a news broadcast about another villain he took down. He'll finally feel at home once he gets One for All back again. He hopes he won't feel so empty. Every once in a while, Izuku hears the past users talk to him. A part of Izuku thinks he's imagining it and is actually going crazy, but another part knows. Knows that after all of this time, a part of OFA is still with him.

He's seen Todoroki a few times as well, but only in passing. They nod, and maybe even say hi, but Izuku doesn't let it go any further than that. Sometimes Izuku goes at night to the Todoroki's house to check in on everybody. Secretly, of course. Endeavor is still a pile of shit, and Izuku can't wait for the opportunity to kick his ass. He doesn't think Todoroki ever notices his presence, especially since he's always using his invisibility quirk.

Then there's Kacchan. Ever since that day at the mall two years ago, Izuku's mind has been full of Katsuki. Sometimes he can still hear him call his name like he did at the mall. He, too, has seen Kacchan a few times, but only from afar. He's seen Katsuki grow taller and stronger. Has seen his determination to become a hero increase tenfold. Izuku is terrified for the day of the entrance exam-only a year away. Katsuki has to hate him. There's no way he doesn't. Who wouldn't after their best friend simply vanishes?

But under all of that horror lies excitement to finally see him again. Not glance, or dream, or pretend, but actually *see* him.

But before he does any of that, he needs to do something first.

And that's to save Eri.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for such the late update! I hope this chapter makes it up to you readers. School has been really hard. So much homework…

I hope everyone has a good day/night! You better

A Promise to the Stars

Chapter Summary

Izuku plans to save Eri.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Things have changed. They usually do, but that doesn't make it any less noticeable. Aizawa is old, and yes, twenty-nine counts as being old. He has witnessed things change and evolve throughout his decade of being a hero. He should be used to it by now, but not when it comes to a certain vigilante.

Aizawa has worked beside Hato for two years now. He's known about him for about four. And every time he thinks he knows Hato, the more confused he gets. Hato never reveals anything personal about himself. Not even his favorite color (believe Aizawa, he's asked). He doesn't know what he looks like because he never removes his mask no matter how hard he struggles for air at times. He can estimate that the vigilante is thirteen to fourteen years old, which is the age Midoriya would be. Yes, he still thinks this vigilante is the missing Midoriya Izuku who vanished four years ago. He's tried on multiple occasions to find out, but has frustratingly failed every single time.

He even asked if Hato ever heard of Midoriya.

They're sitting on their old roof. Hato is on his fifth steamed pork bun that he got from Aizawa. He has three more left, and the hero doubts that there will be any leftovers. Aizawa is sucking on a lychee-flavored jelly pouch as he gazes at the bustling city below.

Finally, he sucks in a breath and asks the question that's been growing in his mind like a weed, "Do you know who Midoriya Izuku is, Hato?" Hato chokes on his bun and develops a coughing fit. Eraserhead begins to worry that he's actually choking when Hato calms down.

Hato faces toward him, "Can't say I have. Why? Is he your secret love child or something?" It's Aizawa's turn to choke on his food. Even though he can't see Hato's face, he knows that the evil child is smirking.

"No. Just a kid that went missing years ago."

Hato is silent for a while. Shota hopes that his hunch is correct and that Hato is about to confess that he is, in fact, Midoriya Izuku.

“Shouldn’t the case have gone cold, then? Declared dead?” Hato says instead, disappointing Shota.

“I promised his best friend that I’ll find him, and his deceased mother that I’ll protect him. I know he’s alive. His friend spotted him a year ago.” Aizawa remembers being at Inko’s grave, promising to always protect her son. It has been his greatest failure.

Hato stutters and takes a deep breath. Something he does when he’s trying to calm himself down. Eraserhead thinks that this could be considered as more evidence that his hunch is correct, but he refuses to tear off his mask. He wants Hato to confess. Aizawa wants to keep his trust.

“Promised his mother, huh? Didn’t know you were the sentimental type, Eraser’,” Hato whispers. He gazes up at the polluted sky, and in that moment, Shota thinks that Hato looks so lonely. Hato speaks again, “What if the kid was seeing things? Maybe you should stop looking and see if he ever comes back. You’re an amazing person, Eraserhead. I bet the friend is, too. Considering that he’s still looking for his best friend. Midoriya would be stupid not to come back to such loving people.” With that, Hato salutes and heads off to wherever he goes. Aizawa has tried to follow him before, but always manages to lose him.

Aizawa hopes that Hato is right, and that Izuku will come back. Even if he is some rambunctious vigilante with no self-preservation.

He hasn’t gotten closer to finding who Hato is, and if Midoriya is related to him or not. He has informed Tsuchauchi about his suspicions, though, and the detective has been trying to gather more evidence that will link Hato to Midoriya.

So far, nothing.

Shota has witnessed Hato’s growth in fighting, and it’s terrifying. Hato is able to take out villains with such cold precision and swiftness. Heroes who have been in the business for years are hardly ever that talented with their fighting technique, but Hato, a teenage vigilante, is a master at it. Not to mention his analytical mind: he’s able to analyze a situation or quirk within seconds. It makes Aizawa hella glad that Hato isn’t a villain.

While he’s grown in his physical skills, Hato has declined mentally. Shota isn’t sure when it started, but he noticed it about six months ago. He started to become less sarcastic and more self-deprecating. He hardly ever laughs or talks now. Hato’s become isolated. What really scares Aizawa is when Hato occasionally gets clumsy when he is fighting. It’s obvious that he’s purposefully making mistakes to get hurt, but Shota couldn’t understand what triggered this change. Was it always there and it was just now getting bad enough for him to notice? Shota has tried to bring it up, but Hato always changes the subject and runs off. This only makes his worry grow.

The vigilante is a pain in Aizawa's ass, but he's a hero. And heroes protect. Especially pesky problem children.

He doesn't know how to put it into words: the loss of his power. It's not painful, nor is it terrifying as he thought it would be. To Toshinori, losing his quirk is like forgetting something important, but not being able to remember what it was. His mind nags at him, telling him that he's forgetting something. But Yagi isn't forgetting his quirk, he's losing it. He thinks about how empty he's starting to feel without the calming buzz of One For All and the knowledge that its past users are with it. He knows losing his quirk will create a big impact on how villains act, and that's why he needs a successor. So they can bring peace, or hope, or serenity back to society.

He's been searching for six months now, and he hasn't seen or thought of anyone that calls to his heart. No one but a boy who visits his dreams. His name is Midoriya and that is all Yagi knows. He thinks he's seen the boy's face before in his dreams, and maybe in real life, but the memories fade so quickly. Toshinori tries to write down as many things as he can about the odd dreams, but it is difficult to describe.

Nezo said that he is welcomed to work at U.A in order to continue his search for a successor, and he might in a year or two, but he's going to wait for now. Yagi doesn't know if it's OFA or him that's being called to Young Midoriya, but what he does know is that this boy is going to be a hero.

Hato hides between the corner of a building as he watches a man with a bird mask walking down a street. Chisaki Kai. Hato makes sure to blend in with the shadows while following the man. He's younger, and hasn't fully developed a clear menacing aura yet, but Hato knows it won't be long. He takes out a small notepad from one of his many pockets and adds notes on all that he's observed.

No signs of Eri

Is frustrated (why?)

Only bought five apples (Eri)

Anything that he picked up, Hato would add. He didn't have One For All, which meant it would be a lot more difficult to defeat Chisaki than it was last time. And this time around he'll make sure no one dies. Not for those who deserve a long life full of discovery.

He follows Kai until he enters his house. People in black bird masks always stand guard near the gate and the main entrance. None of these guards are familiar to him, and he has no idea what their quirks are. He's trying not to worry about that at the moment, especially since he has his camouflage quirk. Hato's main focus is to save Eri. He needs to save her. She's only four during this time, but Hato wouldn't doubt that she hasn't already endured Chisaki's evil.

So he watches, and he waits. He'll make a plan to save her before he meets All Might. Hato knows he won't be able to do this alone; not with how powerful and large Shie Hassaikai is. He hates admitting that he needs help because of how dangerous this fight will be. And right now, Aizawa and Yamada are the only heroes he can truly trust with his vigilantism. *Maybe* Kayama since Aizawa and Yamada trust her, and he has no idea where All Might is at this time.

What if Aizawa doesn't agree to help? No, that's stupid. He will, or else Hato will have to do this alone. He knows that Shota suspects him to be Midoriya Izuku, although he has no idea how he got that indication, but Hato has to ignore that risk of the underground finding any more clues as to who he is for the sake of Eri.

After all, He did promise her.

It was a week before the shit hit the fan. Before he got kidnapped, before Kota died, before he got broken into becoming a puppet to the league.

Izuku and Eri were on the dorm roof, both wrapped heavily with blankets. They snuggled close to each other, and looked up at the twinkling night sky. The sky seemed to be putting on a show just for them. Nothing seemed to matter at that moment besides the fact that they had comfort within each other.

"Deku-nii?" Eri asked. Her voice feather-like against the warming silence.

"Yes, Eri-Chan?" Deku responded, petting Eri's hair. It was Momo who discovered how much Eri liked to be stroked on the head.

"Why did you save me?"

Izuku didn't need a moment to think before he answered, "Because it looked like you needed help, and everyone deserves to be saved."

It was silent for a while, and Izuku thought the conversation was over. Then, Eri spoke again, "Will you always save me, no matter what?"

Izuku extended his pinky finger to the sky, as if to make a promise with the whole world, "I'll save you for all of eternity, Eri."

Eri giggled, "You can't save me forever! That's impossible!"

Izuku smiled, so bright that it could've been a star, "Sure I can! As long as you need me, I'll always be here."

"I'll always need you, Deku-nii."

He won't break that promise, and he'll gladly tear down every single wall of Shie Hassaiki if it means to fulfill it.

_____

"Problem Child, what the fuck," Aizawa said. So exasperated that he thought that he was going to explode.

The said child straightened his spine as he emitted waves of determination, "I'm telling the truth. I need the hero's help for this one, Eraserhead. As many who are willing to fight with a rogue, teenage vigilante." His voice was serious and held a hint of desperation in it. Aizawa had never heard him sound like that before, and this is how he knew that the kid wasn't messing around.

Hato continued to stand firm. Aizawa knew that he would go on this rescue mission with or without help. He also knew that there would be no stopping him, either. How Hato came to know about Shie Hassaiki and a girl named Eri, he had no clue, but Hato wasn't lying. He never lied about things like this.

Aizawa really, really needs a nap.

"You do understand that this mission is going to take weeks to formulate, right? Possibly months," Erasherhead said. But in his mind he was thinking of something else entirely. All of the dreams that he's had about a green-haired problem child have been hinting at it being memories. Memories that haven't happened yet, but connect to the present. What if, and this is only if Hato is Midoriya, rescuing Eri has happened before? That would explain why Hato knew about Chisaki.

What was he thinking? Time travel to that extent had to be impossible. It was completely illogical. Right?

Hato's shoulders hunch in stress. His voice is slightly panicked as he speaks, "A few weeks, sure, but not *months*. I don't have that kind of time, Aizawa," he's surprised to hear his real name coming from the vigilante. Hato only uses it when something really important is happening, "We need to save Eri-Chan within the month. If no one wants to work with me then that's fine, but I'm not going to let her suffer any more. Not again." The last sentence is muttered so quietly that Shota can't interrupt it.

He looks at the frail, but strong kid in front of him and notices how tired he looks. Hato has been fighting for four years. Maybe more than that. Why can't Aizawa do anything more for him? Hato's on a gray line that no one knows how to maneuver around. It's endlessly frustrating.

He hopes that he could at least do this for him, "I'll see what I can do. Meet me back at the roof in three days. Got it?"

Hato relaxes a fraction with relief, "Got it." And right before Aizawa was about to go, he heard Hato say, "Thank you, Eraserhead."

"You're welcome, kid."

Izuku collapses onto his bed. His room has changed since he first moved in two years ago. His walls are painted a forest green with a black accent wall. His bedding is an autumn orange. He has three All Might Posters hung up in various places and a few other hero figurines as well. On his desk below his bed is a picture of him and Ru during their twentieth birthday a few months ago.

His entire body aches– covered with bruises and wounds fading into scars. Izuku has never been fond of his body. To him it has always been weird and out of place. Something that always needed improving on. But now, he can hardly look at it. His body is covered with small and big scars. There aren't scars just from the Arena anymore (Star shaped burn on his right hand, a silver line from an arrow on his left calf, and many more miniscule scars), but from battles over the past four years. There's a silver blob of a scar right below his collarbone on his right side where he was stabbed, there are scars from being burned, having quirks used on him, falling off a roof, getting *thrown* off of a roof, and so many more.

The scars he hates most, however, are not the ones from battles that have left him cold and alone, or the ones where he made countless mistakes, but the ones he's given to himself. He despises how clean and precise they are, and that he didn't even have a solid reason for doing it. Whenever he draws a blade across his skin, or punches his leg until it bruises, or scratches until he's too tired, are not the nights where he's failed tremendously. Most of the time when he engages in this activity is when Izuku has had a genuinely good day. But then something always shifts at night, and things come crashing down all over again.

He started doing it a week after he saw Katsuki that day at the mall, two years ago. That entire week he had been on edge, always jumping at the slightest sound. Patrol wasn't working to ease his nerves, and same goes with working at the cafe. Izuku had reached his limit.

Izuku doesn't do it often. Maybe once a week. Sometimes once every two weeks, if he's trying really hard. Most of the scars are on his hips, but there are a few on his arms as well. Small and far inbetween so that it would be easy to chalk it up as an accident from baking if Ru ever sees them.

Izuku will stop. Some day. Just like he stopped all those years ago before he even knew that being a hero could become some twisted reality. He just doesn't have the strength to stop today. Or tomorrow. Or next month.

Soon, he'll save Eri, and he'll be one step closer in putting all of this to a close. Aizawa has agreed to help him, and he knows that he will be able to persuade Aizawa and Yamada into adopting Eri. Just like they did last time (Izuku knows it's a lot to ask, but it's the only way that he will know that Eri will be safe).

Izuku needs to rest. His brain is muddled with fatigue, but his body is restless. Izuku knows that he won't get a good night's sleep, but he has to take what he can get. Afterall, tomorrow means a new day. And a new day brings endless possibilities.

Chapter End Notes

Another chapter! I actually like this one, and can't wait to start writing the battle to save Eri :D

Everyone excited for the holidays? I'm wishing everyone happiness!

Idiota

Chapter Summary

Izuku realizes that heroes can be a bunch of idiots

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki knows when Izuku is watching him. He can never see him, but he knows that the Damn Deku is there. And *no* , he is not crazy. He can't explain how he knows when Izuku is near him, but he *does*. He doesn't do anything about these feelings, he's too afraid that he'll scare Deku off. Katsuki doesn't know why he can't see him. Maybe it's because Izuku has gotten really good at hiding, or he disguises himself as someone else.

Bakugou doesn't take comfort in the fact that Izuku comes to see him. He's glad that the idiot is still alive, but why isn't he brave enough to say anything? It pisses him off, and once Katsuki finally gets to *see* him, he's going to give that damn Nerd one hell of a punch on the face. He feels like he's slowly losing everything. Even himself. Katsuki is so alone. It doesn't matter that the whole school looks up to him like some god, or that his quirk and body have grown incredibly strong. Katsuki's parents are amazing, this he knows, but it's not enough.

Maybe that's a selfish thing to say after everything he's ever received in his life. How lucky he's been. But his parents can't understand him no matter how hard they try, and that's okay, because parents aren't supposed to understand everything about their child. It just makes it difficult to talk to them about things where they can't see the reasoning to. They can't determine why he's so angry now, or why he's not happy.

Katsuki was at the dining table eating coconut curry when an argument broke out. It was his fault, really. He was the one that started the stupid conversation.

"I'll be in U.A. soon. I'll make sure to give Deku a greeting he'll always remember, then I'll drag him back here." He doesn't know what inspired him to say this, but it seemed important to say the words out loud. Maybe speaking them aloud will urge the hope of seeing Deku turn into a reality. He truly believed his parents would've backed him up.

His parents glanced at each other. His father looks as he always does- worried, and his mother develops a stern look on her face. Katsuki feels the familiar tick of anger at the back of his mind. It's a warning, he thinks. He should have never said that.

Katsuki was just about to excuse himself so he wouldn't inevitably explode at them, when the old hag decides to speak.

“You don’t really think that, do you?” Mistsuki says, her voice stern, but not mean.

He narrows his eyes. Think what? What could she possibly be talking about? He knows, of course, but he refuses to admit it. Katsuki decides to deny that fact that’s been lingering at the back of his mind for over a year now.

That his parents have given up on his best friend.

“What?” He fights to keep his voice even. He doesn’t want to yell at his parents. Not in a situation like this.

“Well,” His dad says, “It’s just that it’s been a while. you know?”

He feels his grip slipping. Katsuki can handle this with the extras at school, but not his parents. Especially since they helped take care of him before he ran away. They are the only ones who have any semblance of understanding.

Katsuki’s form his hands into fists The nails biting into his hand so furiously that they draw small specks of blood.

Mitsuki sighs and takes off from where his dad ended. Katsuki gives them one last look as a warning. *Don’t do this. Don’t you dare.*

“Don’t you think it’s time to move on? It’s been years, and you still think he’s coming back. Katsuki, you need to think that maybe he’s *not* coming back. Face it, it’s about time to give up.”

Give up .

Katsuki doesn’t know what that means. He doesn’t *give up* . Not now, not ever. The fact that his own parents would say these words to him is like a punch in the face. With the addition of brass knuckles. Katsuki has never been truly mad at his parents. He has never felt the searing rage that burns so hot it almost seems cold. But he’s feeling it now, and there’s no way to stop it.

Katsuki isn’t sure if he wants to. After all, he’s been holding this in for who knows how long. He’s tired, and there’s only so much he can hold back.

He stands up. Knocking his chair back as he does. He feels like he's running a fever, except that his mind isn't foggy. No, it's the clearest it's been in four years.

"I'm not going to fucking 'give up' on Izuku. Not when I know he wouldn't give up on me," he tries to take a deep breath, but it doesn't help. His hands are trembling, "I thought you two out of everyone else would understand that. I'm going to see Deku again. Plain and simple." Katsuki can't be here. He needs to get out. The big house has turned claustrophobic, and is denying him the fresh air his lungs are craving. So, he does the only reasonable thing, and runs out of the house. He doesn't care that it's almost dark, or that he has no idea where his feet are leading him. All Katsuki does is let the chill air fill his burning lungs.

_____

Izuku, now disguised as Hato, is sitting in a room full of heroes. It's been four days since he's talked to Eraserhead, and less than twenty-four hours since the hero told him that the heroes agreed to create a plan to save Eri

Except, there's one problem.

Hato is a vigilante that likes to tease heroes, a lot of which are in the very room he is in. He's also a 'kid' (he's using that term loosely. What does being a kid mean, exactly? He doesn't know anymore), so he's having a rather difficult time being taken seriously.

Which, of course, pisses him off.

They're all sitting next to a long table, just like the one they used during the last timeline. The meeting started ten minutes ago, and no one knows shit about what they're talking about. Hato sighs through his mask.

Aizawa says, "Chisaki Kai is the leader of Shie Hassaikai and is holding a little girl hostage. Our goal is to save her with as little casualties as possible." Thank God for Aizawa, who has the talent to scare any hero with just a shift of his voice.

"And how are we going to do that? Use this kid," Rock Lock says as he points his thumb towards Hato, "as bait?" Hato sits up at this because that's… That's not a bad idea. Even if it was meant as an insult towards him, he doesn't care. Rock Lock can be as immature as he wants.

Some of the heroes chuckle at this, but Midnight shuts them all up, "Be quiet! We wouldn't even know about this if it wasn't for Hato. Besides, he's been known to be more capable than most of you."

Midnight is such a badass.

"We don't need this damn kid. He's going to be a liability," Endeavor shouts at what he thinks is an appropriate volume. If Hato wasn't trying to get on these heroes' good sides, then he would've kicked him in the balls right when the flaming bastard entered the room.

Liability.

He hates that word. It makes his skin tingle and chest tighten. He hates the fact that he's scared of that word; of how true it might be.

Hato opens his mouth for the first time since the meeting started. He ignores Aizawa's sigh and mutter of, "Here we go."

"Then use me as your bait. If I'm such a 'liability' , give me to Chisaki and I'll plan an escape with Eri from the inside."

"No waaaaaaayyyy, kiddo. We don't want to put people in harm's way, and that includes you" Present Mic exclaims. And Hato loves Yamada, but he can't help but be annoyed with him at the moment.

"This *whole* mission is putting us in harm's way. But everyone in this room signed up to get hurt the moment they started saving people." This causes the whole room to erupt.

"This kid is suicidal."

"He actually likes this idea?!"

"He's reckless."

"Does Hato have a death wish or something?"

They're wasting time. Why can't they just accept that he wants to help? All he's *ever* wanted to do is help. Every second they talk about if they should trust him, if he's useful, or if he's telling the truth is precious time that could be spent on creating a plan to save Eri.

Just when he thought that this was a bad idea, that maybe he should've gone about this alone is when someone who he's been trying to ignore speaks up.

"I haven't had any encounters with Hato," His booming voice causes everyone to snap their mouths shut, "but I think he's good. Why would he risk getting arrested if he wasn't speaking the truth? I can tell that all this kid wants is to save the girl, and we're wasting his time by arguing," All Might finishes. Hato's eyesight turns blurry after hearing Yagi's voice after so long, and it was used to back him up. How special, he thinks, to hear everyone's voices again. Even if those voices are from idiotic heroes.

"I trust Hato," Aizawa says. Something about Aizawa declaring his trust to him makes his heart warm up, "and I think that he'll be able to successfully do this."

"Hun, how long do you think it will take you to get all the information you need for us?" Midnight asks, sounding so motherly. Hato knows that tonight, he will cry. For a number of reasons. Seeing All Might again, Midnight reminding him of his mother (he still thinks about her every day. Still aches for her embrace), and Aizawa trusting him. Even with a room full of heroes who don't trust him, there are still who he knows are by his side. No matter who he is.

Hato clears his throat, "Two days. I just need to focus on the basics: how many people there are, what kind of quirks, and the easiest escape route." He doesn't mention the potential problem of getting Eri to come with him. She's four, a completely different person from what she was in the last period when she was six

They discuss it over for the next hour, making sure every detail is in place. They decided that the mission will start in three days, just enough time for Hato to prepare an excuse for Ru about his inevitable absence.

"It's settled then," Thirteen declares, "We meet up in three days to save Eri-Chan."

After the meeting, Aizawa pulls him to the side, "Just so we're clear, you're not going to get yourself killed, right?" There's pure worry swimming in Shota's near black eyes. Hato knows the answer, but finds it hard to open his mouth. How do you promise someone that you won't die? You can't, because life is unpredictable and it takes and takes and then takes some more.

"Of course not, old man. There's still so many people I need to save."

It's the only answer that had truth in it.

“Hey Zuzu?” Ru says right after dinner. Izuku looks up at Ru. Their hair is still the same shade of blue, but is cut into a bobbed haircut now. The hair is longer in the front than in the back, laid out in soft waves. Nothing much has changed about Arai, and Izuku is thankful for that. The cafe has grown in popularity, and they’re twenty now, but her personality is still the same. In fact, Izuku is proud to say that she seems happier now. Less lonely.

“What’s up?” It’s the night after the meeting, and Izuku is antsy. He knows that the next three days are going to be painfully slow. Not to mention he has to figure out an excuse for Ru as to why he’s going away for a couple of days (hopefully only a couple).

“I know this is last minute, but I just planned it today. My friend from high school just moved from Tokyo to about an hour away from Musutafu. I was going to go out there and spend the week with her. I’ll close the cafe, so you won’t have to worry about running it all by yourself,” Ru explains, excitement already sparkling in her eyes.

Huh. That wasn’t hard at all.

Izuku tries not to look too enthusiastic as he says, “That sounds so fun! I’m glad you get to see your friend, Ru. The free time will be good for me, too. I’ve been wanting to try out some more pastry recipes for the cafe. When will you be leaving?”

“Hopefully by tomorrow afternoon. You sure you’ll be okay? Damn, I don’t think we’ve ever spent more than a day apart! How weird.”

Ru’s right, and it will be weird. Izuku has gotten so used to always having Hotaru around with their loud laugh and boisterous attitude. At least he’ll be kept busy so he doesn’t feel alone.

Izuku nods, “I’ll be okay. Don’t worry.”

Ru squeals and starts talking about their friend and all of the things they’re going to do. Izuku listens, but it’s hard to process any information. He’s got the first step to the rescue mission done, and now he needs to prepare.

After all, he’s going against Chisaki Kai. The man who can dissemble his very being without even blinking.

Chapter End Notes

I hope everyone has an amazing holiday! No matter which one you celebrate :)

Vivamus

Chapter Summary

Izuku meets Chisaki Kai... Again

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku is terrified, and anyone who says anything different is a fucking liar. He's always scared. Whether it's an extra *thump* of his heart or a cold sweat that transitions into a storm of anxiety. He doesn't remember a time where he hasn't been scared. Perhaps that's why he's survived for so long. And it's important to know that Izuku doesn't hate fear, it reminds him that he's human, but it's not the easiest feeling to deal with.

Especially when he's supposed to be acting casual in front of a villain group.

Izuku is without a mask, wearing only black cargo pants and an oversized navy sweatshirt as protection. He has throwing knives hidden in his red shoes, but that's it. Not unless you count four quirks, but he's trying to stay discrete to remain quirkless.

It's been three days since the meeting with the heroes and everything is set in place, waiting to take motion. He has a hidden earpiece and a small black button to alert the heroes what's going on. For obvious reasons, the earpiece is to talk to heroes and to inform them of any necessary information. The black button, smaller than his thumb, is for emergencies. It'll alert any hero on the mission immediately after pushing the button down for three seconds. It also serves as the signal for when he's ready to bust out with Eri.

So here he is, standing near the front gates of Shie Hassaikai, urging his hand to move and press the doorbell. Which, to him, is so weird that a villain organization would have a *doorbell.* Who's going to ring it? The pizza man?

Breathing in, Izuku rings the doorbell. It doesn't take more than a couple of seconds for the intercom to come on, a high pitched voice speaks through, "Who are you? What do you want?"

Izuku releases his breath and pulls his shoulder back. Standing as tall as his five feet and three inches will let him. "I'm homeless, and am willing to do anything. I need a job. I don't care what it is or what kind of… *business* you need me to do," he says. His voice is desperate, but not too desperate. He has a semblance of losing control, but hasn't quite yet.

A new voice comes through the intercom. This one the exact opposite of the other person: low and impossibly scratchy. Like he screamed for hours on end and damaged his vocal cords.

“Anything, ya’ say?” The man asks.

Izuku nods even though they can’t see it, or, he doesn’t *think* they can’t see it. He didn’t notice any cameras when he scoped the place the day before.

“Yes. I’m tired of being out in the dirty streets, having people look down at me in disgust.”

“How old are ya’?” The deep voice questions.

Izuku winces at that question. He doubts that they would let a fourteen year old into Shie Hassaikai, so maybe he should lie. He does look older for his age. Maybe he could pass as sixteen.

But if they catch him on that lie? Then they would surely turn him down.

He takes the risk and answers, “Fourteen, sir.” Both of the people on the speaker laugh at this, probably thinking he’s lying. Izuku doesn’t say anything, knowing that they would find out that he was telling the truth sooner or later.

“Yeah, right,” said the squeaky voice. “You got some nerve coming here. Pretty fucking stupid if you ask me.”

Good thing Izuku didn’t ask him, then.

“Le’ me ask the boss,” the other man says. Izuku waits, hands in his sweatshirt’s pocket, trying to get them to stop shaking.

He hears footsteps coming from inside that property, and then a door closing. The steps come closer until Izuku could hear the other person’s breath and smell the sanitizer practically washed over them.

The gates open smoothly with hardly any squeaking emitting from them. Once they fully open, a man is revealed. Izuku sucks in a sharp breath, not expecting to see this man so soon.

He looks younger. His skin is smoother and not as sunken. His yellow eyes don't have the overwhelming amount of coldness to them, but only a layer of it. And he's not wearing a bird mask- not yet. Instead, it's a plain, black cloth mask.

"What's your name?" Chisaki demands. His eyes narrowed with suspicion. Izuku is reminded how fast this man could kill him.

Izuku stands firm, "Keisuke, sir." Chisaki looks him up and down, examining him. Izuku doesn't move, not even to take a breath.

"And you want a job?" Kai asks. Izuku wonders if one of the people on the intercom had a telepathy quirk; that would explain how the information traveled so fast.

Izuku nods, "Yes." He doesn't give anything else away. He probably already knows that he was 'homeless', and saying anything more than necessary might dig up holes in his story. Chisaki might be evil, but he's not stupid.

"Do you need a place to stay?" Chisaki already knew the answer, but he asked anyway. Maybe it was to see how desperate Izuku was, and how much control he could hold over him.

"Yes," Izuku says again, trying to muster any childlike innocence he might have left.

Kai hums, "Very well. A new position just opened up due to… circumstances. You can be a guard here, and sleep in one of our guest rooms." Chisaki starts to walk back to the estate, and Izuku takes that as an invitation to fall into step behind him. He doesn't need to think too hard what the 'circumstances' were.

"What do you need me to do?" Izuku asks, not knowing if asking questions will make Chisaki irritated.

He glances at Izuku, "Guard duty. Patrolling, making sure no one is acting out of line. Can you fight?"

Izuku nods, in which Kai says back, "We'll see about that."

They're inside the house now, going down a long hallway with bright, artificial lights. Izuku's nose burns with the smell of bleach. Chisaki hands him a surgical mask while they continue their walk without a word. Izuku puts it on, and he's surprised by how much he feels like Hato at this moment. A mask, no matter what kind, transforms him into someone else.

He’s not sure how he feels about that.

They take turns and twists, going down a flight of stairs. It’s the basement where they had the attack. Stone walls and tiled floors with brighter lights than the ones on ground level. Izuku wonders if this is a trap, and Kai is luring him down here as another experiment. Either way, Izuku is going to get Eri.

His sensory quirk -the first quirk he developed- hasn’t warned him of anything dangerous yet, so Izuku takes that as a good sign. They stop at a wooden door that looks like it leads to a closet, but when Chisaki opens it, Izuku finds out that the room isn’t a closet, but a small bedroom. The room reminds Izuku of the dorm room Todoroki had at the U.A. dorms, albeit less fancy. There’s a futon in a corner, and that’s about it. Another door is located to the left wall where Izuku assumes a bathroom is.

“This is where you’ll be staying for the time being. Your clothes are dirty. I’ll get Mika to grab our uniform for you.” Chisaki looks Izuku up and down again. He tries not to squirm at his scrutinizing gaze.

“What’s your quirk, Keisuke?”

Izuku looks from the room to Kai. “Don’t have one,” he says firmly. He’s said this to countless people, so the words leave his lips as fluently as breathing air.

To his surprise, Chisaki doesn’t so much as even blink at him. There’s no hint of disgust or hatred, but instead, his bird-like eyes gleam with interest.

“You’re quirkless,” he states. In which Izuku nods at him, making sure not to break eye contact.

“I am.”

“What’s that like, I wonder?” Izuku doesn’t like the tone in his voice, or how Kai straightens his spine even more than it already was. He feels like a bug under a microscope, and maybe, Izuku thinks, he’s not far off from that analogy. He doesn’t know when Chisaki started to work on quirk-erasing bullets, but having a quirkless boy will probably only let the idea fester and grow.

Izuku shrugs, “Shitty.”

They continue walking through the estate, Chisaki showing him the areas that he will be guarding. He’s to work night shifts, which will do wonders on his already screwed up, near non-existent, sleep schedule.

They pass two double doors on the left, and Izuku sees light peeping through the bottom of the doors. “What’s that room for?” he asks, already having an idea. He wonders if she’s in there right now. Is she alone? Playing with those useless toys that offer no comfort? Or is she getting torn up, only to get mended together over and over again?

Both thoughts send a tsunami of rage through Izuku. It takes everything he has to not throw Chisaki Kai against the wall and make him beg for mercy.

(That idea scares him. This isn’t who he used to be. The past Izuku would try his best to resolve issues without violence. Now, he craves to hurt those who have wronged him and those he loves. The urge to drive his fist into something over and over again until his fist is a broken, bloody mess is getting harder to resist.

When did he start to scare himself?)

“A storage closet. We have a lot of those. Nothing interesting,” Chisaki says smoothly. He offers no hint of keeping a secret in his facial expression, but Izuku notices how he speeds up in order to pass the door as quickly as possible.

They make it back to his room, “Meals will be served to your door for breakfast, lunch, and dinner. We don’t like newbies to go out until we know we can trust them, so I advise you to stay in the estate for a while.”

Izuku walks into his room and holds onto the door, ready to close it, “Sounds good to me. Thank you for welcoming me into your home.”

Chisaki turns and starts to walk away, and just as Izuku is about to close the door, Kai says one more thing, “Keisuke, I’ll have you know that betraying Shie Hassaikai’s trust will lead to severe consequences. Even if you’re a kid, the rules don’t change. I do hope you understand that.” With that, Chisaki continues to walk away.

Izuku closes the door, takes off his mask, and gets right to work. He starts to look all over for any kind of cameras that might be hidden in his room. After he’s cleared it, Izuku moves onto the bathroom. It’s small, toilet, sink, and shower all crammed together. He doesn’t find any cameras in there, either. He plops down onto the bed, and huffs once he realizes that it isn’t as plush as it looked.

Turning on the earpiece, Izuku starts to talk in soft whispers, “Made it in the Shie Hassaikai’s residence. Got a job as a night guard and had a scope of the estate. No sign of Eri-Chan yet, but might know where she is.”

“Good job, kid,” Aizawa’s voice rings through his ear. Izuku relaxes at hearing a familiar voice. “Have you met Chisaki yet?”

Izuku crawls under the thin blanket, hoping to get his mind to rest. “I have, and… he’s pretty much what I expected. He doesn’t think twice on removing those that betray him, and is determined to have things under his control.”

“Got it,” Aizawa replies, “How are you doing, Hato?” Izuku’s mind muddles at this question. What was Shota asking, exactly? How he was doing on the mission, or how *he* was? He’s not used to this question, and will probably forever be shit at answering it.

He takes the easy route, “Fine. I’m going to try to get a few hours of sleep. I don’t think I’ll be able to get any after this for a while.”

Aizawa sighs, and anxiety jolts through Izuku. Was he disappointed? He really hated when Aizawa got disappointed in him.

“Okay, kid. Try to get some rest, got it?”

Izuku scoffs, his eyelid already weighing down, “Whatever… Old man.”

Then all went black.

Aizawa couldn’t believe he agreed to this. A child. *Child.* Is doing something that most heroes wouldn’t even volunteer to do. They should have thought of something else, and not risk the life of a kid.

“What were we thinking?!” Aizawa shouts as he paces the living room of their apartment.

Hizashi frowns, “Hato would’ve gone whether or not we agreed to it. You know that, Sho.”

Silence envelopes them, but it’s not awkward. They thrive in silence- it’s the foundation of their relationship. Aizawa walks toward his husband and lets his head fall onto his chest.

“I know it’s him, ‘Zashi. Every single instinct I have is telling me that Hato is Midoriya Izuku,” Aizawa whispers, suddenly more tired than he’s ever been. He takes comfort in the sound that echoes throughout Yamada’s chest. His heart beat has always been the best music.

Hizashi wraps his arms around him, “I know. I believe you.”

“These… dreams that I’ve had. The ones with him, but a different version of him? They’re something deeper than just weird dreams. It’s- like a *memory* . I swear that these dreams actually happened. Even though they’re with people I haven’t meant, or who have grown older. Maybe I’m going crazy,” Shota forces out. He’s only told Hizashi the bare minimum of his dreams. In fact, this is the most he’s ever talked about them.

Hizashi cups his face with his hands, “You’re not crazy. After all, we do live in a world with heroes and villains. There’s not much to be surprised about.”

Aizawa chuckles dryly, placing a kiss on his husband’s lips.

He nods, making a promise to himself, “We’ll protect him, no matter who he is. Hato, Midoriya Izuku, is part of something bigger than anyone can carry by themselves. We’ll be there.”

Yamada smiles, “No matter what.”

Chapter End Notes

Hi wonderful people! How are you doing? I hope everyone has had a good start to the new year, and if not, then I'm sure it'll get better!

I hope everyone has/had a good day!

Savior Complex

Chapter Summary

Izuku gets ready to save Eri

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku wakes up at four in the morning fully awake and buzzing with energy. He gets out of his rock-hard bed and takes a shower in which the only setting is cold. He tries not to think about all the scars he's accumulated over the years. Izuku stopped bothering to keep count after he got out of the Arena, not sure why it was ever important. A deep hollow feeling swarms his chest, like there's a big gaping hole there, when his eyes catch on the angry red lines cascading against his hips. Silver scars surround the healing cuts- some long and silver, others thick and darker. The last ones were made a few days ago when he had an especially bad nightmare about Eri.

Izuku had just broken the hold the LOV had on him, and was no longer being controlled by them. He went to the first person he saw, which was Eri.

She was quiet, her eyes hollow as she laid on her knees staring at Aizawa's dead body. The life that Izuku took when he was being controlled. Aizawa couldn't bring himself to hurt Izuku, but how Izuku wished he had.

Izuku stared down at them in horror, bile burning the back of his throat. He walked towards Eri slowly and reached a hand towards her.

When she turned to look at him, it was as if she had stabbed him. Eri looked terrified. Terrified of him.

"Why? Why did you do this?" The worst part of the question was that it held no hatred in it. Instead, it was void of trust and full of sorrow no child should ever have to feel.

Izuku chokes back on a sob, "Eri-Chan. I didn't-"

Tears had finally started falling from Eri's eyes. Izuku has never seen her this devastated before.

"My papa. He's gone."

And then she was, too.

Izuku gets dressed in a black sweatshirt, gray pants, and then puts on his surgical mask before he hears a knock at the door. He looks at the digital clock on his nightstand to see that it's only four-thirty. He didn't think anyone else would be awake.

"Who is it?" He asks, voice raspy from not using it since last night.

"Irinaka, you turd," Answers a squeaky voice- the same voice that answered the gate yesterday, "I have your breakfast."

Izuku slowly opens the door, only letting enough space to see who this "Irinaka" was. It takes a moment for Izuku's mind to place his familiarity, and then he realizes that this was the person who controlled the walls at the beginning of the raid. What was his quirk called again? Izuku remembers it sounding like the word "mimic" before fully remembering that Irinaka's quirk is called Mimicry.

Izuku opens up the door wider. Irinaka is short, wearing a black bodysuit with a white mask. He's holding a bowl with what looks like to be porridge and a soft egg on top. He tentatively takes it, remembering to act like a child with no clue as to what they're supposed to do.

Izuku sniffs it using his quirk and doesn't smell anything off with it. It just smells like it looks like- porridge. Probably extremely bland porridge.

"You're a night guard, but that doesn't mean you don't have chores to do. Beginning at six, you'll be training with Tengai until nine. Then you'll meet with Chisaki."

"Why?" Izuku asks, not liking the idea of having to come into contact with Kai again so soon.

"You'll know once you get there."

With that, he leaves. Leaving Izuku alone with his plain, boring porridge.

———

Izuku finishes his breakfast (not as bad as it looked) with half an hour to kill before training, so he roams. He checks the hallways for cameras and finds about a dozen, but easily avoidable through blind spots. He increases his hearing in an attempt to hear anything that would indicate Eri was near, and is about to stop when he hears whimpering.

He looks around and doesn't see or hear anyone else, so he continues to walk closer to the whimpering. He comes to a stop right in front of the door he mentioned yesterday when Chisaki was giving him a tour. Izuku knew that this room, and perhaps many others, were more than "storage closets".

Izuku knows it's risky, but he has to see Eri and tell her that everything will be okay soon. He's here to help- to save, so he unlocks the door that surprisingly only has normal locks on it, and slowly opens the door. It's heavy, so heavy that he doubts that they would need a lock to keep Eri in.

Izuku doesn't even get to take a step inside when a small body collides into him, pushing him to the ground. Instinctively, Izuku wraps his arms around the person to protect them and gets a sense of deja vu.

He looks down to see a small girl with pale blue-gray hair that reaches to her mid-back. She's cowering. Her eyes wide and dull with fear. She must be so afraid.

Izuku knows that she's afraid of him.

"It's okay," He whispers kindly, "You're not in trouble."

Eri buries her face into his shirt, "P-please don't. I don't want to be torn up again." Eri's voice sounds more childlike at the age of five than six, but it still contains that soft, melodic tune.

It breaks Izuku's heart to see her like this, "You won't, Eri-chan. I'm here to help."

At this, Eri looks up to see who he is for the first time, and her eyes widen with still a tinge of fear, but curiosity as well.

Eri doesn't know hope yet, but Izuku wants to give that to her.

"H-help?"

Izuku nods, "I can't tell you my name yet, but as soon as we get out, I'll tell you anything you want."

At this, Eri pushes herself off of him and begins to shake her head to the side as tears spring to her eyes, "No. I can't leave. He'd only hurt me, and you. I don't want to hurt you."

He maintains an open body language, but doesn't move closer, "I'm not going to get hurt, especially not by you, Eri-chan. You're going to get out, and soon, but I need you to go back to your room so we don't get caught. Is that okay? I'm so sorry, I know you probably don't want to do that."

Eri's silent for a moment, probably processing as much as she can. "My name… How?"

Izuku realizes his slip-up, but quickly covers it up, "I have to know the name of the person I'm saving, don't I?" Before anything else happens, Izuku hears footsteps coming down the hallway, "Now, I need you to go back to your room for just a little longer. I'll be back. I promise."

Eri runs back to her room- her footsteps being impossible to hear with a normal human ear. Izuku quickly shuts and locks the door right before a guard with long, straight silver hair wearing a cloth mask makes it down the hallway.

The guard stiffens, "What are you doing here? You're supposed to be training," they yell. Izuku wonders if everyone here knows where he's supposed to be, and hopes that he'll learn where others are supposed to be, too.

He feigns sheepishness, rubbing the nape of his neck as he answers, "Sorry about that. I got lost. Can you show me where the training room is?" With this, the guard relaxes. Izuku hears her say "fucking children" under her breath and resists to roll his eyes.

"Whatever. Follow me, kid."

"Thanks!"

Walking to the training room was uneventful, thankfully. However, he did find some sort of pattern of what halls the guards go down and estimated how long it takes for each one to finish walking down one. He tried to ask what the guard shifts are like so he knew what to expect for future references, but the guard only informed him that there were people who had shifts during the day, and others during the night. Not exactly helpful.

The training room is large. Just about as big as the entire second floor space in the bakery. It's traditional- with bamboo floor mats and wooden beams. There are no windows, even though they are on ground level. The room is dim- not that lighting affects Izuku anyway.

He sees a tall man wearing a gray robe with a black sash. He's wearing a navy blue mask and has blond spiky hair. Izuku's sure he was at the raid, even though he never encountered him during the fight, he saw him get arrested.

Izuku didn't get the luxury of introductions. Instead, right when he walked into the room he was attacked. He had no time to react as he was swept off of the floor, landing hard on his back. He did a kip up, narrowly avoiding a kick to the stomach. He ducks as the clan member swipes at him. Izuku drops to a crouch and uses one of his legs to kick his attacker's feet from underneath him.

"You know me, so who are you?" Izuku says quickly as he jumps back from him.

"Tengai Hekiji." That was all Izuku got before he was back to fighting again.

Tengai did a turn jump kick, hitting Izuku right in the chest. All of the air in his lungs leaves him, and he is left gasping.

They go for a few minutes before Izuku goes in for a punch for the throat when instead of his hand meeting flesh, it meets a golden barrier. He cries out as he feels his index finger break from hitting the barrier.

"What the fu-"

“Our fight is now over,” Tengai Hekiji announces, finality in his voice.

“I can still go!” If Izuku can’t prove himself, can’t beat him, then what is he worth to the clan? What does that say about him trying to fight more of them?

“You can, but I’ve learned enough from you.” Izuku takes a sharp intake of breath. Of course that's what this was for. Tengai wanted to know his moves and style, so he could become predictable.

He reminds himself that he will never be predictable. Not with them thinking he’s a lonely, scared, quirkless boy wanting to be useful to anyone.

He composes himself, “And?”

Tengai tilts his head, “And what?”

“What did you learn? I’m here to get better, right? How am I supposed to do that when I don’t know what to improve on?”

Tengai takes a moment to consider this, and right when Izuku thinks that he won’t get an answer, Tengai says, “You’re intelligent, but reckless. You have the strength and skill, but don’t know how to truly harness it. Your mind switches right on over to sacrificing yourself to win instead of using that as a last resort. That’s what makes you beatable.”

Izuku takes a step back, unable to hold in his shock. He doesn’t know what he was expecting, but it wasn’t that. They must've been fighting for three minutes tops, how did he get that detailed of an analysis?

“And how do I fix that?”

Tengai’s cheeks lift from underneath his mask, telling Izuku that he’s smiling.

“Know what keeps you breathing.”

———

Izuku walks to his room after a few more hours of basic training and technique, pondering. Know what keeps him breathing? What is that supposed to mean?

He knows he’s reckless, but that’s okay as long as he gets to his end goal. He would take a hundred knives to the heart if it meant protecting those he loves.

By the time he takes another shower and gets dressed -almost forgetting to put a mask on-, it’s almost lunchtime. Izuku is just about to open the door to do more searching when there’s a knock on the door. He opens it thinking it’s… what’s their name? Irinaka? For another task, but instead he’s met with Chisaki.

“Hello,” He says. Voice dull. Izuku’s stomach swirls, thinking he had done something wrong.

“Do you… need something?” Izuku asks, wanting Kai to be gone as fast as possible.

“Come with me. I need to get some shopping done.”

Izuku has no choice but to follow.

———

“I thought I wasn’t allowed to go out?” Izuku asks as they exit the Shie Hassaki residency. He doesn’t know where they’re going, and because of that he’s on edge. For all that he knows this ‘shopping spree’ could be a test to see if he’s loyal or not.

Kai doesn’t even spare a glance at him, “Not without supervision. If you tried something, one of my members or myself would be able to kill you easily.” A spark of irritation lights itself up in Izuku. He hates it when

people treat him like a weak child. Yes, he can use that assumption to his advantage, but it's also severely undermining. He did not train for hours on end to be seen as weak. He's worked too hard for that.

To his surprise, they actually were going shopping. A toy store, to be more specific. Izuku knew why, but Chisaki didn't know that.

"Why are we at a toy store? I may be a kid, but I don't spend my time playing with pieces of plastic." It's one of those stores that looks really cramped from the outside, but is absolutely humongous once you go inside. The ceilings are at least fifteen feet tall and the store has two stories. Toy planes attached with invisible strings are stuck to the ceiling and are flying around. There's giant lego sculptures, expensive-looking dolls, and hero figurines that make Izuku drool.

"We're here because the kid I look after is a spoiled brat that doesn't like anything I give her," Chisaki replies, looking agitated. Izuku has to resist the urge to punch him in the face (his fingers on his right hand might be broken and throbbing, taped together, but he still has his left hand).

"Okay… So why bring me?" They're in the stuffed animal aisle now. Shelved walls filled to the brim with stuffed toys. He noticed that Kai is being extra careful in staying away from the squealing kids and exasperated parents. He sees the disgust in his eyes and takes great pleasure in knowing that Kai's extreme germophobia is making him suffer.

He grabs an All Might plushie (Izuku totally doesn't make a note in his head to come back and buy it) and destroys it with his quirk faster than a lightning strike. Izuku takes a step back warily when Kai looks at him, "Because, Keisuke, you are a kid, and therefore know what another child might like more than an adult."

"Why don't you bring the kid here with you?" Izuku tries to look innocent while asking this, but Chisaki shoots him a sharp stare anyway.

"She's shy."

Izuku wonders why. Keeping Eri isolated and abusing her wouldn't make her scared to interact with other people *at all*.

Just then, a bunny catches his eye. It's white and fat. Not overly big, but just enough where it'll offer comfort to a child hugging it. He goes over to it and touches the fur. It's incredibly soft and squishy, something he knows that Eri will love.

"This," Izuku says, grabbing the bunny off of the shelf. He hugs it, and it's perfect. He knows without a doubt that Eri is going to love it.

Chisaki doesn't try to hide his judgemental stare, "Really? A fucking bunny?" Izuku ignores his disdain and firmly nods. They walk to the cash register where the cashier refuses to meet their gaze. Her hands shake as she takes the bunny and scans it. Mumbling the price as quietly as possible.

Kai rolls his eyes and pays. With that, they walk out the door into the bright sunshine. The blossoms on the trees are just starting to show, and the sun is finally showing its warmth.

While walking back to the house -only stopping to get onigiri- Izuku braves himself for a question.

"Can I give it to her?"

"What?"

Izuku refuses to back down, "Can I give the bunny to her. She might like it more if someone closer to her age gives it to her." Not the best reasoning Izuku could've come up with, but he needs a way to earn Eri's trust as quickly as possible. No matter how little that may be.

Kai thinks for a moment, and Izuku can feel his hope fade, but then he nods, “Fine, but you’ll be watched on our surveillance system.”

Izuku smiles behind his mask, “Fine by me.”

Izuku is standing in front of Eri’s door with the bunny in his hand. He’s in a position where the camera’s can’t see him, but is well-aware that as soon as he enters the door to Eri’s room, all cameras in there will be pointed to him.

Without thinking too much about it, Izuku opens the door slowly and walks in, letting the heavy door close behind him. There’s a basic lamp illuminating the room that seems too big for one person. Too cold and desolate for a kid. The lamp is on a brown nightstand next to her bed that has a pink duvet color. On the bed sits Eri. She’s hugging her knees, her short hair hiding her face.

“Eri-chan?” Izuku says just above a whisper. He doesn’t dare come any closer. Izuku wants her to give him permission first so she can have some semblance of control.

Her head snaps up, her red eyes widening in fear, but slowly relaxing once she sees who it is. Eri is still tense and ready to bolt at any hint of ill will, but Izuku takes it as a plus that she isn’t scurrying to hide right away.

She doesn’t speak, so Izuku slowly sits down and crosses his legs. He removes his mask, not caring for what Chisaki might say about that later, and smiles gently at her. He holds up the bunny, “I got this for you.”

Eri slowly crawls to the edge of her bed to peer at it closer. She looks like she desperately wants to hold it, but doesn’t know how to ask.

“Do you want to hold it?” Izuku asks. At her hesitant nod he says, “can I come over and give it to you?”

This question takes longer for Eri to answer, but Izuku doesn’t mind. He just smiles reassuringly at her.

At Eri’s nod, Izuku gets up and slowly walks to the end of her bed and sits down on the ground right next to where Izuku is sitting on her bed. He gently gives Eri the bunny and smiles as she carefully runs her hands through the soft fur as if it’s real.

“You got this for me?” Eri asks, wrapping her arms around the plushy. The bunny makes her look even more small and lonely. Izuku wants to scoop her up and run out of this place, but knows that would be suicide.

He nods instead, “Mhm! I thought you would like it. It’s okay if you don’t, though.”

Eri shakes her head, “I like it. Thank you. Are you going to take my blood now?” She asks as if she’s asking what the weather’s going to be like. Izuku freezes, his blood running cold.

Eri notices his reaction and curls even tighter around the bunny, “I’m sorry! Did I do something wrong? I’m sorry, I won’t do it ever again. Please don’t stop being nice to me.”

Izuku quickly masks his face void of any negativity, “You didn’t do anything wrong, so please don’t be sorry. I should be apologizing- I’m the one that scared you. And no, I’m not here to hurt you or take your blood. I will never ever do that, I promise.”

She wipes her eyes and nods, but Izuku knows that she doesn’t believe him. Not yet, and probably not for a while.

“Eri, remember when I told you that I’m here to help you?” She sniffles and nods, “I’m still going to do that, and then you won’t have to worry about these people hurting you ever again.”

Eri looks about ready to say something, but there is a knock on the door and a voice saying that his time is up. Izuku's about to get up when Eri pounces on him and hugs him. Izuku's shocked for only a moment before gently wrapping his arms around her. He feels his shirt getting wet and holds her a bit tighter.

"I'll see you soon, Eri-chan." He slowly untangles himself from the hug and gets up. Izuku gazes at Eri hugging her present and lets a tear drop. Everything inside him is screaming for him to stay with Eri, but he can't, and it's killing him.

Izuku puts on his mask and walks outside the room where Irinaka is waiting for him. He makes sure his face remains neutral and nods at the smaller man.

"Dinner is next to your door and then it's time for your shift to start."

Izuku nods and starts walking towards his room, only to be stopped by Chisaki.

"Chisaki, yo!" Izuku calls nonchalantly. He ignores the fact that his heart starts trying to beat itself out of his chest.

"I see that it went well," Kai replies, his eyes remaining as soulless as ever.

"Yup! She's a really sweet girl." Izuku wants to get this over with as soon as possible. His hands are trembling with the need to punch him, and God knows that wouldn't go over well.

"I have a special assignment for you tomorrow," this makes Izuku go still. His racing heart drummed in his ears.

He tilts his head, "Yeah? What is it?"

"I've always been interested in the quirkless, so I thought we could perform some harmless experiments." The glint in his eyes tells Izuku that these experiments aren't going to be harmless whatsoever. Images of getting blood drawn, or being torn apart and put back together again assault his mind. A chill runs down his spine, fear being splashed over him

If that happens, Izuku's scared that he won't ever be able to get out of there with Eri.

"Oh, okay. I guess that seems interesting."

Chisaki looks him over, "I'll be at your room early in the morning. Be ready."

Izuku mocks a salute as Kai walks past him, and only continues the walk to his room until he can no longer see Kai.

Once he gets to the room Izuku crumbles to the ground, gasping for breath. His hands are shaking like miniature earthquakes, and it takes him multiple times to make a call on his earpiece.

"Problem child," Aizawa greets. Izuku's throat is locked and he can't get any words in, so Aizawa talks again, "Hato, you there? What is it?"

Izuku forces his mouth to form words, although it's a lot harder than it should be, "Change of plans."

Aizawa, alarmed, says, "What the hell do you mean?" "We're leaving tonight."

Chapter End Notes

I am SO SO SO sorry for not updating in FOREVER. Oh my god, life has been, well, life. Which is to say chaotic and messy. Lots of things have happened, some good, some not so much. While this chapter has taken me a long time to write, it gave me a distraction and something to worked toward to that wasn't my endless school assignments that just get replaced with more as soon as I finish one.

I'll try to update as soon as I can, but just know that I'm going to finish this story.

I love all of you!

Bleeding Out

Chapter Summary

The Battle begins

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku was dizzy and choking on air. His eyesight was blurred, and it took him a minute for him to realize that he was crying.

What was happening to him? Why was he so… Terrified?

Izuku sees Nighteye's body barely holding together, skin as pale as snow. Mirio's bloody, haggard, body. He feels the nightmares that kept him up weeks on end and Eri's fear that faded, but always lingered.

This is happening. Again. Only differently. Izuku slaps his cheeks hard enough to sting for a few moments afterwards and gets up from the ground. He puts on his purple sweatshirt and black cargo pants that he snuck in with his backpack. He slips the throwing knives into the little slips on his pants and straps his bo staff to his back. Finally he puts on his black kitsune mask, feeling the shield of strength that comes along with it.

He grabs the rest of his belongings and with one last breath, opens the door.

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The heroes are gathered a mile down the residence forty-five minutes after Hato's call. Right after Hato hung up, Aizawa scrambled into action. Texting the hero group chat for this mission and telling his husband what's about to go down.

They're out the door in less than five minutes.

"How do we know he's ready for us?" Mirko asks. They're all in a hero residency building preparing to rush toward the scene as soon as queued.

“He’ll press the button we gave him, and will help sneak us as vigilant as possible,” Aizawa replies. He jumps at every little sound, every little *itch* . His body is screaming at him to run over to Hato right now and get him away from the danger.

But that won’t do anything good.

“Great, so we have to trust that he won’t get killed in the meantime,” Endeavor grunts, irritable at any time of the day.

Shota ignores him.

———

Hato takes his first step out of his room and snaps the nearest camera close to him, It dangles from the wire uselessly. This is when time heightens in importance: it won’t take long for them to notice the cameras going out.

Every step he takes is another camera broken. He sees a night shift guard and with a tilt of his head, the guard is slammed against the wall, knocked out.

Hato starts to pound his feet against the floor faster. He’s close to Eri when he runs into Irinaka.

“Keisuke, hey! Did you get lost or something? Your area is over there,” the short man says as he points in the opposite direction.

Hato just takes another step, and Irinaka finally sees what he’s wearing, and tenses.

“I’ve heard about you… You’re that Hato vigilante, right? What the hell were you thinking sneaking into this base, huh? I’m going to kill you!” It is then that Irinaka transforms into his true form and is no longer in his black bodysuit. He gets taller and muscular, his hair showing in great blond spikes.

Hato doesn’t even flinch. He stares as Irinaka takes control of the floor and, like a shockwave, it comes waving at him. Hato starts running towards it. He grabs his bo staff and uses it to catapult himself up and over the shock wave. Once he lands, he pivots to face Irinaka while grabbing a throwing knife and throws it at the villain. It hits him right in the thigh, making him scream out in pain.

“You son of a-” He wasn’t able to finish his sentence because within seconds Hato was in front of him with the staff swinging forward. It hits Irinaka right on the temple, knocking him out for a good while. Hato yanks out the knife, wiping the blood off on Irinaka’s shirt before putting it back into its secure place.

Without taking a breath, Hato continues on sprinting. He reaches Eri’s door -making sure to destroy all the cameras as he does- and opens the door.

“Eri?” He whispers. The room is dark, but it only takes a split second for his eyes to adjust. He sees her asleep in her bed and releases a sigh of relief, thankful that he got to her before Overhaul did.

His feet carry him to her bed and puts a hand on her shoulder, shaking her gently. Eri’s eyes snap open and she’s about to protest until she sees Hato.

Even with his mask on, she says, “The Kind Boy.” Hato nods, smiling beneath his mask, and gently scops her up into his arms.

“Are we leaving?” She asks, wide awake.

“Yes.” Hato starts to run again, heading towards the entrance of the house.

“Where to?” Hato makes sure her head is buried in his shoulder so he doesn’t have to see him knock out the guards walking the hallways.

“Home.”

He presses the back button.

_____

Back with the heroes, a blaring alarm goes off.

“Why is it so damn loud?!” Death Arms scowls. Eraserhead pulls out a small black box- almost like a walkie-talkie- and presses the side button five times, indicating that he got the message and shutting the sound off.

Eraserhead looks up at the crowd of heroes, some he's never even talked to until this moment.

"It's time."

Hato runs, taking guards out without a hint of mercy. Eri is clutching his sweatshirt as tightly as her ting fists allow, her mid-shoulder-length getting tangled in the chaos.

He makes it to the entrance and bursts outside in the gardens. He's so close yet so far to the entrance. Hato can see it, and if he can see it, then he can grab the invisible line that his mind allows him to see and yank the doors open. He and Eri could escape.

Only, that doesn't happen, because what seems like all of Chisaki's most trustworthy members are there, guarding the entrance.

And right up front is Chisaki Kai himself. Bathed in the moon's luminescent glow, his eyes shining like stars ready to create a supernova. Hato grips Eri tighter, nearly covering her with his arms.

"Chisaki," Hato growls out. His voice was a stranger to his own ears, the roughness of it scratching at his throat.

Overhaul stares at him blankly, but he knows anger when he sees it. Has experienced it from himself and the hands of others too many times.

And this is anger. Rage burning white-hot. It is seeping out of Kai, infecting everyone else around him- fueling them. Hato gulps. He can't take this many alone, especially not with a child in his arms. He had trouble fighting Overhaul last time *with* One For All, and the training session with Tengai… At least he can use his quirks now, but it won't be enough.

Finally, Chisaki speaks up, his voice low, "How *dare* you. I let you in this house and gave you an opportunity most won't even know to dream of, and you *throw it away* ?! Into a flaming pile of shit like it's nothing?! "

"There was nothing for me to throw away. I'd never join you. What you did to Eri-Chan was inexplicable… Nothing is going to burn except for you."

And those were the last words spoken before all hell broke loose.

Tengai ran after him first, a barrier surrounding him and the others following suit. Hato's head was already starting to pound intensely from over exertion of his quirk, but like all things, he pushed past it.

Hato reaches for one of the large oak trees that are in the garden, and with all of his strength, he *pulls.* Tengai and the others stop running once they notice the tree shaking, not knowing it was Hato's doing. The soil starts to tear, roots springing up like flowers. His head was pounding, vision going blotchy. He feels something wet drop from his nose, and knows it's blood.

Hato keeps on going.

The tree rises from the ground, levitating from the ground. The villains look between the tree and the vigilante. Tengai starts to strengthen the barrier, focusing on himself while weakening the other's.

With a swing of his left hand the tree goes borrowing towards them, along with the group surrounding Chisaki. The tree, like a baseball bat. Hits the members closest to him, breaking everyone's shields except for Tengai's and sends them flying into the air.

Most of the people furthest from him are unscathed, Tengai only being quirk-exhausted. Hato himself is panting, ears ringing too loud to hear anything else. He sees Chisaki's lips move, but it's all white noise.

More villains start coming when his knees start to shake, Eri sobs into his chest.

"Don't worry," he says as he gips her tighter "I got you."

It's at that moment that the heroes arrive. The gate breaks off of its hinges, falling on top of a few members. Hato breathes a sigh of relief once he sees Eraserhead at the center of it all. They make eye contact, and Hato briefly thinks that he sees a flash of worry cross his face, but dismisses it.

He's struggling to stand, but he finds something in himself to keep on moving even when all he wants to do is fall. He grabs the hunters knife that was tucked away in his shoe, and shifts Eri to piggyback.

"Just hold on, Eri-Chan." He briefly registers her nod, and looks up to see a helicopter above them. The new broadcasters have already found out about this raid, and it's definitely going to be broadcasted all over the city.

The fight continues. Villains and heroes blending together into a blur. He sees flames, bunny ears, a machine, and threads all work together to fight the villains. Aizawa appears next to him, scarf at the ready. He takes out the Yakuza thugs with the help of Hato and his staff. One of the thugs knicks his hamstring with a knife, but Hato barely notices it. It's barely deep enough to bleed, and won't leave a scar.

"How are you holding up?" Eraserhead says as he stomps on one of the thugs for safety measure.

"Never better," Hato grits out, but even he finds the statement incredibly fake. His ears aren't ringing as bad as before, but the migraine has taken up every part of his brain, making him want to puke. "We have to get to Overhaul. If we take him out, then everyone else will fall. We need to end this now, so he won't be able to hurt anyone else ever again."

Eraserhead gives him a once over, a look that he's given both Hato and Izuku. He thankfully decides not to say anything about Hato's state. He looks at Eri as well, and a weird expression crosses his face- something that Hato doesn't have the time to decipher.

They make eye contact, and then they run. Chisaki is standing in the middle of the chaos, smiling underneath his mask.

Shota erases Overhaul's quirk, and Hato sees the exact moment Overhaul notices that he is powerless. Hato holds up the knife and aims for his shoulder, but he dodges. Hato grunts in pain when something hits him, and he hears Eraserhead shout. The pain is overridden by adrenaline and the need to save, save, save.

He uses his telekinesis and yanks Kai to the ground. Hato hears Eraserhead run into someone, attacking them. Who, Hato doesn't know, and doesn't care.

But it means that Eraserheads eyes aren't on Overhaul anymore. Hato cusses eternally , and before Kai notices that his quirk is back, he brings the knife down to his shoulder.

"You'll have to kill me before I stop!" Overhaul strains. Hato grabs him by the collar and headbutts him.

They both grunt in pain, "I won't kill you." Aizawa, now done with his own fight with Chronostasis, tosses him a pair of quirk-erasing cuffs. Hato catches them, and just as he feels the searing pain of being disassembled, he puts the cuffs on him then smashes Kai's head against the ground, thus knocking him out.

He stands up, noticing that most of the other members have been taken down by the heroes. He looks at Aizawa and gives a thumbs up. He gently kneels down to the ground and lets Eri go. He turns to face her, and there are tears streaming down those red-apple eyes.

“Are you okay?” He asks gently. It probably doesn’t sound as comforting as he would have hoped, but it seems to relax Eri. Or maybe it’s the fact that everything is finally over.

“Y-your name. Can you tell me now?” Eri whispers, fear still etched into her voice.

Hato laughs, “Okay. Know that you have to call me Hato when you’re talking about me, or if I’m wearing this mask. Do you think you can do that?”

Eri nods, “Hato.”

leans in closer so no one else can hear, “But my real name is Midoriya Izuku. Deku is what special people call me.” It feels foreign to say Deku. No one has called him that in years, and it feels like a home he forgot existed.

“Am I special?” Eri asks with an amount of self-consciousness that no one her age should possess.

“You are perhaps the most special of them all.” And for the first time since he’s seen her, Eri smiles genuinely. Nothing big, but it’s real, and that’s enough.

Hato stands up from his crouched position and lends Eri his hand. They start walking towards Shota and Hizashi when he feels a wetness on his sweatshirt. Shota starts running towards them when the pain becomes clear.

He remembers the burning sensation he felt when he was attacking Kai, and how Eraserhead shouted. He remembered that Chronostasis carried a gun with him.

Hato’s hand is red from his sweatshirt.

The last thing he thought before he fell was that if he died, at least no one else did.

_____

Aizawa sees him fall. It's like slow motion- his body losing its fight with gravity, Eri's mouth falling open, her arms wrapped around herself before she follows Hato and starts shaking him,

He runs over to him, sliding onto his knees and immediately pulls his sweatshirt up to put pressure on the wound. He tries to ignore the other scars that the young boy owns and the blood seeping through his fingers.

"We need medical attention now!!" Besides him Eri is crying, and Present Mic tries to comfort her, but nothing can tear her eyes away from the person who saved her.

He sees the police come and take the villains away, Overhaul shouting vile curses, but no sense of relief fills him- only dread. It seems like an infinite amount of time has passed before the rescue team comes over and starts to do emergency treatments on Hato.

"We need to take him to the hospital. He's sustained a lot of minor injuries as well, along with what seems to be massive quirk exhaustion," A person with snakes for hair says. Aizawa nods and watches as they load him onto the stretcher.

"Where are they taking him?" Eri screeches, sounding panicked, "I need to go with him, please!"

It's at this moment that Aizawa decides that sending him to the hospital will only end in disaster. They're going to remove that mask, and the only outcome of that will be chaos.

He'll need to mediate it.

Shota bends down to Eri's trembling form and says, "You are so, so brave, and I need you to be brave for just a little longer. Hato is going to be okay- he always is. Yamada here is going to meet us at the hospital, and you'll be able to see Hato in a few hours. I promise that once today is over, we'll give you so much to smile about."

Eri sobs, and it breaks his heart, but he has to go. Yamada steps besides Eri and offers her his best, warmest smile. Aizawa hops into the ambulance and then they are zooming to the nearest hospital.

And there, on the stretcher is Hato.

Without his mask.

Katsuki stares at the TV in shock.

"What the fuck?" He says, his parents for once not commenting on his inappropriate language.

On the TV is a sky view of Shie Hassaki, and the battle that is taking place there. Katsuki had never seen anything like it before. Heroes he both knows and has never seen before are battling members of the clan, and in the middle of it all is a masked boy that can't be older than him. He's holding a staff and is running towards a tall man with a black mask. He has never seen this boy before, but he feels connected to him somehow. Katsuki cries out when he sees the boy get shot, but he doesn't seem to notice it because he keeps on fighting.

The battle is soon over, and the boy collapses. Katsuki feels his chest clench and his hands pop with many explosions. Something about seeing that kid collapse made him so incredibly angry and worried at the same time. The confusion only made it worse.

I'm going out on a run," he says as he gets up from the couch.

"Oh no you don't," his mother says to him, her voice firm.

"Huh?! Why not?" Katsuki needs to get out. He has so much energy and needs to get it out- it's becoming a problem. He trains for hours, but he still feels a swirl of anxious energy even when his muscles shake with strain and his eyes burn with exhaustion.

"Did you not just see the TV? I'm not letting you go outside when something like that just happened. It's not safe."

Without giving his parents another look, he stomps upstairs and slams the door to his room. Immediately, he starts to punch his punching bag with every ounce of strength he has.

It's only a year until the entrance exam, and he's still not where he should be. It's never enough. How will he be able to protect Deku if he can't even get a handle on making his quirk stronger, better, and longer-lasting? These things that he thought would be straightforward are instead a maze, and he's so done with it all. He doesn't know what he's feeling anymore. Everything is a swirl that is impossible to separate and it makes him lash out, always having to do *something.*

He stops punching the bag, sweat running down his forehead. Lately, everything has felt off. As if his body isn't his own and he isn't where he should be. Bakugou has felt like this his entire life, but it's getting stronger. Something big is missing, and it only adds to the weight on his chest.

And then there's that thought: the one that makes him flinch. The fear that has been latched onto him like a leech for the past several years.

What if Deku never comes back?

Chapter End Notes

:)

Counting the Days

Chapter Summary

Izuku is not okay with Aizawa knowing his identity.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku wakes up in pain.

Which, to say, is not an uncommon occurrence. But this pain was all over his body with occasional stabs of agony when he breathed too deeply, not the usual soreness. He rapidly blinks his eyes as he tries to wave the sleepiness away, like fanning fog.

Once he is no longer half-asleep, he doesn't even need his sight to know exactly where he was. The scratchiness of the blankets, something squeezing his finger, the strong smell of cleanliness.

A hospital. He was in a fucking hospital. That's when the memories came crashing down on him: the battle, Eri, the pain of getting shot.

His mask. He didn't have his mask.

Izuku shoots up from bed in a panic, but is soon greeted by white-hot pain. He winces as his eyesight blotches and lies back down on the stiff pillow.

"You shouldn't do that," said a rough voice. Izuku snaps his head to the left and sees a face that utterly terrifies him at that moment: Shota Aizawa.

He knows .

He hadn't noticed him when he first woke up, too distracted by where he was to think about who else might be here. Who might know who he was. Izuku thought he was panicking before, but he was wrong. Now, all he could think was *shit, shit, shit, shit.*

Izuku jumps out of bed, and almost passes out in the process, but he doesn't fall. He rips out the IV and takes off the oximeter on his finger. He's wearing a hospital gown with his vigilante outfit on the chair opposite of Aizawa. His backpack is there, too.

He takes a step towards the window, knocking a vase with pretty white lilies in it to the ground. He doesn't have the energy to care at the moment, only being able to think about how to escape. Everything else will come later. He knows that his scars are on full display, and not just the ones that he gained from being a vigilante or in the arena, but the self-inflicted ones as well.

Aizawa stands up slowly. Oh how Izuku hates being treated like a wild animal. It's happened a substantial amount.

"Midoriya," he starts, and any hope that Aizawa wouldn't recognize him vanishes, "It's okay. You need to lie down so you don't rip the stitches."

Like Izuku cares about ripping a few stitches. He needs to get back to the cafe before Ru gets home and then avoid Aizawa for as long as possible. But then Eri flashes through his mind, and his goal of escaping is temporarily replaced by another one.

Izuku takes another step back to keep his difference, but Aizawa just takes one forward. He lets out an irritated sigh and runs his hand through his thick curls.

"Eri," he says.

Aizawa's face contorts into something he can't quite decipher. It almost looked akin to shock, or even pride, and neither made any sense.

"She's safe. Just finished her check up. You were out for twelve hours."

Izuku relaxes a tiny bit knowing that Eri is okay. "Where is she now? You better not have left her alone, or with someone I don't know."

"She's with Yamada in the waiting room, sleeping." Shota takes another step closer and Izuku pins him with a glare as he does. It doesn't seem to affect him much to Izuku's dismay. "Look, we need to talk about you. You've been missing for over five years. Bakugou still goes to the police station to see if they've found anything."

Izuku winces, but it's not because of his injuries. The comment of Kacchan hurt him more than any bullet ever could. What added to the pain was the fact that Aizawa did it on purpose- he knew that comment would hurt him.

He saw the guilt on Shota's face, but Izuku didn't offer forgiveness. His identity was revealed and he needed to get out of this hospital as soon as possible.

"Midoriya, it's going to be okay. Where are you staying?" Izuku's eyes narrowed as he saw Aizawa press a button on his phone. Maybe to alert someone? Probably Present Mic, or someone else Eraserhead trusted. Midnight? Nezu?

Like hell Izuku was going to tell him where he was staying, even if it was to ease his worry that he wasn't living in some shitty alleyway. And how *dare* Shota claim that it was going to be okay? He knew nothing, and he had absolutely no right to say that everything was going to be okay when nothing *ever* seemed to go right. In order for Izuku to earn something good, something horrible has to happen. Saving Eri equals his identity being revealed, winning a fight against a harmful person gifts him with scars, befriending Tomoura just to have him taken away by All For One. It never stopped.

Knowing that Shota has seen his quirk (the healing one has well), Izuku uses that to his advantage and lifts his hand to catch the bundle of clothes and yellow backpack that comes flying towards him.

"Leave me alone, Eraserhead. It's not time yet."

Because it always came back to time, didn't it? Years, months, weeks, minutes, seconds. Izuku was always running to keep up with it, but it never ended. It was infinite.

He was close enough to the window that he could see that he was a couple of stories up. In just a glance, he analyzed that he could jump and use the ledges of the building to slow down his fall. He'd be okay.

"Izuku," the use of his first name caught him off guard, but the look on Aizawa's face increased that shock tenfold. He looked almost desperate, and so incredibly worried. Izuku felt tears gather up in his eyes. He wanted to be with Aizawa, Hizashi, and Eri so bad that he felt nauseous. He wanted to be himself around them, and not a fake facade behind a mask.

But he couldn't; not yet.

"Stay. We'll take care of you and help you with whatever is going on. Something's happening, am I right? I don't know what it is, but I feel like I should. Midoriya, I have memories of you that have never happened. Can we talk about this?"

Izuku couldn't believe it. Aizawa said he had *memories* from something that hasn't happened yet. It has to be memories from the other timeline, but how? Was it a loophole in the quirk?

He has to get out. Staying would only mess things up further. It might completely blotch his meeting with All Might, or it could gain AFO's attention. Neither could he risk happening.

Izuku shatters the window with his staff and jumps on the windowsill with his bare feet. He looks back at Shota, and loses control of a stray tear.

"I'm trusting you with Eri. I have some things I have to do first, so this is goodbye.

He jumps.

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Aizawa breathes a sigh of relief as he looks up at the blooming cherry blossoms lined throughout the park. Izuku and Eri were a few feet ahead of him hand in hand. Eri was laughing at something Midoirya had said, and it was wonderful to hear the chimes of Eri's laugh. It was a sound that he didn't get to hear often, but something Midoriya had such an ease of creating.

It was Izuku's idea to take them out to a cafe he's been to a couple of times. Aizawa was hesitant at first- nothing ever seemed to go well when they went outside of the school's campus, especially if the problem child was involved. But this particular student was incredibly stubborn to a surprising degree that contradicted his timid personality.

He finally won Shota over when he said, "Sensei! The cafe isn't just a regular cafe… It's a cat cafe!"

"Cats?" Was his reply. The problem child had had the audacity to smirk mischievously after that, knowing that he had won.

Besides, the kid needed a break, and Eri adored him. There was also the opportunity of seeing cats and getting coffee in the same *setting.*

They walked past the park towards a cottage styled building that looked more like a house than anything else. It was painted baby blue with white edges. Purple flowers were overflowing from the wooden boxes attached to

the deck's railings. The white fence surrounding the house provided an area where beautiful vines grew. In the front yard to the right of the entrance was a sign that said Purple Majesty: Cat Cafe.

Izuku and Eri were skipping up the stairs with Aizawa not too far behind him. As soon as they entered, a girl working the counter looked up and smiled, "Midoriya, hi! I haven't seen you in ages." The girl was in her early twenties with lilac hair in a braided crown and eyes that looked exactly like opals.

Midoriya scratched the back of his head, "Haha, yeah… I've been pretty busy."

"Hero stuff I bet?"

"You could say that," Izuku then gestured to Eri and Aizawa, "This beautiful young lady is Eri, and this is my Sensei, Aizawa. Guys, this is Imai Ninako. She's the owner of this cafe." At that moment a fluffy gray cat jumped on Izuku's shoulders, "Ayla! How are you doing girl?" Izuku asked before putting the cat into Eri's arms. Her eyes sparkling with the want to hold the fluffy creature, but not knowing how to ask. Her face lit into a bright smile as soon as the cat, Ayla, snuggled up next to her in her arms.

Aizawa looked around and noticed that there were cats everywhere. In cubbies, beds, couches, customer's laps. There were so many different kinds and ages. To say the least, Shota was glad he came.

Imai laughed, "She missed you. Do you want your usual?"

Izuku nodded, "Yes please! Eri will have your famous apple cider with a twist." Izuku leans in towards Aizawa, "The 'twist' part is vanilla ice cream. I always get the Purple Majesty, it's what this cafe is known for. It's a tea, though, so if you're looking for coffee a great choice would be the lavender iced white mocha, or the mint cold brew, but there's also-"

Aizawa put a hand on Midoriya's shoulder and looked at Imai, "A black coffee, please." Imai makes a hand salute and runs up to the cash register. Midoriya digs for his wallet, but Aizawa beats him to it and puts his card down on the table.

"Sensei, it was my idea to come here. Let me pay."

"Too late." Izuku looked like he was about to argue further, but must've known it was futile because he just smiled.

"Thank you."

“You’re welcome, Problem Child.”

Aizawa had a pleasant time at the cafe, perhaps the best day he’s had in a while. Today, Midoriya seemed more relaxed than he ever has before, and it made him wonder what caused the boy to always be so stressed and anxious all of the time. It must’ve been exhausting.

Aizawa smiled to himself. He’ll just have to allow more of these outings. He could always use the excuse of needing some good coffee since the school was half-decent at best.

But they never got the chance to go to that cafe again. Because it was only a couple weeks later that everything went to hell.

Aizawa crumples to the ground, still in the hospital room. It felt like hours had gone by, but in reality it was hardly a minute. The memory had come in a flash, like a dream.

Shota took a deep breath. He had to find Midoriya. He started to alert the nurses that he ran away, and then told Yamada what had happened, Eri still asleep in his arms.

Yamada’s face contorted into worry, “He can’t get that far with all of those injuries… Can he?”

Aizawa doubted it, but he also had no idea where the kid was staying, which was a problem in itself.

“He was so close, but I let him slip. And he *knew* , ‘Zashi. He knew what I was talking about when I mentioned the memories. He looked terrified. And the *scars* . He had so many of them, and some were clearly self-inflicted. We need to help him. Hato, Midoriya, it doesn’t matter. We need to save this kid.”

His husband placed a kiss on his forehead before they began to walk outside of the hospital. Shota had just signed the papers that had to do with Izuku’s stay, and also put him down as his emergency contact. That way if Midoriya was ever admitted into any hospital, the hospital would be able to contact him.

“We found him once. We’ll find him again,” Yamada said with calm reassurance.

Aizawa sighs for what feels like the millionth time that day, “Guess I have a few phone calls to make.”

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Izuku falls onto his bed with a grunt. Ru was supposed to arrive today from visiting their friend, and thankfully wasn't here yet. Izuku slowly turns so he's laying on his back and takes off his hospital gown. Right above his left hip bone is a line of stitches. Beads are welling up between the threads, and Izuku curses. The pain was making him loopy, and he couldn't possibly act normal around Ru while his stitches were on the verge of ripping. He also saw bruises littering his stomach and legs of varying shades of purple, red, and nasty green. He was going to be sore for days, probably even weeks.

Izuku crawls off his bed and shuffles to his bathroom on his hands and knees, grabbing his pajamas that he forgot to pick up and bringing them with him. There was no way he could trust himself with standing up. He was lucky that the hospital he was at was only a few blocks from the cafe, and don't get him started on how difficult it was to sneak around in a hospital gown. If it were any further he would have passed out in an alleyway somewhere, and that never led to anything good. He makes it to the bathroom and opens the bottom cabinet for his medicine supplies. He pops two pills of ibuprofen and swallows them dry. He grabs antibiotic ointment, superglue, gauze, and tape. He didn't have energy to reduce the stitches, so he hastily puts the ointment on his wound and then the superglue; he'll deal with removing the stitches for later. He then puts some gauze onto the wound to keep it clean and keeps it in place with the tape. He's going to have to remove it every day to ensure it won't get infected.

The whole process was going to be a pain in the ass.

Once Izuku was done, he forced himself to go downstairs to get something to eat. His stomach was growling at him, and he knew if he didn't feed himself right now he would just regret it later. He grabs a plate and places three sakura mochis on it. Was it the most nutritious meal? No, and he didn't care. It was a comforting snack, as well as his own creation. It was served every Thursday for customers and was always sold out. He had gotten the idea because it was Uraraka's favorite dessert, and creating it felt like he was still a part of her life, even if she didn't know him yet.

He brought the plate up to his room along with a mug full of jasmine green tea with a hint of honey. As he ate, his mind began to wonder. Aizawa knew who he was, and that definitely was a cause to worry about. Eraserhead could do a number of things now that he knew for sure that he was alive. Telling the Bakugou's (Izuku wouldn't be surprised if he already has), opening the investigation and putting posters up, telling Nezu (this could be really bad because Nezu knew everything, and what he didn't know, he would in a matter of time).

It would also make being a vigilante harder now. He couldn't work with Eraserhead anymore, so while he's fighting villains and saving people, he's also going to hone in his senses even further in order to try and avoid the underground hero. It was going to be exhausting.

At least Eri was safe. Izuku would've done everything over and over again if it meant that she was safe. He didn't regret it, and never would.

Just as he takes his last bit of his mochi, he hears the door to the entrance open and Ru calls out, “Izzzuuuuuu!!! I’m home!”

Izuku smiles before slowly getting out of bed. He had missed Ru, and was excited to see her again. He just wished he didn’t feel like he just got run over by a truck.

He stumbles down the stairs with his empty plate and puts it in the sink. He sees Ru in the living room saying hi to all of the cats. All of them were begging for their attention as they fought to get the most pets.

“Ru! You’re back!” Arai stands up and grins at him before attacking him with a hug. Izuku almost screamed in pain, but withheld it by biting hard on his tongue. He returns the hug with just as much force before letting go and asks, “How was the trip?”

This gets Ru off on a tangent, their arms gesticulating wildly in the air, “Oh, it was fantastic! I hadn’t seen her in such a long time and you wouldn’t believe it when I tell you how cute her pugs are. Two chunky little fellas that looked like their faces were smacked by a frying pan.”

Izuku smiles, embracing the energy that is Ru.

His identity might’ve been revealed, and things might get harder, but at least he had this moment.

He would take it.

Two months later, he was standing near the entrance to a tunnel. He hadn’t been here since *that day* , and a part of him that still revolted from anything slimy or jello-like urged him to run. But he stayed in place.

Afterall, this was the day he had been waiting for. He looked up as a green wall of slime appeared above him, and he glared at it right in the eyes.

“Bring it on.”

Chapter End Notes

I hope this chapter is okay :)

Revelation

Chapter Summary

Izuku finally gets to see All Might… and someone else

Chapter Notes

Izuku's quirks (because I was stupid and completely forgot that one existed)
Telekinesis: Can make any being move on its own. It's harder the bigger the object is. Too much use will result in extreme migraines and bloody noses (I'm just now seeing the connection to this and Stranger Things)
Enchanted Senses: He can hone in on his senses, making them super human. Can cause overstimulation and pain if used too strongly. Also gives him a danger sense, usually Izuku describes it as a "whisper" in the back of his head.
Healing: He can heal someone else's injuries, but in return, he feels the pain of the injury (ex. when Ru got shot, and he healed it, he later felt like he got shot.)
Invisibility: Izuku can turn invisible, but only if no one was aware he was already there in the first place, then they're able to see him. If someone becomes aware that he's there, then he becomes visible again as well.

Hope that helps!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You're going to be a worthy sacrifice, kid. Thank you," the sludge villain yells as he grows like a tsunami, waiting to collapse.

"We'll see about that." Izuku gets into a fighting stance. But before he could do anything, he heard the whipping of the wind. Something, *someone,* was moving at incredible speeds.

Izuku knew who it was, but the loud exclamation of, "I AM HERE!" still made him pause in surprise. He knew he was going to see *him* today, but the reality of it hadn't truly sunk in. He was finally going to see him:

The number one hero. All Might.

Just like before, All Might trapped the villain into a plastic water bottle with practiced ease. Izuku stared, always and forever amazed by the being that is the Symbol of Peace. He wished he had a notebook in his hand to ask for an autograph. He cursed himself for forgetting it.

Hopefully he'll have another chance to ask.

All Might smiled at him, standing tall with both hands on his hips. The epitome of a superhero. The sun reflected off his grin, nearly blinding Izuku.

"Young man, are you alright?" Izuku nodded, trying to find any sort of words. This was not the time to stop functioning. *Damn his fanboy antics.*

All Might looked like he was about to say something, but then stopped, frowning. Izuku frowned back, not knowing what was wrong.

"Young man, have we met?" Izuku froze. They've met a couple times years and years ago. He didn't think All Might would remember him. Let alone recognize him. It was also when All Might was in his regular, skeleton form.

Izuku decided to be honest, "A few times, I think. It was a very long time ago, though. I'm surprised you remember."

His eyes seemed to light up from recognition, but his frown deepened, "Perhaps…" He smiles, but it's forced, "Weird. I think I've had a few dreams about you, but you were a tad bit older. Funny how the mind does that."

Izuku tries to hide his shock. Was Yagi experiencing something like Aizawa was? The memories? If so, what were they seeing?

All Might takes a step back, holding up the bottle with the villain as a gesture, "Well, I better get going. I have to report this to the police. Take care, Young Midoriya!" Izuku's breath gets caught in his throat. Did All Might even realize he said his name? Even though he hasn't told him yet? There's no way he could remember his name from years ago when he barely even remembered meeting him.

The realization that All Might was about to leave creeped up on him. This was not how he planned this to go at all. He reaches out, "Wait!"

"Sorry, Kid! I don't have time for fans right now, but your support is much appreciated!"

All Might jumps.

And Izuku grabs on.

_____

Young Midoriya. Suddenly, the memories come back. The ones that show the boy that is now holding onto his leg as they fly through the air.

Yes. The boy he is so very fond of, even though he's only met him a few times, when he was shorter and more child-like. He's the boy that he's had dreams of, though not in years. The one who seems so important, and has been written down in his journal. He realizes the dream-like memory about when they supposedly first met was very much like what had just occurred not even a minute prior. The sludge villain, the tunnel, and a young boy clinging to his leg…

This boy -Young Midoriya- was his future successor. At least, that's what everything seemed to tell him. His quirk giving him messages, the only time to do so, about the boy.

But how could he be certain that this boy was going to be a hero? He had the gut instinct, the memories (they were memories… right?), the whispers, but what about the physical proof?

"Kid?! What the hell are you doing?! Let go!" All MIght realized he was running out of time. Blood was dripping on his chin. He had to get away so this kid didn't see who he really was. The man behind the costume.

"I need to talk to you!" He said, or at least tried to say. The wind was blowing his face back, his cheeks wobbling comically, "Besides, if I let go now, I'll die!"

Shit. This kid has a point.

He lands on a rooftop.

He doesn't have much time left.

_____

Izuku falls on his butt as they land on a rooftop. *The same rooftop as before.*

Once Izuku gets to his feet he looks back at All Might and is not surprised to see Yagi Toshinori in his place. The skeleton-looking man is sitting with his back resting against the corners of the roof; he looks tired and confused.

"Look, I know this might come as a surprise, but-" Yagi starts to say before Izuku cuts him off.

"Yagi." The hero's head snaps up, and Izuku panics. He had this whole speech planned about how he knew about One for All and that he was connected to it, but his mind was running a blank. All he could think about was *do you remember this?* Could *you remember?*

"How do you know… You know me." What started as a question became a statement. All Might might not understand entirely, but he wasn't completely oblivious, either.

Izuku wanted to run up and hug him. Oh, how long it's been. He craves the relationship he and Yagi used to have. The one only a father and son could have. He missed the laughs, tears, and trust that he used to have with this man. He wants it back.

Please, let him have it back.

"I-," He didn't know what he was going to say, but the words left him anyway, "Is a hero defined by their quirk? Or is it who the person is, that defines them as someone who saves?"

Do you think someone without a quirk could be a hero?

It was an echo through a tunnel, but Yagi remembered that timid, little voice asking him such a significant question.

He wanted to say yes. Yes, anybody can become a hero. Why didn't he? What would have been the outcome (what was the original outcome?) if he had?

Yagi remembers this, but not fully. It's the feeling of a memory, on the brink of breaking free. A song he knows the words to, but not the rhythm.

"Young Midoirya," did the kid even tell him his name? He doesn't know.

Izuku waits. He's used to waiting. He's willing to wait for as long as it takes.

He just needs to be back to the cafe by sunset, or Ru will be mad (they can be really scary).

"It's not the quirk that defines the hero," Yagi answers, "but the person. It doesn't matter what quirk they have, but how they use it."

Izuku doesn't know why he asks this, but he needs to. Even though he knows the answer that's going to be given, he feels like it's a part of him, this question.

"Do you think that someone without a quirk could be a hero, too?" He shouldn't be asking this. It's not important. He's wasting time, but his mouth, as it often does, doesn't care. And words spew out uncontrollably.

Yagi sighs and lifts his shirt, revealing the wound that would never heal. Izuku winces, even though he's seen it before. He wished he had tried harder to stop Yagi from entering that fight all those years ago. He guesses that some things just can't be changed (how that terrifies him).

"I got this in an undocumented fight with a villain. My respiratory organs were severely damaged and I lost my stomach. I can now only be All Might for three hours a day. All this damage, even with a quirk like mine?" Yagi laughs, but it lacks humor. It's full of self deprecation. Izuku squeezes his eyes shut, knowing what's coming next. Sure, he's not quirkless anymore. He has four quirks! Increased senses, levitation, healing, and invisibility (although he never uses that one. He probably should). But it's still a *part* of him. It's in his history and has created him to be the person he is now. Nothing would have happened if he wasn't diagnosed quirkless. A blessing, and a curse.

What Toshinori says next, rattles Izuku, "I don't know. I don't think there's ever been a hero who was quirkless, so I can't give you an honest question. I can ask you this, do you think someone who is quirkless would be willing to work harder than anybody else? To face discrimination, backlash, and opposition? Would they be willing to risk their lives day after day when everybody else has the upper hand?"

Izuku finds himself nodding furiously, "Yes. I believe that anyone could be a hero. People who lack a quirk can still gain an advantage through technique, or strategy, or analysis. Someone who is willing to work ten times as hard as anyone else deserves the opportunity that everyone else has." It's all that he's wanted to hear. A version of himself from long ago would be crying now with a newfound hope. Could someone without a quirk be a hero?

Yes, yes they can.

Before Izuku could say anything else about quirks, One for All, or just about *life* , a big explosion rings out. Izuku whips around to see a big cloud of smoke a few blocks away. His eyes widen and meet Yagi's eyes. Yagi's pockets are empty; the sludge villain is gone.

Kacchan.

How could he be so stupid?! In his eagerness to see All Might, he let himself forget about the most pivotal moment in his meeting with the hero.

Izuku's feet carry him to the door to the stairs without him even having to think. He doesn't say goodbye to All Might- almost forgets about him. His mind is telling him only one thing, and that is:

I have to save Kacchan!

_____

Ten minutes earlier…

Katsuki is walking home from school, alone. He was invited to go to the new arcade with a couple of extras, but he could only deal with them for so long. Today, his sensei pointed out that he was applying to U.A., shining the spotlight on him like he always did. The entire classroom's attention turned on him, praising him for applying to the top school in Japan.

He wanted to yell, *"I'm going to make it! And Deku is too! Do you remember him? Do you even know who I'm talking about? Damn extras!!"* He was so full of anger. He always was, and it was exhausting, but he had no idea how else he could *be* . He relied on his raging fire to get through the day, to push him to become better, stronger, faster so he could prove himself to U.A.

To prove himself to Deku.

Katsuki was so lost in his mind during his walk home, taking the short cut down an alleyway, that he didn't realize the bottle right in front of him. He tripped and caught himself before he could fall to the ground.

"Stupid, fucking-" but he couldn't finish his range of curses, because suddenly, he couldn't breathe.

He couldn't *breathe.*

Slime was slithering down his throat, making him want to puke. It was surrounding his body, inhibiting any movement. He didn't know what was happening. Fear started to spread across Katsuki's body like a virus. He needed air. He needed to get out.

"Finally, a suitable puppet, and a strong one, too."

Oh, I'll show you strong, Katsuki thought.

He released a series of explosions. Small at first, but they steadily grew in size. He needed to break free, or gain the attention of heroes. His lungs were burning, but he still released explosions. They were the biggest that he's ever created, and if he wasn't fighting for his life, Katsuki would have been amazed by his own power.

He couldn't lose to this shitty-looking villain.

Katsuki didn't lose.

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Izuku's body knew exactly where to go. He turned invisible in order to not draw attention, and to use it to attack the villain.

He just had to get to Kacchan and think about everything else later. He wasn't Hato- he had no mask on. He was just ordinary Midoriya Izuku. A boy who loved Bakugou Katsuki.

What if something goes wrong? This wasn't like last time. What if he's too late, or All Might doesn't arrive?

What if Katsuki didn't make it?

No . He couldn't let himself think that. He was going to get there in time.

The smell of smoke was almost suffocating, and only got worse as he drew nearer. He rounded the block to find a group of civilians watching the disaster. The heroes, Kamui Woods, Backdraft, and Death Arms were already there trying their best, but there was only so much they could do against the massive explosions and the safety of a child at risk.

Still invisible, Izuku ran through the crowd toward the sludge villain, and there was Kacchan. He hadn't seen him in so long, and he wanted to cry in relief and terror. Relief for finally, *finally* , seeing him again, and terror because it's been so long. What if he hated him? Izuku wouldn't blame him if he did.

Izuku grabs a metal pipe on the ground while still running and throws it smack dab in the middle of the villain's eye. The villain screeches, and it gives Katsuki a few precious seconds of air. The villain knew someone threw the pipe, and was now aware that there was someone else fighting against them.

He could now see Izuku, so it didn't matter anymore if he activated his quirk or not. He switched it off, making it so everyone could see him.

Meaning, Kacchan could see him.

"I-Izuku," he whispered, voice rough from having been choked moments prior.

The sludge villain was still shocked from the attack, and seeing the boy he tried to use earlier that day appear out of thin air only stupefied him more.

Izuku took this to his advantage and grabbed Katsuki's uniform collar, trying to drag him out.

"Kacchan!" He was stuck, and he couldn't get him out with sheer force alone. He was about to activate his telekinesis to help pull him out, but the villain had overcome his shock, and began to absorb Izuku into his body as well. Slime was clutching around his throat tightly, putting him into a choke hold.

All Might. He needed All Might. Izuku tried to get out, to do anything, but it was like trying to swim up a violent upstream- he wasn't moving anywhere.

"What the fuck Deku!" Katsuki screamed, and if Izuku had the air, he would have laughed. Of course the first sentence Kacchan would say to him after years apart would involve cursing at him. How fitting.

Izuku was running out of air, and he couldn't grab onto anything. Black spots were starting to float across his vision, but he fought to cling onto consciousness. He just needed to wait a few more minutes.

And then, finally, a loud voice shouted out, "I AM HERE!" Katsuki and Izuku were suddenly blown away, the slime dissipating around them. They both landed a few feet away, Izuku getting a nasty scrape on his elbow, and Katsuki using an explosion to soften his fall. Izuku couldn't feel the pain of his new injury, though. He was

too distracted by All Might, standing right in front of them with a smile on his face, fist in the air. The once clear sky formed a cloud, and it started to rain. Izuku looked up, letting the rain wash down on him.

All Might didn't leave him. It was a fear he didn't know he had until it left him, leaving him filled with relief. The sludge villain was passed out, already getting pulled back by the other heroes on the scene.

Before anything else could happen, Katsuki and Izuku were both pulled away (in opposite directions, because of course) by separate emergency teams to check them for any injuries. He could hear that Katsuki received only minor burns from over exertion from his quirk and bruised ribs and throat. Izuku sighed, glad that Katsuki hadn't received any serious injuries.

Izuku's elbow would scar, the medic said, and he needed stitches, which they gave them to him right there. It was deep, but not a long gash, and it should heal fine, especially due to the medic's quirk which erased the chance of infection and increased the healing speed.

"What a cool quirk!" Izuku couldn't help gushing, "It's super helpful, and I bet it's saved so many lives. Are there any drawbacks? Like do you feel tired after using it, or does it become less effective depending on how big the injury is, or-" Izuku was interrupted by Death Arms scoffing to get his attention. Izuku smiled sheepishly at the medic, who smiled back before leaving to check on the civilians.

"Boy," Izuku cringed at being called that. It was like he was a child (he was, physically, but even if it was true it didn't mean it didn't irritate Izuku). "You can't just *jump* in like that, okay? You could have been seriously hurt, or worse." Before Death Arms could reprimand him farther, All Might stepped in and put a hand on the other hero's shoulder. Death Arms grumbled begrudgingly before walking off to survey the damage. All Might smiled at him and took both of his hands, shaking them wildly.

"Glad to know you're okay, Young Midoriya! That was truly brave and hero-like, but try to leave that to the pros, okay?" Izuku wanted to argue that the pros weren't even doing anything, but knew this was just something All Might had to say. The number one hero then leaned in and whispered, "Meet me at the same roof after sun down, okay? We need to talk." Izuku gulped, and nodded. He knew what it was going to be about, but he was surprised by the wave of nervousness that came over him.

The truth was, he had no idea what was going to happen next.

All Might stepped back and saluted, "Well, I'm off! Take care!" and with a gust of wind, he was up in the air, disappearing.

Izuku looked down, he was sitting on a bench not too far from the scene, and noticed that his hands were shaking uncontrollably. Was it adrenaline? Or anxiety of everything that happened, and will happen?

Izuku decided it was all of above.

He was too lost in his thoughts that he didn't hear heavy footsteps walking towards him. He didn't even notice the shadow that had fallen over him.

Only when a voice said, "Izuku." Did his head snap up.

It was like his face didn't know what to do with all of the emotions he was overwhelmed with, so it went slack, not revealing any of what he was feeling.

"It's been a long time, Kacchan."

Chapter End Notes

Low key proud of this chapter. It was a lot of fun!

And look at me, updating within a week!

Phases of the Moon

Chapter Summary

Katsuki and Izuku reunite

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku abruptly stands up from the bench he was sitting on and hugs Katsuki; he hugs him so tight. Katsuki has grown, obviously. He's taller- taller than Izuku just like he's always been, and he's built more muscle. Not only that, but there's a sense of maturity that the other Kacchan didn't have at this age. It's somber, but red-hot as well. Frayed around the edges as if it was still being stitched up.

Katsuki still smells like campfire and eucalyptus, something that is strangely comforting to Izuku.

Izuku lets go begrudgingly before Katsuki even has time to hug back, not that Izuku thinks he would want to, anyway. He grabs his best friend's wrist and starts walking. This area is too public for Izuku, and it doesn't feel safe. It's his paranoia, he knows, from years of being a vigilante and everything before that, but he won't be able to fully be in the moment if he's constantly hyper aware of every little thing.

"The fuck- where are we going?" Katsuki tries to stop, but Izuku doesn't let him. Katsuki isn't the only one who's gotten stronger over the years. He makes sure his grip is present, but not too strong to hurt. He'd never do anything to hurt him.

Blood was everywhere. On his hands, in his hair, he could even taste it.

Kacchan smiled, saying it wasn't his fault.

It was. It was it was it was! Katsuki was being delusional, he should have cursed him, yelled at him, tried to kill him.

God, how Izuku wished he was killed when he got kidnapped by the LOV. Death would have been a blessing compared to this.

Blood was dripping from Kacchan's mouth. Izuku was crying harder than he's ever cried before, his throat was in agony from sobbing and screaming, but the tears kept coming.

“Please, Kacchan! I’m so sorry. Sorry, sorry, sorry. I didn’t want this! Don’t…” Izuku sobbed. Blood and tears and snot and sweat everywhere, “Don’t die. I can’t live without you.”

Katsuki smiled. He was still beautiful. His hand held Izuku’s cheek, and Izuku grabbed onto his hand with both of his. As if that would do anything.

“You’ll find a way, Nerd,” Katsuki coughed, “Kiss me. One last time.”

Izuku screamed, “It won’t be the last time! After this, I’ll kiss you so much that you’ll get sick of me.”

But he was already gone.

Izuku spaced back in to find that he was still walking with Kacchan’s hand still in his. A tear had run down his cheek, and he hastily wiped it away with his free arm. Kacchan was still yelling at him, completely missing the fact that Izuku had completely dissociated, or just not caring.

Izuku came to a stop and looked straight ahead at the park. He knew that if he looked at Katsuki right now, he would just burst into tears.

He’s imagined this reunion hundreds, possibly thousands of times. All of the things he would say to him, all of the sorrys he would whisper, shout, and convey to Katsuki. Maybe he would even tell him the whole truth. Unlock the past, present, and future and finally tell someone.

None of that happened. Instead, he stood there, staring at the old playground that was starting to show its age through marks and rust.

How was he supposed to express years of yearning, sorrow, and regret?

He couldn’t.

_____

Katsuki wouldn't have let this *idiot* drag him here if he wasn't so paralyzingly numb. All he could do was stare at the back of Deku's head and yell stupid curses that Izuku didn't even seem to *hear* . His green, fluffy hair was the exact same from when he saw it all those years ago at the mall. How could that stay the same when so many other things have changed? Katsuki stares at Deku, and notices. He notices Izuku's navy sweatshirt that seems to swallow him all (he always seemed so small, like a breeze could take him away), the strength of his hand holding his, the way Izuku hastily wipes his face.

The fact that Izuku was still a crybaby was comforting.

Once they stop at the park, Katsuki starts to *feel* . Years of repressed confusion, anger, and *hurt* start to erupt. A dormant volcano suddenly awakening.

His palms fizzle and pop and he takes pleasure in Izuku's flinch. He wants to inflict all the pain Izuku has made *him* feel. Because how dare he? How *fucking* dear he show up after years of nothing?

"Look at me," Katsuki whispers, but Izuku either doesn't hear him or chooses not to hear him. He says again, "Look at me dammit! You owe me at least that much." He hates how they're *here* , at this shitty little park next to Strawberry Street. The same freaking park where they played and had fights. The same one where Izuku got fucking *kidnapped* and where they met the Hot n' Cold freak.

He hated that he still came here every Saturday. Had memorized every scratch mark, every screech of the swing set. He loathed that Izuku was looking at it like he hadn't been here *once* since he's left. Like it meant nothing to him.

Izuku turns his head to meet Katsuki's eyes. It's the first time since they've been reunited that Katsuki has actually been able to see his eyes. They still shine like emeralds, and Katsuki knows that he could still get lost in them. Izuku's eyes convey a pain that seems too much to bear, and he almost looks away. He fights the urge, and only sharpens his glare. He won't make this easy for Deku.

He's going to make it hell.

Izuku still doesn't say anything, and Katsuki *boils.*

"You *left!"* He screeches, and he hates how his voice threatens to break. "And you didn't even have the guts to say goodbye in person. Am I really only worth a letter a few paragraphs long? Do I mean so little to you?" He was breathing heavily. He had so much to say, and so little words to use.

Maybe that's why he punched Deku in the face.

Katsuki always believed in action over words, and right now, he was feeling too much to properly say what he wanted to. To say how much pain and loneliness and *worry* was impossible. He had more energy than he's had in so long and he had no idea what to do with it. Punching Izuku wasn't even a thought, only an action. Izuku stumbled, but didn't fall. He didn't look surprised in the slightest that he had punched him. Katsuki was the only one left feeling surprised by his actions, but he refused to let guilt overwhelm him when he saw Izuku's lip bleeding, his chin already forming a bruise.

What shocked him even more was the look of resignation on Izuku's face.

Izuku had *expected* the hit, and didn't even dodge. He probably even thought he deserved it.

He did. He deserved a thousand. Katsuki hated him. He hated him *so much* . And he hated the fact that his body was begging him to run up to Stupid Deku and hug him. To question him about the bags under his eyes (another thing that hasn't changed) or tease him about wearing a sweatshirt on the hottest day of the year thus far. He yearned to know what he's been doing, and *how the hell* he has a quirk now.

Izuku looked at him, and it took everything in Katsuki not to look away. Izuku looked so *sad* . And for a moment, Katsuki almost believed that maybe he didn't need to make him feel all the pain that he's felt in these years.

Because at that moment, Izuku looked like he carried enough sorrow to crush them both.

"You mean everything to me, Katuski. You are worth the whole world, the stars, the moon. I left because I had to, but know that it killed me. I have thought about you everyday. Know that you are still my one, true, best friend."

Izuku's eyes had watered, but he clenched his fists hard enough that it had to hurt, and continued to speak as Katuki stood frozen.

"But I'm not sorry for leaving. I can't tell you why, but maybe someday I will. God, I hope so," Izuku said, muttering the last part to himself.

Katsuki half wanted to yell more, demanding an apology. Another half of him just wanted to hold his best friend.

It turns out, the latter was stronger.

Holding Izuku felt like coming home. He had never hugged someone this fiercely before. Doesn't even remember when the last time he initiated a hug was, but this, even if it was only for a moment, felt *right.*

Izuku hugged back with just as much strength (it was then that he realized that he wasn't the only one who had gotten stronger), burying his head into his chest.

Katsuki was smart enough that this wasn't the end of this argument, and that only more would start. But with all of the energy evaporating from him leaving only exhaustion, he could hardly bring himself to care. Maybe tomorrow, or the next day, or even an hour from now, but not this second. Not when he finally had Izuku back.

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They released, much to Izuku's dismay.

"I missed you," he said. He couldn't help but stare as the setting sun reflected off of Katsuki's sandy hair, making him radiant. His ruby eyes were sparkling and bright. Izuku had almost forgotten how bright those eyes could shine.

Katsuki looked like he was about to say something, but Izuku interrupted him, finally registering that the sun was *setting.*

"Shit." If he weren't so panicked, Izuku would have laughed at Katsuki's comical surprise at his language. "It's getting late, Ru is going to be mad. I hate it when she gets mad. She'll bring hell down on me. Not to mention that I have to meet someone soon. Maybe I could stop by and tell them I have an errand to run? Yeah… That could work, but Kacchan. I can't-"

"Yo!" Katsuki yells, startling Izuku out of his muttering. He looks up to see Bakugou almost smiling at him, "So you still mutter, huh?"

Izuku scratches the back of his neck sheepishly, feeling his face heat up, "Yeah. I don't think I'll ever be able to stop."

Katsuki *tchs* as he looks up at the painted pastel sky, "I'll come with you."

He tilts his head, "What?"

Katsuki glares at him, as if he was stupid for not being able to read his mind. Izuku never thought he would miss someone glaring at him, but he found that he *had* missed it. Katsuki says, “We can’t stay here forever, and I don’t trust you to come back again,” Izuku winces at that, “So let me grab some stuff at my house and I’ll spend the night wherever you are staying. You *are* staying somewhere, right?” Katsuki’s face was stern, but Izuku could clearly see the worry creases there.

He nods, and Katsuki sighs in relief, “It’s about a mile from your house. You can grab some stuff, but I can’t go in with you.” He ends the conversation by walking towards Katsuki’s house. Two people in less than three months have found him out, three if he counts All Might, but he isn’t sure if the hero even knew that he went missing all those years ago. Adding the Bakugou’s into this would be too much, especially since he knew they would make a big fuss over it. Alerting the police, never taking their eyes off of him. Aizawa is already a pain in the ass to avoid and Izuku isn’t looking for any more annoyances.

Katsuki huffs and starts walking next to him (not behind, not in front, but *beside* him. Izuku swells with content), “They miss you. You left them too.”

He really wasn’t going to go soft on him, was he? That’s fine; Izuku deserved it anyway.

Izuku doesn’t say anything else for the entire walk, and neither does Bakugou. His chest heaves once they make it to his driveway. This house used to be his home, too. It was a beautiful house, and had such a *Bakugou* essence to it. Izuku remembers the warmth he alway felt when he entered this house and how he always felt like he was welcomed there. This home had given him support, security, and *love* . He itched to go inside, but he couldn’t. It would take too much time, and he had to go to the cafe, somehow get Ru and Kacchan distracted, and then go see All Might, which was something he fully hasn’t processed yet.

He could almost *feel* One for All thrumming in his veins.

“I’ll be back in five minutes tops. The old hag is probably going to kick me out of the house once she finds out I’m going over to a ‘friend’s’. *Don’t move.* ” Izuku salutes, chuckling as Katsuki grumbles. He opens the door, and for a moment Izuku sees the light in the house. He almost reaches out towards it. It was such a warm glow, and it looked so safe. He wouldn’t mind if that light had swallowed him whole.

But then it was gone, and Izuku was once again alone. He couldn’t believe that he was here. Not just at this home, but with Kacchan as well. It felt like a dream, but that was almost less likely than it being reality because Izuku never had good dreams.

He pinches himself, just in case.

A few minutes later, Katsuki opens the door, and Izuku is startled out of his thinking. Katsuki is yelling over his shoulder, duffel bag in hand, “Yeah, yeah. I got it. See ya’ old hag!” He shuts the door. Izuku could hear

Mitsuki perfectly through the door, yelling curses at her child but then muttering an “I love you, kiddo” underneath her breath. Izuku smiled, loving the sound of Mitsuki’s motherly voice.

Katsuki looks at Izuku and visibly relaxes, probably fearing that he wouldn’t be here. Izuku doesn’t think he could if he tried. Not again.

With Katsuki at his side, he says, “Let's go.”

The silence is so loud between them; so many words left unsaid. Izuku was almost twitching with energy. He hated absolute silence- it always drove his anxiety bouncing off of the walls and only gave room for his thoughts to become more noticeable.

Surprisingly, it was Katsuki who spoke up first, “So who is this ‘Ru’? They're your girlfriend or some shit?”

The question had surprised him so much that he started laughing- really laughing. His eyes watered, and his cheeks started to hurt, the serious expression on Katsuki’s face not making it any easier to quell his laughter.

“What?!” Katsuki shouts, “What’s so funny, huh?”

Izuku gulps down some air and wipes a tear from his eye, “Ru is *so* not my girlfriend. They’re like an older sibling to me if anything. I’ve been staying with them for a few years. Helping her with the cafe and doing homeschool.” It was then that they pulled up to the baby blue coloring of the cafe.

“Here we are,” he says as he opens the door with Kaiteki Cafe's signature design, a black cat facing a wreath of roses. Katsuki walks in toe and almost trips over a sphynx cat, which hisses at him.

“You live… here?”

Izuku nods, “Well, not *here* . We have a small apartment above this that we actually live in, but I suppose we do cook and eat down here.”

“Izu! Is that you?! Thank god, I almost just burned the house down. I hope you’re okay with take out today. Soup is not my forte.”

Izuku sighs while Katsuki looks alarmed. Izuku waves him off and mouths “It’s okay” to him. Really, this was a daily occurrence. Whether it was almost burning the house down, almost stabbing herself, or almost stabbing someone *else* .

“It’s me! I brought a fri-guest.” He didn’t think that he was allowed to call Kacchan his friend at the moment. It’s not like he deserved the title, anyway.

Katsuki and Izuku both wince as they hear a clatter of the pans and pots from the kitchen before Ru comes running into the main area of the cafe.

“A guest!? Izu, you *never* bring anyone here. I didn’t even know you had friends!”

Katsuki barks out a laugh and Izuku flushes, “Ru! I do have friends!”

They give him a look, “Name one.”

Izuku points to the fluffy Siberian cat, “Myra is my friend!”

Now Katsuki is giving him that look, “That’s just sad.”

“Shut up,” Izuku replies.

Ru fakes a cough and glares at the both of them, which sends shivers of fear down both of their spines. “Are you going to introduce me or not?”

Izuku shakes his head up and down furiously, “Ru, this is Kach- erm, Bakugou Katsuki. Kacchan, this is Arai Hotaru.” Ru squeals and pulls Bakugou into a hug, in which Katsuki does not look happy at *all* and refuses to return it.

Ru lets go and giggles, “Ohhh, I see, you’re a grumpy one. Tell me, how did you two meet?”

Katsuki starts to say, “We’ve known each other since-”

But Izuku erupts, his voice squealish, “At the park! Clumsy me bumped into him, and spilt his coffee all over him. I offered to get him another coffee, but he wanted ice cream instead. Turns out, that’s a good way to make a new friend.”

Thank God Ru didn’t watch the News.

Katsuki gives him a half confused, half angry look before nodding.

“Well, Bakugou,” Ru says, “Please make yourself at home. Ah! I’m so excited. Let me make some tea and then you tell me some things about yourself. Izuku’s never brought anyone here before!”

Izuku starts to back up towards the exit while Katsuki follows Arai to the Kitchen/dining room. “I’m, uh, I realized that I forgot some things at the grocery store the other day, so I’m going to grab them real quick.” Katsuki whips around with his eyes wide, Izuku winces. He was going to be late to see All Might. That wouldn’t exactly make the greatest impression.

Ru waves him off, “Yeah, yeah, whatever. You do that while I treat our guest. Teenagers these days; so forgetful.”

Izuku runs out of the door before Katsuki could stop him, “Be back soon Kacchan!”

He hears a muffled, “Deku! You idiot!” But Ru must’ve trapped him because Katsuki doesn’t come after him.

Izuku lets his legs speed up, his thoughts racing along with his body. This day went so inexplicably sideways that everything he thought could’ve happened has been completely erased.

He just hopes luck is on his side.

Izuku is barely out of breath by the time he reaches the roof of this fated building. The sun has set, and the sky is almost black with only a few stars dotting it. The moon was perhaps just a few days from being full. He wonders what his life was going to be like when that time comes. He takes a deep breath before continuing to walk forward, where he sees All Might in his normal form.

“All Might,” he says, voice barely above a whisper. But Yagi hears him, and calmly turns around, yet Izuku knows he’s nervous by the hunch of his shoulders and the white knuckles of his clenched fists.

“Young Midoriya,” his tone is serious and holds only righteousness and determination.

“We need to talk.”

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Chasing Tomorrow

Chapter Summary

Everyone is moving to a better tomorrow.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Aizawa was stupid to believe that getting Midoriya to talk to him would be easy.

It very much wasn't.

Oh, they've encountered each other plenty of times, and have even fought a few thugs together as well, but as soon as they're done fighting, Hato was gone like he was never there to begin with. He's tried to talk to the kid every chance he got, but he wouldn't listen. He alerted Tsukouchi of Midoriya being the infamous Hato, but even with that knowledge, he hasn't been able to find much of anything. They've looked at security cameras to see what patrol routes Hato takes (which Aizawa already had a pretty good idea on what they were) to see if it would lead to where he might be staying.

Problematically, the Problem Child knew how to avoid cameras quite well. Aizawa swears that Midoriya was trying to give him gray hairs.

He wants to help him more than anything. Midoriya has not had a pleasant life from the looks of it. He's been kidnapped and forced to fight for two years in the Arena, only to come home to the knowledge that his mother had passed away, and then there's the *before* . A time that only Midoriya truly knows. One with death and sadness, but also a classroom of rambunctious teenagers that have such potential.

Then there was Eri.

Oh how he was pissed when Midoriya planned a rescue mission, gathering heroes who would never otherwise work together (let alone with a *vigilante*) to save her and then leave her in *his* care. What was the damn kid thinking? Sure, he's a teacher, but that doesn't mean he likes kids (he ignores his husband's whispers of "you seem quite fond of Midoriya, and he's a kid.").

However, Eri is a sweetheart, and he doesn't mind having her around. He begrudgingly admits that he's glad that she's under his and Hizashi's care.

Not that he would tell that to anyone. Ever.

The first few weeks were hard. Eri barely spoke and flinched at any sound or fast movements. The only times she did speak during the beginning weeks was to ask where Deku was. Aizawa, at first, had no idea who she was talking about.

“Deku? Who are you talking about?” Shota had asked. Eri had quickly shut down, saying sorry. Clearly curiosity was not a thing that was encouraged at the Shie Hassaikai estate. It took days of gentle questioning to get her to answer.

“The kind boy who saved me. He said I was special, which meant I could call him Deku. He wanted me to call him H… Hato? But you’ve been calling him Mid- Mid,” Eri scrunches her face up, not being able to pronounce Izuku’s last name, “And he said people who only knew him could call him that.”

It suddenly came to Aizawa where he had heard that name before. Midoriya’s best friend, Bakugou Katsuki, called him Deku.

Over the weeks, she had slowly become who she was supposed to be: a child. A young one at that, barely five. Her appetite grew, and the two men had to hastily learn how to cook proper meals. Luckily, Eri was patient with their developing cooking skills. That, or she just truly didn’t care because she was being fed consistently. Aizawa tried not to think about that too much.

She had her own room with a bunny nightlight, and carried her bunny stuffed animal everywhere. There was a time where she forgot it in the car and had her first meltdown. It was horrible, and only because Yamada and Shota loathed to see her cry. What was worse was seeing her face morph into guilt and fear after finding her bunny (named Benji). She didn’t speak for two days after that, even after the couple told her that it was okay to cry and be upset. That they expected it, and that it was healthy.

They didn’t think she believed them.

Over the past two months, Eri’s skin flushed with color. Her cheeks were no longer gaunt and she’s developed a new-found energy. She still doesn’t sleep well, often waking up in the middle of the night with hellish nightmares. She doesn’t like to talk about them, or anything that has to do with Overhaul. They said that it was okay if she didn’t want to talk right now, but that they were here if she ever wanted to.

Before the rescue, Aizawa and Hato had met up to discuss further plans. Hato had described Eri’s quirk with great detail, and when he asked how he knew such things, the boy had just shrugged and said, “I can’t tell you! Where would the fun be in that?”

It turns out, the vigilante had been extremely accurate in his analysis of Eri's quirk. They hadn't had too many problems with it so far: A few apples turning into blossoms, a pillow turning into a chicken (that one was hard to explain to Eri), and Hizashi's freshly trimmed face returning to its scratchy, whiskery face, in which he had groaned and grabbed the shaving cream again. Despite these harmless acts, Shota was still careful. Deactivating Eri's quirk as soon as he saw it. She seemed to have not much control over it, and it only activated with bursts of emotion. They would get to training it soon, but wanted to focus on healing Eri first.

Eri was kind and held no ill-will towards life or the world. She was so gentle with their cats, and loved them to death. On multiple occasions they had found her surrounded by them, fast asleep (they might have taken a few photos).

She cried when she stepped on a bug, brought an injured bird to their house (they had mixed feelings about that) and constantly asked if Deku was okay and when she was going to see him again.

Aizawa had no fucking idea.

Not until two months after the rescue. Aizawa was cooking dinner while Yamada was doing some paperwork. Eri was watching TV and eating sliced apples. She must've been flipping through the channels because Shota could hear the different music and voices change every few seconds.

Suddenly, Eri's feet came tapping to the kitchen and she yelled, which was never really much of a yell, "Deku's on TV!" It was the loudest he's ever heard her, and the brightest. Aizawa dropped the knife that he was using to cut up vegetables. It clattered to the ground inches from his foot, but he barely noticed it.

He followed Eri to the TV and saw Midoriya in a sea of flames.

Fighting a fucking villain.

Aizawa sighs.

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Ru stares across the table nursing her cup of tea. She's smiling so big that her cheeks hurt. Right across from them is Bakugou Katsuki, AKA Izu's first friend. That they know of, but Ru's pretty sure that this was Izuku's first friend.

He looked like he had a stick up his ass and wanted to bolt, presumably to wherever Izu ran off to. He's quite funny looking, and not what Ru would think as a compatible friend of Izuku's. But Ru's quirk gives her a sense of how lonely people are, and while Izuku's loneliness had alleviated since they've known each other, Ru could

still sense a gaping hole that pained her as much as it probably pained Izu. Then Bakugou came with Izu by his side, and the hole seemed to have shrunk in the blink of an eye. So yes, Ru was glad that Bakugou was here, but that didn't mean they could just outright trust him.

No. An interrogation had to happen.

"What are your intentions with Izu?" Ru started out, and laughed when Katsuki choked on his tea. He blushed, and Ru almost pitied him. Almost.

"I- What?!"

Ru's smile changed, and the little devil inside of her cackled at Bakugou's widened eyes, "Don't just expect me to trust you right away because Izu does. I need to make sure you won't hurt him. He's been through enough." Bakugou's eyes widen at that, a melancholy passing through them.

Ru isn't dumb. They suspect that Bakugou and Izuku have a deeper history than just a few hours.

Bakugou looks Ru right in the eye, ruby red meeting ocean blue. Bakugou Katsuki is determined, Ru concludes. She just doesn't know what he's determined about.

"I'm his best friend," Bakugou states, and Hotaru raises an eyebrow. Best friend? After supposedly not even half a day of knowing each other? Katsuki must see their suspicion because he says more, "We've known each other since we were kids. Don't ask me why he didn't tell you; I haven't seen him in years." Bakugou huffs a breath, suddenly looking like the energy was vacuumed out of his body.

Ru looks down at her tea, frowning. "And why haven't you? Seen him, that is."

"Because he ran away. Simply just… disappeared into fuckin' thin air." Ru heaves a sigh. They've always known that Izuku was different. A mind so old yet so incredibly young at the same time. The world hadn't treated him kindly, and he refused to tell anyone about it. Everytime that Ru had pushed him to talk to them, to *anyone* , about it, he would shut down or argue.

"Izu has always been closed-off. I see him as my own brother, and love him to death, but sometimes, he's a stranger," Ru whispers, offering a small smile to the teen, "I met him, gosh, over two years ago. I was walking near the cemetery where I felt a deep, aching loneliness -that's my quirk, I can feel other people's loneliness- that I almost had trouble breathing. That's when I saw him, crying next to a grave with a bouquet of weeds in his hand. It was heartbreaking. That's when I invited him to come stay with me and help with the cafe. He doesn't talk about who he was before we met no matter how much I pry. I've learned to help him be who he is now, so he can have the strength to heal."

Bakugou's eyes are brimming with tears, so Ru takes their empty mugs to wash them and allow him some privacy.

"I'll show you where Izu's room is, and you can wait for him there. He disappears sometimes, but he always comes back."

Ru watches as the kid sniffs and straightens his back. His voice is angry and strong, "He fucking better."

Ru smiles because finally, someone who could really help Izuku is here.

They just have to give it time.

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Midoriya Izuku stands on the rooftop, mere feet away from Yagi Toshinori. The cool night breeze sends goose bumps up his arms, but he hardly notices the dropping temperature. He's too captivated by who stands before him, of what lays ahead.

"Yagi-San," Midoriya says, but it gets caught in his throat and comes out barely a whisper like a breeze in the wind. Yagi turns around to face him, hearing his soft greeting.

The great hero smiles warmly. Izuku's heart squeezes at the sight, "Young-Midoriya. I was beginning to think you wouldn't come." The sentence was meant to be a joke, but Izuku could hear the worry in his voice. He has spent enough time around this man to interpret the undertones of his voice, his facial expressions, the weight he carries constantly and forever.

The sun is now gone and the sky is dark. The city light offers enough light for the average person to see well enough, so Izuku knows Yagi can see him smiling back, "Sorry, I got held back." He begins to walk toward Toshinori and gaze at the city next to him as they talk, but once he gets about two feet away from the place next to his past (and possibly future) mentor, he comes to a halt.

Yagi seems to go still as well. Breath hitching.

Izuku can hear it. *One for All.* It's calling out to him, like a telephone signal or electricity traveling through wires.

Midoriya... That was the first user.

Midoriya, we've missed you. Nana.

Midoriya! Took you long enough! The fourth user, Shinomari.

All of the users talk in sync, *We knew you were coming. For the past fourteen years, this quirk has been calling out to you. Soon, it won't be only a part of your mind, but your body, heart, and soul as well.*

Their voices make Izuku want to cry. They're so beautiful. A song that's been so quiet that he's tuned it out, but now it's all he could hear.

Once passed down, One for All will be more powerful than ever. You will learn to harness it once again. We are a part of you as much as you are a part of us. We are infinite. We will guide you to save the future.

And we will help you, Nana says. The other voices have faded. *We will make sure you don't lose yourself, and we will guide you back to what you need most.*

Love.

With that, the voices were gone, but Izuku didn't feel empty. He felt warm, like he had just cuddled up in a blanket and drunk his favorite tea.

"You know already, don't you?" All Might says quietly. The way he says it makes it sound not like a question, but a realization.

Izuku fights the urge to make himself smaller, "What?" He could mean so many things, all of them relating to OFA.

"My quirk is calling to you. I think it has been for a while." Izuku notices that Yagi's shoulders relax, and his fisted hands droop. He doesn't seem stressed or confused, but content.

Izuku makes the last final paces to Yagi's side and crosses his arms on top of the roof's gate. The thrumming between them gets stronger, so much so that Izuku could have sworn he saw a spark of green electricity between them.

“Do you feel it?” Asks Toshi, “The energy, the past users, my quirk?”

Izuku hesitates for a split second before nodding.

“How? Why?”

He knows that All Might was talking to himself, but answers anyway, “I don’t know.” And it’s the truth; he truly doesn’t know why that even though he *shouldn’t* feel connected to OFA in the way he does at this time, he does. “I don’t know,” he says again.

Yagi nods, believing him. It’s then that he smiles and transforms into his hero form. Izuku yelps and takes a step back.

All Might’s power and promise of protection rain down on him; it’s overwhelming. His smile is radiant even though being in this form must cause a massive strain on him.

“You want to be a hero,” All Might says to him.

“I do.” *More than anything* . Even with all of the heartache, pain, and unbearable grief, he still wants to be a hero. To save those who haven’t fully lived yet, and to give hope to those who’ve never embraced it before.

“You can be a hero. My quirk, a quirk that has been passed from one user to the next, stockpiling power and getting stronger from each user, is connected to you in some way. I know that asking you this is a lot, but will you succeed me and receive my quirk?”

Izuku laughs, tears streaming down his face. He did it. He’s finally *here* . He feels power in his veins as if he’s already received the quirk.

“Yes!” He exclaims with everything he has. He won’t let All Might down.

Not again.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for the support! It means so much

A New Page

Chapter Summary

Izuku has no idea what's going to happen next.

He tries not to let it weigh him down with anxiety, but it's very much present.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Yagi felt his chest loosen as Izuku showed up on the roof, greeting him. He'd been stressed out of his mind that the kid wouldn't show up, especially since he was so *sure* that this boy in front of him would be the next wielder of One for All. He wouldn't have known what to do if Young Midoriya hadn't shown up.

It was when Young Midoriya started walking towards him that something had shifted. Yagi's skin started to prickle all over like a healing sunburn. It was a sensation he had never experienced before, and he wanted it gone. It made him want to crawl out of his own body. It stopped right when Toshinori was on the brink of not being able to handle it, but it's also when the voices had started.

He hadn't heard them in years, but their voices were a broken record imprinted into his mind.

It was Nana's voice that took over. God, it was *her.* How he missed her. He thought about her everyday, and not a day went by that he didn't think of the *what if* . What if she was still alive? What if I got to say more to her? What if I could've saved her?

Toshi… Her tone was loving and sincere. Toshinori wanted to say something to her, but he couldn't. It was like someone placed a lock on his vocal cords, prohibiting him from making the smallest of noises.

I know you know Midoriya is special. I know you've been having dreams of him…

Yes, but not in a long while. He had written them down, hadn't he? It's been who knows how long since he's even looked at it. The journal had simply… slipped from his mind.

You have to remember him. He needs *you to remember.*

She could talk about so many different things, but why this? It's then that the dreams flash through his mind, a push provided by Shimura Nana.

The first dream: a rooftop. A boy who wanted nothing else but to become a hero.

Then a different scenery. The smell of blood and smoke and tears. Black spikes coming near him, and he knew that that was his death.

The second dream: A funeral of a boy. He had a red cap and red shoes, but Yagi couldn't remember his name. All he clearly remembered was the fact that Midoriya wasn't there. A purple portal appeared, and that was all he knew.

The third and final dream: he had felt so incredibly empty. The last of his power was gone, but he didn't seem to mind. His successor was next to him. The same boy on the rooftop (both now and before), green eyes sparkling with tears and whispers of promises to make him proud (didn't he know? He was already proud).

Yagi could hardly breathe. *Young Midoriya.* He's existed before. He's been here before. Different time, but same circumstances.

Good. Nana compliments, *Midoriya Izuku* has *to receive One for All. You know this.*

Guide him, nurture him. You will understand with time.

Time. It was always about time. Yagi had a feeling that this had a lot more to do with the seconds, minutes, hours in a day, but something more *universal.*

Everything fades and then lights up once again with life. The traffic down below was a lot louder than he remembered it to be and he's more aware of the wind caressing his skin. He sees Young Midoriya and comes to a realization that yes, he wanted this boy to become his successor, but now he *needs* it. Perhaps he doesn't know why this fact was so important and non-negotiable, but he knew then and there that Midoriya Izuku was destined to have OFA. No one else should have it. No one else *could* have it.

He musters up the strength to transform into All Might.

And asks him the long-awaited question.

It's well after midnight when Izuku comes sneaking through his bedroom window. He and All Might had discussed training, and he wasn't surprised to hear about Dagoba Beach. Disappointed, however, when All Might said his body, while trained, wouldn't be ready for One for All at the moment. He thought he would have been ready with everything he's done, but it turns out that he *still* wasn't strong enough.

When he had expressed this to All Might, the new mentor simply said, "Being 'strong enough' will never be an attainable goal. It'll only get higher, and it will only leave yourself feeling like you're not enough. You *are* enough. Cleaning Dagoba beach won't only train you physically, but it will increase your mental stamina as well. This is to ensure your safety, Young Midoriya, but know that I will always see you as enough."

He had cried, and only cried harder when All Might proceeded to tease him about being such a crybaby.

After they decided to meet up at the beach in the morning, Izuku decided to roam the streets. He knew Kacchan was waiting, but he needed to think. About what he was going to say to him, what he was going to do once he started at U.A., as well as the whole Aizawa situation.

He may have fought a few criminals trying to rob a group of friends as well. Dropping them off at Tsukauchi's station all tied up, but that was neither here nor there.

Once he had made it to his room, it was well past midnight and he was dead tired. He had expected Kacchan to still be up and extremely pissed, or sleeping in their guest room. Instead, he saw Katsuki asleep in his bed, looking as calm as an unbothered lake. Izuku smiled before turning off the lamp illuminating the room and climbing up onto the bed. It was a bunk bed (his desk underneath it), so it was a bit awkward to crawl in without waking up Kacchan.

He knew Katsuki would have questions. So, so many questions with an equal amount of conflicting emotions. He knows that Kacchan saw his invisibility quirk, and will ask about that, but what about all of the other million questions he's going to ask? Saying he was a late bloomer is an easy enough lie, but everything else? Even he hardly knew what was going on.

Izuku didn't know how many more lies he could tell. How many secrets he could keep locked away. His entire *life* had been built with lies upon lies. He hated how good he's gotten at it, and how he could hardly discern what was the truth. Who was he, under all of these mistellings?

He was a stranger to himself. It was terribly lonely; not knowing the person you were stuck with for your entire life.

Izuku squeezes his eyes shut and tries to ignore Katsuki's body so close to his. He could feel the comforting heat radiating off of him, hearing him breathing in and out, even the faint sound of his heartbeat.

In the end, it was the soothing sound of his best friend's breathing that lulled him to sleep.

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Katsuki hadn't realized he had closed his eyes until he was startled awake by a sharp movement to the left of him and a deep intake of breath.

He slowly opened his eyes to see Deku next to him breathing heavily. He looked frantic, and he was gripping his arms with what must have been painful strength. The lack of light made it hard to see finer details, but even so, Katsuki saw Izu's wide eyes and hunched shoulders.

It was a familiar scene. One that Katsuki had almost forgotten about. When Izuku was living with him, he had often awoken to find Izuku like this. He had always had night terrors and bags under his eyes, and a sorrow fell on his shoulders once he realized that Deku still had them.

At first, he was afraid he had forgotten what to do when Deku got like this, but then his body went on autopilot. He slowly sat up and whispered, "Deku, I'm here. Do you know where you are?"

Izuku looked at him as if he had totally forgotten he was there- he probably had. Usually when these nightmares happened (at least when Izuku lived with them), Izuku would get lost in his own torturous mind and seek Katsuki out for comfort. At times, he hated to be touched during these moments, but every once in a while he would crave physical comfort. Katsuki would hug him and let him feel his breathing, or he would stay at a distance and whisper simple things to him. Like the latest hero or what they had done that day.

This time was different. Izuku's eyes looked at Katsuki, and he *smiled* . He was still shaking, and panic was still in his eyes, but he had completely oppressed the frantic fear.

"Sorry Kacchan," his voice cracked, "I didn't mean to wake you."

Bakugou narrowed his eyes, "Don't just try to push the panic back for later, Stupid. You should know by now doing that only makes it worse later on."

Deku heaves a heavy sigh and collapses onto his back, staring up at the ceiling.

Katsuki was just beginning to think that he fell back asleep when his hoarse voice whispered, “How do you still know me so well?” It was pure curiosity, but there was also agony in it. Katsuki couldn’t understand how such a simple sentence could hold so much sorrow in it.

Absentmindedly, Katsuki thought it was because Izuku had lost himself since leaving. Or maybe he never knew himself to begin with, and had only gone deeper into a cruel maze.

The answer comes easily, “I will always know you.” He hears Deku’s harsh intake of air. No matter how far apart they are, or whether it’s another ten years until he sees him, Katsuki will always know Izuku. He will never become a stranger.

He doesn’t move when he feels Deku slowly relax next to him, folding into a fetal position next to his chest. Katsuki wrapped a loose arm around his torso, and for a moment, it was like they were kids again having a sleepover.

“Do you have nightmares constantly?” Katsuki asks, not knowing if he wants to hear the answer. Izuku hums, pretending to think about it.

“Not too often.”

It’s a lie and they both know it. Through his sleepiness, anger blazes through him. After everything, the least he deserved was the truth. He uncurls his arm from Izuku and turns to face the opposite direction. He feels tears sting his eyes and hates himself for it. during moments like these, he didn’t want a hurricane of emotions. All he wanted was the persistent burning of anger. He wanted it to burn away all of the other emotions that he didn’t want. Worry, happiness, the urge to protect the Damn Nerd.

He despised the fact that he was disappointed that Izuku didn’t reach towards him, to ask what was wrong. All he wanted was to feel satisfaction at knowing that he was making Deku overwhelmed with guilt. The idiot deserved it.

He felt Izuku get on top of the covers and jump out of bed. The warmth his body left behind was quickly leaving, and it took all of Katsuki’s willpower not to say, *Wait. Don’t go. Not again.*

He allowed one last thing to slip past his lips; something he had been dying to ask, “You’re quirkless. How do you have a quirk?” He saw Izuku’s body outline next to his door, just getting ready to leave and do God knows what.

“Turns out I was a late bloomer. Happened while someone was attempting to mug me. Funny that, how something so trivial would unlock my quirk. Would’ve been a lot helpful earlier.”

He knew he was talking about the Arena, even though Izuku had always refused to talk about it no matter how many times he had asked.

Katsuki didn’t say anything, only letting his eyes close, feigning sleep. Although he knew he wouldn’t be sleeping anymore tonight. He heard Izuku close the door and repressed the urge to scream.

He was stupid to think that things would return to normal with them given time. Nothing would be the same as it once was before.

He didn’t know what to think about that.

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Izuku brews himself some sencha in the kitchen, not bothering to turn the lights on. It’s thirty till six, and Izuku agreed to meet All Might at the beach at seven. Ru will be up in half an hour to open up the cafe, so Izuku decides to make some breakfast for everyone. He starts with the cats first, making sure each one gets their required food measurements and either dry, wet, or a mix of cat food. He grumbles at how freakin’ spoiled the cats are, but makes sure to give each one a kiss on the forehead anyway.

He cooks a simple dish called okayu, rice porridge, and adds pickled plum to it for extra flavor. For protein he makes tamagoyaki with kimchi on the side for Kacchan. Just as he finished, Izuku hears Ru’s loud thumping and eventually sees her jumping down the stairs, no doubt waking up their guest.

“Good morning, Izuku!” They hug him, which was something that he only recently became used to, and he hugs back with just as much force. “You made breakfast! Thanks dude.” Ru proceeds to make herself a massive cup of iced coffee (always iced, no matter how cold it is outside. Ru says hot coffee was for the weak). He dishes Ru, ears twitching as he hears Katsuki get out of bed grumpily. He starts to brew tea for Kacchan. Katsuki always liked chai, and Izuku had recently created a special chai tea that was only sold on Saturdays. It contained cinnamon, cloves, nutmeg, black pepper, black tea, and orange peel. He had named the tea *Ground Zero.* Katsuki in the other timeline told him he would’ve gone with that as his hero name if he hadn’t been drawn to Dynamight.

He turned from the kitchen counter to greet Katsuku (Ru was stuffing their face, so they just went with a half-assed wave), “Good morning, Kacchan.” He then sets Katsuki’s portion of the tamagoyaki and okayu on the dining table, “I made a chai tea recently, and I’d hope you would try it. You don’t have to if you don’t want to, of course. I don’t even know if you still like chai tea, or tea in general, so I won’t be offended if you don’t-”

“Would you shut up for just one second? I’ll try the damn tea.” Izuku smiles, and nods, trying to ignore the tenseness that had yet to fade from last night, or maybe it was from the years separated.

He puts his tea and plate down at his usual spot and goes to fetch Katsuki’s tea. He pours it in one of Ru’s many rugs. This one had a cartoon frog holding a knife, saying “Peace was never an option.”

It was fitting for Kacchan.

He watches as Katsuki takes a small sip of the drink, and then after a moment, takes another sip. Izuku smiles, happy he won over Katsuki with his tea.

He doesn’t say anything, not that Izuku thought he would. He looks at the clock and realizes that he has to meet All Might soon, and starts shoveling food into his mouth, along with deciding if he should just tell Katsuki about OFA now or wait until later. Maybe he should just invite him to train with him? That might aid in reconciling their friendship as well.

“Woah, Izu, you’re going to choke. What’s got you in such a rush?” Ru asks, their mouth full of the rice porridge.

He ignores the curious gaze that Katsuki sends him and wipes his mouth with a napkin, “I know it’s last minute, but do you think you can handle the cafe without me for a few hours? I need to start training for U.A.”

Ru doesn’t even think about it before she waves him off, “Of course I can handle it. You do your hero training thing and I’ll lore customers in with my sexy looks.”

“I’m coming with you,” Katsuki demands, not even bothering to ask. Izuku sighs, expecting this. Sure, he could explain everything to him, but what about All Might? It was different before, when he knew about their relationship dynamics and trusted Katsuki to keep it a secret. Now, they were complete strangers, having met only twice. And the first time was years ago when they toured U.A.

“Kacchan… Don’t you need to get home?” It was obvious that he was trying to get Katsuki to leave, which probably would only make him want to stay even more.

Katsuki *tchs* , his gaze turning into a glare, “The old hag won’t fuss about me until dark, and if she does, I have a phone for a damn reason, Nerd.” Instead of offering any further comment, Izuku takes the last sip of his tea and starts to gather all of the plates.

“Don’t worry about them, Izu. I’ll get it. Now go train, but if you injure yourself I will never let you out of my sight again, got it you clumsy fool?” Ru says calmly, as if talking about the weather instead of threatening him.

Izuku hastily nods, throwing a glare at Bakugou when he snickers.

“We have to leave in five minutes, so that gives us plenty of time to change clothes and get ready,” Izuku says to Katsuki. He doesn’t bother to ask if he’s coming along. It would be a waste of time when they both knew the answer.

He tries really hard to ignore the butterflies in his stomach at the thought of Katsuki wanting to go be by his side, even after everything.

You truly don’t deserve him .

The thought is quick, but vicious. It chews at Izuku constantly, and he can do nothing about it.

“Let's get a move on, then,” Katsuki tells him, already moving up the stairs. Izuku sighs. It was going to be a long day, and he was already exhausted from the lack of sleep.

He followed his best friend up the stairs, wishing that this new page in life wasn’t going to be torn apart.

Chapter End Notes

I'm going to right a very angsty one-shot now.

Pushed to the Brink

Chapter Summary

Izuku finally gets to train with All Might, and someone else.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He and Izuku were walking to the beach, Katsuki trying not to let the lack of sleep show. They hadn't discussed last night, and Izuku seemed too nervous to talk about it.

“What’s got you so nervous? It’s just training,” Katsuki barks, making Deku jump. He clearly had not been paying attention to his surroundings. Bakugou scoffs at his idiocy.

“Well, you see, I have a mentor, and he doesn’t know that I’m bringing you. I, uh, should probably call him,” Izuku stammers out. Katsuki’s eyes narrow in suspicion- where did he get this ‘mentor’? He hopes that this dude wasn’t some total stranger with no experience. He sighs, knowing Izuku, he probably found this guy on the side of the street.

He pretends not to pay attention as Izuku pulls out his phone and calls the guy.

“Um, good morning!” Deku yells, a bit too loud, “So, I’m on my way. Mhm! I can’t wait! But I, uh, might be bringing someone?” There’s a long silence, and Izuku winces, shrinking in on himself, “You have to trust me on this All- Toshinori-San. He’s going to find out sooner or later, and I trust him with my life…” Katsuki sees as Izuku’s resolve hardens, “You and I both felt it. If the other users trusted me, then can you?” Izuku’s voice was stronger, and Katsuki almost felt grateful for the fight Izuku was putting up. He was confused as hell though. Past users? Why would it be such a big problem if he joined in their training, anyway? He rolls his eyes.

“How do I know he will find out?” Izuku screeches, “Well, uh, gut instinct?”

Katsuki mutters quietly, “Idiot.” Laughing at the glare Izuku sends him.

Izuku sighs, “Look, you’ve met him before. Remember the blond boy yesterday? Yes, that one.” Suddenly, Izuku brightens up. Katsuki forgot how bright he could shine, “Thank you so much All -er- Toshinori-San! I’ll see you soon. Goodbye.” He hangs up and looks at him, eyes sparkling, “You better be grateful, that was a pain.” Katsuki flips him off.

They reached the beach just as the sun was beginning to show its full beauty, reflecting off of the clouds in warm yellows and pinks. What wasn't beautiful, however, was the beach itself. It was piled high with trash- a makeshift dump.

"Why the hell are we meeting here? Who's this dude anyway?" Katsuki demands. They better not be about to be kidnapped. That is *so* not on Katsuki's bucket list.

Izuku only grins mischievously, "You'll see."

They walk towards the end of the dump, where the sand becomes visible and a boardwalk extends out to the ocean. He sees a tall, skeleton-looking man that's vaguely familiar waving at them. Izuku waves excitedly back. Then, unexpectedly, he grabs Katsuki's wrist and starts to run toward the man, dragging him along.

Once they reach the stranger, Katsuki yanks his hand away from Deku's, ignoring the hurt look on Deku's face.

The weird man smiles at them, though it looks strained, "Young Midoriya, and you must be Young Bakugou. I'm Toshinori Yagi. I believe we've met before, although it was years ago when you last saw me in this form"

Katsuki was hit with a blast of recognition. He *had* met this old man before, when he toured U.A with Deku when they were younger. However, something he said didn't make any sense.

"What do you mean, 'this form'?" He looked at Izuku in question, who avoided his gaze.

Suddenly, smoke engulfed Toshinori. Katsuki takes a step back, and feels his jaw drop when he sees who's now in front of him.

All Might.

"Surprise!" Izuku yells awkwardly. Katsuki wants to punch him, but he's too entranced to see the number one hero. This is the second time in less than twenty-four hours he's seen his idol up close. He's amazed, and totally flabbergasted.

"You're… Deku's mentor?" His mouth is dry, mind whirling so much that he can hardly grasp at words. He's starting to regret coming here with Izu. It's almost too much, and now he understands that this was supposed to be private. He wasn't meant to know anything about this.

Yet, Izuku let him come. Katsuki didn't want any more lies, and Izuku had chosen to show him the truth with this.

He forced himself to take a deep breath and not flinch as All Might coughed, steam pouring off of him before reverting to his normal form.

"He is," Deku confirms, "I'm sorry to do this to you, Kacchan, but what happens next must never be spoked about to anyone else, okay?"

He steels himself for whatever the hell was going to happen.

Izuku watches as Katsuki takes everything in. All Might's quirk, the past users, and Izuku being his successor. Thankfully, he doesn't go too in depth about One for All, he talks about the training regime (Izuku was *so* excited to clean up the beach again) and fails to mention All for One to either of them, which was to be suspected. Afterall, All Might thought AFO was dead, so why dig up old ghosts?

Katsuki looked calm, but Izuku could tell that he was overwhelmed. This was too much to take in at once, and Izuku wasn't only thinking about OFA and him being All Might's successor, but all of it. Being reunited, being held from a distance because Izuku was such a coward, never knowing if he could trust Izuku. Knowing he had caused all of this made him hate himself and want to scream that he was so sorry and that if he could have kept any of this pain from happening, he would have.

Katsuki was quiet for a long time, but they were both patient in waiting for his true reaction. Finally he spoke, and it wasn't what Izuku expected, "How do I not know you're just going to use him as a weapon?" His voice was rasp and defensive.

Izuku didn't know what to think about that question. Yagi had never treated him like an empty vessel. Yes, he wasn't the greatest mentor or teacher at the beginning, but who would be when they had nor prior experience? Yagi treated him like a person, the first one to have done so besides his mother in years.

But Izuku wasn't only a weapon, he was a *war*. In the last timeline, he had spilt blood on both sides. An empty puppet at first turned into a furious monster out for revenge.

He takes a deep breath, pushing the panic down to the deepest corner of his heart. He had to be fine with being this battlefield, if it meant to save those he loved.

Izuku was about to say that All Might won't do what Katsuki fears, that this is okay and he *knows* what he's getting into.

All Might beats him to it and says, "Young Midoriya is a person. Not a weapon. I promise to never treat him as such. A hero isn't just the quirk they possess, but who they are as well. Kindness, compassion, and determination are traits that Young Midoriya possesses, and what will make him a great hero."

Katsuki's silent, a fight in his eyes. He slowly nods his approval and smirks, "Where do we start, Number One?"

Training was brutal. Muscles that he forgot existed were threatening to tear off, and the sweat dripping down his back along with his sweatshirt made him feel gross and claustrophobic. They had started with organizing the sections they were going to do, and then began to move the smaller objects toward the dump. At times, All Might would make them run back and forth as fast as they could while carrying heavy objects. It was a stark difference from running across rooftops with light weapons.

He had caught Kacchan blowing up the smaller items, which each time he had reprimanded him by saying, "Kacchan, don't cheat."

"It's not cheating, Damn Nerd, it's using my resources."

It felt good to work so hard. The exhaustion that came with over exertion of the body was always a feeling Izuku adored, perhaps a little too much. Being so physically fatigued made him feel like he was doing something, and that he wasn't being useless.

They had stopped for a lunch break. All Might had brought the three of them bentos with cute animals made out of rice and vegetables. Izuku gulped down the water, pulling at his sweatshirt. He looked at Katsuki who was wearing a tank top and stabbing his food with his chopsticks, shoving it into his mouth.

Izuku quickly adverts his gaze from Katsuki, cheeks warming up, and not because of the heat. He diverts his attention to his food and takes small bites; he's never that hungry right after an intense workout, but forces himself to eat anyway. He's a bit dizzy, and knows that if he doesn't eat this, he'll for sure pass out.

"All Might," He asks, gaining the hero's attention, "Do you think it will take us the entirety of the ten months to clean this?" His true goal was to have a couple months to adjust to OFA once again, especially if what the past users said was true and that it would be stronger.

He didn't want to gain those hideous scars on his arms that had kept him up at nights, a thousand needles stabbing into them.

Yagi swallows down his food before speaking, "We should be done before then, especially if Young Bakugou continues to help. Although that doesn't mean that you'll be ready- you still have to do training outside of this beach, which we'll do together to make sure you're not overburdening your body."

Izuku huffs, "I can train by myself as well. I know my limits."

"Do you?" Katsuki speaks up, eyes searing him. Izuku ignored him, rolling his eyes.

All Might smiles warmly at him, and it makes Izuku's heart swell. That smile had always given him determination and fatherly love. He had forgotten how much it meant to him.

He's forgotten a lot of things. What was Uraraka's favorite food? What did Iida's voice sound like? What did Todoroki's smile look like?

It was terrible of him to forget his best friends. His classmates face's were faded, the only clear picture of them were their still bodies and pained expressions.

Yagi's voice brings him back to the present, "You can stretch and do some strengthening exercises by yourself, but I want to do the more exerting stuff with you to ensure that you're staying healthy. I advise you to stick to that meal plan we talked about as well. You not only need to gain some weight, but maintain it as well. Otherwise you won't gain the necessary muscle."

Izuku sighs, too tired to argue. He might bend the rules a tiny bit, since All Might had said nothing about not going out at night as Hato.

"Don't worry, Young Midoriya. I'll make sure you're on track."

"Just follow the stupid regimen, Deku. Don't want you collapsing and wasting time," Bakugou says in his own encouraging way.

They get back to cleaning the beach, Izuku trying to hide his simmering frustration. He can't tell them that all he *does* is worry, and that he knows better than anyone how precious time was. Sometimes he wanted to

scream at someone, *anyone* , that he worried to survive and how he was *petrified* that time was slipping through his fingers. He wouldn't know what to do if all of this was for nothing, that none of it changed a thing.

The frustration had pushed him to work harder, numbing his body screaming at him with strained muscles. Katsuki saw him working harder, and like everything else Bakugou Katsuki did, he turned it into a competition. Izuku caught on, starting the game. They moved objects of various sizes and weights with increasing speeds. Katsuki was using his quirk to help him move faster, while Izuku was secretly using his telekinesis to move objects in front of Bakugou, causing him to trip. He couldn't help but laugh at how childish they were being.

All Might let it go on, increasingly entertained by the boys' competitiveness. Once the sun had begun to set, All Might made them stretch before saying their goodbyes. He and Izuku would meet here again tomorrow, and Bakugou would be welcome to come as well.

They started walking to Bakugou's house (Katsuki had brought his bags with him), both of them too worn-out to talk. Izuku felt like he was going to pass out from the way his body was aching combined with the lack of sleep. He dragged his feet against the sidewalk, not having enough energy to pick them up.

"I'll be there tomorrow," Bakugou states as they near his house.

"You really don't have to," Izuku says. Kacchan's presence leaves him on edge at times, like walking blind. He never knew when they were going to burst into another fight, or when Katsuki would demand a further explanation of the past few years.

They make it to the driveway, "See you tomorrow morning," Katsuki waves, completely ignoring Izuku's prior statement.

Izuku waves goodbye even though Katsuki couldn't see it with his back turned and starts the walk back to his cafe. In that moment he finally rolls up his sleeves to let his skin breathe, revealing scars from years of battles. If one were to work close enough, they would also see a set of scars that lined the back of his wrist, made from before he moved to his hips.

He doesn't think he'll ever be able to stop the growing number of scars that adorn his body like tattoos.

Izuku walks into the cafe (sleeves rolled down) and is greeted with the smells of kare rice, a japanese curry. He travels to the kitchen and sees Ru stirring the pot full of curry.

“Anything I can do to help?” Izuku asks. Ru jumps a full foot in the air and shreeks. Izuku bursts out in laughter, lightness filling his stomach.

They spin around, glaring, “Holy shit Izuku! You can’t just sneak up on me! I’m not as young as I used to be, you know.”

Izuku smirks mischievously, “Not my fault you’re not aware of your surroundings.” Ru doesn’t say anything as she turns back to the curry, only giving him the finger.

“To answer your question, yes. Can you get the dishes and set the table? Then we can talk about your day.”

“Of course,” Izuku replies. He starts getting out the bowls for the curry and smaller ones for the rice before placing napkins and utensils on the table.

It’s not long until they are sitting at the table. Izuku’s mouth waters at the sight of the delicious food, stomach grumbling. “Thank you for the meal!” He says before putting a spoonful of the kare rice in his mouth, not caring that it was way too hot.

“Slow down, kid. It’s not going to run away from you,” Ru says as she blows on her food, “So, how was training with that Bakugou guy?

Izuku swallows another bite, “It was hard, but I liked it. I’m going to have to train like this until the entrance exams, so I’m looking forward to getting stronger. Kacchan does well, too. He’s for sure going to make it in.”

“You’ve known him for a lot longer than you told me,” Ru states. It wasn’t a question. Izuku narrows his eyes, not knowing how to continue the conversation. They could have been speculating, and Izuku could write it off and deny it.

Ru speaks again, “I had a talk with Bakugou when you went on your little ‘errand’.” Izuku cringes. He should have known that Ru would try to get more information out of Kacchan. He sometimes forgot how smart Arai was, and it often bit him in the ass.

“Ah,” was all he could say. Shoveling more food in his mouth so he wouldn't have to talk.

It seemed Ru was determined, though, “He also mentioned that you just disappeared one day. I’m assuming that was before we met?” His appetite was slowly diminishing. Not in a million years had he imagined this conversation with Ru. How stupid could he be? Of course they would’ve found out sooner or later.

“I don’t see how this is important.” It shouldn’t be, not to Ru.

Ru slams her fist on the table, making Izuku flinch. He’s never seen them this mad before, let alone at him.

“Don’t you dare say that to me. You have lived with me for over two years. *Two goddamn years.* I’ve never asked because I thought you were an orphan failed by the system, or shushed out by society. But from what Bakugou was saying, you had a loving family trying their darn hardest to make you feel important.”

Izuku chokes down tears. This wasn’t *fair* . He couldn’t explain to Ru why he ran away, not fully. Just like he couldn’t completely tell Kacchan. He was bound by chains of lies and secrets. He for sure couldn’t tell Ru that he ran away to become a vigilante with Stain, who was now gaining the attention of the police. He couldn’t tell her that he had become a vigilante to train for the deadly future, and to take down as many villains as possible that would have posed a possible threat later on. That maybe, just maybe, he became Hato to run away from himself and having to see Katsuki’s face everyday knowing that he couldn’t save him.

They would say he was crazy, and maybe he was.

“Don’t you know how it feels?” Ru asked, tears brimming her eyes, “To have your parents not want you anymore just because you were trying to figure yourself out? To be pushed into a system who didn’t want you because you were too old? To know that you will never have people love you the way your parents used to?”

“Ru-” Izuku’s voice cracked. They’ve never really talked about Hotaru’s past, but Izuku could see now the pain it left engraved on her heart.

“Why can’t you let people love you, Izu?” Ru whispered. Their voice sounded like a heartbreak.

Izuku stilled, “I-what?”

“Bakugou is the first person I’ve seen you be friends with. It took me months for you to trust me enough to *cook* for you. You hate compliments, love hugs but don’t know how to receive them, and you never ever ask for help. You’re my little brother Izuku, let me give you the support you’ve given me through working at the cafe and cheering me on and for just being *there* .”

“You really don’t need to do that,” Izuku rasped, throat dry. There was an onslaught of emotions that he didn’t know how to deal with and it was jarring him.

Ru shook her head, “But I *do.* Can’t you see that that’s what family is for? We lift each other up. Not leave one person to carry all of the weight.”

He covered his face with his hand, hiding his tears. He didn’t want to cry, and didn’t know *why* he even was, but the tears wouldn’t stop.

“Please,” he begged, “Stop. I don’t know how to deal with this. I’m doing *fine* . Ru, please believe me.”

They got up from the table and walked towards Izuku, kneeling down and giving him a hug, “But you’re not fine. I don’t think you’ve been okay for a long time, Izu.” Izuku buried his head in her shoulder and wept. He couldn’t form any words through the storm of emotions and exhaustion, so he just wrapped his arms around Ru, clinging on.

They stayed like that for a long time.

“It’s going to be okay, Izu. I promise.”

Is it?

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the late update! I've been super tired and busy lately. I'll try to get the next one out in a week.

Exulansis

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He holds the glass in his hand, carefully. His pinky finger is extended, far away from making contact with the glass. He raises it to his lips and takes a small sip, enjoying the burn the whisky gives off as he swallows. It's eerily quiet in the bar, as it always is. Kurogiri was usually in the bar keeping him company, but Master needed him for one reason or the other. Shigaraki Tomura couldn't give a flying fuck on what Master needed him for. He was happy to get drunk with no one but himself for his company.

He glares down at the nearly empty glass of whisky, fighting the urge to scratch at his neck. At times like this one, his mind starts to drift to the boy from The Arena; the only reason why he was still alive.

Hato.

He's repeated that name over and over again. It circled his mind when he couldn't sleep (which, to be honest, was most nights), and when he felt crushed by loneliness. He repeated it in order not to forget the one person in his life that seemed to care about *him* . Not who he could be, or what could be done with his quirk, but him as a person of the present. Hato's face had slipped away, only a blurry outline of his image remained in his mind. His voice was all but erased, not that it mattered anyway since it's definitely changed after all of these years.

Tomura finishes his drink and then pours himself another one. All For One had given him a place to stay, a purpose, something to direct all of his anger and pain towards, and he would do anything to make him proud. He wonders what Hato would think about where he was now. One thing he remembered so clearly about the kid was his utter devotion to help people- to damn what happened to him. Would he be disappointed? Pissed out of his mind? Or would he worry and try to help? Tomura laughed at the last thought. No one would be crazy enough to stand up against Master. Besides, he didn't need help. He had someone who believed in him, and that was more than he's ever had before. It's not like he could go anywhere else, anyway. Yes, he had to hurt people and do awful, awful things, but he told himself that it was okay, because those people weren't so good. At least that's what Master had told him.

It was too late for him. He was far too deep in this path toward villany. It was the sole reason why he never let himself think about if he actually *wanted* it.

He wonders if Hato thinks about him as well, or if he's completely forgotten about him. He drowns the sadness and hurt that comes with that thought by finishing his whisky in one swallow, mildly coughing at the rough burn.

It's not like they'll ever see each other again. He doesn't even know if Hato is still alive or not. He tells himself he doesn't care.

The ache in his chest tells him otherwise.

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It was dark out. He was walking outside, and he could see up ahead a city, but it wasn't Musutafu. In fact, it looked out of place, like a stage. There weren't any lights besides the street lamps, making it seem abandoned. A ghost town.

It was then that Katsuki realized that this was another one of those dreams that seemed just as real as reality.

He was beginning to think it might be.

He was overwhelmed by the onslaught of emotions whirling him. He felt anger so hot that he thought it would actually burn him. It was an anger he had never experienced before. It was twisted like a thorn bush, going in so many directions without a sole target. He realized he was the most angry at himself, but he didn't know why.

What was hidden under the fury was a pain that was unlike anything he's had to bear before. Guilt so piercing that it cut right down to his soul, leaving an unerasable scar. Katsuki thought he would choke on it- a part of him hoped he did.

Deku was behind him, but he couldn't bring himself to look at him. He hated him, but that wasn't necessarily true, was it?

Katsuki watched himself. He looked stronger, more defined. He also looked lost.

Katsuki witnessed his fight with Deku. His component with a quirk that must be One for All, but this Katsuki didn't know what that was. He thought Deku had lied to him, and then was only left with twisted confusion and anger when this Izuku had told him that it was a gift.

Katsuki looked on at the violent, emotional fight. He noticed how Izuku somehow looked younger than the one he just saw a few hours ago. He had scars on his arms, but the burn mark on his palm that was in the shape of a star wasn't there. His eyes were livelier, too, and there wasn't any darkness under his eyes, either.

He knew who was going to win before the fight even ended. It wasn't him being overly confident, he just knew.

“Why was I the one that ended All Might?!” His voice was broken and raw- he could hardly recognize himself.

Katsuki froze, refusing to register the words. He… he ended All Might? *He couldn’t believe that. He wouldn’t. It was impossible, but what was this incredible guilt he was feeling, then? He refuses to think about it. He wouldn’t allow this to happen. He would change this painting with his own hands.*

Izuku froze, sorrow and that familiar spark swirling in his eyes. The spark that ignited whenever he saw a person he wanted to help. There was something else in there as well, something that Katsuki had seen in his Izuku’s eyes but could never decipher.

He felt how even though this version of himself slapped Izuku’s hand away, he still wanted comfort. He just didn’t know how to ask for it, and it only cut the pain deeper.

Slowly, the scene began to blur and meld. Then it morphed into another. It was the complete opposite of the one before. He was in his room (but it wasn’t his room, which was really confusing) lying on his bed with his back propped up on pillows. Someone’s head was on his chest, and he didn’t even need to look down to know that it was Izuku. They were watching an All Might movie, their legs tangled underneath blankets, his hand softly combing through Izuku’s unruly hair. The only light illuminating the room was the screen and the warm lamp.

Katsuki had never felt this warm before. He was filled with an affection that he knew was only reserved for the boy snuggled up to him. He was incredibly calm, something he hasn’t been in a long time. He never wanted this scene to end, and would gladly live in it. He watched himself as he brushed his lips on Izuku’s head. Warmth flooded his face, and he looked away, feeling as if he was intruding on a private moment even though this was his *moment.*

Even though he’s seen terrible, awful, things through these visions, he would gladly live through them if it meant he would get this one moment. He would live through a thousand lifetimes just to get to this.

Katsuki woke up with a determination that he hasn’t had in a long time. He knew with absolute certainty that dreams could not contain that amount of emotion, depth, sensations. He’s had horrendous nightmares before, but has not once felt the fear or pain in them as he did in the one where he witnessed his and Deku’s fight. He’s had some wonderful dreams, but never with as much love and safety as that one.

They weren’t dreams. They couldn’t be, and he knew exactly who he had to talk to.

It was a good thing he was seeing him soon.

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The night before…

Izuku was on a light pink bean bag upstairs, covered by cats. There were two fighting for a spot on his lap, a ragdoll kitten named Pocky that Ru had found abandoned a week ago curled on top of his head, and several others purring around him. Across from him was Ru, sitting on their worn gray couch looking the most serious he has ever seen them. He busied his hands by petting the two cats on his lap, refusing to make eye contact with Arai.

“Can you please talk to me?” Ru asked, tone on the edge of pleading. Izuku hated how worried she looked- because of him.

Izuku shrugged, still not meeting their blue eyes, “There’s nothing to talk about.” He managed to barely get his voice above a whisper. It did not make the sentence sound any more convincing. He did not want to be here, and felt like he was about to jump out of his skin. He earned to be outside jumping across rooftops, pretending to be someone he wasn’t.

“You know that isn’t true,” Hotaru responded, not unkindly. “There’s so much going on in that head of yours. Don’t you think it would be relieving to share some of it?”

Maybe, but he couldn’t.

“It would be impossible to form into words, let alone comprehend. Some things aren’t meant to be talked about.”

Ru answered by saying, “And some things are, especially if they’re chipping away at your soul. You’re withering, Izuku.”

Why couldn’t they just leave him alone? Even if he were to talk, where would he even begin? In the first timeline when he was diagnosed as quirkless? Going to U.A and making wonderful friends? Watching them all die, mostly because of him? Or should he start when he traveled back in time, only for things to fall apart when he got sent to The Arena?

If he were to talk, it would be sporadic. Practically in a whole different language that he himself could barely understand on his best of days.

Izuku shakes his head, only to feel guilty when Pocky meows irritatingly. “Why can’t you just let sleeping dogs lie? I can’t talk about it. If I could, I would, but it’s way more complicated than that.”

“You can’t or you won’t?” Ru barks out, frustration at the edge of their voice.

“Both!” His voice cracks at the sudden volume change. His fists are clenched so tight they hurt. He only clenches them harder.

“What about Bakugou? You left him for *years* , and you won’t tell him anything as far as I can tell.”

Despite deserving it, Izuku’s hurt by what Ru said. Kacchan was his weak spot, but also his strength.

“You don’t know *anything* , Arai. Don’t bring Kacchan into this. I’ve lived through enough for two lifetimes, and if you think I’ll be able to just *talk* about it, then you clearly aren’t ready to listen. I’ll talk on my own terms, and I’m asking you to respect that.”

Ru slouched, “And if that’s never?”

Izuku lifts his hand to his head and pets Pocky, “Then it’s never.”

A tear slips down their cheek, “I love you.” It wasn’t what Izuku had expected, but it numbed the sorrow. He hasn’t had anyone say that to him for a long, long time.

He smiles softly, “I love you, too, Ru.” He gently gets up, putting Pocky on the bean bag, and carefully dodges the other napping cats. He hugs Ru tightly, and she hugs back with just as much strength, “I’ll be okay.”

“Please don’t destroy yourself Izu. I wouldn’t be able to bear it.”

Izuku gives her one last squeeze before releasing the hug, “Good night, Ru.”

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He’s outside, legs dangling over the high ledge. The breeze is cool, but not nippy, a hint of warmer days ahead. He knows he should try to get some sleep, especially with getting so little of it the night before, but Izuku had to get out. He yearned to put the mask on and patrol the beautiful city.

So, he did just that.

Hato had been out for a little over an hour, running around the city looking for anyone who needed help. He had decided to sit on a rooftop and gaze at the night-lit city before heading back to the cafe. It was a view he would never tire of, and would gladly give up some sleep in order to view it for a little while. It was perhaps the most at peace he’s been in weeks.

He wished it didn’t have to be ruined so soon.

Hato heard Aizawa approaching, and heaved a sigh once he heard him land on the rooftop he was on. He didn’t bother acknowledging him, hoping that pretending he wasn’t there would make him disappear.

It didn’t work.

Eraserhead walked toward him, and once he got too close for comfort, Hato stood up and increased their distance.

“Midori-”

“Don’t call me that,” Hato snaps. People couldn't leave him alone, could they?

Eraserhead stills, “Hato. Are you going to let me talk, or are you going to run away like you’ve done the last dozen times?”

Hato huffs, a part of him tempted to do just that, but his muscles weigh him down. He doesn’t think he’ll get a block away before his limbs give up on him. So he stays, not saying a thing.

He sits back down again, and so does Aizawa, keeping his distance.

“You’ve been missing for almost seven years.”

“Thanks for the reminder,” Hato snaps back. His head is so heavy, like lead. His eyes burning with exhaustion and mind fumbling incoherent thoughts together.

“Can you at least tell me you’re staying somewhere safe?” Aizawa asked, and there was so much care in his voice that Hato’s anger at him evaporated.

He nods, and Aizawa gives a sigh of relief.

“I saw you on the news the other day. You’re reckless, you know that?”

Hato laughs, although it comes out as a deep release of breath, “Oh come on, it wasn’t *that* reckless.”

“Running into a raging wall of fire to attack a villain with nothing to protect you against? I don’t think you know what the word ‘reckless’ means.” A silence covered them for a few moments before Shota spoke again, “So I take it Bakugou knows where you are now?”

Hato sighs and nods again, “Yup. Trying his absolute best to make me feel like shit about leaving as well. Not to say that I don’t deserve it.”

“He’ll learn to forgive you, if you let him understand.” It was a hint at something more. To tell a story that wasn’t meant to be told. Not yet.

He changes the subject, “How’s Eri-Chan?” He thinks about her a lot, and guilt gnaws at him for leaving her.

“She gets better everyday. You should hear her laugh; it’s amazing. She asks about you a lot. How you’re doing… when she’s going to see you again.”

“Soon. I’ll visit her and spoil her so much that she’ll grow sick of me.” He gets up on aching legs, knees popping. Eraserhead stands up as well, turning to face him.

“I’ll hold you to that.” With a final nod, Hato is jumping across rooftops, albeit a bit clumsily. Luckily the cafe isn’t too far, and he manages to get to his bedroom window without falling from a roof. He slides it open and quickly gets ready for bed.

As soon as he hits the comfort of his blankets, he’s out.

This is a very shitty drawing of Hato’s vigilante costume that I drew ages ago and kept forgetting to post. If someone wants to redo it, please do! Just comment if you have, and we can get connected through email so I can post it (with credit, of course)



Chapter End Notes

The next chapter might take longer, but I promise it’s going to be good! I’m so excited to write it hehe

Unwoven

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku wakes up full of an anxious energy that makes him want to run across the city and back without stopping. He hops out of his bed and hurriedly puts on his workout clothes: A navy sweatshirt with his “shirt” shirt underneath and black athletic shorts. He only has a couple of scars on his legs, the most noticeable is a straight silver line on the side of his left calf from when an arrow grazed his leg in The Arena. All the other ones are from falling off of rooftops or falling in general.

He slides down the railing and is surprised to see Ru already up with breakfast and a packed bento.

“Good morning, hero-in-training! I made some onigiri with eggs in it for breakfast and packed you a bento. Need to keep you well-fed!” Izuku’s struck by just how lucky he is to have Ru. Without them, he would probably be surviving off of instant raman and protein bars.

He runs over to Ru and hugs them tightly, “Thank you,” He whispers, meaning so much more than making the food.

Ru ruffles his hair, “You’re welcome, little dude! Now come and eat with me before you have to go away. I steeped some White Peony tea as well.”

They eat silently, but it’s not uncomfortable. Izuku embraces it, not often getting peaceful quietness. His muscles are aching from yesterday, but it’s a good sort of ache. One that tells him that he trained hard- something he’s going to do again today. He thinks of seeing Kacchan again today, and finds himself both excited and terrified. Bakugou Katsuki is both known and unknown, and Izuku hates not knowing when he’s going to get pestered again by where he went, what he did, why he left. He hates coming up with answers that only ever skid past answering the actual question.

Breakfast is over sooner than he liked and Izuku packs some black sesame cookies for All Might and a container of homemade hot sauce he had made a few days ago for Kacchan.

“I’ll see you soon, Ru. Try not to drive the customers away!”

She waves her hand, “Pft, I’ll have trouble getting them to leave! Be safe, Izu.”

Izuku smiles, anxious to get this hungry energy out, “I will.”

He runs.

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He sees Katsuki walking along the path to the beach and runs to catch up to him, yelling his name.

Bakugou glances at him and keeps walking, but noticeably slows down to make it easier for Izuku to catch up to him. Izuku is quick to get to his side and instantly notices that while the blond looks like he got no sleep, he also seems to have a powerful energy radiating from him that just screams *Kacchan.*

“Good morning,” Izuku says, a bit forcefully. He wants to act normal around Katsuki, but knows that doing so would only make him more rightfully angry. It leaves him scrambling to figure out *how* to act in front of him without screwing things up further. Katsuki doesn’t say anything. Izuku can’t tell if he’s ignoring him or is just lost deep in thought, or both. He pulls his yellow backpack around and hands him the container of hot sauce.

Katsuki stares at it like he’s never seen anything like it before, “What the hell is this?”

“Hot sauce. Homemade. I made it a few days ago and thought you might want some.” Now that he’s saying all this is aloud, he feels stupid. Bringing someone hot sauce as a gift? Seriously? He might not even like it. He’s tempted to tear the container from Katsuki’s hands and stuff it back into his backpack, pretending nothing ever happened.

Katsuki stares at it a moment longer before putting it in his bag, “Thanks,” his voice contains the roughness of someone still waking up,”I’ll have some for lunch.”

There’s a long pause as they continue walking before Katsuki speaks up again, “Yo, Nerd, do you have a phone?”

Izuku stumbles mid step before swiftly recovering, “Er, yeah? I don’t really use it often.” It was a present from Ru the first Christmas they spent together. He only had Aizawa’s, Tsukauchi’s (it was funny annoying them), and Ru’s phone numbers. He had hacked his phone in order to make it untraceable and really only ever used it to tell Ru if he was running errands. Maybe he sent Aizawa funny cat videos, but that was neither here nor there.

Katsuki holds out his hand, “Gimme.” Not seeing any reason to argue, Izuku unlocks it and hands it to him (the wallpaper being the Cafe’s logo behind a periwinkle background). Katsuki fiddles around with it before handing it back. Izuku looks down to see that he had added his phone number under the contact number ‘Kacchan’. He can’t control the smile that grows.

“Why did you give me this?” He asks, not able to come up with any logical reasons.

Katsuki huffs, “So we can keep in contact, obviously. And so I can bother you whenever I want.” He smirks at that, and Izuku internally groans. Handing him his phone was a mistake.

He pouts, “Whatever.”

They reach the beach soon enough where All Might is waiting, and after a quick warmup, they’re back to cleaning the beach. It’s grueling work, and Katsuki being oddly silent is stressing out Izuku. He pushes himself to work at a steady pace, trying to ignore everything else. He wipes his mind clean of the past and future, and if an unwanted thought occurs, he just forces himself to work harder.

They end earlier that day; at lunch time. Izuku feels disgusting with the sweat sliding down his sweatshirt and sticking to his back and yearns to take a shower.

They sit down on the hill of grass, and Izuku gives the cookies to All Might. His heart swells at the grateful smile the hero sends him- a part of him still a fanboy.

Izuku and Katsuki hungrily dig into their packed lunches, and Izuku tries to be discreet as he watches Katsuki try the hot sauce with some of his boiled egg. He doesn’t say anything, but he does start to lather his other food in the spicy sauce as well. Izuku shoves down a laugh with some of his food, trying not to be too proud of himself.

“You two are doing a wonderful job. It’ll be cleared out in a few months time- probably even before the ten months are up,” Yagi comments as he takes a drink of his smoothie.

“I have school, so you losers won’t have me to help you until the weekend,” Bakugou says pridefully, but Izuku can tell that he’s disappointed to be missing out.

“Young Midoriya, don’t you have school as well?” He shrinks slightly with both Yagi’s and Kacchan’s eyes on him.

“I’m homeschooled, but I’ve technically completed the required education for my age, so I’ve just been reading here and there to keep my mind fresh. The person I live with gives me assignments as well, but since I’ve finished everything, I technically don’t have any ‘school work’.”

Yagi nods, as if that makes perfect sense, “I see. You still have to study for the written part of the entrance exam, though, so make sure you keep up with your studies. That includes you, too, Young Bakugou.”

Bakugou scoffs, “Of course I’ll be ready for the entrance exam, Old Man. I’ve already started to study.”

Izuku smiles at him, “You won’t have any problems getting in, Kacchan. You’re so smart.”

For a moment it looked like Katsuki had blushed, but Izuku wrapped it up to the training.

“Like hell I won’t! I’ll pass that damn test with a perfect score!”

Yagi and Izuku both laugh, in which Katsuki only grumbles some more. Before long, Yagi is giving them his goodbyes, saying he’ll see Izuku in two days (tomorrow is supposed to be a ‘rest day’), and walking off.

Izuku’s legs are jello, but he forces himself to stand up. He wants to help Ru with the cafe as much as he can today and tomorrow since she’ll be handling a lot of it on her own most days. Besides him, Katsuki is still sitting. He has a serious look on his face as he looks towards the horizon. It makes him seem older than he is, and that scares Izuku. Being older means that time is slipping by, and the timer is getting closer and closer towards going off.

He’s getting sick and tired of always being terrified.

Before he can say anything, Katsuki says, “We need to talk, Izuku.” He could be talking about a million and one things. Every single one is a subject that Izuku doesn’t want to talk about now, or for the foreseeable future.

“Sorry, Kacchan. Maybe some other time? I really want to help Ru with the cafe today”

Katsuki talks as if he didn’t hear a thing he just said, “Sit. This can’t wait. Stop running off and let me talk, and *listen.”*

Izuku’s cornered, and he knows it. If he declines this invitation then Katsuki will only be angrier and delay the inevitable.

So he sits, hoping that he can spin enough lies to protect his secrets that are embedded into his heart.

He's going to get the truth out of Izuku. Because he knows that somehow, *he* is intertwined in Izuku's secrets. Izuku is the lock, and he better be the key.

The Damn Deku is sitting so close to him, yet he seems worlds away. How can he know someone so well, but still feel like he's looking at a stranger? He knows what he wants to say, but struggles to say them out loud. The words are right there in his mind, but he's afraid that saying them out loud will cause something to irrevocably crumble. He refuses to look right at Deku in fear that whatever expression he's wearing (or trying to hide) will prevent him from saying anything.

Katsuki clenches his fists and takes a deep breath. It's one of those rare times he hopes to be wrong. That nothing is serious and he's just being overly paranoid.

But it's Izuku, and nothing is ever straightforward with him.

"I've been having these dreams," he sees Izuku flinch from the side of his eye, and all of his hopes of this being simple diminishes, "They feel so *real* . Like a memory that you've almost forgotten, but still hold on to the main fragments of. You're in them, always, or at least the presence of you is always in them. You're so *different* in them too."

He pauses, letting Izuku jump in and fill in the gaps. He sighs when he doesn't and continues, " *Fuck* . I know this sounds batshit insane, but I don't think these dreams are *dreams* . They've happened, even though I'm older in them, and know people I've never met before, I just *know* . And I think you know what I'm talking about, and that you can explain what the hell is going on because I am so damn tired of secrets."

He finally looks at Izuku, and the first thing he notices is how utterly still he is. Katsuki isn't sure he's even breathing. He's paler, too, the flushness of his face from exercising completely nonexistent. His eyes are dull and filled with uncontained fear. He looks terrible, but like everything else, Katsuki refuses to back down.

"You're being paranoid, Kacchan. They're just dreams," Izuku whispers. His voice breaks and he's curling in on himself.

He's lying, and oh how that angers Katsuki.

"Stop lying," He sneers. Izuku curls further in himself, gripping his arms so tight that Katsuki doesn't doubt that they won't leave bruises later on.

“Lying can be a kindness,” Izuku says, like that’s a perfectly sound argument for this.

“I don’t give a damn about kindness, Deku. You should know that, or do you not know me anymore?”

“I’ll always know you, Kacchan. Always.” It comes out as barely a whisper, and if Katsuki wasn’t so close to him, he wouldn’t have been able to hear it.

“Then tell me, and don’t say ‘it’s not that simple’ or ‘you won’t understand. *Make* me understand.” He could tell that Izuku was finally cracking. There was want in his eyes, and in that moment, Izuku seemed so impossibly alone. “Let me be with you,” Katsuki says, trying to convey how much he wanted to help Izuku. How he didn’t need to be alone. That he would always be within reaching distance.

It is then that Izuku started to shout, “And where the hell would you want me to start, huh?! You’re wrong: it’s not simple, and you don’t even know what you’re asking for. As soon as you know, you’re going to wish that I’ve never told you.” Katsuki had never been so happy to have Izuku anger directed towards him. He was finally getting through, even if it was just the prologue to something much bigger.

“Maybe I won’t, but that’s not for you to decide,” Katsuki pauses before adding, “Start from the beginning.”

“Which one?” Izuku laughs without humor. His hair is covering his face, shadowing his face from any emotion.

Katsuki stills. His head is pounding with the inevitability of something huge. It feels like a dam moments away from breaking. He clenched his eyes tight to try to get rid of the feeling. It doesn’t help.

“What?” He rasps, barely able to get the word out. Sensations are flooding him. He hears the phantom of laughter and drums and shouting. He smells smoke, newly sharpened pencils, and freshly baked cake. He feels love and rage and pain. He nearly forgets where he is, what he’s trying to do.

“There’s so many pathways I could take to tell you. Do you want me to start when I was first diagnosed quirkless?” Katsuki stifles a gasp. Did this really start a decade ago? But the statement felt wrong, as if there was a big chunk he was missing. He rubs his temples and tries to concentrate as Deku continues, “Or when I first met All Might, and how much more you despised me when you found out I had a quirk?”

What? Why would he despise him? He already knew what this training was for, and while he was a bit jealous that All Might noticed Izuku first, he wasn’t hateful towards him.

Deku gives a self-deprecating laugh, “Or maybe when we became friends again, and you apologized for all of the shit you pulled me through?”

Shadows of images of Izuku in a middle school uniform backed up in a corner shaking. Of people laughing at a pathetic quirkless person, everyone encouraging Katsuki to be crueler, crueler, crueler-

Pray for a quirk in your next life, and take a swan dive off of the roof of this building.

“Oh my God,” Katsuki says. He’s shaking and terrified of everything, but Izuku’s trapped in his own world and fails to notice. He feels like gravity is pushing him to the ground, growing heavier with more pressure.

He might be sick.

“How about when everyone died because of *me* , and so I went back in time to try and save everyone. To try and save you.” Izuku isn’t crying, but he sobs. It’s perhaps the most gut wrenching sound Katsuki has ever heard and he doesn’t ever want to hear it again.

Katsuki remembers. He remembers that masked hatred he felt towards Deku, his idiotic friends, his first date with Izuku at the amusement park (he’s in too much shock to process *that*), and he remembers dying.

The pain he felt was white-hot. The feeling of being drained of blood is dizzying and awful. But the worst part was seeing Izuku’s face while he was holding Katsuki. It was nothing short of broken, and he wanted nothing more than to see his best friend smile. He remembered wishing for more time, so he wouldn’t leave Izuku all alone.

“Oh my God,” Katsuki repeats. He can’t… he just *can’t* . Fuck, fuck, fuck wholly *shit.* His mind goes on overdrive. The memories from before and now were mixing together making him disoriented. A lifetime of Izuku always by his side whether he liked it or not, of nights lying awake hating him in order to ignore his bleeding insecurities. Then there was the time when they were always together until Izuku wasn’t there anymore, and then he was for what felt like seconds before he disappeared again. When he lied awake thinking about why he couldn’t stop thinking about him and why the hell he had left.

He suddenly felt so very old from what he had been just a few moments ago.

He tries to crawl away, to stand up, to fucking move, but his body ignores his commands. He’s stuck, but his mind was racing. At last, he moves and grabs hold of Izuku’s shoulders. The Damn Nerd flinches like he forgot

Katsuki was there. He could tell by the hunch of his shoulders that Izuku wants to get away from him, but Katsuki won't let him.

"Izuku," he breathes, "I remember." It was perhaps the most important two words he has ever said. It seemed to have made time slow all around them. They were the center of the universe.

For a moment, Izuku only blinks at him, and Katsuki could've sworn he saw a spark of hope in his emerald eyes, "You what?"

Katsuki couldn't believe that Deku had somehow done… this. Fear swallowed him at the fact Izu had been carrying this for over a decade. The nightmares he always had and his intelligence started to make more sense. He finally had the puzzle pieces he had been missing for years.

He tries not to choke on his words, "I- I don't remember everything, but I can *feel* it. It'll come to me, I fucking know it. I just- I, *how?* "

Everything was going too fast, and it was affecting both of them. Izuku looked like he was on the edge of a panic attack, although he hid it well.

"Back before," he sniffs and gasps for breath. Acting as though Katsuki was the only thing anchoring him, "When I was with the League. As… As a 'last gift' Tomura gave me another quirk."

Katsuki interrupts him, "'Another'? Did they give you more? Shit, what did they do to you? There was never a chance-" He cuts himself off. There wasn't a chance because one day Izuku had shown up with the League, looking like the only thing keeping him standing was the hatred tortured into his skin.

Then it was a bloodbath. And it continued to be even after Izuku had broken out of the spell he had been under.

Deku shakes his head, "It doesn't matter. He was being controlled like the rest of us, and- and he wanted me to change everything. I didn't know what he had given me until I had done it."

He recalls that last time he saw Izu before he was taken by the League. He and Izuku were taking Kota to the park when a villain from the LOV had flown into Izuku.

Kota had only wanted to help, but the villain was too powerful for them -just heroes in training- to fight and simultaneously protect the boy or even get him far enough away from the destruction.

They were both on the ground, and Kota had blocked an attack that was meant for Izuku.

He was dead before he hit the ground.

After that, it was a sea of uncontrollable green lightning. It was equally horrifying as it was tragically beautiful. Katsuki had been trying to revive Kota, hoping that he could save him.

In the end, Izuku had exhausted himself along with losing himself to grief and anger. It was then that the villain had taken him out.

Izuku was gone by the time Katsuki had called out his name.

“Do you really remember?” Izuku asks, breaking Katsuki out of his tumbling mind. The other boy had basically collapsed into him, as if all of his strength had left his body. Katsuki held him while trying to keep him up.

“I do,” he whispered into his hair, tangled and messy.

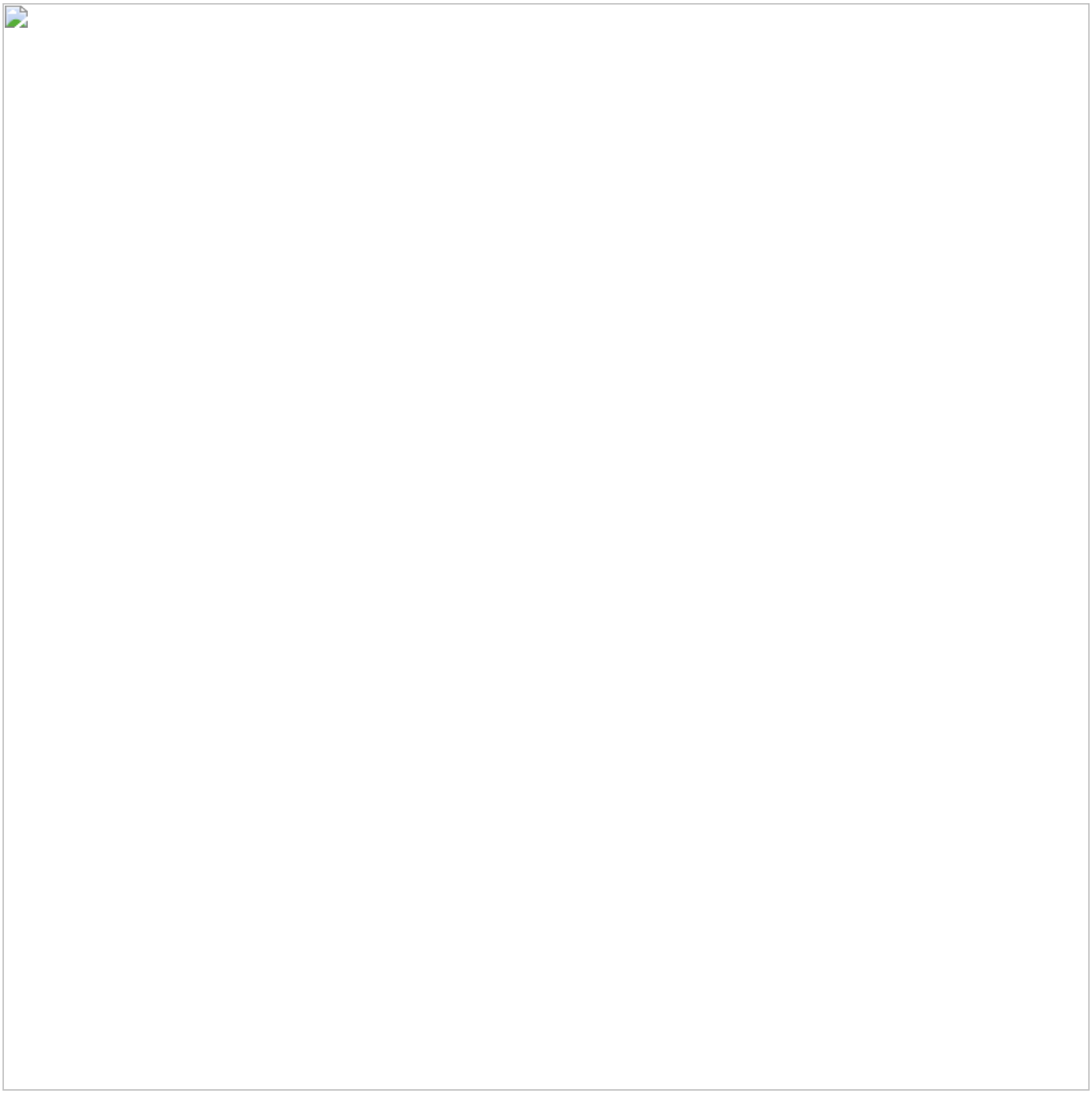
“Thank you,” was the last thing he said before passing out into his arms. The stress he must’ve been experiencing along with the training and lack of sleep finally catching up with him. Katsuki had no idea what he was thanking him for. Shouldn’t that be the other way around? He’s the one who went back into time and bore the weight of the world.

Katsuki didn’t know what else to do, so he went back to the cafe.

He wondered when he would come out of the pure shock of it all.

All he knew was that when reality crashed down on him, at least he had the present to come back to.

Nao did this wonderful piece of Hato! Way way better than mine! Thank you so much :D



Chapter End Notes

Thoughts? Not exactly how I thought this chapter would go, but I like it.

Take care!

Amae

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He was floating. It reminds him of the days in the dorms where he'd wake up to the sun warming his face and his body being comfortably hugged by his mattress. The feeling was a dream itself, one he had forgotten ages ago but embraced so easily.

The stillness of his body and deep relaxation of his bones was what startled him to fully awake. He came to the slow realization that he was being carried, and once that fact settled in, his body turned to an intense thrumming of adrenaline and panic.

He was being kidnapped. Izuku had no idea how or when, but why else would he be on someone else's back? He couldn't believe he had been stupid enough to let his guard down. He should know far better by now.

Izuku's eyes snap open. He twists his body to the side so his legs are wrapping around the person's torso. He then proceeds to put both legs on the ground and flips the person on to the ground.

"What the *fuck-"* yells the oddly familiar voice. Izuku breathes hard, and it is then that he remembers where he was, and who he was with.

Which meant that he had just tackled Kacchan.

Izuku gulps. He was a goner. This was it. Katsuki was going to bury him alive.

He scrambles to apologize, "Kacchan, I'm *so* sorry, I thought-" he was being kidnapped, but what sane person would have that as their first thought when they woke up to being carried by someone?

Maybe he had lost his sanity. It wouldn't surprise him, especially when there were times when he felt so out of body that he didn't feel human at all. Maybe he's lost his humanity altogether.

He tries not to think about it too much.

"The *one* time I tried to be nice, and you tackled me to the ground! Damn Nerd!" Izuku winces, offering his hand to help Kacchan up.

Katsuki stares at it, melancholy swirling in his ruby eyes. It's then that Izuku realizes that Katsuki remembering wasn't a dream. It was real. So very real.

Offering his hand to help Kacchan has just become so much more. It was a symbolization of everything they were, of what they will become. Children in a river, students trying to deal with what life was becoming, a promise to be together.

They were walking around the campus. Both had decided to ditch their friends at lunch in order to spend some time alone with one another. They've been dating for a month and no one has a clue that they've become more than rivals. It's a mystery that no one's figured it out, with how snoopy the class was.

They were holding hands. Katsuki's smooth, warm hand squeezing gently on Izuku's rough, scarred one.

"We should do this more often," Izuku had said. It wasn't often that they got time alone together, especially with such a tranquil setting.

"I wouldn't mind getting away from those extras now and again," Katsuki grins.

Izuku bumped into him playfully with his shoulder, "You love them."

Katsuki stays silent. Izuku looks at him questionaly, feeling Katsuki's hand squeeze his tighter, but not uncomfortably so.

He stops walking, and Izuku stops with him. "Kacchan?" He asked. Katsuki's face was relaxed but serious, an expression not often found on him.

Katsuki lifts their joined hands in front of them, and makes eye contact with him.

"I love you," he had whispered like it was a secret meant for only them to share. Izuku's breath faltered, his heart skipping multiple beats.

Surprisingly, Izuku's eyes hadn't watered. He grinned so big that his cheeks had hurt. He squeezed Katsuki's hand in return.

"I love you too, Kacchan."

To them, it wasn't just a confession; it was a promise. They would be together, hold on to one another, and always accept the other's hand.

Katsuki and Izuku stare at each other. Izuku's just about to pull his hand back when Katsuki grabs on to it. Izuku automatically helps him up, butterflies fluttering in his stomach.

Izuku tries to let go of his hand, but Katsuki holds on to it. He looks up to see Katsuki staring intently at him.

"Kacchan?" He questions, butterflies flying away.

"There's so much I still don't know. So much shit has happened, and I doubt I even know half of it." He's serious, and Izuku knows that he won't be able to get away. Not when his body keeps on gravitating towards him.

But telling him everything? That's too much. It's then that the recent events catch up to Izuku. Katsuki remembers. He *remembers* . How does he not hate him? After all, it was Izuku's fault that their classmates, their *family* had died.

Katsuki remembering was both a beautiful dream and a horrible nightmare. He was no longer alone in some ways, but now he wasn't the only one who knew how much of a monster he was.

And Katsuki said not everything had come back yet. The fact that more memories will come back to him leaves Izuku breathless.

The past is only half of the story. They both know that. He knows that Katsuki deserves everything laid bare, but Izuku doesn't think he can do it.

Faintly he realizes his vision has begun to blur. His breathing becoming rapid.

He would have to talk about The Arena. How Tomura was captured by AFO and now he's probably being controlled by him. Does he even remember him? Izuku had promised that Tomura could come home with him after they got out, but that promise turned out to mean nothing.

God, he had *killed* people. Even though it was better them than the children fighting to their deaths, he had still taken lives. Jude, who was a horrible person, died because of him. Madoka, a child barely getting a taste of life,

taken away from him. He probably killed people during the battle with Overhaul. Hitting people with a giant tree was *definitely* lethal.

He was a *monster* . He tried to make amends by saving people and slashing himself with a razor, but it was never enough.

“Iz..u.”

Both of his hands were clenching his sweatshirt. He wanted it off, but he couldn’t remove it. Not with Katsuki there. His body was a shattered vase, impossible to put back together . He was leaning forward, gasping for air. The words *monster, killer, a useless son of a-*

“Izuku-”

He felt hands on him, and all he could think about were the hands that tortured him when he was captured by the League. The hands that had electrocuted him in The Arena. The hands that had threatened to take him apart and put him back together again.

They were still on him. They were *always* on him. He needed them off. His body reacted for him, flinging the hands off of him with his quirk. Enough force to send the person skidding a couple feet away. He faintly heard explosions, but couldn’t register them for what they were.

“Goddamnit, Izuku! Listen to me!”

Kacchan .

He gripped at his sweatshirt harder, trying to ground himself. His hearing was muffled, eyesight blurred with unshed tears. His back was drenched in sweat, his shirt sticking to it uncomfortably. He wanted to close his eyes and fall into a deep sleep filled with nothing. No dreams, no sensations, no nothing. A deep, dark, black hole.

Izuku took a slow inhale of air, trying his hardest to slow his fast breathing. His hearing began to clear, and he could hear Katsuki’s footsteps coming closer. He straightened his back with wobbly knees and looked up at Kacchan's concerned face. His arms were pink and lightly skinned. Izuku knew without a doubt that that was because of him. Katsuki only knew him to have his invisibility quirk. Definitely not a telekinesis one. He felt his eyes widen as he took a step back.

He had *flung* Kacchan off of him. He really does screw everything up, doesn't he?

"Deku-" Katsuki says, and Izuku almost melts, but instead he takes another step back.

"I'm sorry," he says because it's the only thing he knows how to say anymore. Panic still grips at his heart. The strain of not falling back into the panic attack was exhausting him.

"Don't-" he shakes his head, "I don't accept your apology. Not when there was nothing to be sorry for."

Izuku's knees give up on him, and he collapses to the ground. Gravel digs into his knees, but he hardly notices. All he notices is the person in front of him.

Katsuki comes closer and drops down onto his knees as well. His eyes are stern; determined. Izuku wants to yell at him to stay away, that he doesn't deserve him.

"I'm sorry," Izuku says again. He's sorry for so many things, and he will keep on being sorry forever no matter how many people say that they forgive him or that there was nothing to be sorry for.

He's never going to forgive himself.

"I'm not accepting your apology, Izuku." His head suddenly feels impossibly heavy, and he can't stop himself from falling into Katsuki's chest once again.

"I don't know what I'm going to do," he whispers.

"You will," Bakugou states as if it were a universal fact like how the sky is blue.

"How do you know?"

Izuku can't see Bakugou's face, but knows without a doubt that he's smirking.

"Because you have me now, obviously."

Izuku takes a deep breath as he stands in front of the entrance to Kaiteki Cafe. He's still shaken up from the past few hours, and will probably be for a while. Bakugou stands beside him silently. His presence alone is enough to give Izuku the confidence he needs to compose himself.

He grips the handle and swings open the door. They must've just missed the lunch rush since most of the cats are not in the front -most likely in the back napping or eating- and some of the tables have yet to be cleaned. There's a small scatter of people on their computers working, reading, or talking with a companion. Ru is up front wiping the counter. Their hair was sticking up in all sorts of directions, almost mimicking Izuku's unruly hair.

He walks towards the counter with Kacchan in tow. He forces himself to smile, but it probably looks half-assed.

"Survived rush, I see," He says as a greeting. Ru's head snaps up, their face holding a radiant smile despite the weariness she must have been feeling.

"Barely. Hi Bakugou. Are you staying over again?"

Katsuki shrugs, "For a while, if that's okay." Izuku can't believe how polite he can be when being a guest in someone else's home. He rolls his eyes. He doubts it'll last that long.

"Of course! This little dude needs a social life."

"Hey! I so do have a social life." If you count pissing off pro heroes and villains and snuggling with cats.

Ru sends him a look that says *yeah, right* . Izuku huffs, knowing better to argue further. He ignores Katsuki's cackle.

"Do you need any help?"

Ru shakes their head, "Nah. I'll be closing in a few hours. Maybe later you can get take out for us from that yummy ramen place?"

Izuku nods instinctively, eager to help, “Sure thing!”

“Okay, now you two get out of the way and do whatever teens do these days.”

Izuku sighs as they make it up to his room. He’s thankful that he didn’t have to help out with the cafe today, even though he would’ve if Ru asked. His social battery was near nonexistent, and he knew his nerves would only mess up people’s orders.

He sees Katsuki look around his room as if it was the first time seeing it.

“You cut down on the merch,” he says, observing.

Izuku shrugs, sitting down on the fluffy carpet and leaning his back against the leg of his bunk bed, “Too much money. It’s easier to be minimal.”

“In case you need to make a quick getaway,” Bakugou commented, bitterness in his tone.

He flinches, “Kacchan-”

“Don’t.” Izuku doesn't try to say anything after that. He knows better than that. He knows that Kacchan needed the quiet in order to process. And there was a *lot* to process.

He tenses as Katsuki picks up the small -now frayed- pink ribbon that was sitting on his desk.

“You still have this?” It was the ribbon that Madoka had. For the longest time, he had refused to take it off, but after becoming a vigilante he grew afraid that it might break and he would lose it.

“Please don’t touch that,” he retorts. Katsuki sighs and sits down across from him, lying down on his back with his hands cushioning his head.

“You’re going to have to talk, Deku.” Izuku falls to his side, turning onto his back. Inches away from Kacchan.

“About what?” He wasn’t playing dumb. There was so much he could say, and he was afraid that if he started, he would never be able to stop. There was also the matter of the fact that it was impossible to know when to start.

“Why didn’t you tell me?” Kacchan whispered, starting a surge of anger through Izuku. He was always, burning burning burning. He wondered how long it would be until he simply evaporated.

“Why *would* I? I had no idea that you would remember. If I suddenly told you that I was from an alternate timeline trying to save the future, would you have believed me if you didn’t remember? No, you wouldn’t have.” He tries to take a deep breath, but it’s shaky and doesn’t really help, “Even if I *did* have any semblance of hope that you would remember, when would I have done it? When you were four? It was nearly too much for you now. There would be no way even you could handle that sort of breakage of your mind on top of learning to control an incredibly powerful quirk.”

He wasn’t angry at Katsuki- not really. He was simply angry at everything and nothing at once, so maybe it wasn’t simple at all.

“What about the other quirk?” Katsuki asks. Izuku sighs. His mind usually running with an overwhelming amount of words empty.

“I’ve been developing them over the years I guess. The League had ‘gifted’ them to me when I was with them” He shudders, remembering the pain that came with having a quirk forced upon him. His body being forced to expand and reshape each molecule in order to fit another one. It was like slowly being cut open with a knife.

Katsuki’s palms crackle, but he doesn’t say anything. Izuku thinks that maybe for once, he doesn’t have anything to say. Or maybe he had too many things to speak aloud that it all just canceled out into nothing.

They’re both silent for a long time. Thoughts of Katsuki hating him coming back to haunt him. He would be more surprised if his best friend *didn’t* hate him. But God, he didn’t think he would be able to handle it if those words were spoken aloud by Katsuki. He’d rather keep the fear to himself than make it into reality.

Izuku flinches when Katsuki grabs hold onto his hand and squeezes it tight enough to hurt a little. Izuku keeps his hand slack, afraid that moving will cause the hand in his to disappear.

“I don’t hate you, Shitty Nerd,” Bakugou says, looking up at the ceiling.

Izuku jolts in shock. Had he been muttering? He really needs to break that habit. “Wha-” He starts out before Katsuki starts to speak again.

“You weren’t muttering. You think so loud that it’s giving me a headache. Damn annoying.”

Izuku scoffs, “You’re just saying that.”

While Izuku can’t fully see his face, he knows that Katsuki’s raising an eyebrow, “When have you ever known me to not tell the truth in order to be nice?”

“Why don’t you?” The words escape his mind before he has a chance to pull them back.

“I want to,” Izuku flinches at that, “But I can’t because you’re the same damn Deku as you’ve always been. Trying so hard to help people. Hating you would be impossible.” They both roll to their sides to face each other. It reminds Izuku of their sleepovers as kids, giggling softly to each other, and then later on at U.A. when they kept each other company when feeling like the world was against them.

“But you have every reason to hate me. I *killed* our friends, and then I left you for nearly seven years!” He wasn’t lovable. He couldn’t be- not after everything he’s done. Everytime he tries to help or do the right thing, someone ends up getting hurt.

He’ll never be a hero.

Izuku recognizes the irritation swimming in Katsuki’s eyes, “You didn’t fucking kill them! I know you’d rather die than lay a scratch on them. When… when *that* started, you weren’t there. Sure, your body might’ve been, but that means nothing. *You weren’t there.* And then you were, and you fought with us.” Izuku curls in on himself, hugging their conjoined hands close to his chest. He doesn’t cry; doesn’t make a sound.

“I know you don’t believe it right now, but I’ll *make* you believe it. If not right now, then someday.”

He knows Katsuki is signing up for a futile goal, but doesn’t have the heart to tell him.

He slowly gets up, letting go of Katsuki’s warm hand while simultaneously blocking out all emotions. He can’t afford to feel too much. It would be dangerous and a waste of time. He’s done enough *feeling* today to last him a whole lifetime.

“We should head out to pick up dinner. The walk usually takes a while.”

Katsuki quickly gets up, “Deku-”

Izuku turns towards him and smiles, “Come on, Kacchan. We can talk more later, okay?”

“We better be.”

Izuku nods, wanting nothing more than to crawl into a ball and turn invisible. To disappear only until things were okay again.

He doesn’t remember the last time anything was okay.

Chapter End Notes

I really like this chapter :)

I hope everyone is doing well!

Never Again

Chapter Summary

Izuku never knew he could fear fear.

Until now.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hato tries to regain his breath as he stares at the guy on the ground with a head wound oozing blood. He had caught the middle-aged man stalking a group of kids, his danger sense going off at the mere sight of him. Whispers in the wind of *catch him, danger* repeating as Hato trapped the guy in a dark alleyway. The streetlamp had been the only light as they fought, not that Hato needed light when he could rely on his other enhanced senses.

The tall, lanky man had a quirk that allowed him to shoot daggers out of his wrists. It was a dangerous quirk, but he lacked experience in fighting, and that's how Hato was able to win so easily.

He had never seen this man before, but something about him had irked Hato. It wasn't often that he'd see villains by themselves, which meant that this man was just starting on his path to villainy and was incredibly stupid, or he was a part of a larger group.

Wanting to leave as fast as possible, Hato sends his location to Tsukauchi, leaving him five minutes to get out of the area before they arrive. He kicks the villain for good measure, and when he's satisfied that he won't be waking up anytime soon, turns to leave.

Only to freeze as an overwhelming presence appears behind him. All of his senses go into overdrive. The whispers turned into shouts along with a thumping pain in the back of his head.

Run, get out, run run run-

He slowly turns around, heart threatening to leap out of his chest. His breathing becomes shallower as his body prepares him to fight or run.

He meets a man towering over him with a horrendous wide smile.

His smile is the only thing that lifts his face. Everything else is covered by massive scar tissue overlapping in all sorts of directions.

Hato's blood runs cold. He doesn't run, or fight. Every muscle in his body has been frozen, and for a second, he thinks it's because of a quirk, but then he realizes it's not.

He's afraid. More terrified than he's been since he saw this same exact man staring at him (he doesn't have eyes, but Hato *knows* that he's being analyzed for his every flaw) at the arena, grinning at Tomura with an extended hand.

All For One.

_____

A few hours earlier…

They had just finished dinner and were back in Izuku's room. Both of them were on Izuku's bed staring at the ceiling that was only a few feet above them. The evening had been quiet- Ru being the only one with the motivation to chat. They asked endless questions about Katsuki ranging from his favorite color (green) to if he thinks he would survive the zombie apocalypse (in which he said, "I'd kill all of those motherfucking zombies").

Ru had smacked him over his head and told him not to use that language in front of Izuku.

(They always used that sort of language around Izuku)

Now, silence blanketed them once again. It was dark in his room, the sun long ago setting. Izuku closed his eyes, liking the feeling of floating in self-induced darkness, trying to ignore how close Katsuki was.

"I should get going," Katsuki whispered, a breath in the infinite darkness.

Izuku locked his lungs, forbidding himself from saying *don't go. Please, stay a little longer.* He nodded, offering to walk home with him.

"I don't need you to walk me home, Izu. I can take care of myself."

Izuku still followed Katsuki out of bed anyway, saying, “I know that, but I wouldn’t mind another walk.” Meaning, in reality, that he wanted to stay up a little longer, leaping across the night sky.

“Whatever, Nerd.”

Izuku took that as a yes.

The walk to Katsuki’s house was comfortable. The spring night was chilly, and Izuku curled into his purple hoodie. He had his backpack on that contained all of his gear. Luckily, Katsuki didn’t mention him bringing his bag, only giving him a weird look.

Izuku gazed at Katsuki’s house with longing, wanting to go in and tell the Bakugous that he was fine, that he was *alive* .

Katsuki looks at him and sighs, “When are you going to let yourself see them again?”

Izuku shrugs solemnly, “I don’t know. Soon, maybe.” He wanted it to be soon. He missed them so much- they were the only other connection he had left of his mother. Right now, though, it would be too much.

Katsuki doesn’t say anything as he gazes back to his home. Then, “See you after school tomorrow?”

Izuku nods, “Yeah.”

Katsuki scoffs and turns to walk towards the door with his hands in his pockets, “I can’t believe I have to go to *school* tomorrow. Now I know I’m definitely smarter than all of those extras.”

Izuku laughs loudly, a raw sound escaping his mouth without permission. It shocks him at how free it was, and how light it had made him feel.

“Good night, Kacchan.”

Katsuki waves, “Night, Nerd.”

_____

“Now who might you be?” All For One asks with an innocent curiosity that contrasts his menacing aura.

How he wished he hadn’t succumbed to the urge of putting on his mask.

Hato stays silent, eyes darting to every possible exit, but he knew it was futile. AFO would catch him before he even took a step. Staying still was the only thing that could get him out of this alive. He hoped.

AFO’s smile broadens, nearly taking up half of his face, “Oh, I know! You’re that little kid that plays pretend hero, aren’t you? What’s your name again? Ato? No, that’s now right. Ah, I got it! You’re Hato!”

He tries to breathe, but he’s frozen. Terror grasps at his heart. He’s never been so terrified.

AFO performs a mock bow, “People call me All For One. It’s a pleasure to make your acquaintance Hato. You’ve been causing me quite some trouble.”

Hato forces himself to talk, “What have I done now?” Does AFO know he’s Izuku? Does he even remember what happened? What *will* happen? What Izuku had done?

AFO chuckles, “Well, first of all, you just took out my newest recruitment. Not that I’m mad; you did me a favor. Now I know that he’s no use to me.”

Hato chokes on his dry mouth, wanting to cough, “You’re… welcome?” he rasps. He wants to sound confident, unbothered. He can’t even convince himself.

“Yes, I suppose I should be saying thank you. You’ve also taken out Chisaki, which wasn’t ideal. I had my eye on him, but you sadly took him out of any equation that I might have formed.” AFO frowns at this, almost looking disappointed.

Hato wants to go home.

“What do you want?” Hato asks, not knowing what else to do. He’s woozy, and it’s taken everything he has not to throw up his dinner.

All For One walks closer, suffocating Hato with his menace, “What do *I* want? Hmm, I want many things, Little Hero. Why don’t you join my League of Villains and find out?”

Hato takes a step back instinctually, “No thanks. I like what I’m doing now.” AFO’s face tightens, a wide smile transforming into a disappointed frown.

“And what is it that you’re doing?”

“Pissing off heroes and villains alike.”

AFO barks out a delighted laugh, nearly stopping Hato’s heart. The villain starts taking a step back, melding with the shadows.

“I’m sure I’ll see you again, Little hero. Try not to get in my way when you do.”

And then he’s gone.

Hato drops to his knees, ripping off his mask as he gasps for breath. Tears stream down his eyes as he chokes on air. He recognizes sirens in the background and hurriedly crawls to a darker corner, turning invisible as he does. His legs refuse to give him strength to stand, let alone walk. So he clutches his knees tight to his chest and the police come and take the villain to the ground. His whole body is shaking and once the police finally leave he throws up violently. Spitting out the excess vomit as he heaves for air, tears and snot and saliva mixing together in a terrible mess.

It takes him an hour to get back to the cafe that’s ten minutes away. He clumsily opens his bedroom window and falls into his room. His funny bone hits the ground hard, but he hardly notices it. Izuku flips onto his back and heaves for breath, desperate sounds come from him as he does so. He’s drenched in sweat, but freezing. He fears he might die, and for a moment he truly believes he will die. That AFO had actually killed him and he was just a lost spirit.

Izuku had just encountered All For One. Did he know? Did he *know?* Know that Hato was Izuku, his son, and that he reversed time to defeat him before he killed everyone and everything he knew?

He claws off his sweatshirt, thinking it will suffocate him if it’s on him for a second longer. He pulls at his hair and claws at his skin, trying to get the encounter of his father off of him. Izuku chokes on a sob with half the mind to be quiet so as to not wake up Ru.

Izuku stays like that for a long time, somewhere in between reality and a world of horror. Eventually, his mind and body shut down, and he falls into dreams that only feed on his panic.

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He wakes up that morning, only a few hours after seeing AFO. His skin has marks from sleeping on the carpet, and his joints are stiff, letting out loud pops as soon as he starts to move. Izuku feels sick, and moments later he runs to the bathroom to throw up once again.

The image of All For One standing over him imprints itself into his mind so that it is all he can see. A shiver runs down his spin at the memory of his stretched smile and eyeless face. Izuku knew he could still *see* him, even without his eyes. His invisible gaze had made Izuku feel the weakest he's been in a long time, and it made him want to crawl out of his skin.

After what feels like hours, but couldn't have been more than half an hour, he gets up from the bathroom floor and washes his mouth out with some water before crawling to his bed. He cocoons himself underneath his blankets, for once not caring that he was supposed to help Ru with the cafe today. Not having the energy to care. He can hardly even look at himself without his heart racing at the moment- he doesn't think he'll be able to interact with anyone else, either.

Izuku closes his eyes once again, hoping to sleep the day away, forgetting that he was supposed to see someone today.

He wakes to the sound of his phone alerting him of a notification. He rubs the sleep from his eyes and sees that it's already dinner time, meaning he's slept the entire day. Izuku also notices several messages from Kacchan in varying degrees of anger and one message from All Might. He clicks on the one from All Might:

All Might

Good morning, Young-Midoriya! I've been sent out on a mission this week,

so I won't be here to advise your training. Here's a list of your training regime for

the week. Don't over do yourself.

Below the message is his day-to-day training and rest days. Izuku sends a thumbs up, not having energy to send anything else. He doesn't even bother looking at Kacchan's messages. Instead, he shuts down his phone and hops off of his bed. He smells whatever Ru is cooking, waking up his appetite. His stomach bites at him in hunger, winning against his nerves that threaten his need to eat.

He puts on a sweatshirt and weakly stumbles down the stairs. He goes to the kitchen where Ru is and instinctually starts setting the table.

“Well, you look like shit,” Ru comments, not bothering to hide their slight irritation.

Izuku huffs, putting the chopsticks and napkins on the table, “Thanks… Sorry, I really didn’t mean to sleep that long. I wasn’t feeling well. I’ll make it up to you.”

Hotaru hums, “You don’t need to make it up to me. I’m glad you got some rest- you needed it. *However* you do owe me for kicking Bakugou out when he came to see you. I could practically see the steam coming out of his ears by the time he left.

Izuku winces, “Sorry. I’ll bake some pastries tonight for tomorrow. I’ll make some sandos that you love as well.”

Ru puts two steaming bowls of curry on the counter and grins, “I suppose I can accept that.”

They both sit down, “Thank you for dinner. Sorry that I didn’t help out today.”

Ru slurps at her curry and waves him off, “I forbid you from saying sorry.” Izuku grimaces, and shoves some food into his mouth, finally realizing how hungry he is.

“How was the cafe today?” Izuku asked, mouth still of food.

Ru wrinkles their mouth in disgust, “Ugh, why do you have to be so gross? Teenage boys are the worst.” Izuku wipes his mouth and laughs.

“I would say sorry, but you just told me not to.”

Ru gives him the middle finger, “It was pretty steady business today. You should have seen this one girl, though. She was a cutie! Bubblegum pink hair, beautiful emerald eyes, and a sleeve tattoo! Izu, you know how I feel about *sleeve tattoos,”* Ru sighs dreamily. Izuku rolls his eyes, remembering one night where she talked to him for a whole hour about women and tattoos.

“Yeah, yeah, I know. Did you at least get her name?” Ru looks at him blankly, and Izuku sighs, “Really, Ru? You didn’t even ask for her name?”

Ru groans, “I was entranced, okay?! She had me under her quirk.”

Izuku takes another bite, making sure to chew and swallow this time before speaking, “She might come again if you didn’t scare her off with your ogling.”

“You think?!”

Izuku sighs.

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He goes back up to his room after Ru retires to bed, having spent a few hours hanging out with them. He’s still wide awake, and wants to put off sleeping for as long as possible.

He doesn’t want to find out what horrors his mind will conjure up.

Izuku’s reminded of the training list All Might sent him. Today’s technically supposed to be his rest day, but he’s already gotten more than enough sleep *and* it’s a little bit past midnight. Meaning that today was actually yesterday.

He can train tonight (or this morning) and then some later in the afternoon. Deep down, he knows that over training won’t do him any good, but he *needs* it. It’s something -one of the only things- that Izuku could control. His encounter with AFO only reminded him how weak he still was, and he knows he won’t feel better until trains at least twice as hard.

Without hesitation, Izuku puts on his workout clothes and hops out the window.

A sick part of him wants to train until he’s too exhausted to think, to stand, to fear. Because he can’t be afraid. Fear will only kill him.

Izuku promises himself to never lose control of his body like that ever again.

Chapter End Notes

I was going to post this last week, but I got sick. Stupid school and teenagers with their nasty germs. Ew. I can't believe I have to deal with these people sneezing on everything and not washing their hands.

ugh.

Thank you for the patience! I hope you have a good week!

Hiraeth

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku knells over, sweat dripping down his forehead onto the cool sand. The sun was rising over the ocean in beautiful pastels, but he hardly took notice of it. He had run the entire length of the beach and back again as his warm up then proceeded to practice strengthening his telekinesis quirk while simultaneously trying to turn invisible. He found that using two quirks that were both physical straining was a lot more difficult than he had initially thought. He hasn't been able to turn invisible while using telekinesis yet, but he seemed to have gotten better at lifting heavier objects.

His mouth moves in incomprehensible mutters, still leaning over with his hands on his knees, "I wonder if when I pulled that tree out of the ground during the Hassaki Raid it unlocked some sort of extra strength in my quirk. It would make sense because ever since then it's been easier to lift heavier objects." To prove this, he goes up to the dump and finds a fridge that's a fairly big size and uses his quirk. His muscles tighten, and a warning of a migraine comes with a pang in the back of his head, but the fridge floats several feet in the air. Izuku floats it towards the rest of the garbage that they had taken out and lets it go with a loud *thump* .

He was dizzy from overworking himself, and he hasn't had anything to eat since the night before. The only thing that was keeping him from falling over was the rage and fears that coursed through him. It was an addictive feeling: to be so angry that anything seemed beatable, breakable. This must have been what Kacchan had felt like. Izuku suddenly understood why the blond always latched onto anger. It was a safety blanket that made one feel invincible. Even with that, Izuku loathed it. It made him feel out of control, and how he hated to be out of control. He couldn't stand it.

Needing to get everything *out* , Izuku walked towards a worn, metal storage container and started to punch it with bare fists, invisibility fading away. He screamed even when his voice cracked. He thought that if he yelled loud enough, hit harder, stronger, all of the panic would seep out of him. But it didn't. It never did. He wanted to get AFO's face out of his head, but it never left him.

He punched again and again until he heard a loud crack followed by throbbing pain surrounding both of his hands. He looked down to see that his hands were a bloody mess, covered in red and torn skin hanging on by a thread. His right thumb was bent at an unnatural angle, and he cursed.

Izuku didn't even know where to begin with cleaning up the mess. The entirety of Izuku's hands were screaming in pain, and the blood prohibited him from seeing where he was actually hurt. He couldn't use his healing quirk- that only worked on other people. He's used it only a handful of times since first unlocking it when Ru got shot. And while his quirk healed the person who had gotten hurt, it only transferred the pain to him, but better him than anyone else.

"Ru is going to kill me."

“Not if I beat them to it,” a voice says from behind him. Familiar and rough and angry. He had been so lost in himself that he hadn’t even paid attention to his surroundings.

Kacchan had snuck right up on him. Izuku stole a sharp breath of air, the agony in his hands no longer at the forefront of his mind. He slowly turned around, not knowing what else to do. He met Katsuki eye to eye and witnessed the moment Katsuki saw the state of his hands.

“Shit, Izu. Are you trying to fuck up your hands again?”

Izuku didn’t have any energy left to react. Maybe he had been trying to ruin himself, so what? It’s not like he couldn’t still feel the phantom pains of breaking his arms repeatedly until they were covered in more scars than actual skin. There were nights where he lay awake and swore that his arms were throbbing and tensing up.

He looked down at his wrecked hands, realizing that he wasn’t wearing his usual long sleeves. There weren’t many scars- most of them being from The Arena and vigilantism. But there were clean silver lines on his forearms that weren’t noticeable at first, but once seen, they were impossible not to notice. He glued his arms to his sides, a weak attempt to have more secrets revealed.

Realizing that Izuku wasn’t going to say anything, Katsuki started talking again, “Are you trying to ignore me? That’s not going to work. You’re damn lucky I respect Arai enough to not barge into their house and drag you out of your room.”

“I wasn’t feeling well,” Izuku muttered. It was the truth, but a broad one.

Katsuki scoffs, eyes narrowing on the blood dripping from Izuku’s hands to the powdery sand, “And now you are? You went from not even being able to answer your phone to *this* ,” he gestures to the beach and him. “In less than a day? I’m getting sick of your excuses.”

Izuku clenches his hands, making the blood come out faster. He winces. Kacchan walks the last few steps to him and gently -something that surprises Izuku- grabs both of his hands, “What the hell are you doing? What happened?” He was getting Izuku’s blood onto his hands, but didn’t seem like he cared in the least. Izuku gulped, briefly thankful that his forearms were facing the ground where Kacchan couldn’t see them.

“You were fine when I went home. Or do I really not know you anymore?” Katsuki’s voice was tough, but Izuku could hear the pain in his voice. He hurriedly shook his head.

“After all these years, you still know me better than anyone.” Katsuki looked up from their joined hands, a question in his eyes.

“I-,” Izuku swallowed, “After you went home, I- um, ran into someone.” His spin crawled with the memories of that night, the terror stapled to his skin. His lungs constrict.

“Who was it?” Katsuki growled. Izuku yanked his hands back, disgusted with any sort of contact. The loose cloth of his clothes made him feel suffocated.

“People call me All For One. It’s a pleasure to make your acquaintance Hato. You’ve been causing me quite some trouble.”

Izuku shrivels back, swallowing bile.

“Izuku,” Kacchan says, calmer, “What happened?”

“All For One,” he spits the name, gasping. His heart gives a jump at the name and he hates himself for it. Katsuki’s recoils, eyes going wide with shock.

“W-what?”

“I was- I saw-.” He couldn’t get anything out, and it wasn’t just fear. Because to tell him about the encounter, he would have to tell him about Hato.

Katsuki straightens, quickly getting over his surprise, “Did he do anything to you? What the hell happened?!” It was weird how Katsuki’s shouting and anger could help calm him. His voice was grounding, and something that Izuku clinged onto desperately.

“No. He just-. He didn’t know it was me.” Katsuki’s face contorts into confusion, “I was fighting a new recruit of his, not that I knew he was with All For One.” Not being able to hold himself up anymore, Izuku sinks down onto the plush sand, hugging his knees. “He introduced himself to me. Asked if I wanted to join the League. When I said no, he just *smiled* and disappeared. I don’t think he had any idea who I actually was or that I was from the future.”

“What do you mean he had no idea who you were?” Katsuki bit out. The answers to his question were multiple. He didn’t know that he was his son or that he was a vigilante.

He smiles bitterly, “Kacchan. Do you really think that I would sit around doing nothing but waiting? When I knew that I could be saving and fighting evil, awful people? That’s not me.”

Katsuki drops down to the ground. Face going slack in shock, “The Hassaiki Raid. There was a masked person there fighting with the heroes. That was you, wasn’t it?”

Izuku was silent. For once, his mouth refused to blurt out words.

“Tell me! Is that why you left?! To play fucking hero?!” Katsuki’s face was squinched up in anger and bitterness. It was a face that Izuku had memorized to the very wrinkle on the corner of his eye. He always thought that Katsuki looked gorgeous like this. Like a kindling flame full of vibrant colors.

But Izuku could see the hurt there, too. And that, he didn’t like nor did he think it was beautiful.

He nods, although it’s as if someone else had taken over his body, “I had the opportunity, and I took it. I couldn’t just stand by when I knew I could do something. I’m incapable of doing that, and you know it. And Kacchan, I’ve *helped* people. Countless people who wouldn’t have been saved otherwise. I’ve taken down villain organizations that would have become a part of the League.” He knew he sounded desperate, but couldn’t control it. He needed Katsuki to understand that he was doing *everything* he could. Making sacrifice after sacrifice for the sake of others.

The next moment, Izuku was lying on his back, face pounding in bruising pain.

“What the-” he said as he stood up to face the now standing Katsuki. His fists were clenched, small pops being emitted from his palms.

“And what about you, huh?!” Katsuki screamed, startling Izuku enough that he took a couple staggering steps back, “How many times have *you* gotten hurt? How many times has someone saved you?”

“Why does any of that matter? I’m still here, aren’t I?” The pounding of his cheek subsided, but he still winced at the stinging of his hands. He looked down to see his black tank top stained dark with blood. He frowned at the ruined new shirt.

Katsuki laughs, but it’s deprived of joy, “Not really. You’re a shell of the person I knew. I thought you were a self-sacrificing idiot before, but *now* . You cease to surprise me.”

It's Izuku's turn to be overcome with anger, "And you just expect me to be the person I was before?!" He waves his hands around in frustration. Losing the care of hiding his arms, "I *can't* be. Don't you get it? Everyone *died. You* died. I was the only one left breathing in a battlefield of bodies. And then I was a kid again and I didn't understand *anything*. Then I got trapped in the fucking death ring only to come back two years later to the knowledge that my mom was dead- one of the people I wanted so much to save. I'm not who I once was. I *refuse* to be."

His throat was raw and dry, muscles aching. He wants nothing more than to collapse onto the sand and close his eyes. But he keeps on standing.

Katsuki's eyes shine, and he hastily wipes them with his arm. Izuku's eyes remain dry, perhaps because he's finally run out of tears, or doesn't even have the energy to produce them.

"You're right," Katsuki bites out, shocking Izuku, "You can't be the same, just like I can't be, now that I remember. But goddamnit Izu, just because you're not the same doesn't mean that I care less about you."

Izuku gulps, too shocked to do anything. "When you saved Eri… You got *shot* . I saw it on live television," Katsuki continues, "You've been hurt countless times with vigilantism, and don't you dare try to deny it."

Izuku thought about saying that he was okay with being hurt, that he thought he deserved it. He kept his mouth shut, not wanting to delve into *that* conversation. Feeling self-conscious, Izuku walks over to his sweatshirt lying on the ground and hurriedly puts it on, not wanting to push further chances of Katsuki seeing his scars.

He turns back to face Bakugou, "Kacchan, getting hurt is inevitable."

Kacchan yells in frustration, and Izuku is overcome with confusion. Bakugou wants to be a hero, and technically already was one, and he understood how dangerous it could be. He had experienced it first hand multiple times.

"But you can *prevent* it!" He yells, "The thing is, I think you try the bare minimum in avoiding getting hurt. Damnit, Izuku, you even met *All For One* and you don't even care!"

"Of course I care!" Izuku screams, the sound being torn from his throat violently. It was an ugly sound. He sees that he shocked Katsuki, but the words keep on flying from his mouth, "You have no *idea* how terrifying it was. He could've found out who he was if he bothered removing my stupid mask. He could've killed me before I even blinked. I was so *scared.* I couldn't even move! I was powerless. Completely powerless."

It was like he was quirkless again at the mercy of his bullies or anyone with the time of day to tell him that he was *beneath them* and that they could hurt him however they wanted because he couldn't do anything about it.

They stay quiet for a long time, staring at their feet. The pain of Izuku's hands is forgotten momentarily. The only thing he can think about is Kacchan, and how messed up everything was.

"Are we always going to be like this?" He whispers, more to himself than Katsuki.

"Like what?"

"Always yelling, fighting- always so *angry* . I don't want this. I just want-" he stops, not knowing the answer to his phrase. But then the answer slips from his lips, "you."

He immediately goes bright red and stumbles to cover up his slip. He had not met to say that. He didn't know what he had met to say, but was definitely not *that* .

He moves his hands up to cover his face, but then remembers what a mess they are and just starts flinging his arms all over the place, "Oh my god, I didn't mean to say that. Please ignore that. In fact, just ignore me right now. I'm a mess. Ohmygodthisissoembarassing-"

He's interrupted by Kacchan's loud, boisterous laughter. His face heats up even more, "Kacchan! Not funny."

The boy continues to laugh, holding his stomach, "You-" he starts before laughing again, "are such a fucking dork. Oh my god."

Izuku sighs, flabbergasted but relieved not to be yelling anymore. He patiently waits for Katsuki to calm down, tapping his foot restlessly on the sand.

Katsuki wipes a stray tear from his eye, and Izuku feels his lips twitch. It was refreshing to hear Katsuki laugh so freely. It was a sound he hadn't heard in a very long time, and it was just as wonderful as he remembered it to be.

Katsuki turns serious again, causing Izuku to stiffen. He gestures to his hands and says, "I'm taking you to the hospital."

"No."

“Yes.”

“Fuck.”

_____

It’s a few hours later and they’re both in his room. Izuku’s hands are itchy and heavily bandaged, and his cheek has an ugly bruise on it making it impossible to hide from Ru. When she saw them enter the cafe her face went slack and then in the most monotonous voice Izuku had ever heard said, “You little shit. You’re lucky that you made all of those delicious treats last night, or I’d *so* be on your ass. I should ground you. And you!” they pointed to Katsuki who gulped, “Why did you let him do this, huh?! Oh you better keep one eye open tonight, mister.”

Once they finally made it up the stairs they talked about Izuku’s vigilantism. What he did, how often he went out, in which Katsuki said, “Do you ever sleep?” Izuku laughed at that. He even talked about working with Stain for a bit and his other quirks that Katsuki hadn’t seen yet. He told Kacchan about Aizawa and how he knows his identity and has been having dreams, too.

“Why haven’t you told him?”

Izuku shrugs, “Didn’t know what would happen. To be honest, the thought of you guys remembering hadn’t truly crossed my mind. I *hoped* for it, sure, but I didn’t believe it for a second.”

Katsuki hums, “You should tell him.”

Izuku scoffs, running a hand through his messy hair, “Then what? He might not react the same way you did, Kacchan. He might learn to hate me.”

“Oh please, Aizawa would never hate you. I’m pretty sure you’re unhateable.” Izuku begged to differ, but knew better than to say anything out loud.

Katsuki continues, “You know he’s going to find out eventually.”

“Maybe, but that doesn’t have to be right now.” Katsuki sighs and closes his eyes. They’re both lying on Izuku’s bed, close enough to touch. They stay apart.

“You should probably go. I have to help Ru close up shop.”

“You're really kicking me out, huh?” Katsuki says in a teasing voice.

“Whatever, I’ll see you in a couple of days.”

Katsuki gets up and Izuku follows. They go downstairs to the door where Ru and Katsuki say goodbye. Katsuki turns to face Izuku, “You’re not going to ignore me this time?”

He shakes his head, pained but understanding of the distrust, “No, I won’t.”

Katsuki nods, “Well, see ya’ Nerd.”

Izuku smiles, “Bye, Kacchan.”

Chapter End Notes

Hope the chapter was decent :)

Take care of yourselves!

Past to Presen

Chapter Summary

Months pass, seasons change.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Past to Present

Slowly, the months begin to pass. All Might comes back from his mission and as the weeks pass, the training gets harder, the objects being lifted heavier. The trees form blossoms which then turn into lush green leaves as summer comes.

Izuku tries to forget about his encounter with All For One, but it's like a scar, fading but never disappearing.

His hands heal, leaving silver lines not unlike the ones he's had before. It makes him seem more full somehow, as if he was an empty canvas before and now he's finally getting painted on. That's probably not the most healthy outlook on his gaining collection of scars, but it's the only one he has.

The dump is slowly diminishing, and after five months of working on it, they are now more than halfway done. All Might never fails to express his amazement, and Izuku never fails to get flustered. Even after all of this time, his heart swells at every compliment the hero gives him. Big or small. They talk outside of training, too. About life, memories, and dreams.

"I know it's silly, but a part of me has always wanted to run a small book store. Featuring books from retired heroes that don't get heard anymore for the only reason being their retirement. Whether it was because of injury, age, or life. I think that the ones who fought before us are the ones you ought to listen to. Besides, sitting down with a good book and a cup of tea is great for the soul," Yagi had said one time while they were looking around in a crack in the wall bookstore.

Izuku shook his head, "It's not silly. Someday, you should fulfill that dream. I'll be your first customer. Kacchan will be your second, of course."

Yagi smiled, warm and deep in his scrawny form, "Thank you, Young Midoriya."

Izuku was able to get a hang of managing training with the cafe as well, and he learned to relieve his stress through experimenting with new foods and drinks. He still resulted into some of his not-so-healthy habits when things got too stressful, too dark, too sad, but those days were reaching far in between. Most days, he was too tired to do anything besides collapse in bed and fall into an empty sleep.

He had, on multiple occasions, been yelled at by both Kacchan and All Might for overworking himself. Especially when they found out that he hadn't been taking rest days and instead was doing extra training instead. He was doing a pretty good job at hiding that fact, until he passed out in the middle of combat training with Kacchan. Neither had even gotten a hit in before Izuku started to feel light and dizzy, as if he were floating in the air. He knew he was going to pass out, but by time he had figured that out, his mind had turned to white static and his mouth refused to form words.

In conclusion, All Might and Kacchan had *not* been happy.

He and Kacchan hung out as often as time allowed them. It was difficult when they were both leading completely different lives. Katsuki still had to go to school and not be gone too long, thus his parents got suspicious, and Izuku had the bakery and vigilantism.

Katsuki had tried to stop him from being Hato, but it was a futile argument and they both knew it. However, Katsuki hadn't given up as per usual and was not afraid to bring up his opinion whenever the topic came up.

The thing is, Izuku *knew* Katsuki was worried about him. Being a vigilante was just as dangerous as being a pro, if not more so. But Izuku loved the danger. Each time he stepped out of the window, mask on, he knew he was risking his life. He *made* that decision. It was one of the few things he felt he had control over, and he was desperate to hold on to it. He needed to know that he could still help people- that he wasn't an entire waste of space.

It was one of the only things he refused to listen to Kacchan about.

It was the end of summer, and a miserably hot day. Izuku was working the front while Ru went to buy more cat food and ingredients. He doesn't work the front often, preferring to be behind the scenes, but he doesn't mind it. He enjoys making conversation with friendly people and bringing smiles onto their faces when they take that first sip or bite. He finds that most people that come here aren't rude, and when he does get a grumpy customer he knows deeply that no one can be happy all of the time. Making those who can't seem to smile smile is one of the most rewarding things about working up front.

It's a slow Monday afternoon with only a couple of customers inside doing their work on a computer or playing with the cats when his hearing catches onto a very familiar voice. Sweet and soft and full of wonder. Izuku recognizes the voice immediately and the gruffer, deeper voice that follows.

He doesn't have any time to react when the door chimes open revealing a little girl with gray blue hair wearing a red sundress with running horses going around the bottom hem of it. With her is a man wearing all black and a scarf despite the weather, looking like he doesn't know what 'sleep' means.

Automatically, Izuku says, "Welcome in." He immediately winced. His shoulder rode up to his head as if it would help disappear.

Eri’s face brightens up, putting the sun to absolute shame, “Deku-nii!”

Izuku sees her, and he crumbles. Face giving a way to a wobbly smile and watery eye. He hops over the counter using one hand and catches her running form in a giant bear hug. He runs his hand over her soft hair and revels in the fact that she wasn’t afraid to hug him. She’s grown a bit since he last saw her nearly half a year ago, and she’s not as skinny. He silently promises to give her as many pastries as she wants because this wonderful girl deserves it. He’ll grow an apple tree through the crack of the cement if she asks and so much more.

He lets go of her reluctantly but stays on his knees to be eye level with her, “It’s so good to see you, Eri-Chan. And you’re so strong now! Have you been lifting weights?” Izuku asks only to hear Eri laugh. It works, and the cafe is filled with laughter that sounds like beautiful wind chimes.

He stands up and finally forces himself to make eye contact with Shouta. His eyes are wide in disbelief, and Izuku would've found it funny if it were any other circumstance. His stomach twists with that familiar sensation of anxiety and dread. Eri grips his hand tightly, her little hand only being able to wrap around four of his fingers. He instinctively squeezes back gently.

Izuku breathes, forcing down the usual urge to run. He paints on a smile, and internally cringes at how fake it must look like.

“Coffee?”

_____

They were both sitting on a wooden bench at a nearby park, watching Eri look for caterpillars. Ru had come back, and let him take a break. Eri had filled their walk with questions for Izuku, making sure to ask every once in a while if she was being a bother.

In which he always said, “You’ll never be a bother to me, Eri-Chan.”

“How are you?” Aizawa asked, drinking the strongest blend of coffee they had. They haven’t seen each other in a couple months. Izuku’s vigilantism had gotten cut back in hours due to how physically exhausted he always was (he nearly passed out a few times on patrol) and overall how stuffed full his life has become. There had been multiple occasions when they had come close to crossing paths, but Izuku had always heard Eraserhead and made sure to go in the opposite direction.

He wasn’t avoiding him. He just didn’t have time to chat, that’s all.

“Fine. You?” Izuku hugged his knees to his chest.

“Fine.” Izuku huffs a laugh. They liked to share details, didn’t they?

“You’ve been avoiding me,” Aizawa says, and it might’ve been Izuku’s imagination, but the man sounded offended.

“Been busy. That’s all.”

“How long have you been at the cafe? Do you live there?”

Izuku smirks, “Why all the questions?” His chest constricted. The unwanted thought that maybe, just maybe, Aizawa could remember, too. That there could be one more person to share the weight of this crushing burden.

Shota sighs, “Come on, kid. Is it really that hard to believe that I care about you?”

Yes.

“I’ve been living at the cafe for about three years now. The owner has been taking care of me.”

He sees out of the corner of his eye Aizawa straighten up, “Arai, the person who was kidnapped. They’ve been taking care of you?”

Izuku nodded, surprised that he remembered, “Yes.”

“I’m glad that you’re someplace safe, kid.” Izuku denies that any warmth flooded his chest.

Izuku stands up, stretched, “I’m going to be applying to U.A. this spring, so be expecting me to be your student.” He grins, knowing all of the trouble he and his classmates were going to cause Aizawa.

Aizawa stands up as well, a look of dread crossing his face and then confusion, “How are you going to pass the entrance exam? You’re… You’re *supposed* to be quirkless. But you’re not.”

Izuku shakes his head, “I’m not.”

Aizawa frowns, “You have two quirks, don’t you? You healed Arai’s wound and you lifted a *tree* from the ground.”

This is the part where Izuku starts to withdraw from the conversation. He starts running towards Eri, pretending he didn’t hear Shota’s words. He knew that he would eventually have to tell him *something* , but he could at least delay that inevitability.

It was at that moment, that he realized how much fear controlled him.

And he didn’t quite know how to stop that.

_____

It was the next day; well into the night. Hato was perched on the edge of the building like a hawk. Using his enhanced vision to zoom in on the city grounds. For once, he was full of energy. Kacchan had practically forced him to go back to bed after he walked into the cafe and got one good look at Izuku (his stare did *not* make Izuku blush). He hadn’t gotten much sleep the night before (by that he means none). His mind raced with thoughts on his encounter with Aizawa, who now knew where he lived.

Speaking of which, Eraserhead was right next to him grabbing any sort of detail that his eyes could gather.

He doesn’t know what to say, so he says nothing. The only indication that he gave to the hero that he knew he was there was a split second of eye contact.

“I had another dream about you last night,” Aizawa says, breaking the silence.

“Cause’ that’s not creepy at all,” he’s happy at the fact that he managed to hide how much that sentence nerves him. A shiver crawls up his spine. It’s not because of the cold.

Aizawa ignores him, “It was the first day of class, and I was testing all of you. Bakugou was there, too, and so many others with such potential.”

“I bet I aced the exam with flying colors,” Hato says, although they both know that was not true. This is the first time that someone has actually told him in detail about these dreams. Whenever he asked Kacchan about them, he simply huffed saying, “Nothing you don’t know about.” He doesn’t push any further than that. He’s not sure he wants to know what Katsuki saw before he remembered everything.

Aizawa almost laughs, “No. I was sure you would be my first student who I expelled.”

Hato winces at that, “Did you?”

The older man shakes his head, “But I didn’t. You surprised me. Something that’s hard to do. For everyone but you, that is.” He stops talking, looking as if he’s trying to grasp onto his thoughts, “You had this… *power* unlike anything I’ve ever seen. Different from the quirks you have now -which you still need to tell me about-. It was bright and strong and it wrecked you. It was as if you were a four year old who had just gotten their quirk.”

Hato laughs. He wasn’t far off.

“But it wasn’t just your quirk that I’m talking about,” Shota continues, “You had this aura that just radiated *hero* . From that first day of class, people had gravitated towards you, and you didn’t even know it. And Bakugou… He *hated* you. You were terrified of him. It was wrong, watching you guys repel against one another.”

Hato doesn’t say anything. He remembers what they were like. How could he forget when memories still flash in front of his eyes from when everything was empty and cruel and heartbreaking?

He thinks it’s not much different from now, except now he has Kacchan and Ru. But maybe that’s all he needs.

“I don’t think he hated me.” It was out before Hato could even blink. He hadn’t met to say that out loud.

Aizawa looks at him in shock, “What?”

He scrambles to say something, “I mean, in your dream. I don’t think he hated me. Kacchan has always felt deeply. It’s never that simple for him. So maybe he did hate me in your dream, but it wasn’t *just* hate.”

Eraserhead hums, but Hato doesn’t think he understands. That’s okay, because it’s taken him years to understand.

Hato catches a movement a few blocks down on another roof. He stands up instantly and squints. The person's form is mostly hidden behind baggy clothing, but he knows that it's not another hero.

"What is it?" Eraserhead asks, standing up as well.

While his danger sense wasn't going off, Hato was still on edge. A breeze hit Hato and it eventually hit the person as well, pulling his hoodie off of his head.

He took a step back, almost falling off the building as he did so. Aizawa put a hand on his shoulder to steady him. He asked something, but Hato could only hear a muffled voice. All of his attention was on the figure, who was now staring at him with his head tilted to the side like a curious cat.

He was taller now. All of his babyness gone. He must be nineteen now, maybe twenty. Hato continued to stare, not quite believing his eyes. The person was lanky with dark red eyes -nothing like Kacchan's bright ones- and pale blue hair down to his shoulder.

Hato took a step forward, then another. He reached his hand out, as if he could communicate who he was from blocks away.

"Tomura."

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for taking so long! Life has been hectic and busy and stressful.

I hope everyone is doing okay (it's okay if you're not)

Quatervois

Hato runs, hopping across rooftops as fast as he could. He hears Eraserhead behind him, and knows that he should tell him to stay back, but his mind is only focused on one objective: seeing Tomura. He trips over something and falls to the ground, somersaulting as he hits the ground and stands up to start running again.

He still sees Tomura, and he's so close. He watches as Tomura notices him, squinting his eyes as he does. Izuku stops running, only a roof's jump away from being on the same building as him. He moves to take off his mask, but right before he can, Tomura starts slowly backing away.

Hato reaches out, "Wait, Tom-" but it's too late. Tomura runs towards the other direction, running into a purple portal.

He sags to the ground, disappointment and dread weighing him down. He couldn't get to him, and now no amount of make believe will cover up the truth that Tomura is still with All For One.

Aizawa steps next to him, "Who was that?"

He sighs, "Someone I used to know."

_____

Tomura lays awake in his bed, body bruised and exhausted but his mind swirling with a thunderstorm of thoughts.

He's thinking about the person he saw hardly an hour ago, running toward him. It freaked him out, but he was also curious. There was something so achingly familiar about the masked person, and for a brief moment, Shigaraki played with the thought that it might've been Hato.

He dismisses the thought, knowing that hope will get him nowhere.

Tomura is not a good person; he knows this. He's stolen and hurt and threatened. The worst part of it all is that he doesn't hate it. Sometimes, he gets lost in the feeling of revenge- of bloodthirst anger. It exhilarates and terrifies him at the same time. There are nights where he can't sleep because closing his eyes will bring a new tomorrow, and each day he knows he changes. He's morphing into a mold that Master created for him, and it's getting harder to believe that he won't be able to fit in it.

He thinks that Hato would be angry at him, but not entirely. A part of him is angry at Hato for not keeping his promise of letting Tomura live with him and his family. Although he knows this is irrational. Neither of them had any control over where he had ended up. But he needs to direct his anger towards someone, Hato or not. Or else it'll just stir in his heart and he'll go crazy.

He doesn't want to be a bad person. Not necessarily. But he doesn't know how to stop. Not with Master, who's taken care of him for years, and is probably the closest thing he'll ever have to a father.

Maybe it's already too late for Shigaraki Tomura. After all, he had agreed to attack U.A. If only to prove himself and illustrate how the hero system failed Tomura. Hato, too. How could the heroes let something as monstrous as The Arena to exist for so long? He was stuck in there for *years* . Not once was there even a hint that the heroes would save them. Not until Hato showed up.

The heroes were ignorant of the deeper hells of the world. He would make them see what life could really be like. How painful it was for someone like him and Hato.

Even if that made him a villain.

_____

It's now two months until the entrance exam, and the beach is once again clean. Izuku's grown both taller and stronger along with Kacchan; with the help of All Might, of course.

All three were standing on the warming sand. The sun was just rising from its slumber, a new day starting.

"Are you ready my boy?" All Might asks. Much too serious for what he's going to reveal in a moment.

Izuku looks at Kacchan, who nods, then looks back at Yagi, "I am."

He cringes as he watches All Might pluck a yellow strand of hair from his head.

"EAT THIS!"

Izuku sighed, a wave of disgust crawling up his spine. He stole a quick glance at Kacchan, and nearly burst out laughing at how utterly horrified he looked.

Izuku never had told him how OFA was transferred to him, too embarrassed.

But Katsuki's expression was priceless. His jaw was dropped, eyes blown wide. For once, he had been shocked into silence.

Dragging his attention back towards All Might once again, he looks at All Might.

"I can't believe I have to do this again," he mutters, too quiet for anyone else to hear. He sighs exasperatedly, "Why can't we just prick our fingers and transfer OFA that way?"

All Might's smile drops, "I suppose you're right, Young-Midoriya."

Izuku could jump in the air with delight, "Great. Let's do that then." He shivered again at the memory of having to swallow All Might's hair. That was something he really didn't want to do again.

Quickly, Izuku pinches his fingertip hard enough that it tears the skin and blood wells, not even wincing at the process. All Might stabs his finger with his tooth, getting the job done as well.

Just as they were about to connect their fingers, Katsuki stops them, "Izu. Are you sure you want to do this?" Izuku could've sworn that he heard the unspoken *again* .

He was sure. He needed OFA to end this war, but he also had to fill up the hole that had been left in the place of One For All and the history it left behind.

"I am. I need to do this." Kastuki nods, and then does something unexpected: he grabs Izuku's hand. A support he didn't know he needed until he had it.

He looks at Yagi and nods, "I'm ready."

All Might smiles, soft and fatherly. It's then that their fingers touch. Blood on blood. DNA intertwining.

For a second Izuku doesn't feel a thing. Yagi raises his eyebrow expectantly, "Well?"

He shrugs, still holding Kacchan's hand, "I don't feel any dif-"

Then he knows nothing.

_____

Izuku's back in the black, swirling abyss. His body is whole, and he finds that he can move around stiffly. Power thrums through him. Everything seems brighter to him now, and it's almost as if he can see the power of One For All dancing around him in brilliant holographic lights.

A gloved hand lands on Izuku's head, "Izuku," Nana Shimura says, "Welcome back."

Izuku looks up at the seventh user, "I'm sorry it took so long."

The fifth user appears next to her, along with the rest, "Oh, c'mon now! No sorries. We're just glad to have you back with us. It's been quiet. Not to mention boring to have to watch the same thing all over again. Guess that's what we get for rewinding time, huh?"

The first user walks forward and kneels in front of him, "You've done such a good job, Izuku."

It's then that Izuku starts to cry. He knew that not having OFA left him incomplete, but he had no idea how big the piece to his puzzle was missing until he finally had it back. Izuku tackled Yoichi in a hug. He couldn't believe that he was seeing them again. They were a part of them as much as he was a part of them- of their legacy.

Yoichi hugs him back, and he feels the rest of the users surround him in an infinite hug.

After their reunion, Kudo says, "Now that we've been reunited, you have to understand that this means that time will continue newly. You have made it to the beginning. You're on a blank page now."

Izuku nods. Kudo was right, this was the beginning of a new time. But it was also the end to a generations long war.

"There are things you must do," Nana starts, "as I know you must know. You have allies. Make more of them. You have to tell Aizawa about everything. There's no running away from it."

“What if he hates me? Thinks I’m a monster?”

Nana shakes her head, “He won’t. He didn’t before and he won’t now. You have to believe in him.”

“Izuku,” En addresses, “Running away from the people who care about you will only make things worse. You can’t win this by yourself. How much longer can you go on being trapped within yourself? People weren’t meant to be alone.”

Fear overwhelms Izuku, “What if they get hurt? What if I fail again?”

Yoichi answers him, “You have to believe in them, Izuku. Your friends are strong. If you push them away, if you sacrifice yourself, this whole thing will be for nothing.”

“Allow yourself to be loved, Ninth.” It was an answer that came from all of the users at once. Voices mending into a singular beautiful voice.

He didn’t know where to start.

_____

He wakes up to someone shaking him violently. He opens his eyes with difficulty and sees a blurry figure that he knows is Katsuki.

He also knows that OFA is coursing itself through his body and it aches all over. Burning in a thousand different places. He doesn’t think when he releases the energy that seems like it’s built up for years. He swears he only breathes- A small inhale of ocean breeze.

He exhales and sees Kacchan’s now clear figure go skidding back at least five feet. The only reason why he didn’t go back any further was because he used his explosions behind him to counteract the power.

Izuku stands up, “Kacchan! I’m so sorry.” He almost falls again when a wave of dizziness hits him. All Might is there to steady him.

“My boy, you have to relax.” It’s only after All Might’s words that he realizes that his body is still glowing red, green sparks flying off. He clasps the power shut, but swears that he feels OFA pounding against his skin,

begging to be released.

“Don’t go breaking bones, Deku.”

Izuku laughs, still having trouble standing up fully, “I’ll try my best.”

Katsuki gives him a once over, “Mhm.”

Yagi’s eyes scrunch together, “Why would you break your bones? Your body should be ready enough for the quirk. At least I was by the time my training was.”

“I don’t have the best of luck when it comes to being unscathed,” Izuku says through his teeth.

Yagi nods, apparently accepting the reason, “Are you feeling okay? I wasn't expecting you to pass out like that.”

“Yeah. I just know I have a lot to do before I’m ready,” he replies. *Ready for U.A., telling Aizawa, the war, not being so damn afraid.*

Izuku gives Kacchan a look that hopefully tells him that he’ll talk about it later, just not right now.

All Might puts one hand on his shoulder and the other on Katsuki’s, “You boys get rest. Young-Midoriya, it might take a while before the quirk fully transfers to your body.Try not to activate it too much before we meet again. I’m counting on you to hold him up on that, Young-Bakugou.”

“Tch.”

Yagi looks at the sun, now fully showing itself, “I have to get going on a last-minute mission. I’m sorry we couldn’t work on OFA today. Try to rest, okay Young-Midoriya?”

Izuku resists the urge to roll his eyes, *as if* .

“Thank you, All-Might,” Izuku says instead. A thank you holding a thousand gratitudes. Past and present.

“Yeah, thanks. Now this Nerd is going to get into even more trouble.” Izuku shoves Katsuki’s side with his elbow.

All Might smiles, “I’ll see you two in a few days. Take care.” He turned and jumped so high that it seemed like he had begun to fly.

Izuku stares up at him and startles when he feels a hand grip his. It isn’t until then that Izuku realizes he’s shaking all over.

“How does it feel?” Katsuki asks, looking at him.

Izuku takes a moment, and then speaks, “It feels like the future.”

_____

His power was immeasurable. The hair on his arms stood up as he watched his protegee fight (briefly Toshinori realized what was happening. Where he was. He tried to imprint each image of the dream into his mind).

He witnesses as Young-Midoriya breaks another glacier of ice, breaking yet another finger. He tries to see if the boy flinches in pain, but he doesn’t. He never does. Never even seems to notice it.

It’s times like these that Yagi feels great despair. He knows that he didn’t train the young man well enough. If he had, then he wouldn’t be breaking bones left and right.

Bones, Yagi realizes. Young-Midoirya was breaking his bones in order to use his quirk. Just like the warning Young-Bakugou had given, *“Don’t go breaking bones, Deku.”*

Another glacier of ice comes towards Young-Midoriya. It shatters into a million shards, just like his fingers. Yagi wants to yell for the game to stop because this damage will become irreparable.

He doesn’t get the chance because Young-Midoriya yells something that he can’t hear. The whole arena erupts into flames.

And through all the chaos, through the knowledge that there was no way he was going to win this, Young-Midoriya smiles.

After that, it's destruction. His protegee broke his arms and legs and was still fighting (Yagi couldn't stand this level of self-destruction. There's no way his Young-Midoriya would go this far . And yet, he knows that he's just lying to himself.)

The fight is over, and all he can think about is his successor. How he failed him, how he can make it better.

He'll just need time.

_____

Toshinori jumps out of bed, nearly tripping on his rug as he rushes to grab his journal. He writes and writes and writes. He doesn't stop writing until he's got every single detail that he remembers on paper

Breaking bones.

A brief image flashes through his mind. Forest green eyes looking down at him, crying alligator tears, saying *I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry.*

Yagi feels a tear slide down his cheek as he stumbles back to bed. There's no way he's going back to sleep, but he wouldn't be functional doing anything else, either.

He knows something's missing. He's so close that he feels if he reaches out a bit further, he'd be able to grasp it.

"Young-Midoriya," he whispers, "What are you up to?"

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Hato breathes in the cool air, filling his lungs with ice. The city was sparkling with its lights. The city taking on a new look for different people. He thinks of the people below his dangling feet as he sits on the roof of a building. He wonders who these people are; what their lives hold. Are they partying, getting drunk on love and celebration? Or are they getting drunk on cheap liquor and hooking up with people who don't even know their

names? How many people out there need to be saved, and he just doesn't know it? Maybe they're the only ones that know that they need help, but are too scared to admit it.

Hato ignites One For All -just barely 5%- and lets the electricity light him up. He looks at his arms and marvels at the power that he now has back. He senses the past users with him. They offer him support, and it's just as thrilling as the quirk he's now holding.

"That's new," Aizawa says as he sits next to him. Hato doesn't jump, not at all surprised that Eraserhead was here. He deactivates OFA.

"Not really." Not to him, at least. It might be to his body and to those who don't remember, but it wasn't new to *him* .

"That so?" Hato nods. With a slight hesitation that no one would have noticed if they weren't looking for it, he lifted his hand to his mask and removed it.

Izuku feels bare without it. Vulnerable in ways he didn't think he could be. But he needs to do this. Not Hato, who's a shield.

"I need to tell you something."

Aizawa looks at him. Izuku thinks he almost looks concerned, "And that is?"

Izuku takes a deep breath. It doesn't help with the anxiety twisting inside his chest. His body shakes with apprehension. All of a sudden, he's freezing but sweating profusely.

He can't do this. So many things could go wrong. He doesn't think he can lose one of the only adults that he truly trusts. Not again.

The past users whisper reassurances. He feels their hands around him in an infinite hug.

Aizawa is patient. He doesn't say anything during Izuku's turmoil. He knows he could back out of this, but the truth is going to be let out eventually. He might as well pick how that happens.

Izuku opens his mouth, "Those dreams you've been having? They're real."

Dysania

Chapter Summary

Midoriya Izuku is falling

Chapter Notes

Trigger Warning: mentions of self-harm

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"What?" Aizawa asks. It was the only thing that he could think of to say. He's not surprised; not really. He knew deep down that the things he had been experiencing weren't dreams, but something else. He hated that dread was pulling in his stomach. Yes, he wanted to know what was actually happening, but there was a part of him that felt safe in this ignorant bliss.

He couldn't be scared of what he didn't know.

Shota sees Izuku sitting next to him. He looks so *small* . His heart aches at the thought of everything this boy has been through. Enough to last lifetimes. He knows it won't get any better once he finds out what's been buried for so long.

Izuku takes a shuddering breath, "They're memories. Not dreams, but *memories* . They've already happened, but you had forgotten. I don't even know how this works. You weren't supposed to remember anything. Kacchan too."

Aizawa squeezes his eyes shut, a pounding in the front of his head beginning to form. "You mean Bakugou has been experiencing this as well?"

Izuku nods, "Yes, but now he knows everything. Or, at least close to everything. He says some things are still fuzzy to him."

Shota shakes his head, "I don't understand." It was too much. How could he have memories of something that were obviously from the future? It was impossible. Illogical.

He was at a funeral for a boy who wore a red cap. Kota was his name.

It was two weeks after his death. Two weeks after Midoriya had been kidnapped. Two weeks of being entirely useless.

He watches as his students mourn. They don't cry, but the pouring rain is doing that for them. He sees Bakugou in the front, and he looks so angry. It reminds him of the beginning, when these kids were just kids.

He holds on to Eri's hand. She's endured too much for someone her age, and now this. Time doesn't seem to know when to give them a break.

Suddenly, a portal appears. Shota picks up Eri and gives her to Iida who nods and runs to get more help. His eyes widen once he sees who steps out of the portal first.

Midoriya Izuku, his problem child.

Although he does not look like himself. His face is gaunt, the bags under his eyes making it look like he hasn't slept in weeks. He thinks that that is probably true.

His eyes are void of any light. There's no flicker of recognition when he lays his eyes on them, and that's when he knows that this is not Midoriya Izuku.

"Everyone!" He shouts just as the League comes through the portal, "Get ready."

Everything that comes after is bloodshed.

Aizawa chokes on his breath at the memory. He *knows* it was a memory. It had the reality in it that dreams lack.

Izuku continues, eyeing him for a second. He knows what's going on, Aizawa realizes.

"I held back on telling you. Even after you told me about these… visions you've been having. I was afraid you would hate me, or think I was a monster. Not that I would blame you for either of those things. When it all comes down to it, I'm responsible for all of those deaths. For your death," he chokes on the last word.

Aizawa hates the world. How ugly it is, how disastrous. It tormented this boy over and over again. Leaving him to believe that he was evil and broken.

He knows that Midoriya Izuku was not a monster. He was peace itself. He was the light and the hope. He was the symbol that would mend this broken world.

He shuts his eyes again, the headache getting worse.

And then, everything snaps.

"I can still fight!"

"Don't leave my sight, problem child."

Tears and smiles and laughter. Late night conversations with a cup of tea, pride filling his chest as he watches Midoriya master his quirk, wanting to protect his kids with his life.

A classroom overflowing with potential. Two leading them, motivating them, inspiring them. The Twin Stars, the Wonder Duo, Bakugou and Midoriya.

Midoriya, unable to control his body, cries as he hurts those he cares most about. People dying, his students *dying, him* dying .

"Fuck," Aizawa whispers. He knows now. Knows everything. He thinks back to his past memories that have revealed themselves long ago. Sitting with Midoriya well past midnight. His student insisted on making him a cup of tea. That it would help him sleep.

He remembers how drained Midoriya had looked. How he had smiled at him as if that would convince him that he was fine. Aizawa wonders how long he's been smiling just to convince others, and himself, that he was okay.

"You remember," Izuku says. He sounded afraid. Aizawa hated that the kid thought that he would feel any ill towards him.

Aizawa nods, "I do. Midoriya, you are not a monster."

“I need to have a smile on my face, so people know everything will be okay.”

Broken bones, near-death experiences, loss. All to achieve a dream that had already been achieved.

The boy, the *kid* , laughs. It’s a hollow kind of thing. It makes Shota’s chest ache.

“Then what am I?”

Aizawa pulls him into a hug that he knows the kid craves but is too afraid to ask. Izuku clings on to his scarf. He holds on tight, but delicately. A feather’s touch.

“You’re Midoriya Izuku. A hero.”

_____

He lies awake on his bed. He stares up at the ceiling and searches. He doesn’t know what he’s looking for. He only knows that he’s missing something. Why else would he be feeling this way?

Aizawa remembers. Izuku is no longer hiding from him. He does not think of him as a monster, but a hero. How could someone think that of their own murderer?

He knows he should be happy, or relieved, or comforted, but he’s not. He is *sad* and he doesn’t know why.

It reminds him of the times he had experienced a rush of happiness with his friends when they all lived in the dorms. How happy he had been with them. But as soon as he was alone in his own suffocating room, heaviness crashed into him and he was left wondering if anything he had been feeling was real.

The drowning sensation was back. His head and chest were so heavy. He had a hard time keeping his breaths even. It was almost too much.

Izuku curled into a ball under his thick blankets. Maybe if he closed his eyes and tried to fall asleep, everything would become quiet. Instead, it made his doubts louder. His mind -always his worst enemy- overwhelmed him

with his failures. It told him he wasn't doing enough and that all of this was pointless because there was no way someone like him could save those he loved. In the end, they all ended up disappearing. Because of him.

He wasn't enough.

Izuku sat up and looked towards his bathroom. The familiar craving of self-destruction always came to him in these moments, although it's been a while since he last gave in.

He thought back to earlier that night. How Aizawa looked at him with such care and told him he was a hero. How he held him even though Izuku knew Aizawa wasn't much of a hugger. He had looked at him as if Izuku had nothing to be sorry for.

He had everything to be sorry for.

"I'm here for you. That's not only my job, but my want. We're in this together."

Shota had said without any room for argument. They went their separate ways after promising to always meet up at least a few times a week.

He had been hopeful and maybe even a bit loved.

Now he felt nothing. Or maybe he felt everything.

Izuku got out of bed and headed towards the bathroom. He told himself *just one more time. Then never again will I do this* .

He told himself this every time.

He turned on the bathroom light, wincing at the brightness of it. He opened the cabinet under his sink and grabbed his singular blade. Bought for exactly this purpose.

Izuku held it to his wrist. He was usually more careful about where he self-harmed, but there was something about doing it on his arms that felt different from his hips. Something more satisfying about it.

He was just about to slide the blade across his skin when he heard his phone ding. He looks up and sees the soft glow of his phone on his night stand. He'd usually ignore it, but no one ever texted him this late.

Izuku walked over to his phone, blade still in his hand. He saw that it was a notification from Kacchan.

2:34 am

Kacchan

Nerd, you up?

Izuku

Why are you still awake?

Kacchan

Fuckin' restless. Thinking about entrance exams

and all the training I still have to do.

Why are YOU still up?

Izuku's mind falls into a blank. A part of him wants to tell him the truth, but what good would that do? Katsuki already has enough on his plate. He doesn't need Izuku burdening him with his bad habits. He twists the blade around his fingers. His wrist were still aching for it

He hated how he resorted to this. But it was all he knew.

His phone lights up with another notification.

Kacchan

I'm waiting.

Izuku

I'm always up this late.

Kacchan

I’m calling your dumb ass.

Izuku thumbles with his phone, droppin his blade as he does. He finally answers it much to his exasperation.

“Kacchan,” He rasps, “What the fu-”

“What’s wrong?” Katsuki interrupts him. Izuku falls silent. He shouldn’t be surprised. Not when Katsuki knew him better than himself most days. However, he is surprised. Was he really that obvious? Just through texting no less.

Izuku doesn’t know if he has the energy to try harder with hiding what goes on in his mind most nights. It’s hard enough to resist resorting to the blade throughout the days where things just became a little too impossible

“I know you’re still there,” Katsuki gruffs. He sounds tired. Exhausted. Izuku knows that he isn’t used to staying up this late and will probably go to bed much earlier the next day.

“Nothing’s wrong Kacchan. Go to sleep.”

He isn’t going to tell him, he isn’t going to tell him, he isn’t going to tell him-

Izuku hangs up before Katsuki could get another word in. He sinks to the floor and wraps his arms around his knees. His fingers claw at his arms desperately. He needs it *out* . All of these feelings and fears and *what ifs.* He’s so sick of it all.

He shouldn’t be like this. Especially not now. Not when Aizawa *finally* knows and U.A. is so close.

And yet, it’s so hard to keep it together. Izuku *has* to keep it together. He can’t fall apart.

His eyes travel to the blade on the ground. He picks it up and crawls to the bathroom. Standing up seems like too much.

Izuku can’t break, so he’ll do whatever he has to do to keep himself sane.

He presses the blade to his skin.

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It's shortly after he's finished cleaning up does he hear a *tap, tap.* He ignores it, thinking it was a bird or the rain.

He does not feel better. He knew he would feel worse. Guilt and ache swirling together in his chest. It always seems like it would make everything better. And at first, it does. After every cut, everything fades into the background as he watches the blood well up.

It's not too soon after that everything comes crashing down on him once again. He hates himself for resorting to self-harm, but he was desperate. He needed the reprieve, even if it was only for a moment.

He wonders how long he'll go one like this: holding everything together until the weight of it becomes too much and he resorts to self-destruction. In a more physical form, that is. Because isn't what he's doing -trying to fix everything by himself-, slowly tearing him apart? Will he get better after he succeeds? Or will he continue to fall?

He just wants all of this to be over.

TAP, TAP.

Scrunching his eyebrows together, he gets out of his bed and goes toward his window. He doesn't need his lamp to see perfectly who it is.

He nearly jumps out of his skin, thanking god that he talked himself into cleaning everything up before going to bed. And for wearing a sweatshirt.

Izuku opens the window, "Kacchan?! What the fuck are you doing here?"

Katsuki huffs and jumps inside. Izuku steps back, "Well, come on in." He turns his lamp on to allow some light. It casts a soft glow in his room, detailing Kacchan's messy bed head and rumpled pajamas.

"You hung up on me," Katsuki says in return. As if that answered all of Izuku's questions.

“ *That's* why you’re here? Because I *hung* up on you?” He didn’t know why he was getting so angry. He didn’t know anything anymore.

How could he come crashing down, when nothing really happened? Nothing *bad* . He had gotten OFA, and Aizawa now remembered, but all of that was good.

It was then that he realized how real it made everything, too. The wait was almost over.

And *oh* , that’s why he had trouble breathing.

Katsuki turns to face him, “Yes, Izuku. I came all the way here because you hung up on me. Because something sounded so *wrong* in your voice, and you wouldn’t tell me.”

Izuku grips his hands around his sleeves, securing them. “I don’t have to tell you everything. I can handle myself.”

He can’t he can’t he can’t he *can’t*-

Katsuki barks out a laugh. Izuku’s glad that Ru’s a heavy sleeper. “Trust me, you’ve made that perfectly clear.”

What has this turned into? Why is it always hurt upon hurt upon hurt?

He sees Katsuki. How dark the bags underneath his eyes have become, the slight shake of his hands, the confusion in his eyes.

Izuku feels himself softening, “Kacchan, you need to take care of yourself. Stop worrying about me.”

Katsuki walks closer to him, so they’re less than a foot apart. “Use those fucking eyes of yours, Izuku. I can’t stop worrying about you. Remember, we’re two sides of the same coin. One can’t happen without the other.”

They’re so close. Izuku’s fingers twitch with the need to come closer. His wrists still sting, and guilt overcomes him. He hugs his arms around himself. He can’t fall apart in front of Katsuki.

Katsuki grabs both of his arms and pulls them closer to him. Izuku barely hides his wince. He hopes with every ounce of his being that he doesn't bleed through his bandages.

"We're in this together. We always will be. You got that?"

Izuku shakes his head. They can't be together. Katsuki had said this exact thing in the last timeline, and they got torn apart.

"No. I can't. People are getting involved enough as it is. I can't-"

"What?" Katsuki growls out, "let people get close to you? Let other people help you? You *can* . You just won't." His red eyes travel down to his arms. Izuku watches as the blond frowns, fear spilling into his stomach. He looks down at his arms and sees that the bandages are peeking through his sleeves.

Izuku yanks his arms back. Dread overwhelms him. Anger slams into him. He's no longer in control over anything now. *When* was he ever in control?

"Izuku," Katsuki says. Izuku looks away. His hands form fists to try to stop the shaking. "Please don't tell me that's what I think it is."

Of course Katsuki knows. He's smart, and he knows that Izuku has done this to himself before.

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They were watching a movie together. Izuku doesn't even remember which one it was, but he remembers being inexplicably happy.

He was curled up next to Katsuki's side, his boyfriend was rubbing slow circles around his wrist. He can't think of a time where he felt more at ease. More safe than he does now.

Then Katsuki stops with his soothing circles on his wrist. Izuku tries to look up at him, but it's difficult when he's pulled so close to his chest.

He can tell that something is wrong, "Kacchan?" he asks. Katsuki doesn't say anything. Instead, he reaches over and turns his lamp on (they're on his bed in the dorms).

The light blinds him for a second and he squeezes his eyes shut. "Wha-"

Katsuki grabs his arms and looks at them. Izuku frowns at him, not sure what he's trying to find. They're the same: messed up and heavily scarred.

It isn't until Katsuki looks closer -at his forearms- that he realizes what Katsuki's trying to find.

He must have felt the thin lines that he himself made.

"Izuku," he says once he's found what he's been looking for. Katsuki looks up at him with wide eyes. Tears gathering at the corner of them.

Izuku hurries to explain. He hates it when his boyfriend cries, especially if it's because of him. "Kacchan, please don't worry. I haven't done… that *in a long time. Since before U.A."*

It was true. He made himself stop the day All Might took him under his wing. Threw away all of his blades and fought the urge through training.

Katsuku's crying now, "I was horrible to you, wasn't I?"

"What? No, no, no. Kacchan- Katsuki. *This was all me. Yes, you hurt me, but nearly everyone did."*

Katsuki's head drops to Izuku's chest, "I'm sorry I left you."

Izuku kisses his head, "It's okay. Because you came back."

———

"I would've gone crazy if I hadn't done *something* ," Izuku says.

“And that something was *cutting* yourself?!” Katsuki shouts, “When was the last time?” Izuku winces.

Thirty minutes ago.

Katsuki grabs his arms. Izuku’s too tired to fight back. He slowly pulls the sleeves up. Katsuki stops breathing. Izuku hates himself for doing this to him.

“You just did.” Izuku nods. There was no point in lying. He’s suffocating. He can’t do this. Why does he always mess things up?

Katsuki sounds heartbroken, “ *Why?”*

Izuku looks up at his best friend. At his everything. “Fourteen years is a long time, Kacchan. I have seen everyone I ever love die because I was too weak. I have been kidnapped- more than once. First time I was tortured and mind controlled. The second I was sent to an arena where our deaths were entertainment. Where I was starved, stabbed, electrocuted, and shot at. Where I saw a kid barely able to comprehend life die. I’ve lost my mom twice and have fought everyday to *keep on going* . Why *wouldn't I resort* to this? The one thing that I can control?” By the time he’s done talking he’s out of breath. Tears are streaming down his face and he notices that Kacchan is crying, too.

Suddenly, Katsuki crashes into him in a bone-breaking hug. Izuku hugs back with just as much intensity. He clings on as if his life depends on it. He thinks that it might.

“I’m sorry. I’m so, so fucking sorry, Izu. It makes sense- it really, truly does. I’m sorry. But it doesn’t make it *right.* ”

Still buried in the hug, Izuku muffles out, “Kacchan, it’s okay.”

Katsuki hugs tighter, “It’s fucking not. I hate this. I hate everything. You don’t deserve this. None of us do. It’s so fucking unfair. I hate what you do to yourself, and I swear I’ll help you. Whatever it takes, I’ll save you.” He releases the hug and looks Izuku in the eye. “I need you. You do know that, right?”

It sounded foreign. That someone cared about him this much. It seemed impossible.

It was lovely.

“Kacchan, I need you too. I need you more than anything else.”

He touches their foreheads together. Forever connected. Always the two sides of the same coin.

“Cling on to me, Izuku. We’ll get through this together. Just stay. Please, stay.”

Izuku couldn’t convey how strongly he felt through words. He would stay. He would fight. He had to. No matter how tired he grew or how broken he became. He’d hold on.

Izuku grabs Katsuki’s face gently. Katsuki was his whole world. He would go back in time again and again if it is assured that he would be safe.

“Kacchan,” Izuku started, but was interrupted by Katsuki’s lips on his. His eyes widened in surprise. He forgot this. He forgot how warm it made him feel.

He kissed back, trying to convey everything that he couldn’t say.

He had wanted this for so long, but had pushed it back. He didn’t think he deserved it, and it was hard to imagine Katsuki ever loving him again. Ever kissing him again. Izuku had learned to only ever get this in his dreams.

Yet, here they were. Izuku’s hands holding Katsuki’s face, their lips pressing against each other. Everything felt so warm. He never wanted this to go away. He knows that he’ll be by Katsuki’s side for as long as he’ll let him be. And even when Katsuki grows sick of him, he’ll still be there. Waiting for this.

Their lips parted, but they stayed clinging onto one another, tears falling down both of their faces. They were never ending. The other began when the other ended. They were timeless.

“Next time, don’t hang up on me, okay? Text me, even if it’s four in the morning. I don’t fucking care. Just let me help you,” Katsuki whispers, kissing his forehead.

Izuku barely manages to nod “Okay.” He lets his eyes close. He feels Kacchan pick him up and put him carefully on the bed before climbing in himself. He let Katsuki put an arm around his waist and listened as he whispered soft things into his ear.

He falls asleep, and this time, there are no nightmares to greet him.

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone liked this chapter!

Happy Holidays!

Agape

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki is holding something. At first he thinks it's his pillow, although he doesn't remember crawling into his bed last night. He gives his pillow a soft squeeze before decidedly confirming that, no, this is *not* his pillow. It's then that he realizes that the reason he doesn't remember going to bed last night was because he didn't. At least not his.

He opens his eyes slowly and stiffens when he sees what- *who* he's holding. Izuku is curled up beside him, his head tucked slightly below Katsuki's. His face is relaxed. Perhaps the most relaxed Katsuki has seen in forever. His arm is slung over Izuku's torso and their legs are tangled up in one another's. He feels Izuku's chest expand with each intake of breath and is so comforted by that small movement that he almost allows himself to close his eyes once again. He never wants this moment to end. He doesn't want things to resume again.

He needs to tell Arai. They need to know because as much as he hates to admit it, Izuku needs more than Katsuki to help him. He also needs to find his blades and make sure Izu never finds them ever again. He'll do anything to keep him safe, and if that means Izuku will be mad at him? So be it. He'd rather be with an angry Izuku for the rest of his life than one who resorts to hurting himself.

Katsuki slowly tears himself away from Izuku even though that's the last thing he wants to do. He quietly jumps out of the bed and takes a deep breath. He brings a hand to his lips and swears that he can still feel the warmth of Izuku's lips on his. He wants that again. He wants more of Izuku in every way possible. He wants to start off from where they were cut off and begin anew all at once. But none of that can happen until he helps Izuku.

He opens Izuku's bedroom door and gently closes it behind him. He hears Ru in the kitchen- most likely getting ready to open the cafe. He starts walking down the spiral staircase and tries to think of ways to start the conversation. His mind comes up blank.

Without turning around Ru says, "Good morning Izuku! I may be drunk on coffee, so apologies in advance if I start bouncing off of the walls."

Katsuki clears his throat, causing Hotaru to turn around. She frowns in confusion before smiling, "Bakugou. I didn't know you were here. Where's Zu Zu?"

Katsuki starts walking towards the kitchen and sits down on a chair next to the dining table. "I came by last night, sorry for not telling you. Izu's asleep."

Ru waves a hand and makes a *psh* sound, “Don’t worry about it. You’re welcome here any time. And good, that boy needs as much sleep as he can get. Do you mind helping me with the displays before I open up?”

Katsuki almost says yes, just to avoid this conversation a bit longer. He looks down at his hands, and thinks of Izuku’s. Izuku’s hands that are already scarred from so many battles. He wonders how much more his body can handle.

“Actually… Arai, I need to talk to you. It’s about Deku.” Ru’s frown returns deeper this time. Their forehead creased. They move and sit down next to Katsuki.

“What is it? I swear if you did anything I’ll personally make your living life make hell seem like an amusement park. I’ll find out where you live and talk to your parents about how you deserve to be grounded for the rest of your life as well.”

Katsuki shakes his head, a part of him relieved that Deku has someone like Arai in his life, and another part scared shitless of them.

“No. I promised I wouldn’t hurt him. And I intend to keep that promise.” Noting the seriousness of Katsuki’s voice, Ru nods. He’s thankful for their silence because it gives him time to gather words that might make sense. “I’m telling you this because Izuku is a shitty nerd who doesn’t care what happens to him. And when you’re carrying as much weight as he is… it’s easy to feel suffocated.” He closes his eyes and sees his bandaged arms. Red faintly seeping through the white. Izuku had fallen asleep before Katsuki could demand to see the extent of his cuts, but he knew that they wouldn’t be thin marks like he so separately wanted them to be (he didn’t want anything there, but he knew that was impossible, so his stupid brain went with the next best thing).

“Bakugou,” Arai says. Katsuki has never seen her so put together before. They weren’t playful anymore, but an adult worried about the one they were caring for, “What are you trying to tell me?”

“Izuku’s been hurting himself.” He doesn’t let himself stop at Ru’s sharp intake of breath, “I found out last night. I… I can’t help him by myself, and you’re the only other person I trust enough to keep him in check.” He rubs his eyes with his hand roughly, “He’s so *good,* y’know? But he doesn’t believe that. He thinks telling people about what he’s really feeling would burden them, and I can’t- I *can’t* allow that.”

Ru grabs both of Katsuki’s hands with hers. Katsuki looks up to see their deep blue eyes sparkle with tears, “Thank you. Thank you so much for looking after him. He’s always been by himself, and I’ve always worried about how lonely he must be. Then you came barging through these doors and I was so happy that Zu had found you. I’ll talk to him, and we’re going to figure this out.” Ru gets out of their chair and hugs Katsuki. He’s surprised by how warm the hug is, and he hugs back even though he’s hardly a hugger.

He wonders where Izuku would be if he had never met Ru.

He decides he'd rather not know.

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Izuku wakes up cold. He curls in on himself into a tight ball to try to salvage some warmth and go back to sleep. It doesn't work because soon his mind is buzzing with all of the events from last night. He shoots up and bangs his head on his ceiling.

"Motherfu-" he's cut off by his bedroom door opening. He glances towards it and is surprised to see Katsuki. He didn't realize that Katsuki stayed the night. He avoided eye contact as he muttered a very half-assed, "morning." while rubbing his forehead.

Katsuki sighs, and Izuku is barely able to contain his flinch. He has to be mad at him, right? They had fought last night, and Izuku had been so mean. Then he burdened Kacchan further by being an idiot and not hiding his cuts more thoroughly. God, he was so selfish. He was always dumping emotional baggage onto Katsuki when he could have just handled it all by himself (albeit not very *well).*

"Morning Nerd. Breakfast is almost ready."

And then- and they, they had-

Kissed.

Izuku felt his face burst into flames as he fell back onto his pillow. He wanted to be enveloped whole by his mattress. There was no way. Why would Katsuki want to kiss him when he was like this?

"Come on, Izuku. I want to do something before breakfast." Izuku sighed and got out of bed. His face still felt hot and knew that he was still flushed.

"What is it?" He asked, finally getting the courage to look Katsuki in the eye. He was surprised to see how serious the other boy looked. He noticed how his red eyes traveled down to his arms.

Oh .

“Kacchan, I’m fine, really.” At Katsuki’s huff Izuku scrambled to say more, “I mean, do we really have to talk about this right now?” He really didn’t want to, and the strong sting of his arms weren’t helping his mind distract itself from something else.

Katsuki took hold of Izuku’s hands gently, but firmly. He always liked how Katsuki never treated him like glass, but was so firm and comforting and *present*. His hands were warm, and Izuku couldn’t stop his hands returning the grip. His shoulders relaxed, releasing a breath he didn’t realize he was holding.

“I need to see them. I want to help you bandage them,” Katsuki said softly, so softly. Izuku stepped toward him and fell into his chest. He nodded because he was tired of this shitty endless cycle. Katsuki’s arms wrapped around him and Izuku allowed himself to take solace in the hug.

“Okay,” he said. Nodding into the crook of Katsuki’s neck, “Okay.”

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They sat on the floor of Izuku’s bathroom. Izuku once again deciding to look anywhere else besides Katsuki. Shame filled him as he rolled up his sleeves and unwrapped the slightly brown bandages. He looked down at them, slightly surprised at how deep they were. When he was initially making them, he didn’t think they were that bad. He could hardly even feel the pain when he sliced his skin open.

It was fine. He was fine.

He let Katsuki grab his arms so he could look at them. He tried not to pay attention to how Kacchan’s hands were shaking, or the sharp intake of breath he took when Izuku unraveled the bandages.

“Do you have any ointment?” Katsuki asks. Izuku barely suppresses a scoff. *Of course* he does. He has a whole damn first aid kit that’s so big and plentiful that it would probably never get used up by a normal person.

Izuku was not normal. He’s already had to restock it more than once since he got it a few years ago.

Izuku opens the drawer underneath his sink and takes out the kit. It’s a big black bag that was probably supposed to be used for makeup and toiletries during travel. In it, he has everything he might need. Ranging from a needle and thread (along with lighter) to scalpels and tweezers.

“Jesus, Izuku. Are you training to be a doctor?” Izuku rolls his eyes.

“Just be thankful I have it.”

“I am. I just wish you didn’t *need* it,” Katsuki says as he grabs the antibiotic ointment and applies some to a Q-tip. He gently applies it to the cuts. The cold salve felt nice on his self-inflicted injuries, and despite everything, Izuku was grateful that he wasn’t doing this alone.

Katsuki begins to pull out the roll of bandage and starts wrapping it around his arms, “How long have you been doing this?” Izuku shrugs. There were multiple answers. When did he first start? When he was middle school in the first timeline. When did he relapse?

“Around a year and a half ago, I think.”

He doesn’t even remember what spurred the action. He just remembered he had come back from a patrol and it felt like he had a ton of bricks on his chest. He could’ve sworn he would have collapsed if he hadn’t done something. So… he did.

Katsuki hums, and Izuku hears a very poorly hidden sniffle. “I’m sorry, Kacchan. Please don’t cry.” The blond had just finished wrapping his arms, so Izuku brings both hands to Bakugou’s face. His red eyes were flooding with tears. Izuku swallowed the lump in his throat. “I’m sorry. Please, don’t be upset.”

Katsuki grips Izuku’s wrists, “How can I not be upset? You’re the most important person in the world to me, so you have to understand how much I fucking hate this. Don’t you get that? How much I care about you? We kissed last night; that has to show you at least a tiny bit how much I care about you.”

Izuku bonks his forehead gently on Katsuki’s, his hands still cupped around the other’s face. He doesn’t say anything. He doesn’t know what to say that would make this all better.

Deep down, he knows no amount of words will make this better in a day. That it’s going to take a lot longer than that.

Finally, he allows himself to say something, “I’ve missed you. I know we’ve been back in each other’s lives for almost a year now, but I’ve missed you so much. I forgot how much until we kissed last night, and I suddenly remembered all the other times when we would kiss back when none of this existed. Back when we were just two high school students training to be heroes.” He wants to kiss Katsuki again, but knows it’s not the right time. The thought there might come another chance ignites hope in him.

They both stand up, “I know I’ve already said this, but you better promise me that you won’t ever do this again.”

Izuku’s silent for a while. He doesn’t know if could keep that promise. “I’ll try. That’s all I can truthfully say.”

Katsuki sighs, “Okay. Someday you’re going to promise me that, got it?”

Izuku nods, “Got it.”

_____

They head down stairs and Izuku immediately notices that Ru is acting off. He looks at Kacchan with a questioning glance, and this time, he’s the one that refuses to look at him.

He told Ru.

It wasn’t a guess. Izuku knew that Katsuki told her.

“Good morning!” He says, trying to add some false cheer into the room. It doesn’t work. In fact, it seems to only make the atmosphere worse. He sits down at the table with Kacchan next to him.

“Morning Zu Zu,” Ru says, a tired smile adorning their face. They set the food down onto the table and sat down.

“Thank you for the food,” both Izuku and Katsuki say in unison. Ru nods but doesn’t say anything. He can tell that she’s thinking- it’s the only reason they’d be so quiet. He tries to eat, but finds that he lacks the appetite to. He tells himself he isn’t mad. And he isn't. Not at Katsuki, who only tried to do what was best. Under the table he grabs Katsuki’s free hand and squeezes. He hopes it conveys that he’s not angry at him. Kacchan squeezes back.

Izuku picks at his food, and once Ru and Katsuki are finished, he offers to clear the table. He gathers the dishes and starts washing them, trying not to think. Having the mind that he does, he seems to only think more.

He’s not mad. He’s not mad at anyone.

But god is he furious with himself. If only he had hidden *it better. If only he wasn't so damn pitiful and weak-*

He somehow manages to speak, "Kacchan, your parents are probably wondering where you are by now," Katsuki scoffs, "I'll meet you at seven at our usual spot, okay?" Their "usual spot" being the beach, where he was supposed to train using OFA today.

Katsuki knows better than to argue at the moment, so he nods. "Better be there, Nerd." Before he leaves, Katsuki ruffles Izuku's hair affectionately. Izuku tries not to let on how much he liked it.

Once Katsuki is gone, Izuku makes his way back to the kitchen table where Ru is sitting. He sits down from across from them. "So he told you."

Ru nods grimly, "Yeah, and no matter how hard I try to wrap my mind around it, I can't seem to understand why you would feel the need to hurt yourself."

Izuku feels a pang in his chest when he hears Ru sound so worn down. He hates that he was the one to cause that. "I'm glad you don't understand. Because that would mean you've experienced what I have, and I wouldn't wish that upon anyone."

Ru lets out a breathy sigh, "Are you going to tell me what led up to this?" she asked in a way that indicated that she already knew the answer.

Izuku shakes his head, "I can't, but know that there are people who know. If that makes you feel better."

Arai grips her hands around Izuku's, "And these people. Are they good for you?"

"Only second to you," Izuku responds.

Ru gives a watery smile at that, "We need to figure some things out. How to prevent you from doing this again."

Izuku was at a loss for words. He was overcome with gratitude for Ru, for Kacchan. Tears came to his eyes. God, he hasn't cried this much in so long.

"I'm sorry," he cried.

Ru's grip tightened, "Oh, Zu, there's nothing to be sorry for. Don't ever apologize for struggling. You have the right to feel whatever you're feeling, and if you don't know exactly what that is, then that's okay, too."

No one has ever said that to him before. He always felt he had to hide that he was struggling. Who would trust a hero who couldn't even take care of themselves?

It all came spilling out, "I'm so weak. How can I be a hero when I'm like this? How can I be anything when I'm so *broken?"*

"Izuku, you are not weak. You are *human* . So incredibly human. And that's what'll make you a great hero. You understand people. The good, the bad, you take it all in, and you still see something to save. You're already a hero, and I can't wait to see how you grow."

Izuku leaned over and gave them a bone-crushing hug, "I'm so lucky to have you."

Ru rubbed circles on his back, "I know, I know, I'm amazing. And so are you. We'll take this one step at a time, okay? We'll get through this. Together."

He had a hard time imagining what that would look like, having done this alone for so long. but he nods anyway, "That sounds good. Really good." He hated being alone, and now he had people who were offering to help him.

He thinks he might just let them.

Ru releases the hug, "Okay! I'm thinking we keep the cafe closed for the day and go upstairs and watch corny movies and eat junk food. How does that sound?"

Izuku lets out a watery laugh, "l'll get the snacks."

The sun was just barely beginning to set once Izuku made it to the beach. The days were noticeably shorter now. Soon, the leaves will turn, and then they will fall. The holidays will come, bringing the entrance exams with them.

Surprisingly, he's the first one to arrive. He had nearly lost track of time watching movies with Ru. They did a whole spree of American Rom Coms. *13 Going on 30, When Harry Met Sally,* and *Notting Hill* were just some of the movies they had watched. He might have done some ugly crying during some of them… or all of them.

Ru had promised him that they would work through this together, and he had believed her. It was a strange feeling: to be able to say aloud this thing he's been holding in for so long. It was a mixture of *oh my god, They know* and *Finally.*

"Sup, Nerd." Izuku looks away from the ocean to see Katsuki in casual workout clothes, waving at him.

Izuku smiles. Soft, but real, "Hi Kacchan." He runs up to him and attacks the blond with a hug. Katsuki lets out a *huff* before automatically hugging back, "Thank you," he whispers. He knows that come morning he might be angry again -at people knowing-, but at this moment, he's glad.

They loosen their hug. Izuku looks up at him and tries to take in every detail. The depthness of his red eyes, the pinkness in his cheeks, the scrunch of his eyebrows. He finds himself leaning in, and he thinks Katsuki is leaning in, too. Deeping down slightly to meet him.

He's just about to close his eyes and lean in to close the gap between them before someone yells out, "Sorry I'm late!" Izuku screeches and jumps back from Katsuki, his face burning. He glares at Katsuki who laughs, but is satisfied when he sees a hint of a blush on Katsuki as well.

"Yagi!" Izuku yells in greeting.

Yagi jogs up to them, smiling wide, "Young Midoriya and Young Bakugou! I'm sorry that I'm a bit late- I got caught up in some hero work."

Izuku smiles, glad to see his favorite hero. Being with All Might always seemed to lift him up, to give him hope on what *he* could do.

Without thinking about it, Izuku lifts his fist, "Thank you for protecting us, All Might. Someday, I promise we'll be the ones to protect you."

———

The sunset outlines Young Midoriya as he raises his fist. It's been years since Yagi has been the one protected. He thinks of Sir Nighteye and the future, how he'll never outrun fate.

“That’s why no matter what happens to you, I’ll be there to fight fate!”

Yagi stared at the boy wearing the U.A uniform. He looked stronger and older than the one from the present. Yet there was something that this Izuku had that the other didn’t: a bright shining spark of hope.

Young Midoriya had tears in his eyes as waited for All Might to raise his fist. The sunset was beaming on both of them, creating beautiful hues of oranges, pinks, and yellows.

Yagi smiles, somehow knowing exactly what his successor was talking about besides only appearing a moment ago. And the fact was, he believed him. If anyone were to change the course of fate, it would be Midoirya Izuku.

Yagi bumps his fist against Izuku’s.

“Are you ready to start training?”

Chapter End Notes

:D

so so sorry for the late update. Life has been exhausting

Take care of yourselves!

Ticking

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Aizawa walks into Nezu's office with dread.

He's running on too many cups of coffee, two jelly pouches (strawberry banana flavored), and zero fucks. All he cares about is getting this over with and going home where Hizashi has cooked a five-star dinner and Eri can present to him another drawing that she made (she said this one was going to be for her Deku-nii.)

Nezu is at his desk sitting on his chair that is raised as high as it goes. In his paws is a cup of tea and to the side of him is a stack of papers. They're probably from all the students signing up for entrance exams this coming February (he knows Midoriya's is in there somewhere). Nezu looks up and smiles, "Ah, Aizawa-San! You wanted to meet with me, right? Please don't tell me you're retiring from teaching, we've been over this. You're too young to retire and just because you don't like teaching-"

Aizawa interrupts, "No. I'm not retiring." He moves to sit down across from Nezu, who pours him a cup of what smells like jasmine tea.

Nezu tilts his head, "No? I don't see any other reason why you would be here, then. I know you usually avoid coming in here at any cost." The principal snickers to himself.

Aizawa scowls, "This is important."

Nezu's gaze settles on him, and he tries to not let anything show. He knows that Nezu is calculating him, making predictions. He doesn't think even the smartest being in the country could guess what he was about to say, no matter how long he stared.

"Do tell," Nezu leans in like he's a student learning about their favorite subject.

"Midoriya Izuku." Nezu's eyes light up at that name.

"I remember him! He was so little when he toured U.A. Remember, Aizawa? You were the one who brought him and his friend here. He was smart, too. I wanted him to become my personal student."

Aizawa nods, trying not to think about Nezu and Midoriya together. They'd be either the downfall or salvation of everything.

He decides to rip off the band aid, "He's from the future." It was blunt, and probably too sudden. But how else was he supposed to start it off?

Shota's been pondering this for a while. He remembers most of everything (*Blood and war and his students screaming-)* , but he still has no idea how his student managed to rewind *time* . Was it a quirk? *Another* quirk of the many he already has?

Nezu tilts his head, "I beg your pardon?" The principle seems cut off guard- the first time in a very, very long time.

He pinches the bridge of his nose and sighs, "Midoriya Izuku rewound time after U.A experienced a deadly war in his second year here. He went back further than he meant to, to when he was barely a toddler."

Izuku had told him that the night he gained back his memories. That information had him lying awake for hours on end thinking about it. Izuku had to face the knowledge -the *memories*- of what happened all by himself for *years.* No one to support or guide him when he got stuck in a dead end or couldn't seem to fight off the nightmares. Izuku had to rebuild all of his relationships, and then get forced into that hideous arena, only to escape to a world further tilted off of it's axis. Aizawa has no idea how he got through it (did he? Could he really say that Izuku got *through* it? Or is his Problem Child just barely trudging along?)

For the first, and probably last time, Shota sees that Nezu's surprised. Out of the possible million calculations he made, this was not one of them.

"How?"

Aizawa shakes his head, "I don't know. I only found out a few weeks ago. I've gained back all of my memories as well, although I don't think that's possible for everyone. I'm telling you this because I need you to believe me. In a few months from now Midoriya and the rest of his class will be attending this school, and know that I will do anything to make sure they live to graduation. I expect you to do the same."

Nezu nods, "Tell me more."

Eraserhead met Hato at their usual rooftop when the moon was high in the night sky. With the city bustling below them, the underground hero told Hato about his meeting with Nezu earlier that afternoon.

"And you didn't tell me you were doing this because?" Midoriya - *Hato* (the kid hates it when he refers to him by his real name while patrolling) asks, irritation barely hidden.

Eraserhead sighs, "Because as much as I loathe to admit it, we need that rat. And I know you would have immediately said no." What he didn't say was that the Problem Child was terrible at asking for help. It had taken years for him to reveal that he reversed time, and only did so because Aizawa practically begged him to tell him what the hell was going on. Aizawa *never* begged.

Hato scuffs, "He's a calculator, Eraserhead. He's going to pick the most logical, cleanest solution. He'll be willing to sacrifice some of us for that. I can't let that happen."

"And it won't. Mido- Hato, we're going to need as many eyes as possible. Nezu has connections and the power to solidify our chances. You know this."

"Then what's the next step? Since you already decided on our last one. " Hato questions. Aizawa notes that the kid looks bone-deep tired. He's going to have to force the kid to retire early after this conversation.

"We get you into U.A. Reintroduce you to Nezu- he's quite excited to see you again. As a forewarning, he wants you to be his personal student."

Hato shivers, "Ugh, never. Although we could probably accomplish a lot together. Do you know how many dark webs there are? I bet we could even hack into the Hero Corp and mess with them a tiny bit… Maybe I'll give that proposition a little more thought."

"I'm going to pretend I didn't hear that. And please don't."

The vigilante shrugs, "Suit yourself." After a brief silence he adds, "Do you think everythings going to turn out okay?"

Shota feels his chest constrict at the fear in the kid's voice- the utter desperation.

He nods, "I do."

And hopes to god that it's not a lie.

If Izuku wasn't so aware of every second ticking by, he would have missed the months slipping by. The autumn leaves fall and decompose to the ground as the days get shorter, the weather colder. Christmas brings laughter and memories full of light and cheer in them. It was the best Christmas he's had since his first one at U.A. Not only did he get to spend the day with Ru and the cats, but with Kacchan as well. They had all exchanged gifts and watched movies until Katsuki had to go back home to celebrate with his family.

The New Year came, in which Katsuki came over and they built a blanket fort like they used to when they were kids. It was the first time in a while that they got to hang out alone. Their busy lives were always pulling them in different directions, and they had things bigger than them to focus on. They never got to discuss who they were to each other.

But under the tent of blankets with a small lantern giving them light, they got to talk about their relationship.

"So what?" Izuku starts, "Are we dating again? Are we just friends? What are we?"

Katsuki looks at him with twinkling eyes. Izuku knows he's tired, and warms up at the thought of him trying to stay up until midnight with him.

"What do you want us to be, Izuku?"

Izuku blushes, "C'mon Kacchan, you know how I feel about you."

He smirks, "I do? I can't seem to recall. What am I to you?"

"You're everything," Izuku says, nothing more than a breath. He studies how Katsuki's face freezes, then slowly starts to relax again.

Katsuki grabs his hand with his. A fierce grip that grounds him. Izuku asks, "Who am I to you, Katsuki?"

“You’re the save to my win. You are my peace and my determination. You are just as I am to you: Everything.” He then blushes and covers his free hand with his face, “Goddamnit, that was cliched as hell.”

Izuku laughs, “I loved it.”

Katsuki uncovers his face, “Of course you did Nerd. You’ve always liked the cheesy crap.”

They slowly cupped each other's face, feeling the other’s presence. When they kissed, the clock did not strike midnight, nor was it perfect. It was light and barely a touch of lips, but it made them smile. It solidified who they were moving forward.

Together, they were everything.

———

Now it’s one month until the entrance exams.

Izuku’s been practicing with OFA nearly everyday, building up muscle and endurance in order to use it at a higher percentage. Whenever he activates it, it burns through him in a way it never had before. He knows the quirk is stronger than it was, and while he knows that this strength will help him win, it’s worrisome. It took him so long to get a handle of OFA before it had this added strength, but now he has to learn how to keep a grapple on this new found power.

He hadn’t realized the power behind One For All until a week after receiving it. All Might had been training Katsuki and him when Izuku started to get frustrated. It had been a combination of having Ru and Kacchan eye him extra carefully now (they thought they were being subtle, which only frustrated him more), learning how to contain OFA with his other quirks, and the lack of sleep he never seemed to catch up on. He could only handle so much for the cup spilled over the edges.

All Might and him were doing some light, quirkless sparring to warm up while Kacchan stretched. Izuku’s head wasn’t in the game, and he got his ass handed to him. The whole morning there was something off, and itch he couldn’t scratch. He was buzzing with anxious energy that was refusing to leave him.

“Young-Midoriya! Where’s your head at, huh? I wasn’t even trying!”

But Izuku was. He was trying so damn hard and he hated that he wasn’t close to his best.

“C’mon Deku! You’re stronger than that,” Katsuki said in his own encouraging way. Yet it only ended up irritating Izuku further. Somedays, he couldn’t give all of his strength. His body wouldn’t let him, or his mind, or both. Nobody was at their best all of the time. No matter how much he wanted to be.

In a motion of anger, Izuku threw one last punch towards All Might. But the punch never landed, because before his fist could meet him, All Might was sent flying back by the pure force of One For All.

All Might’s large form left deep lines in the sand from where his feet tried to drag him to the stop. He finally braked himself, now a good thirty feet away from where he just stood.

Izuku was breathing heavily. At first he thought he had accidentally activated his telekinesis quirk. When he realized it was not that and instead OFA, it was because His body was still flashing with green sparks.

He hardly even felt One For All. Which meant that the percent he activated must have been small.

“What. The. Fuck,” Katsuki whispered.

He had pushed All Might, someone who was over five-hundred pounds, dozens a feet away without even *touching* him.

That would have taken at least 10% of OFA to do, especially with someone as powerful as Yagi. If he had barely even felt himself activating OFA… then that meant he used at the most 1%.

Something was different this time around.

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Izuku has been trying his best to get a grip on OFA. In the first few weeks of having One For All, he found that not using the quirk for a while made it build up and sometimes come out in uncontrollable bursts that would lead to him straining a muscle. Now, a few months later, his body has become more accustomed to holding such a powerful quirk and the outburst hardly ever happens anymore. Having a quirk is just like a muscle, so he tries to train it as much as possible. He’s running on limited time, and he tries to swallow down the panic at the thought of having to get used to One For All again.

Izuku can now use OFA up to 15%, although only for a minute tops before his body feels as though it’s on fire and his grip starts to slip. His other quirks tend to slip under his control when he’s using OFA at a higher

percentage, as though his body has trouble holding all of them at once. He nearly revealed his multiple quirks to All Might when he was training with him.

Which brings him to another obstacle: Yagi is gaining back his memories. Maybe it's not a problem, and could actually be a good thing, but it leaves Izuku in a constant argument with himself if it'll ever be a good time to talk about All Might about it. It's not like Izuku *knows* Yagi is regaining his memories. More like intuition. Yagi sometimes gets this far away look when Izuku does or says something and he has to snap him out of it. Toshinori himself has asked a few times if they've already done something, or saying he's having a deja vu moment.

Izuku has come to the belief that those who are regaining their memories (how many people? And why those people?) will only fully remember once Izuku tells them about what happened- what *will* happen. He only has Kacchan and Aizawa to go off of, but All Might hasn't fully remembered yet, and who knows how long he's been having flashes of memories.

He's asked Katsuki what he thinks he should do during their many days spent together (he still finds ways to avoid his parents. Afraid of adding more targets on people he cares about, afraid of explaining the unexplainable to people who have never truly lived in his world). Katsuki believes that Yagi has the right to know, but that he shouldn't try to focus on too many things at once. Instead, to take things in steps and stages. Focus on OFA and U.A. now. Then maybe think about telling All Might.

He's been getting more antsy as the months have gone by. With only one month left until the entrance exams, Izuku can hardly sit still. He's always itching to do something. Patrolling for hours at night, searching for Tomura, training OFA along with his other quirks (stronger, stronger, stronger-), planning for what's next. He can sense his body slowly dragging down from exhaustion, but his mind never settles down.

Sometimes he gets the urge to self-harm. His wrists scream at him to put a blade against them, but Katsuki took his blades away, and Izuku promised. He gets so angry in these moments when he's huddled under the covers in his bed or in the shower that's pouring white-hot water on him. He gets mad at Katsuki and Ru for taking this away from him, and then rages against himself for being mad at the people who are only caring for him. He hates that he's not normal. Normal people don't slice their skin on purpose, nor do they yearn for it.

During these moments he might call Katsuki, but he hates doing that because then neither of them get sleep. At times he'll bring his blankets into Ru's room and sleep on their floor just so he's not alone. When it's really bad, he'll go on patrol, being purposely more reckless when fighting.

Izuku just needs to get through this (This month, the entrance exams, then everything else). He can do this. He tells himself every time he can't sleep, every time he wakes up. He sees Ru, Kacchan, Aizawa, and All Might, reminding himself that this is worth it. He can do this. Because he has them.

And they are everything.

Chapter End Notes

Make sure you take care of yourself <3

Moments Like These

Chapter Summary

The U.A. Entrance Exam.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki is waiting for him at the entrance of the cafe. His book bag is slung over his shoulder lazily and he's wearing Aldera's uniform. He's not nervous, but not at ease, either. He's holding himself uptight, hands clenched and white-knucled.

Izuku smiles at him, saying without words *I know. I feel the same.* Izuku isn't wearing a school uniform since he's technically homeschooled. Instead, he's wearing black pants with a black button up jacket and a white undershirt. He gives Ru a hug and whispers, "Thank you."

Ru playfully slaps his shoulder, "What for? You've gotten this far with your own two feet. You're going to do great, and once you two get back, I'll have the biggest feast you've ever seen." They smile, "I love you, kiddo."

Izuku wipes tears from his eyes, ignoring Katsuki's small laugh, "I love you, too."

Ru nods, and then looks to Bakugou, "Knock em' dead."

Katsuki rolls his eyes, "Obviously." He fails to hide his smile.

"Now get out of here!" Ru exclaims. Izuku puts on his yellow backpack and slips on his red shoes. He meets Katsuki at the door and takes his hand.

"Ready?" Katsuki asks.

Izuku walks out of the cafe, "ready."

U.A. is beautiful. He has to stop walking to admire it, pulling Katsuki to a stop as well. Excited teens walk past them, but Izuku doesn't take any notice. The U.A. building stands tall and proud, sunlight reflecting off of its windows. He meets Katsuki's eye and smiles. He's waited so long for this day.

He turns to look back at the school, but gasps and takes a step back.

"Izu?"

The building is on fire. Smoke's enveloping it as the once gorgeous school crumbles to the ground. He swears he hears the screams of the people who didn't make it out. Izuku looks around and only sees red. Bodies are on the ground, flames swallowing everything in their path, destruction painting every surface. He nearly gags at the rancid smell of blood and burning flesh.

"Izuku."

He takes another step back, then another. A figure catches his eye.

It's *him* .

Blood is splattered on his alternate's face. His eyes are blank and dull, and it's easy to tell that no one is really *there.* That the body standing in front of him is just a puppet doing what it's told to do.

Something grabs his arm, "Izuku!"

He blinks, and everything is back to normal. The skies are blue, the trees aren't on fire, and U.A. is still standing. He slowly becomes aware of Katsuki gripping his arm, panic swirling in his ruby eyes. Izuku gulps and squeezes his eyes shut. He swears he can still smell the smoke and blood.

"Sorry. Just… Sorry." He feels as Katsuki lets go of his arm and quickly grabs his hand instead. He feels himself slightly relax at the familiar comfort.

"It's not going to happen."

“It might.”

“It won’t.” At the sheer truthfulness of Katsuki’s words, Izuku wills himself to look up at him. By looking at Katsuki’s face, he sees that Katsuki truly believes what he said without an ounce of doubt.

Izuku squeezes his hand, whispering, “Thank you.”

“Tch. What kind of boyfriend would I be if I didn’t help you?” Izuku huffs a small, but real laugh. He loves that word. *Boyfriend.*

They continue to walk towards the building, but Izuku must have not been paying attention to where he was putting his feet, because he trips. He squeezes his eyes shut, cursing himself at being so clumsy.

He never hits the ground. All he feels is a sense of deja vu, and when he opens his eyes, he sees that the ground is mere inches from his face. He realizes that he’s floating. Izuku’s eyes widened, knowing what this meant. This has happened before.

Katsuki’s arms hook under his arms and gets him standing on his feet again. Izuku hardly even registers his presence, and very blatantly ignores his huff of annoyance at being ignored.

Because right in front of him is Uraraka Ochaco.

She smiles. He can’t believe he forgot how radiant her smile was. “Are you okay?” she asks. He just gapes at her, so she continues to talk, “I stopped you with my quirk, I’m sorry I didn’t ask first. I kinda figured you wouldn’t mind,” she lets out a small laugh.

Katsuki jabs him in the ribs, knocking him out of his speechless state. “N-no. I didn’t mind. Thank you.”

“Tch. He’s clumsy as fuck. Knowing him he probably would’ve broken his nose.” Izuku glares at Katsuki before smiling at Uraraka.

She smiles back, all warmth. “Well, I guess I’ll see you later. Good luck!”

She’s already out of hearing distance before Izuku manages a “You too.” He looks at Katsuki as he feels a smile stretch his face. Katsuki offers a small smirk of his own.

He knew he would be seeing everyone again. *Obviously* he would be seeing everyone again. But now that knowledge has become a present reality and he finally lets himself feel excited about it.

He grabs Katsuki's hand and starts dragging him towards the entrance, "Lets go!"

He hears Katsuki perfectly as he grumbles about having plenty of time, but knows by the squeeze of his hand that he's just as anticipatory as he is to see his friends. Friends that don't even know him yet.

They enter the building.

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They're sitting in the big lecture hall with the hundreds of other students hoping to be a part of U.A's student body. Izuku is sitting right next to him, just like last time, and is muttering up a storm. A part of Katsuki wants to shush him in order to avoid Four Eyes' comment, but another part of him wants it to happen again. Mostly because he thinks it'll make Izuku happy to see Iida again, but also because he remembers how goddamn funny it was last time.

"And you!" Iida yells from across the massive room. Izuku immediately stops his muttering and only stares at the boy, mouth hanging open. Katsuki snickers as Glasses continues on his tangent, watching as a blush creeps up Izuku's face. Izuku looks at him in fake betrayal, a smile unable to be kept hidden on his face.

"You could've warned me!" Izuku whispers, softly punching Katsuki in the arm.

"Where's the fun in that?"

God, he loved this. His appreciation for it has only increased as their time together increased. He loved every moment with Izuku. The bickering, comforting, training, basking in each other's presence. He wanted it to last.

A lot longer than it did last time.

"Whoever gets the lowest score of the two treats the other to their favorite restaurant?" Katsuki challenges, wanting some fun out of this incredibly long test that they have to take *again* .

"You're so on!" Izuku whispers.

But apparently he was too loud, because from across the room they could hear Iida say, “Ahem!”

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After the written test, they have a quick lunch break before the physical. Katsuki drags Izuku away from the crowd with lunches he packed for both of them.

“Kacchan! Where are you taking us?”

“Be patient, will you?” They were both tired after the written test, and Katuki knew a crowded cafeteria wouldn’t help either of them. So he led them toward a little patch of forestry where a little wooden bench was placed and birds could be heard chirping a happy little tune. “Remember this place?” He asks.

Izuku has a soft smile on his face, eyes alight with warmth. “Of course I do,” he replies. He then smirks, “It’s when you finally got the guts to say that you love me.”

“I said it first!” Katsuki yells, triumph in his voice.

“I confessed first!”

They looked at each other and burst out laughing. It was a moment of peace that rarely came. Katsuk makes sure to soak in the sound of Izuku’s laughter- a sound that wasn’t often made.

“C’mon nerd, let’s eat before we kick some ass.”

So they sat on the carved bench with sun beaming through the trees, basking in the other’s presence.

Their hands intertwined, and they didn’t let go.

_____

Izuku stands at the entrance to the physical exam. He tries to even his breathing, knowing he’ll be fine. He ignores (or attempts to) the what ifs. At least he doesn’t have to worry too much about activating OFA like last time. Maybe he could even get away without breaking any bones.

He was lost in his head -as he so often is- and didn't hear Yamada announce the start of the test. The loud buzzer set his feet running towards the gate. Right away he came face to face with a robot. Something that had seemed so intimidating was now child's play.

Izuku refined his control to 1% OFA and sucker-punched the robot in its face. The power was enough to smash its head in.

Izuku maintained the 1% throughout his body and started to run towards another robot when a flash of purple hair caught his eye. He changed direction and saw Shinsou trapped underneath a robot. Izuku swung his leg and kicked the robot off of him. He held out his hand, which surprisingly, Shinsou took.

"Thanks," he grumbled. He already looked like he was giving up- knowing now how this test was more suited for physical quirks. The thought of him giving up so quickly enraged a small part of Izuku.

"There's a hidden point system. Try not to just focus on attacking the robots, but helping people. You'll be able to make it." He barely notices Shinsou dumbly nodding before shooting off into another direction.

He doesn't go overboard with taking out the machines. He could take them all, but why take someone else's chance? He gets enough to secure him a passing grade, and then moves on to helping people stuck under rubble or reaching their limit with their quirk.

"THREE MINUTES LEFT!" Yamada's voice calls out.

Uraraka. He has to find Uraraka. He's deep within the fake city now, and he doesn't remember where he was when they released the zero pointer. Izuku pushes himself to 3% as he starts running through the streets and alleyways. His body stings with overexertion. He hasn't used OFA for this long consecutively yet and he's starting to feel the consequences of pushing himself.

He keeps going.

Izuku hears it before he sees it. His legs shake as the ground trembles, and as he rounds the corner, he sees her stuck underneath the rubble. Everyone is running in the opposite direction, the Zero Pointer's shadow looming over them. People shove past him, some even try to get him to follow them.

But his feet know what to do. They carry him toward one of his best friends, and for one moment, everything slows. He's calm and clear-headed. The boisterous sound around him dims into a muffle.

He lunges, and then he is flying. He's higher than the buildings, the wind cold and refreshing against his face. His legs are on fire, but he doesn't pay them any mind as he swings his fist and thrusts it towards the giant.

He doesn't even make contact with it, but the force of the wind alone is enough to utterly destroy it. The face - if you could still call it a face- crumbles. It falls back, and then he's falling, too.

Izuku's mind scrambles for ideas to soften his landing. Trying to latch onto something with his telekinesis, but his attention wavers whenever he tries to get something. He whirls around in the air, attempting to point his arm towards the ground. He thinks if he times it right, he could flick the ground to create enough wind force to soften his landing.

Right before he's about to release a shot of OFA, Uraraka slaps him. He's levitating for only a second until he's dropped the extra few feet and slams hard onto the concrete ground.

The wind is knocked out of him, and he can't breathe. He gasps for air, feeling blocked off of it. He sucks in again and again, and finally he's able to grab air.

Izuku hears Uraraka say something, but he's too dazed to register the actual words. Relief overwhelms him that he once again protected her from the zero pointer and she, in return, saved him from splatting on the ground in a bloody mess.

He doesn't need to look at his limbs to know that they're broken. He's been friends with the pain of broken bones for a long time now. He hardly even registers the pain of it these days.

At least he'll be able to see Recovery Girl again.

"He's surely grown in these past few years, hasn't he Aizawa-San?" Nezu asks, never taking his eyes away from the several monitors.

Aizawa barely manages a nod, too busy staring at Yagi, who had his eyes glued onto Midoriya getting emergency treatment for Recovery Girl. Yagi's knuckles were white from clenching his hands so hard. He could practically see the worry emanating from him. Aizawa looks back to the screen and is relieved to see that Izuku's limbs were no longer mangled in a stomach-twisting way. The boy hardly even seemed to register the pain of multiple broken bones (which was worrying- how much his pain tolerance has increased to a near impossible level), and was now chatting animatedly with Chiyo.

He walks over to Yagi's side and says, "Tough kid, huh?"

Toshinori nods, looking proud. "Very. He's going to do well."

Aizawa has never understood Midoriya's and Yagi's relationship, but he knew not to push it. He had known that Midoriya was Yagi's successor, but he never knew how that formed. He never even truly knew -until now- that they had known each other before Izuku started U.A. Maybe he would find out more in the near future. He would just have to talk to Izuku when he was in a good enough mood to be open with him.

But that's not what he was after. Not today, at least.

"I actually met him a long time ago, when he was just a little kid," Aizawa started.

Yagi finally looks at him, "Really? As did I. It's strange how paths intermingle."

Aizawa hums, wondering if Midoriya had met All Might so early on in the last timeline as well. "It's strange… Even before I met him, I felt as if I knew him." Maybe he was being too blunt, but it was a test. Midoriya had told him that only he and Bakugou remembered. But if there were to be any other people that would remember about the time before this one, it had to be Toshinori Yagi.

Yagi chuckles softly, "I've actually had dreams of him. They started around the time when I met him, but the weird thing was that he was this age. Looking exactly as he does now, only perhaps a bit stronger. Some of those dreams were pleasant and happy, others…"

"Were filled with war and grief?" Fills in Aizawa.

Yagi's eyes drop, no doubt remembering the small fragments of those terrible dreams. What *he* thinks are dreams.

"How did you know that?"

Aizawa looks back at the monitor. Izuku's being slowly helped up by Uraraka. He looks so grateful to be able to be next to his friend again.

Izuku's going to need more people to be by his side. He can only carry so much by himself, and it's time for someone else to know. To help carry this god-awful burden.

"We have to talk."

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Yagi has never talked to Aizawa before, not really. They've done missions together, but full conversations have never passed between them. He was surprised, to say the least, when Aizawa approached him during the exams. He had been so focused on Young Midoriya (he was so, so proud of him. He was extraordinary. Although, he was not happy with how he ended up with several broken bones) that he hadn't even realized Aizawa had walked up to him until he started talking. Even then, it had taken Yagi a moment to realize that the underground hero had been talking directly to him.

Now, they were at a small cafe not too far from the school. Aizawa with coffee and him with herbal tea. Yagi had texted Midoriya how proud he was, and that he was sorry he couldn't meet up with him that day to tell him in person. He also ordered Midoriya to rest, knowing that the boy would need it.

The two heroes sit awkwardly as they blankly stare at one another. They're sitting outside with minimal people walking about. It's fairly private, and he frowns at how weird and confusing this scenario was.

"So," Yagi starts, finally breaking the silence, "what did you want to talk about?"

Aizawa takes a long sip of his coffee, the only indicator that he was potentially nervous about whatever the topic was that he wanted to discuss. That only made Yagi more anxious, because he never knew Aizawa to be a nervous person.

"Midoriya Izuku," Aizawa finally says. Yagi perks up at hearing his successor's name. Nothing bad could come from talking about Young Midoriya.

"Ah, okay. What about him?"

Aizawa ponders for a moment, "He's different."

Something about the way Aizawa said that unnerved Yagi, but he nodded anyway, "Agreed. He's going to be a fine student, and a great hero."

Aizawa brushes off his comment, gripping his coffee cup a bit too hard. “You mentioned your dreams about him. How it was almost as if they were based in the future.”

Yagi eyes Aizawa’s coffee cup. There’s a small chip in it. He wonders how much more pressure it will be able to take until it shatters.

“Yes, I suppose they did. I tried writing them down as soon as they happened, but the details were always so quick to run away.”

Aizawa nods, as if he perfectly understands what he’s saying. But he can’t; there’s no way. How could he understand seeing his own death? Feel the sharp, black spears pierce him, or having his head placed on the lap of a crying boy whispering *“I’m sorry, I’m sorry. I’m so sorry,”* ?

“What if they weren’t just dreams?” Aizawa asks, staring down at his empty cup. Yagi’s heart thuds against his chest painfully. The thing is, he *knew* that they weren’t dreams, but he couldn’t explain them as anything else.

Aizawa sighs, “Like I said before, I met Midoriya a long time ago, just as you did. And just like you, I had dreams revolving around him. Dreams of him as my student, some good, others terrible and gut-wrenching. All of them seemingly too *real* to be a dream.”

Yagi shakes his head, although he doesn’t know why.

“Your feet moved on their own, didn’t they?”

He squeezes his eyes shut, “Why are you telling me this?”

Aizawa leans forward, “Because those dreams? They were real.”

He was helpless. Young Midoriya was missing, and there was nothing he could do.

The boy was on the ground sobbing. The colors of a sunset raining down on him. He was swallowed by his black middle school uniform, but All Might knew that the boy was going to discover a strength that no one else had. It was only a matter of time.

His head felt like it was going to explode, but he managed to force words out, “What does that even mean?”

“They really happened. In a different timeline, before Midoirya rewound time to save us.”

“I’ll fix this! Somehow, I’ll fix this!” Izuku yelled, screamed, sobbed. Yagi was so, so weak, There just wasn’t enough in him anymore. But even then, Yagi believed Izuku with all his heart. He knew it was going to be okay. Even if he wasn’t there to see it.

He looks at Aizawa, vision blurred by tears.

“They were memories.”

“I’ll make you proud, All Might!”

“My boy, You already have.”

He remembered. God, he remembered.

“I won’t let anyone hurt the people I love ever again. I’ll do whatever it takes.”

And he did. Midoriya Izuku did the impossible.

All alone. For so long.

Yagi covers his hands and cries.

“You too can become a hero.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so, so much for all of the support. I can't explain how much I appreciate it.

Love you all!

Saudade

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hato was just about to jump out of his window when his cell phone rang. No one ever calls him, so he immediately assumed it was an emergency. He got off of the window sill and took off his mask. He checked his phone to see it was Yagi who was calling him. He frowns, trying to ignore the anxiety swirling in his stomach.

“Hello? All Might?” He says, careful to keep his voice quiet and even.

“Ah, Young Midoriya,” Yagi says. Izuku immediately heard the nervousness intertwined in his voice. It only made him more nervous. It was a little past eleven at night, way too late for this call to be just a casual one.

“Is everything alright? Do you need me? What's wrong?” Izuku stammers, unable to control his worries.

Yagi ignores his questioning, or perhaps doesn’t hear it at all, “I know it’s late. I was actually going to tell you this tomorrow, but I couldn’t sleep and all I could think about was telling you-”

Izuku looses control of his patience and interrupts him, “All Might!” He instantly feels guilty about shouting, “Sorry. Just- can you tell me what’s wrong?”

“I remember,” Toshinori forces out, like it had been glued to the back of his throat for a long time.

A pit drops to the bottom of Izuku’s stomach. It grows into a series of frantic thoughts.

“I-” he says, but can’t get anything else out. He’s stuck in place, and he has to constantly remind himself to breathe.

All Might remembers.

He *remembers.*

He knows that Izuku has been lying to him all this time. That he was the cause of so many people dying, that he had the capability to be a *monster* . Sure, Kacchan and Aizawa didn’t think of him that way, but who's to say

that All Might wouldn't? He'd probably had the most potential of hating him out of everyone else. Afterall, he was All Might's successor. Or, was supposed to be. But now Yagi knows that Izuku fought a war on the *wrong side* , aiding in so many people's deaths. *His* death.

Izuku didn't snap out of it until it was too late. AFO's mind control had done its job, and was now leaving Izuku to deal with the consequences.

He may have not been able to control his actions, but he had been able to see and feel everything. It was the sensation of being trapped in a prison. Except the prison was his own damn mind and there had been no way out.

He saw the way his classmate's faces crumbled once they saw him with the league. For a while they refused to attack them, but Izuku didn't give them any mercy. He witnessed as he attacked them, using all of their weaknesses. Izuku knew them all- had written them down to help them get stronger.

He felt their blood spill onto his skin. Heard their screams of pain and anguish. Izuku yelled and yelled with no sound coming from his mouth, begging them to attack *him to* kill *him.*

Izuku stood by as his mentor was killed by AFO. Watched as Todoroki burned and burned. Stole Uraraka's last breath, and Iida's, and Kaminari's.

"Young Midoriya?" Yagi whispered. His voice was gentle. Why was it so gentle?

"All Might?" He barely choked out. His name was a list of questions. What was All Might going to do now? Did he despise Izuku as much as he did?

"It's okay. We're going to be okay," Yagi stated. He was always so kind. Izuku's heart squeezed. He didn't understand this kindness. He didn't know why it was being given to him.

"What? I don't- why aren't you yelling at me? Why aren't you angry?" He should be more than angry. He should be so much more.

Yagi sighs, and Izuku flinches, "Young Midoriya, I'm not angry. At least, not at you. Never at you. I'm mad that you had to go through all this all alone for so long. That you had to carry the weight of our lives, our memories, on your shoulders. That's something that not even the greatest hero should be expected to do. In actuality, I should be thanking you."

Izuku sank down to his bedroom floor, no longer having the strength to carry his own weight, “Thanking me?” The idea seemed preposterous. Why on Earth would anyone be thanking him?

Yagi laughed gently, “Yes, my boy. Thank you for giving everyone a second chance. You’ve given us what no one else has the opportunity to have: a second chance at life. Thank you for caring and protecting and loving us, even when we had no idea. Even when -to us- you were just a stranger.”

Izuku couldn’t speak. He was choking on so many emotions at once, and it was near impossible sorting through all of them.

Luckily, Yagi keeps on talking, “I’ll text you tomorrow, okay? We can talk about what comes next because thanks to you, you gave us that opportunity.”

Izuku’s mind is whirling, but he manages a nod, only to realize that All Might can’t see him. “Ok… yeah, ok.”

“Good night, Young Midoriya.”

“Good night, All Might,” Izuku whispers, so quiet that he barely hears it himself. They hang up,and Izuku gives up all hope on going on patrol. Instead, he mind numbingly climbs into bed without even changing out of his vigilante outfit and gets under the covers.

He’s asleep as soon as he closes his eyes.

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He grips on to his whisky glass tightly, pinkies lifted. He stares hard at the ice cube, daring it to melt and waterdown his drink.

Today is officially the first day of class for U.A students. He knows this, just like he knows the sky is blue and if he puts all five fingers down on his glass, it will disintegrate into a pile of ash.

This is the week where everything will change. He’s been preparing for this for *years* . Even since AFO found him at The Arena. All of the training, all of the side hustles, all of it, was for this.

The first step to burning the hero society down to the ground.

Shigaraki Tomura feels something akin to excitement at what this week will bring. He despises the heroes (except one-) and everything they've failed to live up to (no one ever saved him. He's still *here*-). He wants to share all of his pain with them, to show how he has *suffered* (no one will ever understand. Only-).

Master has trained him (yells and quirks against his skin and manipulations) to fester his anger. To keep it bright and burning.

He doesn't think he'll ever not be angry. It is a part of him -this anger- and without it, he's just a scared kid locked in a cage.

With one swallow, he downs his whisky. It burns delightfully all the way down his throat to his chest.

Only a few more days. Soon, he'll finally be able to show his face and all that he has become. He'll win this game. He'll pass this test.

After all, this is what consumes Shigaraki Tomura. Encompassing him like a black hole. It doesn't matter if this is who he wants to be, or who he is. This is the path he was led to and he'll be damned if he trips.

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They're at the beach, just the two of them. Izuku brought pastries from the cafe, although he knows neither of them will eat right now. The sun is setting, but the clouds are too thick, too gray, to hold any colors.

He's tense next to All Might. No number of deep breaths help relax him, and he feels his shoulders rise up like walls.

They're both sitting on the hill of grass, not speaking. They swim in their silence for a long time. Izuku was still trying to wrap his head around the fact that All Might remembered.

"So you know now? Everything?" Izuku asks, the first one to break the silence.

Yagi nods, gaze directed to the fading sun, "Some of it's still blurry, but yes, I remember." Izuku hums. Words, usually so easy for him, are lost. Yagi continues, "Young Midoriya… how long have you been doing this?"

Izuku tilts his head, "What do you mean?"

“I mean- God, I met you when you were just a small child in this timeline. You tried to warn me about my battle with All For One. You’ve been dealing with this for that long?”

Izuku shrugs, not mentioning that it was longer. “You have to understand, I couldn’t just immediately tell someone what had happened. I didn’t *know* people could remember. I came to the notion that I had to do it by myself, and by the time I understood that others could help, I became so used to doing it alone.”

He didn’t mention that he didn’t want to burden people. He knows that Katsuki has nightmares about dying. Nightmares that were once a reality. Izuku can’t fathom the idea of knowing you *died* , only to be revived into the past. And now three people had to do that.

“What about Mrs. Midoriya? Surely she knows something. After all, you two are connected by blood.”

Izuku winces, the familiar stab of grief makes itself known at the center of his chest. He tries not to think of his mother because once he does, he can’t stop.

It’s then that he realizes that All Might still thinks that he’s living with her. That he’s still a son.

Izuku shoves the words out, “She died a long time ago.”

Yagi sputters and chokes. He doesn’t say anything for a long time, and Izuku finally gets the will to look over. He’s surprised to see that the hero is crying. Tears streamed steadily down his cheeks.

“Y-yagi. Are you okay?”

Yagi sniffles, “I’m sorry that I didn’t know about your mom’s passing. She was such an amazing woman.”

“You didn’t know because I didn’t tell you,” Izuku says.

Yagi wipes his eyes, “Know that I will always be on your side, My Boy. I, along with the others who remember, will make sure you’re not alone in the battle. We’re going to fix this. And we’re going to do it together.”

His words brought unwanted tears to his eyes. Even so, a smile formed on Izuku's face, "Thank you… Thank you."

Yagi guided Izuku's head to his shoulder, forming a side hug, "No need to thank me, Young Midoirya. After all, we're heroes. It's what we do."

Izuku realized that somewhere along the way -Perhaps years ago-, he forgot what it truly meant to be a hero. Maybe he had given up on that dream, believing that he couldn't be a hero after the things he's done.

But All Might's words reignited that spark. The urge to become a hero in every sense of the word.

He wanted nothing more than to save the people he loved, and isn't that what a hero was?

At that moment, Izuku thought that maybe, just maybe, he could continue on the path toward his dream. A dream that he had nearly forgotten about.

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Katsuki and Izuku walk into U.A. holding hands. He notices Izuku's eyes glued to the ground, so he forces Izuku to stop walking. They're both shaking. Katsuki squeezes Izuku's hand tighter.

"Izuku," he says as he looks at him. Katsuki usually forgets that Izuku is a couple inches shorter than him, and it's always a shock when he fully registers it. Izuku usually gives off the air of someone who's larger than life (and he is. He's brighter and more beautiful than the fucking sun), but sometimes he tries to disappear. And it's in moments like this one, that Izuku looks so *small.* "Look at me," Katsuki urges.

Izuku listens to him, although a bit grudgingly. His eyes slide immediately to Katsuki's, making sure to avoid looking at everyone else.

"It's okay to look at everyone. It's real." It's something Katsuki has been repeating to himself all morning. He looks around the hallway, at all the excited, nervous, hopeful students bustling about, trying to get to their classes. His heart squeezes as his eyes catch onto people he used to know- is *going* to know.

"Everytime I look, all I see are their deaths," Izuku whispers, his tone anguished.

Katsuki returns his gaze back to him. Izuku was clearly uncomfortable; he was never one to share his deeper emotions, and that only got worse during these past few years. Katsuki knew he was working on it, and was proud of him. He was also glad that Izuku felt safe enough around him to tell him his troubles with trust,

“Then you’re going to have to keep on looking. Get used to the fact that we’re standing here, and our friends are, too.”

Izuku’s eyes sparkled, but not with tears. Katsuki thinks that they shone with something akin to hope. The Nerd nodded and started to walk, still holding Katsuki’s hand.

This time, both of their heads were held high.

_____

Izuku walks through the giant class 1-A door. He knows exactly who’s inside before stepping foot inside, his enhanced hearing picking up every single sound.

He sticks close to Kacchan’s side as they stand near the door. Both are staring at everything they can get their eyes on. Izuku feels his chest constrict, and he has to blink rapidly in order to erase all the flashes of memories resurfacing.

It’s Iida who notices them first. He walks over to them (He didn’t have legs. Oh god, he didn’t have *legs* -), posture ramrod straight.

Izuku squeezes Katsuki’s hands tighter, who squeezes back with just as much strength.

“You’re the person who was muttering during the written exam,” Iida states as a greeting. Izuku’s face heats up, “And you also ran *towards* the zero-pointer.”

“That’s me,” he chirps, his voice sounding foreign to his own ears.

Katsuki scoffs, “He was the only one brave enough to fight that piece of shit. And he saved someone because of that.” Izuku nudges Katsuki with his elbow, urging him to play nice. Katsuki only nudges him back (with far more strength than he gave).

Iida nods, and then holds out his hand, “My name is Iida Tenya, pleased to make your acquaintance.”

Izuku releases his hand from Katsuki’s, who grumbles at that, and shakes Iida’s hand, “Midoriya Izuku.”

That’s when Uraraka and Kirishima come up to them, all smiles and wonder.

“It’s you!” Uraraka says, “The clumsy boy.”

“The clumsy boy?” Izuku stutters, ignoring Katsuki’s snicker.

Uraraka nods, “I’m Uraraka Ochaco. I can already tell that we’re going to be great friends!” Izuku’s heart warms. He’s finally able to be with his best friends again.

“I’m Midoriya Izuku, but you can call me Deku if you want.” It was a name that only Katsuki and Uraraka ever called him out of heroics, and it was something that he wouldn’t mind happening again.

Uraraka tilts her head, “Deku? It sounds like Dekiru!” Izuku nods, because that’s exactly what it sounds like, and that’s what he wants it to mean. *You can do it!*

Kirishima butts in, pointing his thumb to his chest, “Nice to meet you Midobro! I’m Kirishima Ejiro.” He looks over to Kacchan, “and who are you?”

“Bakugou Katsuki.” Katsuki has a smirk on his face, and Izuku thinks about how relieving it is to see Kacchan so happy- it reminds him that he’s not the only one dealing with seeing his best friends again after so long.

The bell rings, Iida yelling out, “Okay, everyone! Let’s get to our seats!” Everyone rolls their eyes, but obliges.

Izuku was just about to walk over to his seat when a hand grabbed onto his collar and pushed him against the wall.

The air was suddenly ice cold, countering the boiling anger of the person nearly choking him.

It was Todoroki Shoto. His heterochromic eyes boring down on him. Izuku tilted his head and smiled, which only seemed to make the other boy angrier. Izuku was fine with that; he understood why Todoroki was so angry with him.

“Hey-!” Katsuki yelled, but what cut off with a stare from Izuku.

“Kacchan, don’t.” Katsuki backed off, albeit not happily. Izuku turned his attention back to Todoroki, “It’s been a while, hasn’t it?”

The hand around his collar tightened, small particles of ice forming on Izuku’s uniform. “It’s been *years* . You *left-”* Todoroki snarled. Izuku’s heart squeezed at the clear ache in his friend’s voice. It was times like these that he wished his healing quirk took away emotional pain, too.

“I had to, and I’m not sorry for it.” He had to protect and protect and protect. He needed to plan and get stronger and fight for the *future-*

Izuku continues, “But I’m sorry I didn’t tell you. I’m sorry I only visited you once. I’m sorry you had to go through so much.”

Todoroki’s hands were trembling, and he finally let go of his collar only to slump down and lay his head on Izuku’s chest.

“I’m so *angry,”* he mutters.

Izuku hums. Everyone in the class was staring at them, but Izuku didn’t care. He distantly hears Aizawa’s near-silent footsteps coming toward the classroom.

“Then be angry,” Izuku says, “hate me, yell at me, do whatever you need to. Just know that I’m still your friend. But for right now, we need to get through our first day of U.A., okay?”

Todoroki steps away from him, and for just a moment, his eyes soften, but quickly harden again. “Know that I’m expecting an explanation from you, Midoriya.”

Izuku smiles and nods. And just like that, the atmosphere is warmer, the ice melting on his shirt. Although he knows it’ll take a while for Todoroki to forgive him -if he ever will-, and that it’ll take some time before they can truly be friends again. Izuku’s patient: he’ll wait however long it’ll take.

Izuku had just taken his seat behind Katsuki when Aizawa walked into the classroom. They make brief eye contact with one another before Aizawa faces the entire class.

The teacher offers a smirk that makes most of the class shudder, “Welcome to your first day of heroics.”

Chapter End Notes

So sorry for such a late post. Life has been so busy (I've been having to constantly remind myself to breathe, literally) with graduation around the corner, extracurricular activities, my birthday (18!), and AP testing.

I hope you enjoyed this chapter though :D thank you for your patience

Tutelary

Chapter Summary

The first day.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku watched. His gaze floated across every student. And as he watched, he analyzed. Making notes on even the most minuscule of details. He notices how Shinsou (Mineta's replacement) lacks stamina and strength, but is agile and light on his feet. Kirishima's quirk makes him slow, and hasn't earned the name "unbreakable" yet. Kaminari looks slightly afraid of himself- of what his quirk can do to him once pushed too far.

He sees the potential, and knows how strong these people will grow to be. But he doesn't know how much time they have, and he knows that they're all going to have to work harder than before. Push them past their limits, train them for something they don't even know is going to happen (and they will learn, eventually. But they're just starting, and Izuku wants them to have their childhood for as long as possible).

Katsuki is strong, but he's not like who he used to be, and Izuku knows this frustrates him. And maybe this frustration is good, because he can turn that into power.

Izuku uses his quirk in the practices Aizawa has set them up for as well, refusing to hold back. Aizawa is repeating these exercises not to potentially expel any students, but to set them up for survival. He knows them, even if they don't quite know him. He's doing what Izuku is doing, soaking in every strength, growth, and weakness to ensure that none of them will die before their time.

It's a weird thing, to excel at something you once failed at. He comes in first in some of the courses, second or third in the others. He ignores the shocked looks from Todoroki (after all, he was supposed to be quirkless), and the curious glances from Shinsou. Everyone seemed surprised by his skill -besides Kacchan and Aizawa-Sensei-, and why wouldn't they be? They don't know that he's done this before, or that he has years worth of knowledge and training on them. None of them have had to fight in war, or be trapped in The Arena, or roam the streets, witnessing the darkest parts of the human species.

He can see the wall building between him and his friends (just classmates, they don't even know him), separating them. Izuku tries to smile warmly at them, and compliment them on how amazing they are (not just their quirks, but *them*).

They're smart, and while they know that he is not like them, they also gather that he wants to be here, with them.

After the courses are finished, Shinsou walks up to him, rubbing the back of his neck. His eyes are downcast, and it takes a moment for him to find words. But Izuku is patient, he has to be.

Shinsou looks up, making eye contact, “I -uh- wanted to say thank you, for helping me at the entrance exam. I wouldn’t have passed if it weren’t for your advice.”

Izuku smiles (Shinsou squints at the brightness), “No need to thank me. You would have made it one way or another. Have more faith in yourself.”

In order to win a war, one has to trust themselves and know just how much they’re capable of.

Izuku squeezes Shinsou’s shoulder before walking to the locker room to change. He grabs his clothes, and just like when he was putting on his uniform, he goes inside a bathroom stall to change. No one has ever seen the full extent of his scars, and he can’t risk freaking any of them out. He wouldn’t be able to answer any of the questions about the electric burn scars from The Arena (among the various others from that hell), his self-harm scars, or the plethora of permanent markings from being a vigilante. He doesn’t bother to count them- doesn’t want to be reminded of what caused them.

People look at him oddly when he exits the stall, but don’t ask questions much to Izuku’s relief. Katsuki narrows his eyes at him; even he doesn’t know the extent of scar tissue Izuku’s body adorns.

It’s then that Kaminari’s voice catches his attention: “Yo, did you guys hear that we’re going to go to the USJ in a few days? I’m so stoked!”

Izuku feels his face pale. He catches Katsuki’s eye and sees that his reaction was similar. They had been so busy with training and focusing on getting into U.A that the USJ attack hadn’t had a chance to occupy their minds. He slowly walks out of the locker room, trying his best to act normal. But a wave of self-hatred and panic washed over him. How could he have been so careless as to forget the class’s first encounter with villains? With *Shigaraki.*

Shimura Tenko. In just a few short days, he’ll be face-to-face with him. The first time in months, in years if he doesn’t count that glimpse of him on the roof.

Katsuki is right next to him. Izuku doesn’t know how long he’s been walking beside him, but as he always does, he takes comfort in his presence.

Katsuki also doesn't know about how intertwined Shigaraki and Izuku really are. He doesn't know that he was the reason he had the ability to travel back to time, nor does he know about the time spent together at The Arena.

"Promise me you'll save me in the next life," Tenko whispered as he injected Izuku with the last quirk. As soon as the quirk was introduced into his system, Izuku started to scream.

It was more painful than any of the other quirks forced upon his body. He writhed and clawed at the ground. His entire existence started to glitch. After all, a quirk that can not only rewind time but create a whole new timeline altogether is a powerful thing. Not one meant to exist in any world, even one full of mutated people.

He felt as though his insides were being ripped up, and all he wanted was death. His limbs flickered only to reappear again.

Once it was over, Izuku was too weak to fight AFO and his mind control. At least until it was too late.

Izuku hasn't kept his promise. He let AFO get to Shigaraki and he's no longer sure if he'll be able to stray from the path that he was put on.

But he has to try. He has to hope that Shimura Tenko is still there, and still wants to be saved.

Izuku takes a deep breath and nods at Katsuki.

"We're going to need to talk to Aizawa."

———

Izuku and Katsuki walk into the classroom during lunch, finding Aizawa zipped up in his sleeping bag in the corner of the room. Izuku sighs, feeling a tinge of guilt for having to wake up the hero when he obviously needs the rest.

Don't they all.

Izuku walks over to his teacher (he still can't believe he can call him that again. It's surreal. He finds it hard to call him "Sensei" when they've been fighting side by side for the last couple of years) and gently, but firmly,

kicks him. Shota wakes up immediately, and out of reflex goes to grab Izuku's foot. Before he can do so, Izuku takes a couple of steps back.

Aizawa groans, "Problem Child."

"We need to talk, along with Nezu and All Might."

He gets out of the sleeping bag and goes to sit at his desk. He stares at Izuku and Katsuki, waiting for them to talk.

"What the hell are we going to do about the USJ trip?" Katsuki rips off the bandaid.

Aizawa pinches the bridge of his nose, "I've been thinking about that."

"Well?" Izuku pushes, "We only have a few days, and there's also that break in that happened."

"We're going to cancel the trip and not tell anyone about it until the day we're supposed to leave. That way it can't leak."

Izuku shakes his head. He doesn't understand; that can't work. But how can he, or anyone? No one knows how deep his connection with Shigaraki goes. Katsuki nudges him with a brush of his shoulder. He senses Aizawa's questioning gaze on him.

He takes a deep breath, "Fine. Cancel it last minute, but know that I'm going to be there. I have to be."

"Absolutely not," Both Katsuki and Shota say at the same time.

"Will you let me finish?" Izuku growls out, "I need to talk to Shigaraki. I can save him and bring him to our side."

"Midoriya, you out of everyone should know that he's too far gone to be saved."

Anger surges through him. He hates it when people assume what he's been through and how it went about. As if he should have a set feeling or emotion to a particular event. But it's not that linear. Nothing ever is.

Most days, he's either feeling everything at once or nothing at all.

"You don't get to dictate *anything* about how I should feel or think about someone. I know him better than anyone at this school, and he knows me too." Izuku takes another deep breath, "He's probably the only reason I survived The Arena."

Both Katsuki and Aizawa tense next to him. Izuku hardly ever talks about what happened in that hellhole, and when he does, it's only in bits and snippets. He only ever lets their imagination come up with the true horrors of that place of pain.

"You mean- he was in The Arena with you?" Aizawa asks.

He nods, "We were in the same cell together." He ignores how Katsuki flinches at the use of the word "cell". But in all honesty, that room was a luxury compared to everything else. "But none of that matters. I promised Tomura that I would save him, in both timelines, and this is my chance to do it."

Aizawa releases a long suffering sigh and Katsuki makes a *tching* sound next to him. "If the Nerd is going, then so am I."

Izuku shakes his head, "No. I'm the only one that can be in there."

Katsuki tilts his head, challenging him, "And why is that? And what about the hundred other villains that are going to be there, huh?"

"Bakugou is right, Problem Child. There's no way I'm letting you go in there alone."

Izuku flings his hands up in frustration, "Look, if you need to be there, then be outside alongside how many other heroes you want there. I just need to get to Tomura, and I can without anyone noticing I'm even there."

He's talking about his invisibility quirk: it makes him unnoticeable unless someone was already aware of his appearance beforehand.

Aizawa groans, and Izuku almost feels bad. Katsuki is still shaking his head. “No. I’m not letting you go in alone. Not after he *took you-”*

Izuku cuts him off, “He doesn’t remember that. And technically, this Tomura isn’t the same as the one you knew before. If things go south, have your backup storm the place and take everyone down. I don’t care. You just have to let me *try.”*

He was going to do this, whether they wanted him to or not. But that didn’t stop Izuku from wanting their trust. He knew he could accomplish this task. Izuku needed to talk to Tomura, but he also needed to see if that boy from The Arena was still there.

Izuku grabs Katsuki’s hand and looks him in the eye, urging him to trust him. He knew it was impossible for anyone but him to understand. However, they didn’t need to understand.

Katsuki whispers a curse, knowing that there was no changing Izuku’s mind. Izuku looks back at Aizawa, waiting for him to say something.

“I’ll give you five minutes,” the teacher says, “If you’re not back by then, or at the very least send some kind of signal by the end of that time limit, I’m having the place stormed.”

“I’ll be waiting too, and you bet your ass that I’ll be the first one in as soon as that last second ends.”

Some of the tension that Izuku didn’t even know he was harboring melts off of him and he smiles, “Thank you. Five minutes is all I’ll need.”

“You better not make me regret this, Problem Child. Now, leave; I have to talk to the rat about this turn of events.”

Katsuki and Izuku turn to leave, and walk out of the giant Class 1-A door. Katsuki’s hand tightens on his as they continue their walk to the cafeteria.

“You trust me, right?” Izuku asks.

Katsuki *tchs,* “Of course I do. But I don’t trust *him.* ”

“You don’t have to, but know that I’m going to save him.”

“And if anyone can, it’s you,” the blonde says. Izuku feels his cheeks warm at the comment, and he smiles, rising on his tiptoes to kiss Katsuki on the cheek.

Red blossoms on Katsuki’s face, “What was that for, huh?!”

Laughter bubbles out of Izuku’s mouth, “Just cause’.”

_____

Katsuki knew that Izuku wouldn’t back down, but that didn’t stop the fear from crawling up his chest. He sees flashes of Izuku bloodstained and exhausted, his eyes empty and lack of control. He knows that Shigaraki aided in torturing him and causing this shit show.

He doesn’t know Izuku’s past with Shigaraki, especially during his time at The Arena (Bakugou has tried looking it up, but there’s nothing. Izuku has only provided snippets, and Katsuki knows that he’s still weighed down by those two years. He knows by the way Izuku mutters and whimpers in his sleep. Whispers of *Madoka* and *keep fighting keep fighting, have to make it to the next round)* .

This doesn’t stop hot flashes of hanger from overwhelming him, though. Because if it weren’t for Shigaraki, maybe none of their friends, their *family* , would have died. Maybe Izuku wouldn’t have had to go back in time and experience so much *pain* . Maybe they would have graduated and become full-fledged heroes together. Maybe Izuku would have learned to love himself by now.

He doesn’t want Izuku to go in alone, but he knows that he wouldn’t be able to change his mind. So he’ll be as close as he can be. He swears that if he gets even a *suspicion* that Izuku’s getting hurt, then he’ll throw all those plans away and attack every single villain in the USJ.

Because even though Izuku might not know how precious he is, Katsuki does. And he’ll make sure that they both live long enough for Izuku to realize that he’s cherished.

That’s all he can do.

Chapter End Notes

Love you all <3

End Notes

And that's chapter one! I hoped you guys liked it. I've worked really hard planning this to make sure it was interesting enough.

I started planning this story in early August, so I'm really excited to have finally published it!

If you have any feedback, feel free to tell me!

Hope everyone has/had a good day!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!